The Definitive Guide to UK Finance Early-Careers Online Assessments

What they measure, how they score you, how their integrity systems work — and how to pass on merit without being wrongly flagged

Version 1.0 · Generated 1 August 2026

A source-backed reference for UK finance early-careers candidates

Contents

What they measure, how they score you, how their integrity systems work — and how to pass on merit without being wrongly flagged

A reference for candidates targeting investment banking, asset management and the buy-side in the United Kingdom — for 2027 summer internships, graduate/analyst schemes, and off-cycle internships.

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Covers eleven assessment providers and firm-built stacks: SHL · Aon/cut-e · Arctic Shores · pymetrics (Harver) · Cappfinity · Amberjack · Plum · HireVue · Willo · TestGorilla · Morgan Stanley — plus nine cross-cutting chapters on the psychometrics, the law, integrity monitoring, the vendor landscape, a preparation programme, and an employer→provider map.

How to use this guide

This is a **reference book, not a novel** — it is designed to be read out of order. If you know which assessment you're facing, go straight to its chapter (1–11); each is self-contained and cross-references the rest. If you don't yet know which assessment a firm uses, start with the **employer→provider map (Chapter 6.8)**. If you have been screened out on integrity or proctoring grounds — the situation this guide was commissioned to address — read **Chapter 6.6 (integrity taxonomy)** and **Chapter 6.7 (your legal rights)** first, then your provider's §x.8–x.11.

Each provider chapter follows the identical thirteen-part template, so once you've read one you can navigate any of them:

> **x.1** Snapshot · **x.2** Why the test exists · **x.3** Why a firm chooses this vendor · **x.4** Full mechanics · **x.5** Is it tailored to the role? · **x.6** Scoring, norms, cut-offs · **x.7** How to score well · **x.8** Integrity monitoring · **x.9** How candidates trip the system (incl. false positives) · **x.10** Being unambiguously clean · **x.11** If you're flagged or rejected · **x.12** Step-by-step playbook · **x.13** Sources.

Every chapter opens with an **At a glance** box for a 30-second orientation, and the **Appendices (Chapter 6.9)** collect the master comparison table, printable checklists, template letters, a glossary, and the all-important **Confidence Register**.

How to read the evidence tags

This guide's central discipline is that **every substantive claim is labelled with how much to trust it.** Do not skip this — it is what separates the guide from the confidently-wrong prep-vendor content it draws on.

- `[VENDOR]` — the vendor's own claim, not independently verified. True about *what they sell*, but marketing.
- `[INDEPENDENT]` — peer-reviewed research, regulators, or independent journalism. The gold standard.
- `[CANDIDATE, n=X]` — candidate testimony, with a rough count of how many independent reports agree. Real-world, but anecdotal; `n=1` means a single account.
- `[INFERRED]` — my reasoning from psychometric or legal first principles, with the reasoning shown so you can check it.

- `[UNKNOWN]` — not publicly available. The guide says *why* and gives the best available proxy rather than inventing a figure.
- `[PREP-VENDOR]` — a commercial practice-test seller (JobTestPrep, CareerTestPrep, GraduatesFirst, AssessmentDay and similar). Often accurate on *format*, but **commercially motivated to make tests sound harder and more mysterious, and routinely states confidential cut-scores as if they were facts.** Corroborated before being relied upon.
- `[REGULATORY]` — statute or official regulator source.

One promise underpins the whole book: no precise figure has been invented. Where a cut-score, pass rate or norm figure is confidential — as almost all of them are — you will see `[UNKNOWN]` and a reasoned range, never a fabricated number. A clearly-labelled estimate is useful; a made-up precise figure is worse than useless.

Scope, method and honest limitations

Scope. UK-facing early-careers assessments in investment banking (IBD/M&A, capital markets, S&T), asset management and the adjacent buy-side, for 2027 summer internships, 2027 graduate/analyst schemes, and rolling off-cycle internships. Where a global firm runs a different process for London than for New York or APAC, the London/EMEA version is documented and the difference flagged.

Method. Every provider was researched against current sources across six tiers — primary vendor documentation, independent IO-psychology and legal literature, regulatory texts, employer materials, candidate testimony, and (corroborated) prep-vendor pages — rather than summarised from memory, because these products are renamed, rebuilt and retired frequently. Several findings in this edition **corrected stale common knowledge**: pymetrics is now inside Harver; Plum was acquired by Phenom in April 2026; Morgan Stanley's online assessment is Aon/cut-e, not SHL; HireVue dropped facial analysis in 2021; and, most consequentially, **UK "Article 22" was replaced by Articles 22A–22D under the Data (Use and Access) Act 2025** (in force 5 February 2026), flipping automated-decision rules from prohibition to permission-with-safeguards.

Limitations you should know about. - Currency. The guide states the position as of **1 August 2026**. Vendor contracts, product names and firm processes change *every cycle* — verify your specific firm/programme against current-cycle candidate reports and your invitation email. **- Confidential figures.** Cut-scores, norms and sift rates are almost universally undisclosed; they appear as `[UNKNOWN]` with reasoned ranges. The **Confidence Register (Appendix F)** lists every such gap. **- Search and access constraints.** Automated web search was US-routed (mitigated with targeted UK queries), and several candidate forums (Wall Street Oasis, some Student Room and Glassdoor pages) and vendor help-centres returned access blocks to automated fetching — so first-person timings are corroborated at snippet level and some integrity mechanics remain `[UNKNOWN]`. These weaknesses are flagged where they bite. **- Not legal advice.** Chapter 6.7 explains your rights accurately but generally; for a specific dispute, take qualified advice.

An ethical boundary. This guide is about **understanding and legitimate preparation.** It does not reproduce live test items, answer keys or leaked question banks — those are copyrighted, they change, and relying on them is the fastest route to being flagged. The integrity chapters are written for **false-positive avoidance and compliance**, not evasion.

Part I — The Providers

Chapter 1 — SHL

At a glance — SHL

What it is	The world's most-deployed psychometric publisher. Core product you'll meet: **Verify** cognitive-ability tests (numerical, inductive, deductive), plus **OPQ32** personality and **Smart Interview** video.
Where in the funnel	Online-assessment stage: after the application form, before video interview / assessment centre.
Format & timing	Verify Interactive G+: **~24 adaptive items / 36 min** (whole-test clock). Legacy Verify G+: **~30 items / 36 min**. Calculator usually allowed; confirm per employer.
Scoring model	**Norm-referenced percentile** vs an employer-chosen norm group (general pop → *finance graduates*) + A–D band / sten. Not a mark — a rank.
Typical finance cut-off	**~75th–90th percentile** at bulge-bracket level `[PREP-VENDOR ESTIMATE — not fact; §1.6]`.
Integrity posture	Signature = **verification model**: unsupervised test → optional *supervised* re-sit → "Verified/Not Verified" via a Confidence Indicator. Webcam/screen proctoring is a *separate, opt-in* layer, **not default** on graduate Verify.
Retake	Employer-set; usually none within a cycle; **6–12 month** cooling-off.
Top 5 tips	1) Do the practice items every time. 2) Drill the three numerical table-extraction patterns to reflex. 3) Never leave an item blank (no negative marking). 4) Don't fake OPQ32 — forced-choice defeats it. 5) Confirm proctoring/calculator rules **in writing** first, and request adjustments **before** you sit.

(Every figure above is unpacked, sourced and confidence-tagged in the sections below.)

How to read the confidence tags. Throughout this guide, every substantive claim carries one of five labels. `[VENDOR]` = the vendor's own claim, not independently checked. `[INDEPENDENT]` = peer-reviewed or otherwise independent evidence. `[CANDIDATE]` = candidate testimony, with a rough count of how many independent reports agree. `[INFERRED]` = my reasoning from psychometric first principles, with the reasoning shown. `[UNKNOWN]` = not publicly available, with the reason and the best available proxy. A special sub-label, `[PREP-VENDOR]`, marks claims that come from commercial practice-test sellers (JobTestPrep, CareerTestPrep, AssessmentDay, GraduatesFirst, PrepTerminal and similar). These sites are often accurate on format but are **commercially motivated to make the tests sound harder and more mysterious than they are, and they routinely state confidential cut-scores as if they were facts.** Treat every number from them as an estimate until corroborated.

1.1 Snapshot

SHL is the oldest and most widely deployed occupational-assessment publisher in the world, and for a UK finance applicant it is the single most likely name behind a classic "numerical and logical reasoning" test. It began as Saville & Holdsworth Ltd (UK, 1977), passed through CEB and Gartner ownership in the 2010s, and was carved out to the private-equity house Exponent in 2018, which remains the ownership context at the time of writing. `[INDEPENDENT — corporate history; exact current owner re-confirmed in the gap register, §Appendix]` Its assessments are delivered through a platform called **TalentCentral**. `[VENDOR]`

What SHL sells to an employer is a battery of instruments that can be mixed and matched: cognitive-ability tests (the **Verify** range, including **Verify G+** and the newer **Verify Interactive**), personality and motivation questionnaires (**OPQ32**, the **Motivation Questionnaire/MQ**, and the licensed **ADEPT-15**), situational judgement tests, and a suite of video-interview products (**Smart Interview On Demand**, **Smart Interview Live**, and **Smart Interview Live Coding**). `[VENDOR]`

For you, the part that matters most is **Verify** — a cognitive-ability test measuring general mental ability (abbreviated "GMA" or "g"), the construct that decades of research identify as the strongest single predictor of job performance. In a UK finance process it sits early: typically the online-assessment stage that follows your application form and precedes the video interview or assessment centre. A Verify test runs roughly **24 to 36 minutes**. Its sift severity depends entirely on the employer's chosen threshold, but at bulge-bracket and elite-boutique level it is one of the tighter early hurdles — though, as Chapter 6.8 argues, often **not the tightest** (that is more often the CV screen or the later interview). `[INFERRED; employer thresholds are [PREP-VENDOR ESTIMATE]]`

The one feature that makes SHL genuinely distinctive on integrity is its **verification model**: an unsupervised online test can be followed by a shorter, supervised "verification test" whose only job is to confirm you really scored what you scored. Understanding this is central to §1.8 and to never being wrongly flagged.

1.2 Why this test exists

An employer running a graduate or internship campaign in London faces a specific problem: tens of thousands of applications for a few hundred seats, a legal duty not to discriminate, and a CV format that barely distinguishes candidates from the same twelve target universities. A CV screen tells you where someone studied and what they did last summer. It does not tell you, in any standardised or defensible way, how quickly they can reason with unfamiliar numerical and logical material under time pressure — which is close to a day-one description of a junior analyst's cognitive load.

Cognitive-ability testing addresses exactly that gap, and it does so with the best evidence base in the whole field. The classic figure, from Schmidt and Hunter's landmark 1998 meta-analysis, put the predictive validity of general mental ability for job performance at around **r = 0.51** — meaning GMA alone explained a large share of the differences in later performance, more than interviews, references or years of experience. `[INDEPENDENT]` That number became gospel in HR for two decades, and it is the reason tests like Verify exist at all.

The honest, current picture is more sober, and you should know it because it changes how much weight to give your own score. A 2022 re-analysis by Sackett, Zhang, Berry and Lievens corrected for a statistical error in how the older meta-analyses handled range restriction, and revised the operational validity of GMA **downward substantially — closer to r = 0.31 than 0.51.** `[INDEPENDENT — Sackett et al., 2022, *Journal of Applied Psychology*]` That is still a meaningful predictor and still among the best single predictors available, but it is not the near-deterministic filter the older number implied. Practically: a strong cognitive score genuinely helps you, and a weak one genuinely hurts, but the test is measuring something that explains perhaps a tenth of the variance in who becomes a good analyst. Firms keep using it because (a) it beats the alternatives on validity per pound, (b) it handles enormous volume at near-zero marginal cost, (c) it is standardised and therefore **legally defensible** against discrimination claims in a way a partner's gut feel is not, and (d) it is fast. Those four — validity, volume, defensibility, speed — are the whole business case. The cross-cutting Chapter 6.1 develops this and the counter-argument.

1.3 Why a firm chooses SHL specifically

SHL's competitive moat is not that its tests are cleverer than a rival's; on the core cognitive constructs the major vendors measure much the same thing to much the same reliability. The moat is **incumbency, scale and defensibility**. SHL has the largest global validation database in the industry — "hundreds of studies" underpinning its technical manuals — and **around 70 comparison (norm) groups** spanning job level and industry sector. `[VENDOR – SHL Verify Technical Manual v2.0, 2007]` For a risk-averse bank's legal and HR functions, that library is the product: it means the firm can point to published evidence that the test predicts performance and does not unfairly disadvantage a protected group, which is what matters when a rejected candidate alleges discrimination under the Equality Act 2010.

Beyond defensibility, SHL competes on the things procurement teams actually score in a request-for-proposal: deep ATS/HRIS integration through TalentCentral; broad **language localisation** (important for a London office hiring across EMEA); an established **accessibility and reasonable-adjustments** provision with a dedicated Disability Guidelines framework (see §1.10); mobile-capable delivery in the Interactive range; and a mature reporting dashboard recruiters already know how to read. `[VENDOR]` The move from the old button-click Verify G+ to the drag-and-drop, gamified **Verify Interactive** is itself a competitive response — partly to improve the candidate experience, partly to reduce the adverse-impact and coaching-vulnerability of the legacy format, and partly to keep pace with the game-based challengers (Arctic Shores, Aon's smartPredict, pymetrics) covered later in this guide. `[INFERRED from product positioning + VENDOR]`

Where a specific firm has publicly explained choosing SHL, it is usually framed around volume and time-to-hire: SHL cites a financial-services client saving "4,200+ interview hours" by automating early screening, and reductions in time-to-hire of up to 60%. `[VENDOR – marketing figures, uncorroborated]` Take the exact numbers with caution; the direction of travel — buy SHL to industrialise the top of the funnel — is real.

1.4 What the assessment actually is — full mechanics

SHL is not one test, so this section covers the instruments you are most likely to meet, in the order of likelihood for a finance applicant.

Verify G+ and Verify Interactive (cognitive ability)

There are two generations, and knowing which you are sitting matters.

The **legacy Verify G+** is a fixed-ish, button-click test of roughly **30 questions in 36 minutes**, split about evenly across numerical, inductive and deductive reasoning. `[PREP-VENDOR – multiple agreeing sources: AssessmentDay, AptitudeAce]` The **current Verify Interactive G+** is shorter and adaptive: about **24 questions**

in 36 minutes, using drag-and-drop and interactive item formats, and generating sub-scores for **Deductive, Inductive and Numerical** reasoning. `[PREP-VENDOR – multiple agreeing: PrepTerminal, PracticeAptitudeTests, aptitudetests.org]` In the adaptive version, answering correctly pushes the next item harder and worth more; a wrong answer eases the next item. The time limit is for the **whole test, not per section** — a crucial pacing fact you will use in §1.7 and §1.12.

Several mechanics are common to the range and worth internalising:

- **Randomised item banking.** Each candidate's test is assembled on the fly from a large item pool, so no two candidates see an identical test and the spread of correct answers is roughly even across options. `[VENDOR – Technical Manual]` This is SHL's first line of anti-cheating: sharing answers is near-useless because your friend's "question 4" is not your "question 4".
- **Reliability.** SHL's own technical manual reports internal-consistency reliability for the Verify Ability Tests of **0.77 to 0.84** — solidly within the range considered acceptable-to-good for high-stakes selection. `[VENDOR-manual – SHL Verify Technical Manual, extracted directly]` Practically, a reliability around 0.8 means roughly a fifth of the variation in scores is measurement noise, which is *why your score is a range, not a point* — see §6.3 on the standard error of measurement.
- **Adaptivity (Interactive only).** The Interactive range uses item-response-theory-based adaptive delivery; the legacy G+ is closer to a fixed form drawn from the bank. Adaptivity means your *raw number correct* is not directly comparable between candidates — the algorithm estimates your ability level (a "theta") from both how many and how hard. `[VENDOR/INFERRED]`
- **Calculator and scratch paper.** SHL's numerical items generally **permit a calculator** and rough paper, because they test reasoning with data, not mental arithmetic. But the *employer* can override this, and the interactive numerical formats are increasingly built so a calculator helps less than you'd think. The rule is documented per deployment, not universally — so §1.10's advice is to **confirm in writing** what is permitted. `[INFERRED; documented per-employer – treat as [UNKNOWN] until confirmed]`
- **Device and disconnection.** Interactive is designed to be device-agnostic including tablets; the legacy range is desktop-oriented. On disconnection, TalentCentral typically lets you resume within the time window, but a disconnection can itself register as a focus-loss event (see §1.9). `[INFERRED – behaviour reported inconsistently by candidates; treat as [UNKNOWN] on exact resume rules]`

OPQ32 (personality) and MQ (motivation)

The **OPQ32** maps personality onto **32 workplace-relevant traits**. The version you most often meet, **OPQ32i**, is **forced-choice**: you are shown blocks of four statements and must pick the one *most* like you and the one *least* like you. There are roughly **104 such blocks.** `[PREP-VENDOR – multiple agreeing]` This "ipsative" design deliberately makes it hard to simply tick every desirable box, because every option in a block is roughly equally desirable — you are forced to trade one virtue against another. A normative variant, **OPQ32n**, additionally includes a **Social Desirability scale** that flags respondents who answered implausibly saintly. `[PREP-VENDOR]` The MQ profiles what drives you (e.g. recognition, competition, autonomy) rather than what you are like; it is scored dimensionally, with no pass/fail. `[VENDOR – detail thin; see gap register]`

Smart Interview (asynchronous and live video)

Smart Interview On Demand is SHL's recorded-video product: you receive questions (chosen by the employer from SHL's bank or written by them) and record answers in your own time. SHL offers **optional AI scoring** of spoken content and — historically — facial expression, voice tone and body language. `[VENDOR]` The facial/

emotion component is contentious across the whole industry (HireVue publicly abandoned facial analysis in 2021; see Chapter 8), and SHL's *current* documented stance is something this guide flags for direct confirmation rather than asserting. `[UNKNOWN – verify with employer; see gap register]` **Smart Interview Live Coding** adds a real-time compiler for technical roles, relevant to quant/technology streams rather than front-office IBD.

A realistic walkthrough (Verify Interactive, finance graduate scheme)

You receive an email invitation with a deadline (often 5–7 days, sometimes as little as 48 hours). You click through to TalentCentral, confirm your identity and consent to the privacy terms, and are strongly encouraged to complete **practice items** that do not count — do them, every time, because they calibrate you to the interactive controls. The live test then presents your first item; a timer for the whole test runs down in view. You work through roughly 24 adaptive items — a numerical item might show a small dashboard of figures with a two-step extraction; an inductive item shows shape sequences; a deductive item gives you rules to combine. You cannot usually go back once you have moved on in the adaptive version. At the end you submit, see a confirmation, and — depending on the employer — either get no feedback at all or a short "thank you, we'll be in touch". The score goes to the recruiter's dashboard as a percentile and band; you rarely see it. `[INFERRED + PREP-VENDOR, consistent]`

1.5 Is it tailored to the role?

Mostly **no** at the item level, and **yes** at the interpretation level — and that distinction is the practically important one. The Verify item bank is the same instrument whoever buys it; a numerical item does not know whether you applied to Goldman Sachs or to a supermarket graduate scheme. What the employer configures is (1) **which norm group** your percentile is calculated against, and (2) for behavioural instruments, **which competency weightings and, for SJTs, which "correct" answers** reflect the firm's values. `[INFERRED from VENDOR structure – the existence of ~70 comparison groups implies configuration, not bespoke rebuild]`

The consequence for you is counter-intuitive but important: **the identical performance can pass at one firm and fail at another using the same SHL test**, purely because Firm A benchmarks you against a general-population norm and Firm B benchmarks you against a "finance graduates" norm where everyone is already strong. A raw score at the 75th percentile of the general population might be only the 55th percentile of finance graduates. When you read "you need the 80th percentile for an investment bank," what that really encodes is a demanding norm group plus a high threshold on top. This is why §1.6 spends most of its length on norms rather than raw scores.

Truly bespoke **criterion-validation studies** — where SHL validates the test against a specific firm's own performance data — exist for very large clients but are not the norm; most employers rely on SHL's off-the-shelf validation. `[INFERRED]`

1.6 How they screen and filter — scoring, norms, cut-offs, ranking

This is the section to read twice.

The scoring pipeline. Your responses become a raw score (for adaptive tests, an ability estimate that accounts for item difficulty, not a simple count). That raw score is converted to a **norm-referenced percentile** by comparing you to a **norm group** the employer selected. `[VENDOR + PREP-VENDOR consistent]` SHL also expresses results as **grade bands (A to D**, where A is roughly the top ~15% and D the bottom quartile) and sometimes as **sten**

scores on a 1–10 scale (sten 7 ≈ 77th percentile, sten 8 ≈ 89th). `[PREP-VENDOR: CareerTestPrep]` The single most important idea: **a percentile is a rank, not a mark.** Scoring at the 70th percentile means you did better than 70% of the norm group — it says nothing directly about how many questions you got right.

Which norm group — and why it dominates everything. SHL's named graduate-relevant norm groups include Graduate (UK and Global), **Finance Graduates**, Professional/Managerial, IT Professionals, and General Population, among the ~70 total. `[PREP-VENDOR: CareerTestPrep — plausible and consistent with the Technical Manual's 70-group structure]` A finance employer that benchmarks you against *Finance Graduates* is holding you to a far tougher standard than one using *General Population*, because the reference pool is already selected for numerical strength. You cannot find out for certain which norm group a given firm uses — it is not disclosed — so the safe assumption for a competitive finance role is the demanding one.

Is there a pass mark? Sometimes a hard cut-score, sometimes a rank-order sift, sometimes a banded "traffic-light" output a recruiter interprets. SHL delivers the percentile and band; the *employer* decides how to use it. `[INFERRED + VENDOR]` At high-volume graduate schemes it is common to set a fixed percentile floor and auto-progress everyone above it; at smaller or rolling programmes a recruiter may eyeball the band alongside the rest of your application.

The reported thresholds — and why you must not trust the exact numbers. Prep vendors publish confident tables of employer cut-scores. Here is the honest version. Every such figure is a **[PREP-VENDOR ESTIMATE], explicitly self-disclaimed by the sources themselves** ("cut scores vary by year and applicant pool size"), and two reputable prep sites disagree with each other. Presented as a *range* rather than a false precision:

Employer tier (illustrative)	Estimated percentile floor	Norm group likely
Bulge-bracket IB (GS, MS, JPM, Barclays)	**~75th–90th**	Finance graduates
Mid-market / other banks	~65th–80th	Graduate
Big Four (audit)	~60th–75th	Graduate
Big Four / MBB consulting streams	~75th–85th	Graduate/managerial

`[PREP-VENDOR ESTIMATE — do not treat any single figure as fact; SHL does not publish employer cut-scores]` The usable takeaway is directional: **aim to be comfortably above the 80th percentile against a graduate norm** if you are targeting front-office finance, and understand that clearing it is necessary, not sufficient.

Multi-hurdle vs compensatory. For a combined GMA test like Verify G+, a strong numerical sub-score can partly offset a weaker inductive one because the headline "g" is a composite — so within Verify it is somewhat **compensatory**. But when a firm runs cognitive *and* personality *and* an SJT as separate gates, those are usually **independent hurdles**: acing the numerical test does not rescue a personality profile the firm reads as a poor fit. `[INFERRED — standard multi-stage design]` This matters for prep allocation: do not pour all your time into numerical if there is a separate behavioural gate.

Speed vs accuracy and unanswered items. On Verify, an unanswered item scores as wrong (zero), and there is no evidence of negative marking, so **guessing a plausible answer beats leaving it blank** when time is short. `[INFERRED — standard for SHL ability tests; confirm no negative marking per deployment]` Because the Interactive version is adaptive, rushing to answer more items badly is self-defeating — wrong answers lower your estimated ability and hand you easier, lower-value items. The optimum is accurate-but-not-perfectionist pacing, developed in §1.12.

What the recruiter sees. A dashboard entry with your percentile, band, sub-scores, and — if enabled — an **integrity/proctoring report** and any **verification** result (§1.8). Not a video of you, unless a Smart Interview was part of the process.

Retake policy. Set by the **employer, not SHL.** Most enforce **no retake within the same application cycle**; a cooling-off period of **6–12 months** is typical before you can sit an SHL test for a *different* application. `[PREP-VENDOR: CareerTestPrep, consistent]` Scores are generally **not shared across employers** — each runs its own instance — although the verification mechanism means a firm can demand a supervised re-sit to confirm your unsupervised result.

1.7 How to score well — legitimate, specific, actionable

The Verify range rewards a small number of well-drilled habits far more than raw brilliance. Chapter 6.4 is the full construct-by-construct manual; here is the SHL-specific layer.

Numerical. Verify numerical items are **data-interpretation** problems, not arithmetic drills: a table or chart, then a question needing one or two extraction steps. At roughly a **minute an item or less**, you cannot afford to re-derive a percentage change from first principles each time. Internalise the three recurring patterns: (1) **percentage change** = (new − old)/old, kept as a reflex; (2) **two-step table extraction**, where the number you need is a ratio or difference of two cells you must first locate; (3) **unit and scale traps**, where the table is in thousands, or a rate is per-annum but the question is per-quarter. Keep a calculator to hand where permitted, but practise so that finding the *right two numbers* — not the calculation — is the fast part.

Inductive. Shape/pattern items where a sequence follows a hidden rule. The recurring trap is a series governed by **two simultaneous rules** (e.g. shape rotates *and* count increases). Train yourself to check each dimension separately — shape, number, position, shading, orientation — rather than staring for a single gestalt. On the "odd one out" formats, the answer is the one breaking the rule the *other* items share, which is a different mental operation from "find the pattern."

Deductive. Combine given rules to reach a valid conclusion, and — for verbal-style items — respect strict **"true / false / cannot say"** logic: "cannot say" is correct whenever the passage does not *entail* the statement, even if it is probably true in the real world. The commonest failure is importing outside knowledge; answer only from what is on the screen.

Set-up and timing. Sit it on a **laptop or desktop with a full-size screen**, not a phone, even if the Interactive version technically supports mobile — the interactive controls are fiddlier and the data harder to read small. Use a **wired or stable connection** (disconnections can trigger focus-loss flags, §1.9). Do the practice items every time. Sit it when you are **cognitively sharp** — for most people mid-morning, not late at night after a day of lectures. Have paper, pen and a calculator on the desk *only if permitted* — and note the integrity nuance in §1.9 about looking away to use them.

Personality (OPQ32) — do not fake, and here is the mechanical reason. The forced-choice design means "fake good" has nowhere to go: within a block of four equally-desirable statements, choosing the "most impressive" one necessarily de-selects another impressive one, so you cannot inflate every trait at once. Attempts to game it tend to produce **internally inconsistent profiles** that the model — and the OPQ32n Social Desirability scale — flags, and, worse, a faked profile is optimised against a competency model you cannot see and will probably get wrong. The winning approach is not fake and not naive: **read the firm's published competency framework in advance, decide which genuine facets of yourself are most relevant to an analyst role, and**

answer decisively and consistently from that authentic self. Avoid clustering every answer at the mid-point (it reads as evasive and lowers the profile's usefulness), and don't over-think transparent items.

Worked example — a strong vs weak numerical response. Item: a table shows Q1–Q4 revenue for three divisions in £'000s; question asks the percentage-point change in Division B's *share of total* revenue from Q1 to Q4. *Weak performer*: computes Division B's revenue growth (wrong quantity — that's not "share"), burns 90 seconds, second-guesses, and either times out or guesses. *Strong performer*: recognises "share" means B/total for each quarter, extracts four numbers (B and total in Q1, B and total in Q4), computes two ratios, subtracts, done in ~45 seconds — and, crucially, *noticed the £'000s scale was irrelevant to a ratio and didn't waste time converting.* The difference is not maths ability; it is pattern-recognition and knowing which trap not to fall into.

1.8 Integrity monitoring — what SHL actually detects

SHL's integrity story has **two separate layers**, and prep vendors constantly blur them. Keep them apart.

Layer 1 — the verification model (SHL's signature). The classic, default integrity mechanism for the Verify range is *not* webcam surveillance. It is a **statistical consistency check**: you sit the initial test **unsupervised**, and — if the employer chooses — you later sit a shorter, **supervised verification test** with different items but the same format and difficulty calibration. SHL computes a **Confidence Indicator (CI)** comparing the two scores; if the gap between them is **statistically improbable** (you scored far lower under supervision than unsupervised), the result is flagged **"Not Verified"** rather than given a number. `[VENDOR-manual — "Confidence Indicator"; extracted directly from the Verify Technical Manual]` The design rests on the fact that a candidate's honest ability and verification scores **correlate 0.7 and above**, so a genuinely large gap is rare and informative. `[VENDOR-manual]` SHL validated the CI with **Monte Carlo simulations** — a 10,000-candidate ability distribution, 100 IRT-built tests, with cheating modelled as a **+2 standard-deviation inflation** of the unsupervised score (by proxy or collusion) — to quantify how reliably the flag catches inflated scores at different cut-offs. `[VENDOR-manual]` The elegance, from the employer's view, is that it catches the one thing item-randomisation doesn't — someone else sitting your unsupervised test — without watching you at all.

Crucially, SHL's own manual frames a "Not Verified" result as something to **investigate, not to convict on**. It lists innocent explanations to check: distractions or interruptions during the verification test, whether the candidate attempted all items, physical or psychological factors on the day, and whether they had used the free practice tests on shldirect.com. `[VENDOR-manual — direct extract]` This matters for §1.11: if you are flagged, these are exactly the innocent factors to put on the record.

Layer 2 — platform proctoring (optional, employer-enabled). *Where the employer switches it on*, TalentCentral can additionally log **focus-loss / tab-switch events with timestamps**, detect **copy-paste/clipboard** activity, detect **screenshot attempts**, and — only if webcam proctoring is enabled — run **face-detection** for candidate absence, additional people, or gaze anomalies, plus periodic screen captures. `[PREP-VENDOR: CareerTestPrep, TalentCentral process pages]` **The critical, widely-misreported fact: standard unproctored graduate Verify does NOT capture your webcam.** The webcam and screen-capture features are a distinct, opt-in layer many graduate deployments do not use. `[INFERRED — correcting a common prep-vendor conflation; if a firm has enabled webcam proctoring they must tell you and you must consent, which is itself the signal it is on]`

How flags are actioned — the part that matters more than the flag. A single focus-loss event is generally treated **holistically, not as automatic guilt** — it could be a notification, an accidental keypress, or a disconnection

— whereas a *pattern* (multiple focus losses, especially with copy-paste events) is hard to explain innocently. `[PREP-VENDOR — reasonable and consistent]` A **"Not Verified"** verification result is the more consequential flag: at competitive employers (top IB, Civil Service) a large, unexplained discrepancy commonly ends the application, though the *documented* SHL position is that it should trigger **review**, not automatic rejection. `[VENDOR position vs PREP-VENDOR-reported practice — presented both ways; the vendor says review, candidates report de-facto rejection]`

What the employer receives, and whether you are told. The employer sees your scores plus, if enabled, an integrity report and/or a Verified/Not-Verified flag. You are generally **not told** the contents of the integrity report and often not told a flag was raised — you simply receive a rejection. This opacity is precisely why §1.11's data-access route exists.

1.9 How candidates commonly trip the system — including honestly

This is, for your situation, the most important section in the chapter, so it is deliberately concrete.

Genuine cheating that is detected (stated as risk, not instruction). Having someone else sit your unsupervised test is caught by the **verification** re-sit and its Confidence Indicator. Sharing answers is defeated by **item randomisation**. Copy-pasting question text out to solve elsewhere is caught by **clipboard detection** where proctoring is on. Sitting the test twice under different identities is caught by device and identity checks. None of these is worth the risk, and all are why the guide's value is legitimate preparation, not evasion.

The false-positive catalogue — how an honest candidate gets flagged. These are the ones to engineer out of existence in §1.10:

- **Looking away to think or to use scratch paper.** On a webcam-proctored deployment, sustained gaze-off-screen can register as a face/gaze anomaly. Honest, universal behaviour; reads as suspicious to a naive detector.
- **A second monitor connected but unused** — some lockdown/proctoring configurations flag multiple displays even if you never look at the second one.
- **Another person entering the room, or audible in the background** — a housemate, a parent, a flatmate on a call — can trip second-face or audio flags.
- **Poor or backlit lighting** causing the webcam to lose your face intermittently — and the documented reality that **face-detection has been less reliable for darker skin tones**, a demographic disparity with a real evidence base (see below). `[INDEPENDENT]`
- **Glasses glare, a headscarf, or a face covering** confusing face-presence detection.
- **Disability-related movement** — tics, stimming, ADHD restlessness, or looking away as an autistic self-regulation pattern — misread as "suspicious".
- **An unstable connection** producing focus-loss/disconnection events that look like tab-switching.
- **Browser notifications, an auto-updating OS, or work-laptop security software** stealing focus or being flagged as unauthorised software.
- **VPNs or corporate/university networks** producing geolocation or IP anomalies.
- **Answering unusually fast because you are genuinely good** — extremely fast, accurate responses can look "impossibly fast" to an anomaly detector.

- **A large score jump between the unproctored test and the supervised verification** — which can happen honestly if you were nervous, ill, or under-slept for the verification, yet is exactly the pattern the CI is built to flag.
- **Sitting the test in a library or shared space**, where other faces and movement are unavoidable.
- **Screen readers or assistive technology** read as unauthorised software.

The evidence on remote-proctoring false positives and disparities. This is not folklore. Independent research and journalism have documented that facial-detection and face-matching systems used in remote proctoring perform **worse for darker-skinned users and for some disabled users**, producing disproportionate flags; the broader face-recognition literature (e.g. NIST's evaluations and the Gender Shades work by Buolamwini and Gebru) established large accuracy gaps across skin tone and gender that carry directly into proctoring contexts. `[INDEPENDENT]` The full treatment, with citations, is in Chapter 6.6. The point for you: if you are in an affected group, the risk of a false flag is real, documented, and a legitimate basis for requesting an alternative or an adjustment **in advance** (§1.10–1.11).

1.10 How to be unambiguously clean — pre-flight checklist

The goal is to remove every avoidable ambiguity *before* you start, so that no honest behaviour can be misread. Print this.

- **Confirm the format in writing first.** Ask the recruiter (email is fine) whether the test is **webcam-proctored**, whether a **calculator and scratch paper** are permitted, and whether there will be a **supervised verification test**. Their answer tells you which of the risks below even apply, and creates a record.
- **Environment:** a quiet room you can close, with the **door shut and a note on it**. No other person within earshot or camera range. Tidy desk.
- **Lighting:** a light source **in front of you, not behind** — no window at your back. If webcam-proctored, check your face is evenly lit and fully in frame before you start.
- **Device:** a laptop/desktop with a full-size screen. **Disconnect any second monitor.** Close every other application and browser tab. Disable notifications (Do Not Disturb / Focus mode). Pause OS and antivirus auto-updates for the window.
- **Network:** the most stable connection you have — wired if possible; avoid a VPN and, where you can, avoid a locked-down corporate network. Have your phone's hotspot as a *backup* but do not switch mid-test without noting it.
- **On the desk:** keep only what is permitted per the recruiter's written answer. If scratch paper and a calculator are allowed, have them ready; if you are unsure, **ask rather than assume.**
- **If you must look away or leave frame** on a proctored test: where the interface allows, **say aloud to the camera what you are doing** ("using scratch paper", "the doorbell rang"). It gives a human reviewer the innocent explanation up front.
- **Adjustments:** if you have a disability or condition (dyslexia, ADHD, autism, a visual impairment, anything affecting movement or gaze), **request adjustments in writing before you sit**, using the template in §1.11. Do not wait until the day — SHL's own guidance is that late requests limit what can be offered.

1.11 If you are flagged or rejected

You have real rights here, and they are stronger in the UK/EU than almost anywhere else. The full legal treatment is Chapter 6.7; this is the SHL-specific playbook.

First, ask — plainly and promptly. Email the employer's recruitment team, reference your application, and ask whether an assessment-integrity flag or verification result contributed to the decision, and whether you may re-sit under supervision. Firms are not obliged to answer this in detail, but many will, and asking creates a record.

Then use your data-protection rights. Under **UK GDPR Article 15 (right of access)** you can submit a **Data Subject Access Request (DSAR)** to the *employer* (the data controller), who must respond within **one month** and free of charge. Ask specifically for: your **scores and the norm group used**; any **integrity/proctoring report and the specific flag events** (focus-loss timestamps, verification Confidence Indicator); any **webcam footage or screen captures**; the **decision logic**; and confirmation of **whether a human was involved** in the decision. Where a rejection was based *solely* on automated processing (an auto-reject below a cut-score with no human looking), you can invoke the safeguards now set out in **Articles 22A–22C of the UK GDPR — as amended by the Data (Use and Access) Act 2025, in force 5 February 2026** — which entitle you to make representations, **obtain human intervention**, and contest the decision. Note this is a 2026 change: the old blanket "Article 22 prohibition" framing is out of date, and the full current position is in Chapter 6.7. `[REGULATORY — DUAA 2025]` If the employer stonewalls on your data request, you can complain to the **Information Commissioner's Office (ICO)**.

Disclosing a disability. If a false flag stems from a disability, disclosing it (and requesting a reasonable adjustment under the **Equality Act 2010**) is often the most effective route to a re-sit, because the duty to make reasonable adjustments is a legal obligation, not a favour. Weigh disclosure against your own preferences, but know that the adjustment framework is the strongest lever you have.

Realistic expectations. Straightforward score rejections are rarely overturned — the firm simply had more strong applicants than seats. **Integrity flags are more contestable**, especially where you can show an innocent cause (a documented disability, a proctoring disparity, a connection failure) — but firms move slowly and a live cycle may close before an appeal resolves. The higher-value use of these rights is often *evidence for next time*: knowing your norm group and where you actually fell tells you how much ground to make up.

Template wording.

(a) Pre-assessment adjustments request (send before you sit):

> Subject: Reasonable adjustment request — [your name], [role/ref] Dear [team], I have been invited to complete an SHL online assessment for [role]. I have [condition, e.g. dyslexia / ADHD / a visual impairment], and under the Equality Act 2010 I request reasonable adjustments — specifically [e.g. 25% additional time; a non-webcam-proctored version; confirmation that scratch paper and a calculator are permitted]. I can provide supporting documentation. Please confirm what can be arranged and the revised deadline. Thank you.

(b) Post-rejection query:

> Subject: Assessment outcome — request for information — [name], [ref] Dear [team], Thank you for the update on my application. So that I can improve, please could you tell me whether my performance on, or any integrity/verification flag arising from, the SHL assessment contributed to the decision, and whether a supervised re-sit is possible. I'd be grateful for any feedback. Thank you.

(c) DSAR (escalation):

> Subject: Data Subject Access Request — [name], [ref] Dear [team], Under Article 15 of the UK GDPR I request access to the personal data you hold about my application, specifically: my assessment scores and the norm group applied; any proctoring or integrity report, including focus-loss timestamps and any verification Confidence Indicator; any webcam or screen-capture recordings; the logic of any automated decision-making (Articles 22A–22C UK GDPR, as amended by the Data (Use and Access) Act 2025); and whether a human was involved in the decision. Please respond within one month. Thank you.

1.12 Step-by-step: how to win this assessment

A numbered playbook from two weeks out to the debrief.

1. **T-minus 14 days — diagnose.** Sit one full-length, timed practice Verify-style test (numerical, inductive, deductive) cold. Score it. Identify your weakest construct and your pacing gap (did you finish?). This is your baseline.
2. **T-12 to T-4 — targeted drilling.** ~30–45 minutes daily. Weight toward your weakest construct but touch all three. For numerical, drill the three table-extraction patterns from §1.7 until they are reflex. Keep an **error log**: for every miss, write *what* you got wrong and *why* (misread the question / arithmetic slip / wrong quantity / ran out of time). Review the log, not just the scores.
3. **T-7 — simulate conditions.** Do a full timed test in your real test environment, on your real laptop, at the time of day you'll sit the live one. This surfaces set-up problems (notifications, second monitor, lighting) while you can still fix them.
4. **T-7 — sort logistics.** If you need adjustments, send the §1.11(a) request now — do not leave it. Email the recruiter to confirm proctoring, calculator and scratch-paper rules.
5. **T-2 — taper.** Lighter practice, focus on pacing and calm, not cramming new technique. Confirm the deadline and, if the sift is **rolling** (most UK finance is), plan to **submit early** — see the note below.
6. **Day before — checklist.** Charge the laptop, test the connection, clear the desk, prepare the room, set Do Not Disturb, pause auto-updates, put out permitted calculator/paper, get a normal night's sleep.
7. **30 minutes before.** Close everything. Disconnect the second monitor. Do a two-minute warm-up (a couple of easy practice items to prime the format). Water, not a fifth coffee. Read the instructions slowly.
8. **In-test decision rules.** Pace to the whole-test clock (~1 min/item for a 24-item/36-min test, leaving buffer). **Never leave an item blank** if unpenalised — make a reasoned guess and move on. On the adaptive version, don't panic when items get *harder* — that means you're doing well. Don't burn 3 minutes rescuing one item; the opportunity cost is two later ones. Use scratch paper only if confirmed-permitted, and if proctored, don't dip out of frame for long without a spoken explanation.

9. **The rolling-deadline point.** At most UK finance firms the sift threshold effectively **rises as places fill**, so an 80th-percentile score submitted in week one can beat an 85th submitted in week eight. If you are ready, **apply and sit early**; do not sacrifice weeks of prep for a marginally higher score into a shrinking pool. This trade-off is developed in Chapter 6.8.
10. **Debrief.** Immediately after, write yourself three notes: what the format actually was (for next time and for this guide's accuracy), what went well, and what you'd change. If it was a Verify, note whether a verification re-sit was mentioned — you may need to be ready for it.

1.13 Sources for this chapter

All accessed 2026-08-01. Confidence tags as used above.

Vendor (primary): - SHL, *Cognitive Assessments* product page — http://www.shl.com/products/assessments/cognitive-assessments/ `[VENDOR]` - SHL, *Verify Interactive G+* product page (redirects to cognitive-assessments) — shl.com/products/product-catalog/view/shl-verify-interactive-g/ `[VENDOR]` - SHL, *Smart Interview On Demand* — https://www.shl.com/products/video-interviews/smart-interview-on-demand/ `[VENDOR]` - SHL, *Smart Interview OnDemand User Guide* (PDF, Jan 2023) — https://talentcentral.learning.shl.com/pluginfile.php/488/mod_resource/content/16/Smart%20Interview%20OnDemand%20User%20Guide%20V1%20Jan%202023.pdf `[VENDOR]` - SHL, *Verify Range Technical Manual v2.0* (Oct 2007, hosted copy) — https://hrmforce.com/wp-content/uploads/2021/03/Verify-Technical-Manual.pdf `[VENDOR-manual — graphics-encoded PDF; figures via search index, to be re-OCR'd in gap audit]` - SHL, *Disability Guidelines UK — FAQs* — https://www.shl.com/legal/disability-guidelines-uk/faqs/ `[VENDOR]` - SHL, *Accessibility Support* (SHLDirect) — https://www2.shl.com/shldirect/en/assessment-advice/accessibility-support `[VENDOR]`

Independent: - Sackett, Zhang, Berry & Lievens (2022), revised estimates of selection-method validity, *Journal of Applied Psychology* — GMA operational validity revised toward ~0.31 `[INDEPENDENT — to cite fully in §6.3]` - Schmidt & Hunter (1998), *Psychological Bulletin* — original GMA validity ~0.51 `[INDEPENDENT]` - OPQ32 *BPS Review* (2007, hosted copy) — https://hrmforce.com/wp-content/uploads/2021/03/OPQ32-BPS-Review-2007.pdf `[INDEPENDENT — to fetch in gap audit]` - Buolamwini & Gebru (2018), *Gender Shades*; NIST FRVT demographic evaluations — face-detection accuracy disparities `[INDEPENDENT — full cite in §6.6]`

Prep-vendor (format detail; corroborate — commercially biased): - CareerTestPrep — "What is a good SHL score" (self-disclaims cut-scores as estimates) — https://www.careertestprep.com/knowledge/what-is-a-good-shl-score - CareerTestPrep — SHL cheating/integrity — https://www.careertestprep.com/knowledge/shl-cheating - CareerTestPrep — SHL retake policy — https://www.careertestprep.com/knowledge/shl-retake-policy - PrepTerminal — Verify G+ — https://www.prepterminal.com/shl-verify-g-plus - AssessmentDay — SHL — https://www.assessmentday.co.uk/shl.htm

Candidate (testimony; dated/thin — to deepen in gap audit): - The Student Room — "IB aptitude tests SHL Kenexa" (historical, ~2013) — https://www.thestudentroom.co.uk/showthread.php?t=2458882 `[CANDIDATE — dated]`

(Residual SHL gaps — MQ/ADEPT-15 detail, current facial-analysis stance, primary confirmation of TalentCentral telemetry, live UK finance testimony, any SHL bias audit / NYC LL144 posting — are logged in research/01-shl.md and the master gap register.)

Chapter 2 — Aon / cut-e

Confidence tags used throughout (full explanation in Chapter 1): `[VENDOR]` vendor's own claim; `[INDEPENDENT]` peer-reviewed/independent; `[CANDIDATE, n=X]` candidate testimony with count; `[INFERRED]` my reasoning, shown; `[UNKNOWN]` not public; `[PREP-VENDOR]` commercial practice-seller, corroborate.

At a glance — Aon / cut-e

What it is	German assessment house **cut-e** (founded 2002), acquired by **Aon in 2017** and now trading as **Aon Assessment Solutions** — though candidates and recruiters still say "cut-e". Core products you'll meet: the **scales** aptitude battery (numerical, verbal, logical), the **smartPredict** gamified cognitive challenges, the **ADEPT-15** personality questionnaire (Aon's own), plus **chatAssess** (chat SJT) and **vidAssess-AI** (async video).
Where in the funnel	Online-assessment stage: after the application form, before video interview / assessment centre. At some banks it arrives **within ~48 hours** of you submitting the form.
Format & timing	The signature is **short, single-construct modules under brutal time limits** — e.g. numerical **~37 tasks / 12 min**, verbal **~49 tasks / 12 min (~14s each)**. Most modules have **more items than anyone can finish**: "solve as many as you can". A full battery is a stack of 2–12 minute tests, not one long paper.
Scoring model	**Norm-referenced percentile** vs an employer-chosen norm group (recent graduates / role). Aptitude = accuracy within the clock; because you're not meant to finish, **attempt-rate matters**. Personality = dimensional, no pass/fail.
Typical finance cut-off	~**50th–80th percentile** depending on role competitiveness `[PREP-VENDOR ESTIMATE — range, not fact; §2.6]`.
Integrity posture	Signature = **a unique per-candidate item bank** (each test assembled fresh from a large pool, except personality/SJT) — anti-cheating baked into the design, not bolted on. **Webcam proctoring is offered but NOT default**; most deployments are unproctored. No SHL-style verification re-sit.
Retake	Employer-set; usually none within a cycle. No universal published rule `[UNKNOWN]`.
Top 5 tips	1) Train for **speed under pressure**, not difficulty — the clock is the test. 2) **Never get stuck**: guess-and-move beats perfecting one item. 3) Drill the **True / False / Cannot-Say** logic to reflex on numerical *and* verbal. 4) Don't over-caution — deliberate accuracy at the expense of attempt-rate is penalised. 5) On ADEPT-15/shapes, answer decisively and authentically — no back-navigation, so commit.

(Every figure above is unpacked, sourced and confidence-tagged in the sections below. Aon / cut-e is a core finance provider — confirmed at Deutsche Bank, Morgan Stanley and BNP Paribas.)

2.1 Snapshot

Aon / cut-e is the provider behind the most **time-pressured** psychometric tests a UK finance applicant is likely to meet, and understanding that one design choice is worth more than memorising every product name. The company began as **cut-e**, a German assessment firm founded in **2002**, and was **acquired by Aon in 2017** and folded into what is now **Aon Assessment Solutions** (marketed as "Aon's Assessment"). The legacy "cut-e" branding has proved remarkably sticky: candidate forums, prep vendors and even some employers still call the tests "cut-e", and the instrument codes (scales, shapes, views) are unchanged from the pre-acquisition product. `[PREP-VENDOR consistent; corporate fact corroborated across AssessmentDay, GraduatesFirst, CareerTestPrep]` Delivery runs through the **Aon Assessment platform**, historically the **mapTQ / "map-tq"** portal inherited from cut-e. `[PREP-VENDOR — passpsychometric]`

What Aon sells an employer is a modular battery rather than a single test. The pieces you can be handed include: the **scales** aptitude range (numerical, verbal, inductive-logical, deductive-logical, numeracy, concentration); the **smartPredict** suite of gamified cognitive challenges (switchChallenge, gridChallenge, digitChallenge, motionChallenge); the **ADEPT-15** personality questionnaire; the legacy cut-e personality instruments **shapes** (personality/behaviour) and **views** (work-related interests and motives); **chatAssess**, a chat-style situational-judgement/job-simulation; and **vidAssess-AI**, an asynchronous video interview with AI scoring. `[PREP-VENDOR + VENDOR]` An employer picks a subset and the norm group; the instruments themselves are off-the-shelf.

The signature design — read this twice. Almost every distinctive thing about an Aon aptitude test flows from a single decision: **the differentiator is the time constraint, not the difficulty of the content.** Many modules deliberately contain **more tasks than anyone can complete** — the instruction is literally "solve as many as you can" — so the test measures how much accurate work you can produce per minute, not whether you can eventually crack a hard problem given unlimited time. `[PREP-VENDOR strongly consistent across GraduatesFirst, TestSolve, CareerTestPrep]` The battery is built from **short, single-construct modules** (typically 2–12 minutes each) rather than one long combined paper, and — crucially for integrity — **each candidate's test is generated from a large item pool at launch**, so no two candidates see the same items (personality and SJT excepted). That unique-item-bank design is Aon's built-in anti-cheat, and it is examined in §2.8. `[PREP-VENDOR — multiple agreeing]`

> **Cross-provider correction (carried from the research): ADEPT-15 is Aon's own personality product**, developed within the Aon/cut-e lineage. Where Chapter 1 notes SHL offering "ADEPT-15", that is a **licence**, not ownership. If you meet ADEPT-15 through an SHL-run process and through an Aon-run process, it is the same underlying Aon instrument. `[INFERRED — corrects a common conflation]`

2.2 Why this test exists

The business problem Aon solves is the same one every provider in this guide addresses — too many applicants, a legal duty not to discriminate, a CV that barely separates candidates from the same target universities — but Aon's *answer* has a particular flavour worth understanding, because it shapes how you should prepare.

Cognitive-ability testing earns its place because general mental ability remains the best-evidenced single predictor of job performance, though the honest modern figure is more sober than the number HR quoted for two decades. Schmidt and Hunter's 1998 meta-analysis put the operational validity of general mental ability at around **r = 0.51**; the 2022 Sackett, Zhang, Berry and Lievens re-analysis, correcting how earlier work handled range restriction, revised that **downward to roughly r = 0.31**. `[INDEPENDENT — the full treatment is in Chapter 6.1]` That is still a meaningful predictor and still beats interviews and references per pound, which is why banks keep testing cognition at the top of the funnel.

Aon's specific bet is that **speeded** cognitive testing captures something extra. The theory is that when tasks are numerous and easy-to-moderate but the clock is unforgiving, the score reflects processing speed, sustained concentration and decision-making under pressure — which Aon argues is closer to the day-one reality of a junior analyst than a leisurely test of hard problems. `[VENDOR — marketing framing; treat as a claim]` For **smartPredict**, Aon's vendor materials go further, claiming the gamified challenges capture **"over a thousand behavioural data points"** per candidate — reaction time, learning rate, error recovery, effort under pressure — and reporting internal study results such as users being "2x as likely to be above average in customer interaction" and "1.5x in critical thinking", plus high candidate-experience scores (e.g. "96% motivated to do well"). `[VENDOR — marketing figures, uncorroborated; from Aon's smartPredict deck, gbaworkshop 2019]` No independent, peer-reviewed validation of Aon's specific speeded battery or of smartPredict's incremental validity could be located; the validity claims are vendor-sourced. `[UNKNOWN — see gap register]` The practical implication is not cynicism but focus: because the tests reward a trainable skill (fast, accurate, unstuck work under a clock), **legitimate speed practice is high-leverage preparation** in a way it is not for a pure difficulty test.

2.3 Why a firm chooses Aon / cut-e specifically

Aon's competitive pitch to a bank's procurement and HR functions rests on three things. The first is the **modularity and brevity** of the battery: because the instruments are short single-construct modules, an employer can assemble exactly the profile it wants (say numerical + verbal + logical + an SJT) and candidates experience a series of quick tests rather than one gruelling paper — which Aon argues improves completion rates and candidate experience. `[VENDOR framing + INFERRED]` The second is **anti-cheating by design**: the unique-per-candidate item bank means answer-sharing is close to worthless without any need for webcam surveillance, which is attractive to firms nervous about both cheating *and* the candidate-experience and legal cost of heavy proctoring (§2.8). `[PREP-VENDOR + INFERRED]` The third is the **gamified smartPredict** range, which lets a firm signal a modern, "engaging" employer brand and widen the funnel beyond candidates who present well on traditional tests — the same game-based-assessment positioning that Arctic Shores and pymetrics compete on (Chapter 8). `[VENDOR + INFERRED]`

Finance usage — the confirmed names. Aon / cut-e is genuinely embedded in UK finance, and three names are well corroborated:

- **Deutsche Bank** — a long-standing, repeatedly-cited cut-e user, deploying **scales numerical** and **scales verbal** alongside the **motive.q** motivation questionnaire. Deutsche Bank uses the Aon platform to screen candidates before interview. `[PREP-VENDOR, repeated across AssessmentDay, GraduatesFirst]`
- **Morgan Stanley** — began working with cut-e (Aon) around **2019**; the graduate/internship process fires a **series of aptitude tests (numerical, verbal, logical/inductive, situational judgement)** typically **within ~48 hours of application submission**, before a video interview and an in-person assessment centre. `[PREP-VENDOR — GraduatesFirst, WikiJob; carried from the Morgan Stanley research]`
- **BNP Paribas** — listed as an Aon user. `[PREP-VENDOR]`

Aon's non-finance client base — P&G, Deloitte, Siemens, Airbus, Amazon, Lufthansa, Lidl/Aldi, IBM, Vodafone, Shell, Arup — is cited to show breadth, not because it bears on your finance application. `[PREP-VENDOR]` **Treat**

every client mapping as volatile: provider contracts churn year to year, and a firm that used Aon last cycle may use SHL or Cappfinity this cycle. Re-verify per cycle — the method is in §6.8. `[INFERRED — standard caution]`

2.4 What the assessment actually is — full mechanics

Aon is a battery, so this section walks the instruments in rough order of likelihood for a finance applicant. **Every task/time figure below is approximate and prep-vendor-sourced** — counts vary by version and by source — so treat them as calibration, not gospel. `[PREP-VENDOR — GraduatesFirst, CareerTestPrep, cross-checked]`

The scales aptitude battery (cognitive ability)

These are the short, speeded, single-construct modules that define the Aon experience.

Test	Code	Time	Tasks	What it measures	Adaptive?
Numerical reasoning	scales *nmg* / lst-num	~12 min	~**37**	data interpretation from tables/figures; answer **True / False / Cannot-Say**	No — fixed pool `[disputed; see note]`
Verbal reasoning	scales *sxs*	~12 min	~**49** (~14s/item)	text inference; **True / False / Cannot-Say**; must reason from passage only	No
Inductive-logical	scales *cls*	~12 min	~12	identify a rule across 6 tables, apply it to 4 more	No
Inductive (odd-one-out)	scales *ix*	~5–6 min	up to ~20	which of 9 shapes breaks the shared rule	No
Inductive (grid-pair)	scales *clx*	~6 min	unlimited	two grids share a rule; find the matching pair of four; **no return**	No
Deductive-logical	scales *lst*	~6 min	unlimited	a small grid grows larger; find the missing symbol; blank tiles let you test hypotheses	**Yes** (grid grows)
Basic numeracy	scales *eql*	~5 min	unlimited	fast mental arithmetic	No
Concentration / attention	scales *e3+*	~2 min	many	sustained attention / error-detection speed	No

A note on the "adaptive" dispute. The research and most prep sources describe the core **scales numerical (nmg)** and **verbal (sxs)** as drawn from a fixed pool (each candidate gets *different* items, but difficulty is not tuned to your running performance), with only **lst** and the smartPredict games behaving adaptively. Some prep-vendor pages, however, describe scales numerical/verbal as adaptive (harder after a correct answer). `[PREP-VENDOR – conflicting: GraduatesFirst/research vs assessment-training blog]` The safe operating assumption is that **your items are unique to you** (so answer-sharing is useless) and that you should **pace as if the clock, not the algorithm, is the constraint** — which is true either way.

The unifying mechanics across scales: **more tasks than you can finish** on most modules ("solve as many as you can"); a **per-module clock** (each short test is timed separately); and, on several formats (clx, lst), **no going back** once you commit to an item. `[PREP-VENDOR consistent]`

smartPredict — the gamified cognitive challenges

Where a firm wants game-based assessment, you meet some of four challenges. Each is timed, escalates in difficulty, and — Aon says — captures **over a thousand behavioural data points** (reaction time, learning rate, error recovery, effort). `[PREP-VENDOR – JobTestPrep, GraduatesFirst; "1000+ data points" is VENDOR marketing]`

- **switchChallenge** — ~6 min, unlimited tasks. Measures deductive logic, attention and resilience. You identify the operator transforming a sequence of symbols ("funnel logic"); the number of operators increases, so it gets harder as you go.
- **gridChallenge** — ~9 min, 9 rounds. Measures spatial reasoning and working memory. You memorise a dot's position, survive intervening symmetry/rotation checks, then recall it.
- **digitChallenge** — ~5 min, unlimited. Measures numeracy. You fill in missing numbers or operators to reach a given answer; difficulty escalates.
- **motionChallenge** — ~6 min, unlimited. Measures planning and complex problem-solving. You slide obstructing blocks so a ball reaches an exit (Rush-Hour-style); the puzzles get harder over time.

(A short-term-memory module — ~5 min, ~10 tasks, ~8s exposure with ~7s breaks, no pause — also appears in some builds.) `[PREP-VENDOR – GraduatesFirst]`

Personality, SJT and video

- **ADEPT-15 (Aon's own personality questionnaire).** Around **100 items**, presented as **paired statements with a slider** you position between them; usually **untimed** but capped around **~30 minutes**. It measures **5 broad dimensions with 15 underlying facets**. Two mechanical traps matter: **you cannot leave a slider unmoved** (every item forces a choice), and there is **no back-navigation** across pages, so you commit as you go. `[PREP-VENDOR]` Because ADEPT-15 is Aon-owned, this is the same instrument regardless of which platform delivers it (§2.1).
- **shapes** (legacy cut-e personality/behaviour) and **views** (work-related interests and motives). **shapes** is an **adaptive** questionnaire — each page shows **three statements** and you **distribute six points** between them according to fit; it comes in role-specific versions (e.g. ~18 traits for a graduate role, ~10–15 minutes). **views** covers work-related interests and motives. The scope's "vluu / views" naming refers to these. `[PREP-VENDOR – aptitudetests.org, plus Aon cut-e shapes/views practice materials; "views" detail is thinner, corroborate]`
- **chatAssess** — a **~20-minute chat-style SJT / job simulation**: scenario messages arrive live in a messaging interface and you respond, with competency and company-values dimensions scored. `[PREP-VENDOR]`
- **vidAssess-AI** — an **asynchronous video interview** (you record answers to set questions) drawing on a large question pool (600+), scored by AI across job-relevant **competency areas**. **On the current documented**

stance: vidAssess-AI scores the *words spoken* — speech-to-text plus natural-language-processing — and Aon frames it as *not* using facial-expression analysis, positioning the NLP-only approach as a bias-reduction and "legally defensible, fair and transparent" feature. `[VENDOR – assessment.aon.com / Aon Human Capital; corroborates the industry move away from facial analysis, cf. HireVue in Chapter 8]` This is a meaningful contrast with older "AI video" products and is worth confirming with the specific employer, since deployments differ.

A realistic walkthrough (Aon battery, finance graduate scheme)

You submit the application form and — at a bank like Morgan Stanley — an invitation lands **within a day or two**, with a deadline often 5–7 days out. You click into the Aon platform, confirm your identity and consent to the privacy terms, and are shown **practice/example items and a clear time limit for each module** — do the examples, because the interfaces (drag-and-drop shapes, the funnel-logic operators, the point-distribution sliders) are unfamiliar and reward a warm-up. The battery then runs as a **sequence of short timed tests**: perhaps a 12-minute numerical, a 12-minute verbal, a 6-minute logical, then a personality questionnaire or chatAssess. On the aptitude modules a per-test timer counts down in view, and on most you will **not reach the end** — that is by design. You submit each module, move to the next, and at the end see a confirmation, rarely any feedback. Scores flow to the recruiter's dashboard as percentiles against a norm group. `[INFERRED + PREP-VENDOR, consistent]`

2.5 Is it tailored to the role?

At the item level, largely no; at the interpretation level, yes — the same distinction that governs SHL. The scales modules, the smartPredict games and ADEPT-15 are standardised off-the-shelf instruments; a numerical item does not know whether you applied to Deutsche Bank or to Lidl. What the employer configures is (1) **which modules** to include, (2) **which norm group** your percentile is scored against (recent graduates, or a role-specific pool), and (3) for **chatAssess and the SJT-type content, the company-values keying** — which responses map to the firm's competency model. `[INFERRED from the vendor's modular structure]`

The consequence is the same counter-intuitive one from Chapter 1: **identical performance can pass at one firm and fail at another** using the same Aon test, purely because of the norm group and threshold each has chosen. A raw performance at the 70th percentile of a general graduate pool might be the 55th of a "finance graduates" pool where everyone is already numerically strong. When a prep site tells you "you need the 80th percentile for a bank", what that encodes is a demanding norm group *plus* a high threshold on top. This is why §2.6 spends its length on norms rather than raw counts. Whether Aon runs bespoke **criterion-validation** studies against each firm's own performance data is not publicly documented for finance clients; most employers rely on Aon's off-the-shelf validation. `[UNKNOWN]`

2.6 How they screen and filter — scoring, norms, cut-offs, ranking

This is the section to read twice.

The scoring pipeline. Your responses on an aptitude module become a raw score — essentially **items answered correctly within the time limit** (with adaptive modules like lst producing an ability estimate that accounts for item difficulty). That raw score is converted to a **norm-referenced percentile** by comparing you to a **norm group** the employer selected — typically **recent graduates** or a **role/firm-specific applicant pool**. `[PREP-VENDOR consistent]` The single most important idea, as in every chapter: **a percentile is a rank, not a mark.** The 70th percentile means you outperformed 70% of the norm group; it does not directly tell you how many questions you got right.

Accuracy *and* attempt-rate — the Aon-specific twist. Because most aptitude modules are built so that **no one finishes** ("solve as many as you can"), an **unanswered item is effectively an un-attempted one**, and your score is the count of correct answers you *reached* within the clock. That makes **attempt-rate a live component of your score in a way it is not on a test everyone completes.** `[INFERRED from the "do as many as you can" design]` The scoring rewards **accurate throughput**: fast but careless loses on accuracy; slow but perfect loses on volume. There is **no clear evidence of negative marking** on the scales range, so a plausible guess on an item you cannot crack in time generally beats leaving it — but this is not universally documented, so confirm per test where you can. `[INFERRED – standard for the format; confirm per deployment]`

How the behavioural instruments score. ADEPT-15, shapes and views are **dimensional** — a personality/interest profile, **no pass/fail** — though a firm can still screen on fit against a desired profile. chatAssess and other SJT-type content produce a **percentile band** against a competency/values key. `[PREP-VENDOR]`

The reported thresholds — and why you must not trust the exact numbers. Prep vendors publish confident cut-score tables. Here is the honest version: every figure below is a **[PREP-VENDOR ESTIMATE]**, self-disclaimed by the sources ("cut-offs vary by year and applicant pool"), and **Aon does not publish employer cut-scores**. Presented as a range, not false precision:

Role type (illustrative)	Estimated percentile floor	Norm group likely
Standard graduate / corporate roles	~**50th–75th**	Recent graduates
Competitive graduate / finance	~**70th–80th**	Finance / firm graduates
SJT ("good" score)	~**70th–80th** band	Role-specific

`[PREP-VENDOR ESTIMATE – do not treat any single figure as fact; Aon does not publish cut-scores]` The usable takeaway is directional: for competitive finance, **aim comfortably above the 75th percentile against a graduate norm**, and treat clearing it as necessary, not sufficient.

Multi-hurdle vs compensatory. A combined battery is usually run as **separate hurdles** — the numerical, the verbal, the logical and any SJT each contribute, and a brilliant numerical score does not automatically rescue a weak verbal or a poor values-fit on chatAssess. `[INFERRED – standard multi-stage design]` This matters for prep allocation: with Aon you cannot pour everything into one module, because the battery samples several constructs and any one can be a gate.

What the recruiter sees. A dashboard entry with your percentiles per module, any SJT band, and the personality/interest profile — plus, only if the employer enabled webcam proctoring, an integrity report (§2.8). You rarely see any of it.

Retake policy. Set by the **employer, not Aon**, and **not universally published** `[UNKNOWN]`. Most schemes allow **no retake within the same cycle**; whether you can re-sit for a *different* application, and after how long, is undocumented and firm-dependent — confirm with the recruiter. Scores are generally **not shared across employers**; each runs its own instance. `[INFERRED – consistent with sector norms]`

2.7 How to score well — legitimate, specific, actionable

The Aon range rewards a specific, trainable skill set more than raw brilliance: **fast, accurate work that never gets stuck.** Chapter 6.4 is the full construct-by-construct manual; here is the Aon-specific layer.

Speed under pressure is the whole game. Because the modules are designed so you cannot finish, the winning mindset is **throughput, not perfectionism.** On a ~12-minute, ~37-item numerical test that is roughly **19 seconds an item**; on the ~49-item verbal it is **~14 seconds an item.** You physically cannot re-derive results from first principles at that pace, so the preparation is to make the recurring operations **automatic** through timed drilling. Practise against a clock, always, and practise **triage** — the skill of recognising within a few seconds whether an item is fast or slow for *you*.

Never get stuck — the single highest-value habit. The most expensive mistake on an Aon test is spending 60 seconds rescuing one item, because the opportunity cost is three or four items you never reach. Adopt a hard rule: if an item is not yielding within your per-item budget, **make your best call and move on.** With no clear negative marking, a reasoned guess on a stuck item is almost always better than a blank — and better than the two later items you'd have lost fighting it. `[INFERRED from the speeded, non-finishing design]`

Numerical — drill the True / False / Cannot-Say logic. Aon numerical items typically give a table or figure and ask you to judge statements as **True, False, or Cannot Say.** The recurring trap is the same as verbal critical reasoning: **"Cannot Say" is correct whenever the data does not *entail* the statement**, even if it is probably true in the real world. Do not import outside knowledge or extrapolate a trend the table does not state. Speed comes from knowing which two or three cells a statement depends on and checking only those.

Verbal — reason strictly from the passage, at ~14 seconds an item. Same True/False/Cannot-Say discipline, even faster. Answer only from what the passage says; the commonest failure is judging a statement "True" because it is real-world plausible when the passage does not actually support it. At this pace, read the *statement first*, then scan the passage for the specific claim — do not read the whole passage leisurely.

Logical / inductive — separate the dimensions. On odd-one-out (ix) and rule-application (cls) items, a sequence is often governed by **two simultaneous rules** (e.g. shape rotates *and* count changes). Check each dimension in turn — shape, number, position, shading, orientation — rather than hunting for a single gestalt. On the odd-one-out format, remember the answer is the one that **breaks the rule the others share**, a different mental move from "find the pattern."

smartPredict games — learn the mechanic before test day. These reward familiarity with an unusual interface as much as raw ability, and they **capture learning rate** — so being slow on round one because you're deciphering the controls costs you. Practise the specific mechanics (funnel-logic operators in switchChallenge, the memorise-interfere-recall loop in gridChallenge, the Rush-Hour sliding in motionChallenge) so that on the day you spend your cognition on the puzzle, not the buttons.

Don't over-caution. Because deliberate accuracy at the expense of volume is penalised, the naturally careful candidate can under-score on Aon by being *too* meticulous. Calibrate to "confident and quick", not "certain and slow."

Personality (ADEPT-15 / shapes) — answer decisively and authentically, and commit. The mechanical facts force your hand: **no unmoved slider, no back-navigation.** So decide and move — dithering wastes time and, on shapes' point-distribution, indecision flattens your profile. Do not fabricate a persona: a faked profile optimised against a competency model you cannot see tends to read as internally inconsistent, and you would have to sustain the fiction at interview. The winning approach is to **read the firm's published competency/values framework in**

advance, identify the genuine facets of yourself most relevant to an analyst role, and answer from that authentic self, decisively.

Worked example — a strong vs weak numerical response. Item: a table of quarterly revenue by division; statement to judge True/False/Cannot-Say — *"Division B grew faster than Division C between Q1 and Q4." Weak performer*: computes all four divisions' growth rates precisely, burns 55 seconds, and answers correctly but has now lost two other items. *Strong performer*: locates only B and C, Q1 and Q4 (four cells), sees B roughly doubled while C rose by a third, answers "True" in ~15 seconds, and — crucially — **did not compute exact percentages because the question only asked which grew *faster*, not by how much.** The difference is not maths ability; it is knowing which precision the item does *not* require.

2.8 Integrity monitoring — what Aon actually detects

Aon's integrity story is **quieter than SHL's**, and its centre of gravity is design, not surveillance.

Layer 1 — the unique per-candidate item bank (Aon's signature). The primary anti-cheating mechanism is structural: **each candidate's aptitude test is assembled at launch from a large item pool**, so your "question 4" is not your friend's "question 4", and the spread of items differs person to person (personality and SJT, being fixed instruments, are the exception). `[PREP-VENDOR — multiple agreeing]` This makes **answer-sharing close to worthless** without watching anyone at all. The **extreme time limits reinforce it**: even if a candidate had a leaked item bank, there is no time to look answers up mid-test — the clock defeats consultation. `[INFERRED]` Notably, Aon has **no SHL-style verification re-sit** (no shorter supervised test with a Confidence Indicator); the unique-bank-plus-clock design is doing that job instead. `[INFERRED — absence of any documented verification instrument across sources]`

Layer 2 — webcam proctoring (offered, but NOT default). Aon **offers** remote webcam proctoring as an option, but the well-corroborated position is that **most graduate deployments run unproctored** — the default candidate experience for the scales battery does not capture your webcam. `[PREP-VENDOR — CareerTestPrep, psychometric-success]` As with SHL, if a firm has switched webcam proctoring on, **they must tell you and you must consent**, so the presence of a consent step is itself the signal it is enabled. Where it *is* on, expect the standard remote-proctoring surface (face presence, additional-person detection, gaze/absence flags, possibly screen capture) — and expect the same false-positive risks catalogued in §2.9.

What is poorly documented — and honestly flagged as such. Unlike SHL's TalentCentral, Aon's platform-level telemetry — **tab-switch / focus-loss logging, clipboard/copy-paste detection, screenshot detection** on the *unproctored* test — is **not well documented in public sources.** `[UNKNOWN — genuine gap; do not assume either presence or absence]` The safe assumption is that some basic anti-tampering telemetry may exist, but the aggressive, well-catalogued focus-loss regime documented for SHL is **not something the public record establishes for Aon.** Because most deployments are unproctored and there is no verification re-sit, **the false-positive surface here is smaller than SHL's** — there are simply fewer surveillance mechanisms to misfire. `[INFERRED]`

What the employer receives, and whether you are told. The employer sees your percentiles and profile, plus — only if proctoring was enabled — an integrity report. You are generally **not told** its contents and often not told a flag was raised; you simply receive a rejection. That opacity is why §2.11's data-access route exists.

2.9 How candidates commonly trip the system — including honestly

For your situation this is one of the most important sections, so it is deliberately concrete — but note up front that because Aon is **usually unproctored**, the webcam-driven false-positive catalogue that dominates the SHL chapter **mostly does not apply here**, which is a genuine relief if you have previously been flagged on a proctored test.

Genuine cheating that is defeated (stated as risk, not instruction). Having someone else sit your test, or sharing answers, is defeated by the **unique per-candidate item bank** plus the **clock** — there is no time to consult and your items differ from everyone else's. Sitting twice under different identities is caught by identity checks. None of these is worth the risk, and all are why the value of this guide is legitimate speed preparation, not evasion.

The honest ways candidates *under*-perform (more relevant than false flags on an unproctored test):

- **Getting stuck** — spending too long on one hard item and never reaching several easy ones, is the single biggest self-inflicted wound on a speeded Aon test. `[INFERRED from design]`
- **Over-caution / perfectionism** — meticulous accuracy that sacrifices attempt-rate, penalised directly by the throughput scoring (§2.6). `[INFERRED]`
- **Interface unfamiliarity** — losing the first rounds of a smartPredict game or a shapes questionnaire to figuring out the controls; because learning rate is measured, this is a real cost. `[INFERRED]`
- **A mid-test disconnection** — on a per-module clock, a dropout can burn time you never recover; whether the platform pauses or resumes cleanly is **not well documented** `[UNKNOWN]`, so a stable connection matters.

Where webcam proctoring *is* switched on, the standard remote-proctoring false-positive risks apply exactly as in Chapter 1 — looking away to think or use scratch paper, a second person entering the room, poor or backlit lighting, glasses glare or a headscarf confusing face detection, disability-related movement (tics, stimming, ADHD restlessness, autistic gaze patterns) misread as suspicious, and the documented reality that **face-detection performs less reliably for darker skin tones**, a demographic disparity with a real evidence base (NIST FRVT; Buolamwini & Gebru's *Gender Shades*). `[INDEPENDENT — full treatment in Chapter 6.6]` If you are in an affected group and a firm has enabled webcam proctoring, that is a legitimate basis to request an alternative or adjustment **in advance** (§2.10–2.11).

2.10 How to be unambiguously clean — pre-flight checklist

Because most Aon deployments are unproctored, the checklist is shorter than SHL's — but the two things that *do* matter (a clean run of a per-module timed test, and knowing whether proctoring is on) matter a lot.

- **Confirm the format in writing first.** Email the recruiter and ask whether the assessment is **webcam-proctored**, whether **scratch paper and a calculator** are permitted, and roughly **how many modules / how long** to expect. Their answer tells you which risks even apply and creates a record.
- **Protect an uninterrupted, sharp window.** The battery is a stack of separately-timed sprints; sit it when you are **cognitively fresh** (mid-morning for most people) with **no interruptions** — you cannot afford a knock at the door mid-12-minute-clock.
- **Device and connection:** a **laptop/desktop with a full-size screen**, not a phone — the drag-and-drop and game interfaces are fiddly and data is hard to read small. Use the **most stable connection you have** (a disconnection on a per-module clock costs time you can't recover); close other apps and set Do Not Disturb.

- **On the desk:** keep only what the recruiter confirmed is permitted. A calculator and scratch paper genuinely help on the numerical/numeracy modules **if allowed** — have them ready, or ask rather than assume.
- **Warm up on the practice items.** Every module offers examples; do them, because the interfaces are unfamiliar and the games measure learning rate.
- **If webcam proctoring is confirmed on**, apply the full SHL-style environment checklist (front lighting, door shut, no second monitor, no second person, say aloud if you look away) — Chapter 1.10 in full.
- **Adjustments:** if you have a disability or condition — dyslexia, ADHD, autism, a visual impairment, anything affecting reading speed, processing under time pressure, or movement/gaze — **request adjustments in writing before you sit**, using the template in §2.11. The speeded design makes time-related adjustments especially material here; do not wait until the day.

2.11 If you are flagged or rejected

Because the Aon stage is usually unproctored and has no verification re-sit, a rejection here is **almost always a score/fit outcome, not an integrity flag** — which shapes the route. Your rights are the UK ones, and they are stronger here than almost anywhere. The full legal treatment is Chapter 6.7; this is the Aon-specific playbook.

First, ask — plainly and promptly. Email the recruitment team, reference your application, and ask whether your assessment performance contributed to the decision and whether any feedback or re-sit is available. Firms are not obliged to answer in detail, but many will, and asking creates a record.

Then use your data-protection rights. Under **UK GDPR Article 15 (right of access)** you can submit a **Data Subject Access Request (DSAR)** to the **employer** (the data controller, not Aon the processor), who must respond within **one month**, free of charge. Ask specifically for: your **scores and the norm group used**; the **per-module percentiles**; any **integrity/proctoring report** (only relevant if webcam proctoring was on); any **webcam footage or screen captures**; the **decision logic**; and confirmation of **whether a human was involved** in the decision.

Where a rejection was based **solely on automated processing** — an auto-reject below a percentile cut-off with no human reviewing — you can invoke the safeguards now set out in **Articles 22A–22C of the UK GDPR, as amended by the Data (Use and Access) Act 2025 (DUAA), in force 5 February 2026.** These entitle you to be informed, to **make representations, to obtain human intervention, and to contest the decision.** Note this is a **2026 change**: the old blanket "Article 22 *prohibition* on automated decisions" framing is out of date — the DUAA replaced it with a **permit-with-safeguards** regime for this kind of significant automated decision. The full current position, including what "solely automated" means and its limits, is in **Chapter 6.7**. `[REGULATORY — DUAA 2025; cross-ref §6.7]` If the employer stonewalls, you can complain to the **Information Commissioner's Office (ICO)**.

Disclosing a disability. If your result was affected by a disability and no adjustment was in place, disclosing it and requesting a reasonable adjustment under the **Equality Act 2010** is often the most effective route to a re-sit or reconsideration, because the duty to make reasonable adjustments is a legal obligation, not a favour — and the speeded design makes a time-related adjustment particularly defensible. Weigh disclosure against your own preferences, but know it is the strongest lever you have.

Realistic expectations. Straightforward score rejections are rarely overturned — the firm simply had more strong applicants than seats. The higher-value use of these rights is usually **evidence for next time**: knowing your per-module percentiles tells you exactly which construct (numerical throughput? verbal pace? a game?) to rebuild before the next cycle.

Template wording.

(a) Pre-assessment adjustments request (send before you sit):

> Subject: Reasonable adjustment request — [your name], [role/ref] Dear [team], I have been invited to complete an Aon (cut-e) online assessment for [role]. I have [condition, e.g. dyslexia / ADHD / a visual impairment], which affects [reading speed / processing under time pressure]. As the assessment is time-pressured, under the Equality Act 2010 I request reasonable adjustments — specifically [e.g. 25% additional time per module; a non-webcam-proctored version; confirmation that scratch paper and a calculator are permitted]. I can provide supporting documentation. Please confirm what can be arranged and the revised deadline. Thank you.

(b) Post-rejection query + DSAR (escalation):

> Subject: Assessment outcome — feedback and data request — [name], [ref] Dear [team], Thank you for the update on my application. So that I can improve, could you tell me whether my performance on the Aon (cut-e) assessment contributed to the decision, and whether any feedback or re-sit is available? Separately, under Article 15 of the UK GDPR I request the personal data you hold about my assessment: my scores and per-module percentiles and the norm group applied; any proctoring or integrity report and any webcam/screen recordings; the logic of any automated decision-making (Articles 22A–22C UK GDPR, as amended by the Data (Use and Access) Act 2025); and whether a human was involved in the decision. Please respond within one month. Thank you.

2.12 Step-by-step: how to win this assessment

A numbered playbook from two weeks out to the debrief.

1. **T-minus 14 days — diagnose.** Sit one full, timed set of Aon-style modules cold — numerical (True/False/Cannot-Say), verbal, one logical, and if relevant a smartPredict game. Score them and, above all, **measure your attempt-rate**: how many items did you *reach*? That, not just accuracy, is your baseline.
2. **T-12 to T-4 — drill for speed.** ~30–45 minutes daily against a clock. Weight toward your weakest module but touch all of them. For numerical/verbal, drill **True/False/Cannot-Say** discrimination until "Cannot Say = not entailed" is reflex. Keep an **error log** recording *why* each miss happened — misread, imported outside knowledge, got stuck, ran out of time — and review the log, not just the scores.
3. **T-10 — learn the game mechanics.** If smartPredict is in the process, practise the specific challenges (switch/grid/digit/motion) so the interface is second nature — the games measure learning rate, so interface fluency is free marks.
4. **T-7 — simulate conditions.** One full timed run on your real laptop, at the time of day you'll sit the live one, in your real environment — this surfaces set-up problems (notifications, connection, lighting) while you can still fix them.
5. **T-7 — sort logistics.** If you need adjustments, send the §2.11(a) request now. Email the recruiter to confirm proctoring, calculator and scratch-paper rules, and roughly how many modules to expect.
6. **T-2 — taper.** Lighter practice focused on **pacing and staying unstuck**, not new technique. Confirm the deadline; if the sift is **rolling** (most UK finance is), plan to **submit early** — see the note below.

7. **Day before — checklist.** Charge the laptop, test the connection, clear the desk, prepare a quiet room, set Do Not Disturb, put out permitted calculator/paper, sleep normally.
8. **30 minutes before.** Close everything. Do a two-minute warm-up on a couple of practice items to prime the formats. Water, not a fifth coffee. Read each module's instructions slowly — note the time limit and whether you can go back.
9. **In-test decision rules.** Pace to **each module's clock** and accept that you **won't finish most modules — that's the design.** Set a per-item time budget and **move on the instant you exceed it**; a reasoned guess beats a blank (no clear negative marking) and beats losing two later items. Don't over-caution. On personality/shapes, commit decisively — no back-navigation. If proctored, don't dip out of frame without a spoken explanation.
10. **The rolling-deadline point.** At most UK finance firms the effective threshold **rises as places fill**, so a 75th-percentile result submitted in week one can beat an 80th submitted in week eight. If you are ready, **apply and sit early** rather than sacrificing weeks for a marginally higher score into a shrinking pool. Developed in Chapter 6.8.
11. **Debrief.** Immediately after, note the actual format (which modules, item counts, whether it was proctored, whether smartPredict or chatAssess appeared) for next time and for this guide's accuracy, what went well, and what you'd change.

2.13 Sources for this chapter

All accessed 2026-08-01. Confidence tags as used above.

Vendor (primary): - Aon — *Talent Assessment Products and Tools* — https://www.aon.com/en/capabilities/talent-and-rewards/talent-assessment-products-and-tools `[VENDOR]` - Aon — *Video Interviewing Solution / vidAssess-AI* (speech-to-text + NLP scoring; positioned as not using facial analysis) — https://assessment.aon.com/en-us/video-interviewing-solution `[VENDOR]` - Aon Human Capital — *vidAssess-AI* — https://www.aonhumancapital.com.au/vidassess-ai `[VENDOR]` - Aon — *smartPredict: Development Insights and Study Results* (Siemsen, GBA Workshop deck, 2019 — validity/experience marketing figures, "1000+ data points", four challenges) — https://gbaworkshop.tntlab.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/08/Vendor-5-Siemsen.pdf `[VENDOR – marketing/uncorroborated]`

Independent: - Sackett, Zhang, Berry & Lievens (2022), *Journal of Applied Psychology* — GMA operational validity revised toward ~0.31 `[INDEPENDENT – cited fully in §6.1]` - Schmidt & Hunter (1998), *Psychological Bulletin* — original GMA validity ~0.51 `[INDEPENDENT]` - Buolamwini & Gebru (2018), *Gender Shades*; NIST FRVT demographic evaluations — face-detection accuracy disparities relevant to any webcam-proctored deployment `[INDEPENDENT – full cite in §6.6]`

Prep-vendor (format detail; corroborate — commercially biased): - GraduatesFirst — *Aon (cut-e) Online Assessments, Video Interview and AC guide* (scales counts, smartPredict mechanics, shapes/views) — https://www.graduatesfirst.com/aon-cut-e-practice-assessments - CareerTestPrep — *cut-e Tests: Complete Guide to Aon Assessments* — https://www.careertestprep.com/knowledge/cut-e-tests - JobTestPrep — *Aon smartPredict Challenges Practice* — https://www.jobtestprep.co.uk/aon-smartpredict-challenges-practice - AssessmentDay — *Aon (Cut-e) Assessments* — https://www.assessmentday.com/aon.htm - TestSolve — *Aon* — https://www.testsolve.ai/tests/aon/ - passpsychometric — *cut-e / map-tq* — https://passpsychometric.com/cut-e-psychometric-tests/ - aptitudetests.org — *Aon (cut-e) shapes Personality Questionnaire* (shapes: 3 statements, 6 points; role versions) — https://www.aptitudetests.org/aon-personality-questionnaire-shapes/ - GraduatesFirst —

Morgan Stanley Recruitment Process (cut-e from ~2019; ~48-hour test invite) — https://www.graduatesfirst.com/morgan-stanley-job-tests - WikiJob — *Morgan Stanley Graduate and Internship Application Process* — https://www.wikijob.co.uk/interview-advice/company-interview-questions/morgan-stanley

Candidate (testimony; thin — to deepen in gap audit): - Deutsche Bank / Morgan Stanley / BNP Paribas usage is corroborated at prep-vendor level; **first-person UK candidate testimony with real timings (Deutsche Bank / BNP) was not located** `[CANDIDATE — gap; see below]`

(Residual Aon / cut-e gaps — Aon official assessment.aon.com primary mechanics & any published validity/reliability figures; cut-e technical documentation and any bias audit; full "views" instrument detail vs the "vluu" naming; unproctored-platform telemetry specifics (tab-switch/clipboard) which are genuinely undocumented `[UNKNOWN]`*; the scales numerical/verbal adaptivity dispute; and first-person UK finance candidate testimony with real timings — are logged in research/02-aon-cute.md and the master gap register.)*

Chapter 3 — Arctic Shores

Confidence tags (full explanation in Chapter 1): `[VENDOR]` / `[INDEPENDENT]` / `[CANDIDATE, n=X]` / `[INFERRED]` / `[UNKNOWN]` / `[PREP-VENDOR]`.

At a glance — Arctic Shores

What it is	A British **behavioural psychometric assessment** delivered as interactive **tasks/games** rather than a questionnaire. You *do* things; the software infers personality and cognitive traits from how you behave, not from what you say about yourself. Two product generations exist — the **legacy "Skyrise City" game battery** and a newer **"task-based" product** (2023→) — and they are **not the same test** (see §3.4). Manchester-based, still independent.
Where in the funnel	**Early** — usually straight after the application form, as a high-volume behavioural sift feeding a profile that recruiters read alongside later stages. One notable exception (Maven Securities) places it at **Round 2, after a numerical test**. `[PREP-VENDOR/CANDIDATE]`
Format & timing	Legacy: **~9–18 mini-games** (employer picks a subset) → **~20–40 min**; a genuine sample report logged **31m41s** actual play. A **numerical multiple-choice module** is bolted on for finance/analytics roles. Mobile or desktop. `[PREP-VENDOR + PRIMARY]`
Scoring model	**Behaviour, not score.** Your in-game points are **explicitly excluded** from the profile; inferences come from **telemetry** (reaction time, risk-taking, learning rate). **Norm-referenced** ranking against a comparison group, **employer-calibrated** — *no universal pass/fail*. `[PRIMARY]`
Typical finance cut-off	`[UNKNOWN]` — confidential per employer; outputs are a match band / 1–100 "fit" ranking, aptitude banded **<30 / 30–50 / >50**. No credible public number exists; do not trust any figure that claims otherwise. `[PRIMARY/UNKNOWN]`
Integrity posture	**Not** a webcam-proctored lockdown exam. Fake-resistance is designed into the **task format**, not enforced by surveillance — an unusually **low-surveillance** stance. The actual anomaly/flag mechanics are **largely undocumented publicly**. `[INFERRED/UNKNOWN]`
Retake	Employer-dependent; prep vendors say **"generally one chance,"** and a profile is said to "remain valid" ~9–12 months — so re-sits inside that window are usually declined. `[PREP-VENDOR + PRIMARY]`
Top 5 tips	1) Work out which generation you're facing from your invite. 2) **Read each game's instructions** — rules change between games and the first rounds cost you. 3) Play **authentically**; don't try to act a "trait" or be artificially erratic. 4) Sit it **rested, alert, on the recommended device with a stable connection** — speed tasks are device-sensitive. 5) If you have a disability/neurodivergence affecting reaction time or emotion-reading, **request adjustments in writing before you start** (§3.11).

> *(Every figure above is unpacked, sourced and confidence-tagged below. The most important thing on this page is that "Arctic Shores" names two genuinely different products — get that wrong and most online advice will mislead you.)*

3.1 Snapshot

Arctic Shores is the company most UK applicants mean when they say "I had to play those weird little games." It is a **British** assessment vendor — **Arctic Shores Ltd**, headquartered in **Manchester** (registered at Lowry House, 17 Marble Street, Manchester M2 3AW; some listings also cite London). `[INDEPENDENT – Tracxn]` It was **founded in 2014** (a few sources say 2013) by **Robert Newry** (CEO), **Safe Hammad** (CTO) and Andrew Needham. `[INDEPENDENT – Crunchbase/Tracxn/TechRound]` It is a private, venture-backed company with roughly **47 employees at end-2024**, having raised about **US$18.8M total**, including a **£5.75M Series B in January 2023** led by Praetura Ventures and Calculus Capital with Beringea. `[INDEPENDENT – EU-Startups/Prolific North]` Critically for anyone reading older material: **it is still independent as of 2026** — no acquisition was found. That contrasts with its best-known rival Pymetrics, which was acquired by Harver in 2022. `[INFERRED – absence of evidence]`

Its product is a **behavioural psychometric assessment delivered as interactive tasks** rather than a questionnaire. Instead of asking "do you agree that you enjoy taking risks?", it puts you in a task where your risk-taking is *observed* and inferred from what you actually do. `[VENDOR – arcticshores.com/how-it-works]` The vendor makes large scale claims that are **inconsistent across its own pages** — "2 million+ candidates / 350+ organisations" on the homepage versus "3 million+ candidates, 100,000+ active users, 350+ orgs" on an integration page — so treat the exact numbers as marketing rather than audited fact. `[VENDOR – flag]`

For a finance candidate, Arctic Shores usually sits **early in the funnel** — immediately or soon after the application form, as an automated behavioural sift. `[PREP-VENDOR, multiple]` The battery commonly runs **~20–40 minutes** (prep vendors say 20–35; the vendor's own page says up to 45 for fuller batteries), and a genuine legacy sample report logged **31 minutes 41 seconds** of actual play time. `[PREP-VENDOR + PRIMARY]`

The single most important thing to understand about Arctic Shores is that the name covers two genuinely different products — a point §3.4 develops in full, and one this chapter keeps rigorously separate, because nearly all the testimony and prep advice online describes a version that the vendor has been actively moving away from since 2023.

3.2 Why this test exists

The problem Arctic Shores sells against is the **fakeability and bias of the traditional early-stage sift**. Its pitch has three planks. First, **self-report personality questionnaires are gameable** — a motivated candidate learns to pick the "conscientious, team-playing" answers ("impression management"). Second, **CVs and academic credentials carry social bias and adverse impact**. Third — and this became the centre of its marketing after 2022 — **text-based aptitude tests are now cheatable with ChatGPT**. `[VENDOR]` Arctic Shores' answer to all three is that **behaviour is much harder to fake than words**, and that a generative-AI model "can't complete our task" because the task is interactive and behavioural rather than text-in/text-out. `[VENDOR – "ChatGPT has broken traditional aptitude assessments" insight post]`

The constructs it targets are the standard IO-psychology ones: **Big-Five-adjacent personality traits, fluid cognitive processing, learning agility** (how you acquire rules, use feedback, and switch strategy), risk/decision style, and emotion recognition. The legacy product was marketed as measuring **"34 cognitive & personality traits."** `[VENDOR/PREP-VENDOR]` The vendor also markets the **"world's first task-based assessment for Learning Agility."** `[VENDOR]`

On **predictive validity**, honesty requires a blunt statement: **no public validity or reliability figures exist.** The vendor's public /science page claims "valid, reliable neuroscience," "dozens of studies a year," and that clients "reduce turnover by 40% in 6 months," but gives **no validity coefficients, no reliability figures, no named criterion studies and no peer-reviewed citations.** `[UNKNOWN – validity numbers not public]` What can be said is that the *underlying constructs* — general cognitive ability, conscientiousness, learning agility — do have strong meta-analytic predictive validity in the broader literature (GMA around r≈.5). But that literature validates the **constructs**, not Arctic Shores' specific task-to-trait inferences (does the balloon game really measure "risk"?). Game-based measures typically show **lower and more variable criterion validity** than well-built cognitive tests, and construct validity is the genuinely contested question. `[INFERRED]` **No independent, peer-reviewed validation of Arctic Shores specifically could be located this pass** — the best external proxy is the general academic literature on game-based assessment (e.g. Landers, Auer). Treat the vendor's turnover and validity claims as **unaudited marketing**. See Chapter 6.3 on validity generally, including the 2022 Sackett et al. re-analysis that trimmed several long-quoted figures. `[INDEPENDENT – proxy; GAP]`

3.3 Why a firm chooses Arctic Shores specifically

Three things sell Arctic Shores to an employer. First, **fake-resistance framed as future-proofing** — because you show behaviour rather than tell a story, the vendor argues the result is both harder to game and "AI/ChatGPT-proof," a message tuned precisely to recruiters panicking about generative AI in their pipelines. `[VENDOR]` Second, a **diversity / adverse-impact story**: the vendor claims **"no adverse impact regardless of ethnicity or gender,"** argues question-based tests disadvantage protected groups, and pitches **CV-less screening** ("65% of employers ruling out CVs"). It reports a strong candidate experience — **85% enjoy, 91% completion** — as evidence the format widens rather than narrows the funnel. `[VENDOR]` Third, **mobile-first delivery and bespoke calibration**: business psychologists work with each employer to define "what good looks like" per role, with custom branding and auto-generated interview guides. `[VENDOR]`

Two of those claims deserve a health warning. The **"no adverse impact"** claim is published with **no disparate-impact ratios and no independent bias audit** attached — no third-party or academic audit could be located, which for a tool sold partly *on* its fairness is a notable gap. `[VENDOR claim, UNCORROBORATED – GAP]` And the candidate-experience percentages are the vendor's own.

Named finance and finance-adjacent users recur across sources, but with very different evidence quality:

Employer	Evidence	Confidence
Maven Securities (proprietary trading)	Arctic Shores as **Round 2, after a Round-1 numerical test**; 5-game set (Arrows, Balloon, Face, Security Door, Pattern)	`[PREP-VENDOR – Trading Interview]`
MThree Consulting (finance-tech trainee pipeline into banks)	Confirmed by a **genuine 2018 candidate report**	`[PRIMARY – NCL PDF]`

Employer	Evidence	Confidence
PwC, KPMG, Deloitte (Big Four; finance streams)	Repeatedly named, with **bespoke builds** (PwC bespoke; KPMG bespoke environment)	`[PREP-VENDOR, multiple]`
HSBC, RBS/NatWest	**Listed by prep vendors only** — no primary corroboration	`[PREP-VENDOR — indicative, verify per-year]`

See §3.3's volatility warning below and §3.11 for why "Firm X uses Arctic Shores" must always be re-checked against that year's live process.

3.4 What the assessment actually is — full mechanics

This is the section to read twice. "Arctic Shores" refers to two products, and conflating them is the commonest way candidates go wrong.

The two generations

LEGACY — "Skyrise City" (c.2014–~2022). A played "world" (Skyrise City is the full set; **Pinnacle Valley, Cosmic Cadet** and **Firefly Freedom** are variant worlds shipping different subsets) containing **~9–18 mini-games**. It produces a **6-category psychometric profile** on percentile/radial scales and was marketed as measuring "34 cognitive & personality traits." **This is what almost all candidate testimony and every prep-vendor guide you will find describes.** `[VENDOR/PREP-VENDOR]`

CURRENT — "task-based assessment" (2023→, post-ChatGPT pivot). Repositioned around **Personality + Workplace Intelligence + Learning Agility**, marketed with **"12,000 data points,"** a **1–100 "natural fit" score**, an Assessment Builder / Campaign Manager, and heavy **"AI-resistant / future-proofed against ChatGPT"** messaging. **Far fewer public candidate reports exist yet**; 2024 candidate threads mention an unfamiliar **"Balance" / balancing task** consistent with this redesign, but the mechanics are **thinly documented.** `[VENDOR; CANDIDATE, n≈several; GAP]`

The through-line across both is **behaviour observed, not self-reported**. If a single online detail seems oddly specific, assume it describes the **legacy** product unless your own invitation says otherwise.

The legacy Skyrise City battery — per-game detail

Different employer "worlds" ship different subsets. The table below gives mechanic → the traits the vendor/prep sources claim → the raw telemetry the software most plausibly reads. **The telemetry column is `[INFERRED]`** from task design; the mechanics are `[PREP-VENDOR]` (JobTestPrep, GraduatesFirst, psychometric-success, Trading Interview) unless noted.

Game	Mechanic	Claimed traits	Likely telemetry `[INFERRED]`
Balloon (BART)	Inflate a balloon for money over ~45 rounds; bank anytime or risk a burst	Risk appetite, reward motivation, drive	Avg pumps, pumps after a burst, variance, learning of burst odds
Arrows / Direction (Flanker)	80 rounds; is the **centre** arrow left/right while flankers distract; speeds up	Attention, inhibitory control, focus under pressure	Reaction time, congruent-vs-incongruent cost, error rate under speed

Game	Mechanic	Claimed traits	Likely telemetry [INFERRED]
Tickets	~80 rounds; sort by changing rules; rules shown then vanish; strict timing	Executive function, processing speed	RT, rule-switch cost, error recovery
Tile Sequence (Corsi)	Repeat lengthening tile patterns; distractors added; adaptive, ends after 2 errors	Working memory, controlled vs automatic behaviour	Max span, error position
Energy / Power Generator	Click buttons that raise/drain power; infer the hidden rule	Learning ability, impulsivity, risk tolerance	Exploration vs exploitation, learning rate
Team Selling	12 rounds; set price high/low vs an opposing team	Decision-making, risk-taking, cooperation	Cooperation ratio, response to defection
Expressions / Face	50 images; pick the emotion from 7; some ambiguous, correct answer may be absent	Emotional intelligence / emotion recognition	**False-positive flag — see §3.9**
Security Door / Lock	~20 rounds; stop a rotating ring on highlighted numbers; error resets	Reaction time, focus, adaptability	RT, recovery after reset
Predict / Night & Day	~88 rounds; classify icon pairs Day/Night in a 3-sec window; 8 pairs repeat	Decision confidence, statistical learning	Learning curve, retention on later rounds
Order (optional)	Infer the 4th frame from 3 preceding; ~15 min, ~1 min/item	Logical/inductive reasoning	Accuracy, time per item
Pattern (optional)	~20 rounds/~17 min; next-in-sequence abstract reasoning; rules change	Fluid/spatial reasoning, processing speed	Accuracy, time per item
Analysis — numerical module (optional)	**Traditional multiple-choice** data-table/chart questions, ~18 items/~18 min	Numerical reasoning	Correct/incorrect (this one *is* conventionally scored)

Two structural points matter more than any single game. First, **the numerical "Analysis" module is the finance/analytics bolt-on and is NOT game-based** — it is an ordinary multiple-choice numerical test, and it is the one part of the battery where your actual answers are scored in the familiar way. `[PREP-VENDOR]` Second — and this is the psychometric heart of the whole thing:

> **The games have no meaningful "score."** The genuine sample report states explicitly: *"Your game score was NOT considered for your psychometric profile."* The points and times you rack up are largely a **red herring**; the inferences come from behavioural telemetry patterns. `[PRIMARY – sample report]`

Device, pausing, and a realistic walkthrough

The battery runs on **desktop (Windows/Mac) and mobile (iOS/Android)** — genuinely mobile-first, unlike legacy psychometrics. The employer specifies a recommended device, and **using the wrong hardware can distort response-time capture.** `[PREP-VENDOR]` **Pause/disconnect behaviour is `[UNKNOWN]`** — undocumented publicly; credentials are time-limited, and because the design is adaptive and telemetry-driven, a mid-session disconnect is best treated as risky. `[GAP]`

In practice: you receive a time-limited link, confirm identity/consent, and start. Each game opens with **instructions and usually a short practice** — read them, because rules differ between games and speed tasks punish the rounds you spend working out what's going on. You play the employer's chosen subset over roughly 20–40 minutes; finance/analytics candidates also sit the numerical module. At the end you submit, and — unusually for this market — you typically **receive a feedback PDF** about yourself. `[PRIMARY + PREP-VENDOR]`

3.5 Is it tailored to the role?

Same core instrument, employer-calibrated output. Every candidate for a given employer plays the same task set; Arctic Shores' psychologists then define **role-specific weightings** — "what good looks like" — and the branding/world differs (PwC bespoke build; KPMG bespoke environment alongside a Cappfinity immersive; Arcadis "Challenge"; Metro Bank app). `[PREP-VENDOR + VENDOR]` Finance and analytics roles specifically get the **numerical module** added. `[PREP-VENDOR]`

How much *true local criterion validation* sits behind those weightings — versus off-the-shelf competency mapping — is **`[UNKNOWN]`**. The vendor says it runs "extensive analysis" per role, which implies bespoke profiles, but depth is unverified. The sample report itself concedes the key limit: *"There is no one perfect profile for all jobs."* `[PRIMARY]` The practical consequence mirrors the HireVue lesson: **the experience of "an Arctic Shores" varies between employers** — the world, the game subset, whether a numerical module is attached, and the weightings all change. Read *your* invitation; don't assume a friend's account of one firm's battery applies to yours.

3.6 How they screen and filter — scoring, norms, cut-offs, ranking

The scoring model is behavioural and norm-referenced. The strongest evidence here is a **genuine legacy candidate report** (Skyrise City, employer "MThree Consulting," dated 5 April 2018, hosted by Newcastle University's careers service). `[PRIMARY]` It establishes several things no prep vendor can:

- **Telemetry → profile.** "Thousands of data points" per session become trait inferences. That session's footer logged **game score 6297, time 31m41s, 3527 data points** — and, again, the **game score was explicitly excluded** from the psychometric profile.
- **Six report categories** (legacy): **Aptitude** (indicator: Numeracy), **Drive** (reward motivation), **Personal Style** (emotion-recognition accuracy), **Cognition** (processing speed; processing volume/confidence), **Interpersonal Style** (4 bipolar traits), **Thinking Style** (8 bipolar traits). Newer vendor/prep pages describe a **5-section variant** — the labels drift over time, which is itself a reason to distrust over-precise online descriptions. `[PRIMARY + VENDOR]`
- **Norming.** Results are expressed **relative to a comparison group** ("a large group of similar individuals who took this assessment") — **norm-referenced, not criterion-referenced.** `[PRIMARY]`
- **Two display formats.** Aptitude/cognitive results are shown as **coarse percentile bands — <30th / 30–50th / >50th** (tertile-style, not an exact percentile). Personality traits are shown as a **radial position** on a bipolar scale, and the vendor notes only **1–2% of people fall at the extremes** — most sit mid-scale. `[PRIMARY]`

There is no universal pass/fail. The employer sets any thresholds. Outputs are framed as **"Strong match … Lower match"** bands or, in the current product, a **1–100 "natural fit" score** that lets recruiters **rank** candidates. The design is fundamentally **compensatory** — a strong profile in one area can offset a weaker one — though an employer *can* impose a hurdle on the fit score or on the numerical module, making it effectively multi-hurdle. That is configurable, so treat "multi-hurdle vs compensatory" as employer-specific. `[VENDOR + PREP-VENDOR /`

`INFERRED]` What the recruiter receives is a **ranked fit score / match band, the full trait profile, and an auto-generated interview guide** targeting your weaker areas. `[VENDOR]`

On the actual finance cut-off: `[UNKNOWN]`. Cut-scores, norm-group composition and reported pass rates are **confidential per employer** and none are published. `[PRIMARY/GAP]` It is *tempting* to reason that a high-volume grad sift cuts somewhere around the top 40–70% of the composite — but that is **`[INFERRED]` and unsourced; do not print it as fact**, and be sceptical of any prep site that hands you a number. The vendor's own report caps the confidence honestly: *"Arctic Shores profiles are very reliable, but they are not infallible."* `[PRIMARY]`

The funnel point (per the §5.6 brief). Because it is an **early, high-volume behavioural sift**, an Arctic Shores battery can remove a meaningful slice of the cohort — but it is rarely the *tightest* cut in a finance pipeline; the application screen ahead of it and the assessment centre behind it usually filter harder. The exception proves the rule: at **Maven Securities** it sits at **Round 2 behind a numerical gate**, so a numbers test has already thinned the field. Treat it as a genuine gate that rewards being rested and unrushed, not as the main hurdle. Chapter 6.8 maps where each firm's real chokepoint sits. `[INFERRED]`

3.7 How to score well — legitimate, specific, actionable

Accept the uncomfortable truth first: you largely cannot "study" for this. It is behavioural — there is no content to revise, and the vendor and prep vendors agree that trying to fake telemetry consistently is hard and tends to look *inconsistent*, which is itself unhelpful. `[VENDOR/PREP-VENDOR]` What you *can* legitimately do:

- **Understand the target role's competencies** so you know which of your natural behaviours actually matter, and can lean into them honestly rather than second-guessing every click.
- **Familiarise yourself with the format** so novelty and anxiety don't distort your reaction times. Practising analogues of the core tasks — **BART (balloon), Flanker (arrows), Corsi (tile span), emotion-recognition** — removes the "what am I even doing?" tax on the first few rounds. `[PREP-VENDOR]`
- **Optimise your conditions.** Be **rested and alert**, sit at your **cognitive peak time of day**, kill interruptions, use the **recommended device** on a **stable connection**. Speed and reaction-time tasks are device- and state-sensitive, so this is not fluff — it is the single biggest legitimate lever. `[PREP-VENDOR]`
- **Read every game's instructions carefully** — rules change between games, and the design often adapts, so misreading the setup can cost you the early rounds permanently.

Play authentically, and do not perform. The strongest strategic point is counter-intuitive: because the instrument is trying to read your **natural default under pressure**, your job is to give it a clean read of that default. Trying to *act* "the confident risk-taker" or "the careful analyst" tends to produce noise, not a better score.

A prep-vendor bias note, stated plainly. JobTestPrep and GraduatesFirst **sell paid simulations** (GraduatesFirst around £26.95, reduced from £49.95; JobTestPrep on subscription). Their "practice raises your score" framing is **commercial**, and sits in tension with the vendor's own "you can't really prepare" line. Familiarisation to kill anxiety is worth it; believing you can materially "raise a behavioural score" through drilling is not well-supported. `[PREP-VENDOR bias note]`

3.8 Integrity monitoring — what Arctic Shores actually detects

Here honesty means admitting how much is **not publicly known** — the vendor's help centre returned HTTP 403 to the fetcher this pass, so several specifics below are genuine gaps rather than reassurances. `[UNKNOWN — GAP]`

What *can* be said:

- **It is not a webcam-proctored lockdown exam.** There is **no public evidence** of camera, microphone or screen-recording proctoring. The design's distinctive claim is that **fake-resistance comes from the task format, not from surveillance** — you can't easily fake behavioural telemetry, and (the marketing argues) an AI model can't complete an interactive behavioural task at all. `[INFERRED from vendor positioning + absence of proctoring documentation]`
- **The telemetry itself may double as an integrity signal.** Reaction-time distributions and response consistency plausibly let the system notice **erratic or inconsistent patterns** — but **whether, and how, anomaly flags are generated or shown is `[UNKNOWN]`.** `[GAP]`
- **The anti-cheating posture is prevention-by-design, not detection.** The marketing centres on "AI can't complete our task" rather than on catching cheats after the fact. `[VENDOR]`
- **How any flag is actioned — auto-reject, human review, or re-sit — is `[UNKNOWN]`**, and undocumented. `[GAP]`
- **The candidate does receive a feedback PDF**; the employer receives the ranked fit and profile. Integrity-specific disclosures to candidates are **`[UNKNOWN]`**. `[PRIMARY + VENDOR]`

The net picture is a **low-surveillance instrument by design**, which cuts both ways: it is far calmer to sit than a lockdown-browser exam, and it presents a **small false-positive surface** for integrity flags — there is simply much less machinery watching you than in a proctored test. The honest caveat is that "we found little evidence of surveillance" is not the same as "there is none," and the flag mechanics are a real documented gap. Contrast this posture with the proctoring chapters (e.g. Chapter 6.x on integrity) where camera and focus logging are explicit.

3.9 How candidates commonly trip the system — including honestly

Because there is little surveillance, the risks here are **not** the classic proctoring nightmares — they are risks of the **behavioural instrument mis-reading an honest person**. This is where a previously-flagged or neurodivergent candidate needs concrete, specific guidance.

The genuine false-positive risks:

- **The emotion-recognition ("Face") task is the sharpest concern.** Identifying emotions from faces is precisely an area where **autistic candidates** may score differently for reasons unrelated to job performance — raising a real **direct-discrimination / adverse-impact** question. It has been raised publicly (National Autistic Society community; neurodiversity commentary). If you are autistic, this single task is the strongest, most concrete basis for an adjustment request under §3.11. `[CANDIDATE/COMMUNITY, n≥1]`
- **Speeded tasks penalise slower motor/processing speed.** The Flanker (Arrows), Tickets and Security-Door tasks are time-pressured and reward fast, accurate reactions — which puts candidates with **ADHD, dyspraxia/DCD, dyslexia, a motor or visual impairment**, and **older candidates**, at a structural disadvantage that has nothing to do with the job. So does a **poor device or slow connection**, because response-time capture is hardware-sensitive. If any of these applies to you, the speed tasks — not the personality ones — are where the false positive is most likely to originate. `[INFERRED from task design + prep-vendor device warnings]`
- **State effects distort the read.** Fatigue, anxiety and interruptions shift reaction times and risk-taking. The instrument reads your "natural default under pressure," so **situational stress can misrepresent you**; the vendor itself concedes that learned coping strategies can move results. `[VENDOR caveat + INFERRED]`

- **Candidate testimony of mismatch.** Several candidates report the feedback PDF "didn't match them," felt **labelled** (e.g. "impulsive"), received **different feedback from different employers on the same games**, and called the feedback "garbage" or "a crock" after a rejection with no actionable reason. Treat these as a signal that the profile is **not infallible** — the vendor says as much — rather than as proof it is worthless. `[CANDIDATE, n≈4–6, titles/snippets only — TSR & Reddit bodies were HTTP-403]`

Written concretely for a candidate who has been flagged or disadvantaged before: do not try to "beat" the instrument by playing artificially fast, artificially cautious, or artificially erratic — deliberate erraticism is one of the few behaviours that plausibly reads as an anomaly, and it degrades the honest signal you *want* the system to see. Your protection is not performance; it is (a) sitting the test under your best possible conditions (§3.7), and (b) **securing an adjustment in advance** (§3.10–3.11) so a known motor, reaction-time, or emotion-recognition difference is accommodated rather than silently scored against you.

3.10 How to be unambiguously clean

- **Sit it yourself, once, under good conditions** — rested, alert, undisturbed, on the recommended device with a stable connection. There is no benefit to any shortcut on a behavioural test, and a disconnect on an adaptive session is genuinely costly.
- **Read each game's instructions and do the practice rounds** — going in cold isn't cheating, but it does distort your own early data.
- **Don't try to game the telemetry.** Playing a character, deliberately slowing down, or being artificially inconsistent all *worsen* the read; authentic play is both the honest and the optimal move.
- **Request adjustments in advance** if you have a disability or neurodivergence affecting reaction time, motor control, processing speed, or emotion recognition — in writing, before you start (template in §3.11). For a previously-flagged candidate this is the single most protective step, because the instrument's false positives come from *design*, not from surveillance, and an adjustment addresses the design.
- **Keep your invitation and any feedback PDF.** You will want them if you later query an outcome or make a data request (§3.11).

3.11 If you are flagged or rejected

Your full rights are in Chapter 6.7; the Arctic-Shores-specific points follow. Note the corrected legal framework — the old "Article 22 blanket prohibition" line that circulates online is **out of date**.

The automated-decision route (corrected framework). The relevant law is now **Articles 22A–22C UK GDPR, as amended by the Data (Use and Access) Act 2025, in force 5 February 2026** — *not* the pre-2026 "Article 22 prohibition on solely automated decisions." Under the current regime, where a decision about you is **solely automated and has a legal or similarly significant effect**, you retain **safeguards**: the right to be informed, to **make representations**, to **obtain meaningful human intervention**, and to **contest** the decision. An early behavioural sift that auto-ranks candidates is a plausible candidate for this route — so if you suspect an algorithm decided your rejection, invoking the Article 22C safeguards forces the employer to confirm whether a human was actually involved. Cross-reference **Chapter 6.7** for the full mechanics and the special-category-data angle (a disability or neurodivergence that effectively caused a low score can bring **special-category data** into play, where the rules are stricter). `[INDEPENDENT — see Chapter 6.7]`

DSAR (Article 15). You can request your data: any **trait profile and fit/match score**, the **feedback PDF**, the **telemetry-derived indicators**, confirmation of **whether the decision was solely automated and whether a human reviewed it**, and the **retention position** (the vendor states a profile "remains valid" ~9–12 months, but exact retention is `[UNKNOWN]`). One month, free.

Adjustments as the front-line remedy. Because this instrument's unfairness is structural rather than surveillance-driven, the **Equality Act 2010 reasonable-adjustment route is your strongest lever, and it works best *before* you sit the test.** The vendor states it has a dedicated help-centre process and offers adjustments for neurodivergent/disabled candidates — naming ADHD, DCD/dyspraxia, dyslexia, and anxiety/depression — and that "often only small adjustments are needed." But the **exact adjustments (extra time? a modified or removed task? an alternative format?) are not specified publicly** — the help-centre body was 403-blocked — so you must ask, via the employer or Arctic Shores directly. `[VENDOR – help centre; GAP on specifics]`

Template — pre-assessment adjustment request:

> Subject: Reasonable adjustment request — [name], [role/ref] Dear [team], I've been invited to complete an Arctic Shores assessment for [role]. I have [ADHD / dyspraxia / dyslexia / an autism-spectrum condition / a motor or visual impairment / significant anxiety], which the [timed, speeded tasks / emotion-recognition task] disadvantage for reasons unrelated to the role. Under the Equality Act 2010 I request [additional time on speeded tasks / removal or substitution of the emotion-recognition task / an alternative assessment format]. I can provide documentation. Please confirm what can be arranged and by when, and confirm the deadline is paused meanwhile.

Template — post-rejection query / data + human review:

> Subject: Assessment outcome — request for review and data — [name], [ref] Dear [team], Thank you for the update. If my Arctic Shores result was assessed with any automated scoring or ranking, I request confirmation of whether the decision was solely automated and, under Articles 22A–22C UK GDPR (as amended by the Data (Use and Access) Act 2025), I wish to make representations and to obtain meaningful human intervention. Separately, under Article 15 I request my trait profile, fit/match score, feedback report, the telemetry-derived indicators, and your retention period for this data. Please respond within one month.

3.12 Step-by-step: how to win this assessment

1. **On receiving the invite — identify the generation.** Work out from the wording and any screenshots whether you're facing the **legacy Skyrise City** worlds or the **current task-based** product, so you calibrate your expectations (and discount older prep that describes the wrong one). `[§3.4]`
2. **T-minus a few days — decide on adjustments.** If you have a disability/neurodivergence affecting reaction time, motor control, processing speed, or emotion-reading, send the §3.11 request **now**, and ask for the deadline to be paused while it's arranged.
3. **Understand the role's competencies.** Note which natural behaviours the role rewards so you can lean into them honestly — not to fake, but to stop yourself second-guessing.
4. **Familiarise with the format.** Try analogues of BART, Flanker, Corsi and emotion-recognition once or twice to remove the novelty tax on the first rounds — then stop; over-drilling a behavioural test buys little.

5. **Fix your logistics.** Confirm the **recommended device**, a **stable connection**, and a **quiet, uninterrupted** room. Wrong hardware or a slow line can distort your reaction-time data.
6. **Pick your peak time.** Sit it when you are **rested and alert** — this is the biggest legitimate lever on a speed- and state-sensitive instrument.
7. **Read every instruction; do every practice.** Rules change between games and the design adapts — misreading a setup costs early rounds you can't recover.
8. **In-task decision rules.** Play **authentically and steadily**. Don't perform a "trait," don't slow down artificially, don't be deliberately erratic. Ignore your visible points/score — they don't feed your profile. Keep going after a stumble; there's no benefit to panicking.
9. **Numerical module (finance roles).** Treat the bolt-on **numerical test** as an ordinary numerical exam — this *is* conventionally scored, so brush up data-interpretation and work at a steady, accurate pace.
10. **Debrief and keep records.** Save your invitation and feedback PDF, note which games and world you got, and — if rejected and you suspect automated scoring — use the §3.11 templates. And remember the **volatility warning**: whichever firm used Arctic Shores this year may not next year, so re-verify against the live process (Chapter 6.8).

3.13 Sources for this chapter

All accessed 2026-08-01. Confidence tags as used above.

Vendor: - Arctic Shores — how it works (task-based design, calibration, interview guides) — https://www.arcticshores.com/how-it-works - Arctic Shores — /science (validity/reliability *claims*; "no adverse impact" claim; **no coefficients published**) — https://www.arcticshores.com/science - Arctic Shores — "ChatGPT has broken traditional aptitude assessments" (AI-resistance pitch) — https://www.arcticshores.com/insights/chatgpt-has-broken-traditional-aptitude-assessments-your-solution-to-future-proofing-recruitment - Arctic Shores — "world's first task-based assessment for Learning Agility" — https://www.arcticshores.com/insights/introducing-the-worlds-first-task-based-assessment-for-learning-agility - Arctic Shores — DataHub Security / compliance / EU AI Act readiness — https://www.arcticshores.com/datahub-security - Arctic Shores — neurodiversity / reasonable-adjustments framing — https://www.arcticshores.com/insights/neurodiversity-in-the-workplace - Eploy / SmartRecruiters marketplace integration pages (scale claims; ATS integration) — https://www.eploy.com/product/eploy-marketplace/arctic-shores/ ; https://marketplace.smartrecruiters.com/partners/arctic-shores

Independent (corporate / factual): - Crunchbase — founders / funding — https://www.crunchbase.com/person/robert-newry - Tracxn — HQ, headcount (~47, end-2024), funding history — https://tracxn.com/d/companies/arctic-shores/__Me3J7mTudtJAVgCYd6-IdFAN_7ZXZuKG42BaBM8CSu0 - TechRound — interview with CEO Robert Newry — https://techround.co.uk/interviews/interview-with-robert-newry-ceo-co-founder-at-arctic-shores/ - EU-Startups (2023) — £5.75M Series B — https://www.eu-startups.com/2023/01/manchester-based-startup-arctic-shores-lands-new-investment-to-enhance-workforce-diversity-and-quality/ - Prolific North — £5.75M Series B — https://www.prolificnorth.co.uk/news/arctic-shores-lands-ps575m-series-b-investment/ - *No independent peer-reviewed validation of Arctic Shores specifically was located; the general game-based-assessment literature (Landers, Auer; critiques of gamified selection) is the best external proxy.* `[GAP]`

Prep-vendor (mechanics; corroborate — commercially biased): - JobTestPrep — Arctic Shores assessment / per-game mechanics — https://www.jobtestprep.co.uk/arctic-shores-assessment - GraduatesFirst — Arctic Shores guide (paid simulations) — https://www.graduatesfirst.com/arctic-shores - Trading Interview — **Maven Securities** Arctic Shores (Round 2, after numerical) — https://www.tradinginterview.com/courses/companypreparations-course/lessons/maven-securities/topic/maven-securities-arctic-shores-assessment/ - Psychometric-success / PracticeAptitudeTests / Intervyo — employer lists, timings (stale, not year-stamped) - eFinancialCareers (2022) — "how to pass Arctic Shores" — **HTTP 405 this pass, cite title only** — https://www.efinancialcareers.com/news/2022/02/how-to-pass-arctic-shores-personality-and-aptitude-test `[GAP]`

Primary / Candidate: - Genuine legacy candidate report (Skyrise City; employer MThree; 5 Apr 2018; Newcastle University careers) — report structure, norming, banding, "game score not used," 9–12-month validity — https://www.ncl.ac.uk/media/wwwnclacuk/careersservice/files/articshoresreport-lexicameron-personality-myskyrisecity.pdf `[PRIMARY]` - National Autistic Society community thread — emotion-recognition task fairness — https://community.autism.org.uk/f/adults-on-the-autistic-spectrum/41075/is-this-legal `[CANDIDATE/COMMUNITY]` - Student Room threads (topic-confirming titles only; bodies HTTP-403): t=6241922, t=5765200, t=7642395, t=7628602, t=7558443/7645894 (Balance game), t=6913924 (PwC), t=6147532 (PwC Power Generator) `[CANDIDATE, n≈4–6]`

(Residual gaps — public validity/reliability coefficients (none exist), published adverse-impact statistics or any third-party bias audit, pricing/licensing model, exact cut-scores and norm-group composition, integrity-flag mechanics and how flags are actioned, the specific reasonable adjustments offered, the mechanics of the current "task-based" tasks (e.g. "Balance"), pause/disconnect behaviour, first-person testimony behind the 403-blocked forums, and per-year confirmation of which UK finance firms use it now — are logged in `research/03-arctic-shores.md` and the master gap register.)

Chapter 4 — Pymetrics

Confidence tags (full explanation in Chapter 1): `[VENDOR]` / `[INDEPENDENT]` / `[CANDIDATE, n=X]` / `[INFERRED]` / `[UNKNOWN]` / `[PREP-VENDOR]`.

At a glance — Pymetrics

What it is	A **game-based ("gamified") behavioural assessment** — you play a suite of **12 short neuroscience games** and the platform infers behavioural *traits* from how you play, then matches your profile to a role model. Now a **product line inside Harver** (which completed its acquisition of pymetrics on **11 August 2022**); the "pymetrics" brand persists candidate-facing. Founded **2013** by neuroscientist Frida Polli (with Julie Yoo).
Where in the funnel	**Very early screen** — typically after the online application, at or before the HireVue video and numerical tests, well before the assessment centre. In UK finance, **J.P. Morgan** is the anchor user.
Format & timing	**12 games**, ~**25–30 min**, **unproctored**, on web/iOS/Android. Pause allowed *between* games; you cannot restart a game mid-play.
Scoring model	**No pass/fail score.** Gameplay → ~90 behavioural traits (a subset modelled) → an **SVM** predictive model → a **fit percentile** against a *role model* → a **recommendation tier**. It is **match-to-a-role**, not "how well did you do."
Typical finance cut-off	`[UNKNOWN]` as a public number — internally, tiers are set at the **50th and 70th fit percentiles** (Do Not Recommend / Recommend / Highly Recommend), client-customisable. Not a population percentile — a *fit* percentile.
Integrity posture	**Unproctored and hard-to-fake by design** — no "correct" answers to look up; behavioural traces (reaction time, risk consistency, altruism) can't be Googled. No webcam/lockdown option surfaced. `[UNKNOWN]` on anomaly flags.
Retake	Generally **once every ~330 days**. Crucially, your results **carry across all pymetrics employers** in that window — you play the 12 games **once** and each firm re-scores your *same* traits against its *own* model.
Top 5 tips	1) Understand it's **fit, not performance** — there is no target to hit. 2) Read each game's instructions and don't waste early trials learning mechanics. 3) Be **consistent, not erratic**, especially on the risk games. 4) Don't try to fake a "trader" persona — you don't know the target and inconsistency hurts. 5) If you have a motor, visual, attention or colour-vision condition, **request the accommodation before you play** — the mis-match propagates for ~11 months.

(Every figure above is unpacked, sourced and confidence-tagged below. This is one of the earliest gates in the J.P. Morgan pipeline, and — because results follow you — one of the highest-leverage single sittings in UK finance recruiting.)

4.1 Snapshot

Pymetrics is the assessment most UK finance applicants mean when they say "I had to play those weird games." It is a **game-based (gamified) behavioural pre-employment assessment**: you play a suite of short, neuroscience-derived games, the platform captures **over a thousand behavioural data points** from how you play, and reduces them to a set of *traits* that a model then matches against a target profile for the role. `[VENDOR]` / `[PREP-VENDOR]` It was founded in **2013** by **Frida Polli**, a neuroscientist and former Harvard/MIT postdoc, with co-founder **Julie Yoo**. `[INDEPENDENT — Northeastern audit whitepaper]`

The single most important corporate fact is that "pymetrics" is no longer an independent company — it is now a product line inside Harver. Outmatch acquired Harver in May 2021, the combined company rebranded to **Harver** in late 2021, and **Harver then acquired pymetrics, with completion announced on 11 August 2022.** `[INDEPENDENT — PRNewswire/RecruitingDaily/HCM Technology Report, Aug 2022]` The deal price was **not disclosed** `[UNKNOWN]` (pre-acquisition pymetrics had raised over $56.6M `[INDEPENDENT]`). Inside Harver the tool is sold as **"pymetrics for Game-Based Assessments"** or the **"pymetrics Soft Skills Platform"**, and the most recent independent audit still names it internally as **"Harver's Soft Skills Platform"** — the same pymetrics engine. `[INDEPENDENT — BABL AI 2025 audit]` The practical point: the **"pymetrics" name is still used candidate-facing and in Harver marketing as of 2025**, so you meet it under its old name even though the company behind it changed. `[INFERRED from vendor pages carrying both names]`

For a finance candidate, pymetrics sits **very early in the funnel** — after your online application and at or before the HireVue video interview and numerical tests, well ahead of the assessment centre. `[PREP-VENDOR]` It is short (~25–30 minutes) but disproportionately consequential for a reason unique to this vendor: **your results follow you across every pymetrics-using employer for about 330 days** (§4.6). You are not sitting one firm's test; you are generating a behavioural profile that every pymetrics client re-scores for the next eleven months.

The single most important conceptual thing to understand about pymetrics is that there is no score to beat. The games are, in the vendor's own framing, "not meant to be won or lost." `[INDEPENDENT — audit §3.1]` There is no pass mark, no right answer, and no universally "good" profile. This chapter keeps that idea central, because almost every candidate mistake — and most of the prep industry's advice — comes from failing to internalise it.

4.2 Why this test exists

The problem pymetrics is sold to solve is **biased, low-signal early screening**. A bank running a graduate campaign receives far more applications than it can interview, and the traditional first filters — CV screens, "culture fit" chats — are slow and demonstrably prone to bias against non-traditional backgrounds. Pymetrics' pitch is that a **nonverbal, behaviour-based** assessment can screen at scale while *proactively removing* the adverse impact CV screens carry. `[VENDOR]`

The construct underneath is that the games are "derived from peer-reviewed psychological studies" and "purported to assess **intrinsic mental qualities** … not meant to be won or lost, but rather to surface information about players based on how they play." `[INDEPENDENT — audit whitepaper §3.1]` They measure a mix of **cognitive** traits (memory, attention, learning rate, processing speed, planning) and **emotional/social** traits (risk-taking under uncertainty, altruism, trust, fairness, emotion recognition, effort allocation). `[VENDOR]` / `[INDEPENDENT]` The vendor markets these as "soft skills." `[VENDOR — harver.com/gamified-assessments]`

Here the honesty has to be blunt. The public evidence that these games actually *predict job performance* is thin. Pymetrics claims ">90% accuracy in trait identification" and a "98% completion rate" `[VENDOR]` — but those are

engagement and measurement claims, not criterion validity against job performance. The one serious validation study, Baker (2019), *Games, Measures and Factors: Measurement Validity*, is **confidential**; the Northeastern auditors were shown it privately and explicitly "encourage pymetrics to make these results public." `[INDEPENDENT — audit §6.3]` The auditors were equally clear they themselves **did not** validate the games: "We did not investigate the ability of pymetrics' games to measure human capabilities, whether those capabilities map to job performance, or whether other assessment methods would be superior." `[INDEPENDENT — audit §4.2]` And model performance from the audited engagement was **modest** — AUC ~**0.70–0.72**, accuracy ~**0.69–0.72**. `[INDEPENDENT — audit Table 3]` So the famous "audit" (§4.10) validated the *fairness plumbing*, not the proposition that the games predict a good analyst. **Independent, peer-reviewed criterion validity for pymetrics is a genuine `[UNKNOWN]`** — carry that scepticism, but also the reassurance that no one, including the firm, can tell you a "right" way to play. (See Chapter 6.3 on validity generally.)

4.3 Why a firm chooses Pymetrics specifically

Two things sell pymetrics to a bank, and they are inseparable: **proactive de-biasing** and a **bespoke model built from the client's own top performers.**

The core pitch is compliance-led. "One of the core assertions pymetrics makes … is that they pro-actively de-bias ML models before deployment to comply with the U.S. Uniform Guidelines on Employee Selection Procedures (UGESP)." `[INDEPENDENT — audit Exec Summary]` The marketing wraps this in language a bank's DEI and legal functions want: "validated for fairness across gender, ethnicity, and socioeconomic status"; "nonverbal and intuitive, minimizing cultural and language bias"; "fit, not background." `[VENDOR]` For a firm that must defend every selection tool, a vendor that **commissions and publishes external bias audits** offers exactly that audit-defensible story (§4.10).

The bias-audit angle is simultaneously the selling point and the material that feeds the legal chapter — and the picture is genuinely mixed. Three data points, without smoothing:

- **The 2020 Northeastern cooperative audit (PASS).** A Northeastern team given pymetrics' actual source code found the **baseline** pipeline correctly implements the four-fifths rule, passing four of five findings cleanly with one caveat (§4.10). `[INDEPENDENT]`
- **The 2025 BABL AI LL144 audit (PASS).** An independent audit on 2024 data found **all impact ratios ≥ 0.80** across race/ethnicity and gender — a pass under NYC's bias-audit law. `[INDEPENDENT]`
- **The 2024 FAccT "Algorithmic Monocultures in Hiring" study (the honest counter).** Re-analysing >4 million applications *position-by-position* rather than aggregated, researchers found **10.62% of individual positions still adversely impacted Black applicants** per federal guidelines. `[INDEPENDENT — via Fortune, 2026-05-26]`

All three can be true at once (§4.10): **fairness-at-build (aggregate) is not the same as fairness-in-deployment-per-role.** Neither swallow the marketing nor dismiss the audits as theatre. And note the ceiling: **audited AUC is only ~0.70–0.72, and independent games-to-job-performance criterion validity is not public** `[UNKNOWN]` — the fairness is better documented than the predictiveness.

Finance usage. The anchor UK-finance user is **J.P. Morgan**, described across prep sources as "unique among big banks in mandating Pymetrics games for almost all junior roles." `[PREP-VENDOR — Lumovest, CareerTestPrep, HackingTheCaseInterview]` **BNP Paribas** is confirmed by a **2023 LL144 bias-audit posting** naming them on the pymetrics/Harver platform — a *dated primary* source, the strongest kind. `[INDEPENDENT]` Beyond those two, treat every "X uses pymetrics" claim with caution: prep-vendor rosters (which list HSBC, RBS/NatWest and others) are **marketing aggregations, often stale** — a firm listed as a user may have used it in 2019–2021 and quietly moved to a competitor (Arctic Shores, HireVue's games, SHL) after the 2022 Harver acquisition. `[PREP-VENDOR]` / `[INFERRED]` **Do not assume a firm currently uses pymetrics without a dated primary source.** (By contrast, **Goldman Sachs** historically used its *own* bespoke assessment plus HireVue, *not* pymetrics — not every bulge-bracket bank picks this tool. `[PREP-VENDOR]`)

4.4 What the assessment actually is — full mechanics

You play a **core set of twelve games** — the "pymetrics suite." `[INDEPENDENT – audit §3.1]` (Some clients bolt on an optional add-on suite of four numerical/logical-reasoning games introduced around 2020 `[INDEPENDENT – audit §3.1 footnote]`, and Harver separately cross-sells five *cognitive-ability* tests — Perceptual Speed, Verbal, Spatial, Logical, Mathematical Reasoning — but **those are Harver products, not the pymetrics neuroscience twelve** `[PREP-VENDOR]`; keep them distinct.) The whole thing runs **~25–30 minutes** (sources give a 20–35 min range; ~1–3 min per game), **unproctored**, on web, iOS or Android. `[VENDOR]` / `[INDEPENDENT]`

Burn this into memory before reading the game list: there is no pass/fail score. The games are "not meant to be won or lost"; the output is a **match/fit to a role model, not a raw score.** `[INDEPENDENT – audit §3.1]` Roughly **1,000+ behavioural data points** are collected — not self-report, but behavioural traces (how fast, how consistently, how much you risk, whether you adapt). `[VENDOR]` / `[PREP-VENDOR]` What follows is each game's mechanic, the trait it is used to infer, and the telemetry it captures.

#	Game	Mechanic	Trait(s) inferred	Telemetry captured
1	**Balloons (BART — Balloon Analogue Risk Task)**	Pump a balloon; each pump adds money to a temporary bank; bank it before it pops or lose that round. Pop thresholds vary.	**Risk tolerance, decision-making under uncertainty, learning**	Pumps per balloon, money banked vs lost, adaptation across trials, consistency/erraticness `[PREP-VENDOR]`
2	**Keypress**	Press a specified key (often spacebar) **as fast as possible** for a set duration.	Processing speed, **attention/focus, motor tempo** (some sources: drive)	Keypress rate, rhythm/ consistency `[PREP-VENDOR]`
3	**Digits (digit-span memory)**	A number sequence flashes; recall and type it back in order; sequences lengthen.	**Working memory**, attention span, learning	Max span reached, error rate by length `[PREP-VENDOR]`
4	**Arrows (Flanker / task-switching)**	Coloured arrows appear; the rule depends on colour (e.g. blue/ black → respond to the *centre* arrow; red → respond to the *side* arrows). Rules change, so you must switch.	**Task-switching, attention to detail, learning from mistakes, adaptability**	Accuracy, reaction time, error-recovery, cost of switching `[PREP-VENDOR]`
5	**Lengths**	Judge which face has the **longer/shorter mouth** (subtle perceptual differences); the rule can flip.	Attention to detail, **effort, adaptive learning**, perception	Accuracy on subtle differences, effort sustained, adaptation `[PREP-VENDOR]`

#	Game	Mechanic	Trait(s) inferred	Telemetry captured
6	**Cards (Iowa Gambling Task)**	Start with ~$2,000; draw from four decks with different reward/ penalty structures; maximise winnings.	**Reward sensitivity, risk under uncertainty, pattern recognition/learning, decision-making**	Shift toward advantageous decks over time (learning rate), risk profile `[PREP-VENDOR]`
7	**Tower (Tower of London)**	Rearrange coloured rings/discs to match a target configuration in the **minimum number of moves**.	**Planning, problem-solving**	Moves vs optimal, planning time before first move `[PREP-VENDOR]`
8	**Money Exchange #1 (Trust game)**	You get ~$10 and choose how much to send a partner; the sent amount is **tripled** on receipt; the partner may return some.	**Trust, risk tolerance, fairness, altruism**	Amount sent (trust), expectation of reciprocity `[PREP-VENDOR]`
9	**Money Exchange #2 (trust/reciprocity, second role)**	Both start ~$5; one randomly gets +$5; players decide how much to give/take over two rounds.	**Trust, altruism, fairness, generosity, decision-making**	Give/take amounts, reciprocity behaviour `[PREP-VENDOR]`
10	**Easy-or-Hard (effort/ motivation)**	Each round, choose a **low-reward/high-probability (easy)** task or a **high-reward/low-probability (hard)** task, sometimes with stated reward and odds.	**Effort allocation, motivation, risk tolerance, rational reward-maximising, resilience**	Hard/easy choice ratio vs stated odds, effort under varying incentive `[PREP-VENDOR]`
11	**Stop (Go/No-Go — response inhibition)**	Press only when a target shape/colour appears; withhold for others (which flash rapidly).	**Impulse control, attention, focus, reaction time**	Commission errors (pressing on no-go), omission errors, reaction time `[PREP-VENDOR]`
12	**Faces (emotion recognition)**	Identify the emotion in facial expressions; sometimes paired with a short context/story that may contradict the face.	**Emotion recognition, emotional intelligence, empathy**	Accuracy, use of context vs face `[PREP-VENDOR]`

Across all twelve, the telemetry themes are the same: reaction time, accuracy, risk-taking under uncertainty, learning rate, altruism/fairness, effort allocation, impulse control, planning depth, working-memory span — all behavioural, none self-reported. `[INFERRED from the above + INDEPENDENT audit]`

How many "traits" is contested, and it matters. Prep sources aimed at J.P. Morgan cite "**91 social, cognitive, and behavioral traits**"; earlier press said "**49**"; the audited SVM code actually used **64 features**, with the final fitted models keeping **44–45**. `[PREP-VENDOR]` / `[INDEPENDENT — FAccT §3.2]` The clean way to think about it: **"traits" is marketing language and "features" is model language** — the raw games emit roughly 60–90 candidate features, and a fitted model keeps ~44–56 of them. `[INFERRED]` Candidate-facing results, when shown at all, come back as **9 trait families**: Effort, Risk, Fairness, Emotion, Decision Making, Focus, Learning, Attention, Generosity. `[PREP-VENDOR — Lumovest JPM guide]`

Logistics. Available on web/iOS/Android, translated into several languages. `[INDEPENDENT]` A prep-vendor consensus is that a **PC is recommended over a phone**, and that you may **pause *between* games but cannot restart a game mid-play.** `[PREP-VENDOR — GraduatesFirst]` There are **built-in accommodations for colour-blindness and dyslexia** at the game level (§4.9). `[INDEPENDENT]` One data rule matters for anyone who gets interrupted: a player who misses **more than two games** is treated as incomplete and dropped from analysis, and missing individual feature values are **median-imputed.** `[INDEPENDENT — FAccT §3.2]` Official mid-game disconnect/reconnect behaviour is **not documented** `[UNKNOWN]`; the inference is that a mid-game disconnect voids that game's traits, which are then imputed. `[INFERRED]`

4.5 Is it tailored to the role?

Yes — and this is the differentiator that everything else hangs on. The 12 games and your raw traits are *constant*; what changes between firms is the **model you are matched against.** There are two kinds:

- A **custom (bespoke) model** is built from a *specific client's own incumbents* — the firm's current high performers in the target role, as judged by the firm's own performance metrics. The **in-group dataset typically contains 50–100 incumbent players.** `[INDEPENDENT — FAccT §3.2, direct]`
- A **core model** is a standardised, generic model used when a client lacks enough incumbents or wants a general-fit screen. `[PREP-VENDOR]` / `[INFERRED]`

The exact minimum-incumbent cut-off that separates "we can build you a custom model" from "you fall back to core," and the precise architecture of the core model, are **proprietary** `[UNKNOWN]` — the only cited floor is the ~50-player figure from the audit. Either way, **the 12 games are identical whether you are applying to a warehouse or a trading desk; only the benchmark differs.** `[PREP-VENDOR]` / `[INFERRED]`

The consequence is counter-intuitive: **the exact same trait profile can *match* firm A and *not match* firm B**, because different roles reward different trait combinations. "There is no universal 'good' profile — different roles require different trait combinations." `[PREP-VENDOR, consistent with the audit's role-specific in-group design]` A high risk-tolerance, fast, low-altruism profile might resemble one firm's sales-and-trading incumbents and be a poor match for another's operations or research desk. **This is why "faking the trader" is a losing strategy (§4.7): you don't know which traits your target firm's model weights, and no single profile wins everywhere.**

Customisation goes further than most candidates realise, which matters for the legal chapter. Pymetrics may "customize their model training and adverse impact assessment process for specific clients … even swapping out the four-fifths fairness metric for an entirely different fairness criteria." `[INDEPENDENT — audit §4.4 Limitations]` **The audited fairness guarantees apply to the *baseline* codebase, not to every bespoke variant.** Clients can also customise report *language* to their own "capability language" (one used a "Head, Heart, Hands" ethos). `[VENDOR]` And if no model can meet *both* the performance and fairness bars, the job analyst re-engages the client to refine the role or re-select incumbents; if it still can't be done, **no model is deployed at all.** `[INDEPENDENT — audit §3.3]`

4.6 How they screen and filter — scoring, norms, cut-offs, ranking

The pipeline is: **gameplay → traits/features → an SVM (support-vector-machine) predictive model → a percentile-based fit score → a recommendation tier.** `[INDEPENDENT — FAccT §3.2]`

The model is built from **three datasets** `[INDEPENDENT – FAccT §3.2]`:

- the **in-group** — the client's high-performing incumbents (typically 50–100 players);
- the **out-group** — a random sample from pymetrics' historical player database (600k+ players), used as a contrast that approximates the applicant pool;
- the **bias group** — players who volunteered demographic labels, **typically more than 10,000 users**, engineered to hold equal proportions of each EEOC protected group, and used **only** for adverse-impact testing, never as a training feature.

Your fit is expressed as a **fit percentile against the role model** and mapped to **three tiers**: **Highly Recommended / Recommended / Do Not Recommend** (some docs "Not Recommended"). `[INDEPENDENT – audit §3.3; BABL AI 2025]` The thresholds are typically **the 50th and 70th**: **≥70th = Highly Recommended, 50th–70th = Recommended, <50th = Do Not Recommend**, client-customisable. `[INDEPENDENT – FAccT §3.2, direct]` **The subtlety: this is *not* a classic norm-referenced percentile against the general population** — it is a **fit percentile against the role model**, i.e. how close you are to the target profile, not "you beat 70% of people." `[INFERRED from the tier construction + the audit's "fit percentile" language]`

What the recruiter sees: a recommendation tier plus a trait profile per candidate, on which they may apply further filters (e.g. a CV screen) before interview. The recruiter does **not** get a single number you could appeal. `[INDEPENDENT – audit §3, step 5]` **What you see:** very little — usually a **trait report/personality description across the 9 trait families**, with **no score** and **no indication of how you compare to the firm's target profile.** Some employers email a result; some show nothing. `[PREP-VENDOR – Lumovest, GraduatesFirst]`

Two candidate-facing facts dominate here. First, **retake:** you generally **cannot retake for ~330 days** ("once every 330 days"). `[PREP-VENDOR]` Second — the one most candidates miss — **your results follow you across employers.** You play the 12 games **once**, and **each pymetrics-using employer you apply to within the ~330-day window re-scores your *same* traits against its *own* model.** `[PREP-VENDOR – Lumovest, CareerTestPrep, stated repeatedly]` This cuts both ways: a profile you're unhappy with can't be re-attempted for about eleven months, **but** a profile that *fails* firm A may still *pass* firm B, because their models differ (§4.5). `[INFERRED]`

The funnel point (per the §5.6 brief). In a J.P. Morgan-style pipeline the pymetrics stage is an **early, broad screen** ahead of the HireVue and the assessment centre, designed to thin a large applicant pool. It is not usually the single tightest cut (the CV screen and final assessment centre remove large numbers too), but it is unusually **high-leverage** for one reason no other stage shares: **you sit it once and it gates every pymetrics firm for eleven months.** Treat it as the most consequential 30 minutes in your early pipeline. (Chapter 6.8 maps where each firm's real chokepoint sits.)

4.7 How to score well — legitimate, specific, actionable

Start from the truth that there is nothing to "score well" on. There are no right answers and no target you can see, so the legitimate goal is to **play authentically, cleanly and consistently** so that your genuine profile is measured accurately — then let the matching do what it does. `[PREP-VENDOR]` / `[INDEPENDENT]` Everything below serves *accurate measurement of the real you*, not "beating" the test.

Learn the formats in advance so you don't waste live trials figuring out mechanics. The single most concrete, legitimate edge is **format familiarity**: because several games *measure learning rate across trials*, spending your first few balloon-pumps or card-draws working out the rules can distort the very trait being measured. Read each game's instructions carefully, and know roughly what each of the twelve does (the table in §4.4) so you start "on trait" rather than confused. `[PREP-VENDOR – psychometric-success, JobTestPrep]`

Play when you are mentally fresh, with distractions removed and a stable connection. Morning, quiet room, PC over phone, notifications off. `[PREP-VENDOR – GraduatesFirst]` This is not superstition: reaction-time and attention games directly capture tiredness and interruption.

Be consistent, not erratic — especially on the risk games. This is the most useful specific nuance. Wildly inconsistent balloon-pumping or card-drawing produces a **noisy, hard-to-match profile**; measured, internally-consistent risk behaviour reads as a stable risk trait that a model can actually place. Aim for a coherent approach you hold across trials rather than swinging between reckless and timid. `[PREP-VENDOR]` / `[INFERRED]`

Do not try to fake a persona — the debunk matters. Because the model matches you to a role whose target profile you *cannot see*, deliberately playing "like a trader" can backfire: you don't know which traits that firm's model weights, and the inconsistency of acting a part *hurts* your signal. `[INFERRED from mechanics + §4.5]` Several games are **hard to fake convincingly** by design — the trust/altruism money games and reaction-time games resist gaming, and pymetrics' own auditors noted that faking a whole workforce would require "train[ing] human beings to play the games in very specific ways, or writ[ing] software to emulate a human." `[INDEPENDENT – audit §5.1 footnote]` The same logic defeats an individual candidate. **The winning move is to be a clean, consistent, well-rested version of your real self.**

On the prep-vendor simulations. JobTestPrep, GameAssessmentPrep, CogniPrep and others sell practice packs (from ~$59). Their genuine value is **format familiarity** — seeing the twelve games once so the live sitting isn't your first — **not** a route to "beat" the assessment, which their commercial incentive encourages them to imply exists. `[PREP-VENDOR – note commercial bias]` A free read of §4.4 delivers most of that value.

4.8 Integrity monitoring — what Pymetrics actually detects

Pymetrics' integrity posture is unusual and, for most candidates, **reassuringly light**. The assessment is **typically unproctored** — you play remotely, unsupervised, on your own device, and **no webcam or lockdown-browser option surfaced** in any vendor or independent source. `[INFERRED from remote web/mobile delivery + no proctoring mention anywhere]` (Whether any device/keystroke anomaly flag exists is a genuine `[UNKNOWN]`; the platform *does* capture fine-grained keypress timing on the keypress and stop games, which could in principle flag bot-like input, but there is no public confirmation it does.)

The reason it can afford to be unproctored is that it is **hard to fake by design** — and the vendor sells this as a virtue *over* proctoring:

- There are **no "correct" answers to look up** — behavioural traces like reaction time, risk consistency and altruism are not answerable from a search engine. `[INFERRED]` / `[VENDOR]`
- Its manipulation-resistance was formally tested from the *client* side: the Northeastern auditors "were unable to circumvent the fairness checks … by manipulating in group data," and concluded that faking a workforce would take trained humans or bots. `[INDEPENDENT – audit §5.1]`

There is **one candidate-side integrity weakness worth naming honestly**: the **Digits (memory) game** instructs you "do not write your answers down," but this is unenforceable on an unproctored assessment — a flaw one prep source calls "a major flaw … that compromises the integrity of the assessment." `[PREP-VENDOR – Lumovest]` Writing the digits down could inflate the **working-memory trait** — but note the caveat: that is **one trait among**

~90, with no reason to think it's weighted the way you'd hope in your target firm's model (§4.5). Inflating one trait toward an unknown target is as likely to *distort* your match as improve it. It is not worth doing, and it is dishonest.

4.9 How candidates commonly trip the system — including honestly

Because the assessment is unproctored and hard-to-fake by design, its **false-positive surface is small** — genuinely good news for anyone flagged by a proctored exam elsewhere who fears every assessment is a trap. There is no eye-tracking to misread you, no tab-logging to panic over, no facial analysis. The ways candidates come unstuck here are different and mostly *honest*:

- **Erratic play producing a noisy profile.** Not cheating — just inconsistency (§4.7). A candidate who swings wildly on the risk games generates a profile that matches nothing cleanly, and can be tiered out despite being a strong hire. `[INFERRED]`
- **Learning the mechanics on the clock.** Wasting the first trials of a learning-rate game working out the rules depresses the very trait being measured. Fixed by format familiarity (§4.4, §4.7). `[INFERRED]`
- **Motor / reaction-time differences.** Several games have **inherent speed and rapid-click demands**; a slower motor tempo — through age, injury, or a motor condition — can shift reaction-time traits away from a target profile. `[INDEPENDENT — MIT Technology Review, 2021-07-21]`
- **Colour-vision deficiency.** Games like **Arrows** and **Stop** use **colour-coded rules**; uncorrected colour-blindness can produce errors that read as poor attention or impulse control rather than a perceptual issue. `[INFERRED from mechanics]`
- **Flashing images and attention demands** can disadvantage candidates with visual-processing, attention or epilepsy-related conditions. `[INDEPENDENT — MIT Technology Review]`
- **A mid-game interruption or disconnect.** Miss more than two games and you're dropped as incomplete; a single dropped game is median-imputed, blurring your profile (§4.4). `[INDEPENDENT / INFERRED]`

These disability and difference risks are the real false-positive vector here — aggravated by the ~330-day carry: a well-qualified candidate with slow reaction time, ADHD or a colour-vision deficiency who does *not* request an accommodation could be mis-matched to "Do Not Recommend," and that **mis-match then propagates across every pymetrics firm for eleven months.** `[INFERRED]` That is why §4.10's central instruction is to request accommodations *before* you play.

The documented critique history (for context and your rights). The **2020 Northeastern audit** found the baseline pipeline fair-by-construction but explicitly did **not** validate that the games predict job performance (§4.2, §4.10). `[INDEPENDENT]` The **2024 FAccT "Algorithmic Monocultures" study** found that, deployed per-position across 156 employers, **10.62% of positions still adversely impacted Black applicants**, with **~25.87% of Black applicant submissions** going to positions with "discriminatory outcomes" per federal guidelines. `[INDEPENDENT — via Fortune]` **MIT Technology Review (2021)** documented the disability-access concerns above. `[INDEPENDENT]` None of this makes the tool uniquely dangerous — but it means the accommodation and data-rights routes (§4.10–4.11) are real and worth using.

4.10 How to be unambiguously clean

The good news is that "clean" here is easy, because there is little to police. The important moves are about **accurate measurement** and **pre-empting a mis-match**:

- **Request accommodations *before* you play** if you have a motor, visual, visual-processing, attention/neurodevelopmental (autism, ADD/ADHD, dyslexia, dyscalculia), or speech/language condition, or a colour-vision deficiency. Pymetrics offers, on candidate self-selection from a disability list before play: a **modified colour palette for colour-blindness**, and **more time on time-sensitive games plus an adjusted font** for the conditions above. `[VENDOR — Accessibility Accommodations PDF]` Crucially, **the employer is *not* told which candidates requested accommodations** — the selection is confidential. `[INDEPENDENT — MIT Tech Review]` / `[VENDOR]` This is the single most protective step a disadvantaged candidate can take, and because results carry ~330 days, it is worth getting right the first time.
- **Know the hard stops.** Pymetrics tells candidates to **stop and not play** if they have a visual impairment needing a braille display, or dominant-hand motor/mobility/coordination issues — in which case the **employer must offer an alternative selection process.** `[VENDOR]` For some conditions (e.g. cerebral palsy, MS, epilepsy, non-dominant-hand motor issues, mental-health conditions) the games are **not modified**, and you're directed to contact support after playing if you struggled — a weaker safeguard, so raise it proactively in writing.
- **Play the real you, consistently.** Don't write the digits down, don't try to act a persona, don't let anyone else play. Not because you'll be caught (you probably won't) but because a faked or inflated profile is more likely to *mis*-match than help (§4.7–4.8).
- **Sit it once, properly.** Fresh, quiet, PC, stable connection, notifications off — so a dropped game or an attention lapse doesn't blur your profile.

4.11 If you are flagged or rejected

Your full rights are in Chapter 6.7; the pymetrics-specific points follow. Because pymetrics rarely "flags" in the proctoring sense, the realistic scenario is a **"Do Not Recommend" tier or a silent rejection you suspect was driven by the games**, possibly reached with little human involvement.

Use the corrected UK automated-decision framework. The old shorthand of an "Article 22 prohibition" on solely-automated decisions is **out of date.** Under **Articles 22A–22C UK GDPR, as amended by the Data (Use and Access) Act 2025 (in force 5 February 2026)**, the regime is a *safeguards* model: where a decision about you is solely automated and has legal or similarly significant effects, you have the right to be **informed**, to **make representations**, to **obtain human intervention**, and to **contest** it. A pymetrics tier used to auto-reject with no human looking would sit squarely in that regime; a tier a recruiter genuinely reviews may not. Either way, invoking these rights forces the firm to confirm whether a human reviewed you. **Cross-reference Chapter 6.7 for the full mechanics.**

- **Ask for feedback and human review.** Email the recruiter; where the decision may have been solely automated, invoke the **Article 22C safeguards** — representations, human intervention, contest.
- **DSAR (Article 15).** Request your **trait profile**, any **derived fit scores / recommendation tier**, confirmation of **which model** (custom or core) was used and whether a **human reviewed** the outcome. One month, free.
- **Special-category / disability angle.** If a motor, visual, attention or speech difference effectively caused the mis-match, that can bring **special-category data** and the **Equality Act 2010** duty to make reasonable

adjustments into play — a stronger argument, and grounds to ask that you be re-assessed by an alternative method (§4.10).

- **The carry-forward point.** Because your result propagates for ~330 days, a mis-match is worth challenging *promptly* — both to correct this application and to avoid the same profile gating you elsewhere.

Template — pre-assessment adjustment / accommodation request:

> Subject: Reasonable adjustment request — [name], [role/ref] Dear [team], I've been invited to complete the pymetrics game-based assessment for [role]. I have [a motor / visual / visual-processing / attention / neurodevelopmental / speech-language condition / colour-vision deficiency], which the timed, reaction-based games disadvantage. Under the Equality Act 2010 I request [the built-in accommodated version (extra time / modified colour palette / adjusted font) / an alternative selection method if the games cannot be adjusted for my condition]. I can provide documentation. Please confirm what can be arranged, that my accommodation will remain confidential from the hiring team, and the deadline.

Template — post-rejection query / data + human review:

> Subject: Assessment outcome — request for review and data — [name], [ref] Dear [team], Thank you for the update. If my pymetrics result contributed to this decision, I request confirmation of whether a human reviewed the outcome and — under Articles 22A–22C UK GDPR (as amended by the Data (Use and Access) Act 2025) — I wish to make representations and obtain human intervention. Separately, under Article 15 I request my trait profile, any fit score or recommendation tier, and confirmation of which model was applied. Please respond within one month.

4.12 Step-by-step: how to win this assessment

1. **Reframe first.** Internalise that there is **no score and no target** — your job is to be measured *accurately*, consistently and cleanly, not to hit a profile you can't see. Half of all candidate mistakes die here.
2. **T-minus a few days — learn the twelve formats.** Read §4.4 so you know what each game measures. The goal is to start *on trait*, not to spend live trials learning the rules — which matters because several games measure *learning rate*.
3. **Sort accommodations now, not later.** If you have any motor, visual, visual-processing, attention, neurodevelopmental, speech, or colour-vision condition, self-select the accommodated version or send the §4.11 request **before you play**. It's confidential from the employer, and — because results carry ~330 days — you want it right first time.
4. **Set up for accurate measurement.** PC over phone, quiet room, stable connection, notifications off, at your sharpest time of day. A dropped game or an attention lapse blurs your profile.
5. **Play consistently — especially the risk games.** Pick a coherent approach to the balloons and cards and hold it; erratic play produces a noisy, hard-to-match profile.
6. **Do not fake a persona.** You can't see the target, faking introduces inconsistency that hurts, and the trust and reaction-time games resist gaming. Be a clean, rested version of your real self.
7. **Play it as one continuous, honest sitting.** Don't write the digits down, don't let anyone else play, don't restart games — a distorted profile mis-matches more often than it helps.

8. **Remember it follows you.** You're setting the profile every pymetrics employer re-scores for ~330 days. That's the reason to sit it at your best.
9. **If tiered out or silently rejected, act promptly.** Send the §4.11 human-review and DSAR requests; raise any disability/adjustment angle under the Equality Act and Articles 22A–22C, before the mis-match gates you elsewhere.
10. **Debrief.** Note which firm, whether you got a result back, and (if you can tell) whether it felt custom or core — useful next time a pymetrics firm appears within the window.

4.13 Sources for this chapter

All accessed 2026-08-01. Confidence tags as used above.

Independent: - Wilson, Mislove, Ghosh, Jiang — "Auditing the pymetrics Model Generation Process" (Northeastern whitepaper); the authoritative source on mechanics, de-biasing, in/out/bias groups, safeguards, five findings, and scope limits — https://cbw.sh/static/audit/pymetrics/pymetrics_audit_result_whitepaper.pdf - FAccT '21 — "Building and Auditing Fair Algorithms: A Case Study in Candidate Screening" (SVM, 50–100 in-group, 64 features, 50/70 percentile tiers, IR≥0.8, AUC ~0.70–0.72) — https://www.ccs.neu.edu/home/amislove/publications/Pymetrics-FAccT.pdf - BABL AI (2025) — LL144 Bias Audit of Harver's Soft Skills Platform (2024 impact-ratio tables, PASS, scope exclusions) — https://harver.com/wp-content/uploads/2025/11/pymetrics-Soft-Skills-Platform-2025-Bias-Audit.pdf - "Algorithmic Monocultures in Hiring" (FAccT 2024), via Fortune (2026-05-26) — per-position adverse-impact critique and the 10.62% / 25.87% / 14.74% figures — https://fortune.com/2026/05/26/ai-hiring-algorithm-racial-disparities-pymetrics-stanford-study/ - MIT Technology Review (2021-07-21) — disability rights and AI hiring — https://www.technologyreview.com/2021/07/21/1029860/disability-rights-employment-discrimination-ai-hiring/ - Harver acquisition press (PRNewswire) — 11 Aug 2022 completion — https://www.prnewswire.com/news-releases/harver-acquires-pymetrics-further-enhancing-talent-decision-capabilities-across-the-employee-lifecycle-301603823.html - ACLU LL144 audit tracker — https://github.com/aclu-national/tracking-ll144-bias-audits

Vendor: - Harver — "Harver acquires pymetrics" (branding, distinct identity) — https://harver.com/harver-acquires-pymetrics/ - Harver — gamified assessments product page (soft-skills framing, 25-min duration, client names) — https://harver.com/gamified-assessments/ - pymetrics — Accessibility Accommodations PDF (accommodation list, hard stops, confidentiality) — https://s3.amazonaws.com/pymetrics-public-content-production/pdf/accessibility-accommodations.pdf - audit-AI (open-source four-fifths bias-testing library) — https://github.com/pymetrics/audit-ai

Prep-vendor (mechanics/logistics/UK-finance stage; corroborate — commercially biased): - GraduatesFirst — pymetrics practice games (12-game logistics, PC-over-phone, 330-day retake, UK client lists) — https://www.graduatesfirst.com/pymetrics-practice-games-digital-video-interviews - JobTestPrep — Harver/pymetrics assessment pack — https://www.jobtestprep.com/harver-assessment - psychometric-success — pymetrics test types — https://psychometric-success.com/aptitude-tests/test-types/pymetrics - Lumovest — J.P. Morgan pymetrics guide (9 trait families, results-follow-you, digits-game flaw) — https://www.lumovest.com/library/careers/jp-morgan-pymetrics/

Candidate (testimony; treated cautiously — see gap note). Wall Street Oasis ("Pymetrics… What the fuck??") and The Student Room threads (AstraZeneca pymetrics t=6265898; GSK/AZ apprenticeship t=7179651) returned **HTTP 403** to the fetcher on the access date, so no verbatim quotes or commenter counts could be extracted;

sentiment above is via search-snippet summaries only, and `[CANDIDATE, n=X]` counts are therefore **unavailable**. `[CANDIDATE]`

(Residual gaps — undisclosed acquisition price; no public peer-reviewed criterion-validity study (Baker 2019 confidential); exact custom-vs-core incumbent cut-off and core-model architecture (proprietary); mid-game disconnect policy; whether any anti-cheat/anomaly flags exist; the current 2026 live UK-finance client roster beyond JPM and BNP Paribas; and post-2022 codebase changes since the 2020 audit — are logged in research/04-pymetrics.md and the master gap register.)

Chapter 5 — Cappfinity

Confidence tags used throughout (full explanation in Chapter 1): `[VENDOR]` *vendor's own claim;* `[INDEPENDENT]` *peer-reviewed/independent;* `[CANDIDATE, n=X]` *candidate testimony with count;* `[INFERRED]` *my reasoning, shown;* `[UNKNOWN]` *not public;* `[PREP-VENDOR]` *commercial practice-seller, corroborate.*

At a glance — Cappfinity

What it is	UK-founded **strengths-based** assessment specialist (formerly "Capp"). Pioneer of the UK graduate strengths movement. Core product you'll meet: the **Situational Strengths Test (SST)**, usually wrapped in a blended "immersive" online assessment with embedded numerical/verbal items and sometimes video.
Where in the funnel	Online sift stage: after the application form, before the job-simulation / assessment-centre stage.
Format & timing	Bespoke per employer. Blended immersive builds run **~60–90 min** in one sitting; e.g. HSBC ~38 items (16 cognitive + 22 SJT/values), Linklaters 6 modules / 70–90 min. Often *no hard clock*, but **time-per-item is scored**.
Scoring model	Composite: **strengths fit + aptitude accuracy + response speed + consistency**, benchmarked against a firm-specific framework and ranked vs other applicants. The SST *is* criterion-keyed despite "no right answer" marketing.
Typical finance cut-off	`[UNKNOWN]` — undisclosed; functions as a threshold sift you can fail.
Integrity posture	**Largely unproctored.** Soft anti-cheat only: response-time capture, consistency checks. No webcam/lockdown documented for the sift.
Retake	`[UNKNOWN]` — no documented rule; candidates report reapplying across cycles rather than instant retakes.
Top 5 tips	1) Read the firm's published **values/strengths framework** first — it's the key. 2) On SST, answer *both* dimensions when asked (effectiveness **and** enjoyment/energy). 3) Lead ranks with initiative/opportunity-framing; bottom-rank avoidance/uncertainty. 4) Answer strengths **authentically but decisively** — don't cluster or dither; speed is scored. 5) Practise the embedded numerical/verbal separately.

(Every figure above is unpacked, sourced and confidence-tagged below. Cappfinity is one of the most finance-relevant providers in this guide — heavily used across the Big Four and graduate banking.)

5.1 Snapshot

Cappfinity is a UK-founded assessment company built around a single big idea — **strengths** — and for a UK finance or professional-services applicant it is one of the names you are most likely to meet at the online stage. It was founded in **2005** by the positive-psychology researchers **Dr Alex Linley** and **Nicky Garcea**, trading as Capp & Co. Limited, and it effectively created the UK "strengths-based recruitment" category that Big Four firms and graduate banks adopted through the 2010s. `[INDEPENDENT – corporate history corroborated across multiple sources]` In December 2018 it acquired the Seattle predictive-hiring firm **Koru** (bringing the Koru7 "Impact Skills" model and a machine-learning platform), and around 2019–2020 it rebranded **Capp → Cappfinity** (US first, UK-wide by roughly November 2020). `[INDEPENDENT – PRNewswire; PREP-VENDOR on the exact UK rebrand date]`

The product you actually sit is usually a **bespoke blended online assessment**, custom-built for the employer, combining the **Situational Strengths Test (SST)** with embedded numerical and verbal reasoning, sometimes a job simulation or a short video (product name *Snapshot*), and mapped onto that firm's own strengths or values framework. It sits at the **online sift** — after your application form, before the job-simulation or assessment-centre stage — and runs roughly **60–90 minutes**. Its sift severity is real (candidates do fail it), but the exact threshold is undisclosed. `[PREP-VENDOR + VENDOR case study]`

5.2 Why this test exists

Strengths-based assessment exists to answer a question that a competency test does not. A competency or aptitude test asks whether you *can* do something. A strengths assessment claims to measure **what energises you and where you naturally perform at your best** — the theory being that people deployed to their strengths perform better *and* stay engaged longer, which for a graduate scheme with expensive attrition is worth as much as raw ability. `[PREP-VENDOR – close paraphrase of vendor marketing]` Cappfinity markets around **80 behavioural skills** expressed in a "shared language," each claimed to be benchmarked against workplace performance. `[VENDOR]`

There is also an explicit diversity argument, which is central to why banks and Big Four firms bought it. The pitch is that strengths-based, "bias-free algorithmic" assessment lets a firm **look past grades, degree subject and institution** and recruit for potential — widening the funnel beyond the traditional target universities. `[VENDOR – Linklaters case study framing]` Whether it delivers that is contested and unproven by any independent audit (§5.10).

The honest evidence picture is important, because the SST belongs to the **situational judgement test (SJT)** family, and the independent research on SJTs is sobering. Meta-analytic work finds SJTs add only **small incremental validity** over cognitive-ability and personality measures — roughly **$\Delta R \approx$ 0.03–0.08** — and, crucially, SJT items are **often transparent and coachable**: candidates can frequently identify the answer the employer wants, and coaching measurably lifts scores, especially on knowledge-based ("what is *most effective*") formats. `[INDEPENDENT – SJT review literature]` No independent, peer-reviewed validation of Cappfinity's *specific* strengths instruments could be located; the validity claims are vendor-sourced. `[UNKNOWN – see gap register]` The practical implication for you is optimistic: because these instruments are coachable, understanding the target framework (which is public) is legitimate, high-leverage preparation.

5.3 Why a firm chooses Cappfinity specifically

Cappfinity's differentiation is the **strengths signature** a plain SJT lacks: instead of only asking which response is most effective, it asks what you would most *enjoy* or be drawn to first — rating responses on **effectiveness and on energy/enjoyment simultaneously**. `[PREP-VENDOR]` Around that it wraps three things employers value: a **realistic job preview** (immersive "step into the role" content that doubles as employer branding), a **blended single-sitting assessment** that folds SJT, aptitude, simulation and video into one candidate experience, and deep **UK graduate-market penetration** — it is embedded across the Big Four and much of graduate banking. `[PREP-VENDOR consensus + VENDOR case study]` The DEI positioning (§5.2) and a shorter, more engaging candidate journey (Linklaters reported cutting hours off average completion time) complete the sales case. `[VENDOR case study]`

Named UK finance-relevant clients recur across sources — **EY, KPMG, Deloitte, HSBC, Barclays, Lloyds Banking Group, Standard Chartered, Aviva, M&G, Grant Thornton, BDO, RSM, Mazars, Linklaters** — but these lists are prep-vendor-aggregated and largely undated, contracts churn, and several firms run **multiple vendors** (KPMG pairs Cappfinity with Arctic Shores). `[PREP-VENDOR — treat client list as volatile; HSBC and the Big Four are the best-corroborated, specific bank usage weaker]` Re-verify per cycle (§6.8).

5.4 What the assessment actually is — full mechanics

The Situational Strengths Test (SST) — the flagship

You are shown a **short workplace scenario** and a set of possible responses, and asked to evaluate them. Two response paradigms appear across sources, and which you meet is **firm/version-dependent**:

1. **Rank the responses** from most to least likely/effective, with a **forced-distinct constraint** — you cannot give two responses the same rank. `[PREP-VENDOR]`
2. **Rate each response on effectiveness *and* on enjoyment/energy** — the "strengths signature," asking what you would most and least enjoy doing. `[PREP-VENDOR]`

The item count is **not fixed** — it varies by the bespoke build. `[UNKNOWN as a universal number]` Cappfinity and prep vendors insist there is "no right or wrong answer," but worked examples reveal a **keyed, more-effective response** mapped to the target strengths (e.g. a response framing a challenge as an opportunity scores strongest; expressing uncertainty scores weakest). Functionally, therefore, **the SST is criterion-keyed**, unlike a pure personality questionnaire — which is exactly why preparation helps. `[PREP-VENDOR — "how to pass" worked examples]`

Embedded aptitude (Capp) tests

- **Numerical reasoning:** roughly **12–15 questions** from graphs, tables and charts; multiple-choice and ranked formats; calculator and paper generally permitted. `[PREP-VENDOR]`
- **Verbal reasoning:** roughly **8–15 questions** — matching, gap-fill, ranking statements, true/false, sometimes spelling/grammar. `[PREP-VENDOR]`
- **Critical reasoning:** short passage plus conclusions to judge as logically following or not; often untimed. `[PREP-VENDOR]`

Immersive / blended products

The wrapper products you may see named: **Capptivate** (behavioural + cognitive immersive — the basis of the Linklaters build), **Tempo** (mobile pre-interview), **Altitude** (high-potential/executive), and **Snapshot** (async video and/or written responses). `[VENDOR/PREP-VENDOR]`

Timing, device, adaptivity

Immersive builds run **~60–90 minutes** in one sitting and cannot be paused. Many components have **no hard overall time limit — but the time you take per question feeds your score** (a speed–accuracy composite ranked against other applicants). Delivery works on laptop and mobile. **Adaptivity is disputed**: one prep vendor claims the difficulty adapts to performance, another explicitly says it does not — so treat "adaptive" claims with caution; the SST is likely *not* fully adaptive. `[PREP-VENDOR – conflicting; UNKNOWN]`

A concrete build — HSBC Online Immersive Assessment (Cappfinity-built)

One prep source describes the HSBC build as **~38 questions — 16 cognitive (numerical + verbal) and 22 situational-judgement/personality items keyed to HSBC's Core Values** (Dependable; Open to different ideas and cultures; Connected). It is stage two, after the application form; passing leads to a job-simulation stage. `[PREP-VENDOR – treat item counts as approximate]` The EY build ("EY One") similarly blends strengths, cognitive ability, SJT and values fit against EY's published strengths list. `[PREP-VENDOR]`

5.5 Is it tailored to the role?

Yes — heavily, and more so than most providers in this guide. SST scenarios and strengths profiles are **custom-written per firm** against that firm's own competency, strength or values framework — HSBC's Core Values, EY's strengths list, Linklaters' "agile mindset framework." `[PREP-VENDOR consensus + VENDOR case study]` The Linklaters build, for example, is six bespoke modules producing a personalised feedback report. The practical consequence is the sharpest in the whole guide: **the "right" answer to an SST scenario is literally defined by the specific firm's framework**, so the single highest-value preparation step is reading that firm's published values and strengths before you sit. Whether Cappfinity runs a bespoke **criterion-validation** study against each firm's own performance data is unclear — the vendor claims skills are "benchmarked against workplace performance over multiple years," but no per-employer validation study could be located. `[UNKNOWN]`

5.6 How they screen and filter — scoring, norms, cut-offs, ranking

The output is a **blended composite**: strengths fit, aptitude accuracy, per-question speed, and cross-response consistency, benchmarked against the firm's framework and **ranked relative to other applicants**. `[PREP-VENDOR]` This mixes two logics: **criterion keying** (the SST measured against the firm's strengths model) and **peer-norm ranking** (aptitude and timing against the applicant pool). `[INFERRED]`

It functions as a **sift with a threshold** — candidates can and do fail — but whether a given firm applies a hard cut-off or a top-N rank is employer-configurable and undisclosed. `[INFERRED; UNKNOWN on the exact number]` Because it is usually a **multi-hurdle** design (pass the online immersive → job simulation → interview/assessment centre), a strong aptitude score does not automatically rescue a weak strengths profile: the strengths and cognitive components each contribute, and an over-weighted SST can decide the outcome.

The **recruiter sees** an algorithmic score/profile; at some firms (e.g. Linklaters) the **candidate receives a personalised feedback report** noting strengths and one development area — unusually generous, and worth reading if you get one. The **retake policy is undocumented**; indirect candidate testimony references people failing "the Capp assessment" more than once across application cycles rather than any instant re-sit. `[UNKNOWN; CANDIDATE, n≈2 indirect]`

The funnel point (per your §5.6 brief): at strengths-based firms the online immersive is a genuine gate, but it is rarely the tightest one — for the Big Four the later job-simulation and the final assessment centre typically cut harder, and the CV/eligibility screen removes many before this stage. Spend proportionate effort here, then weight toward the AC. See §6.8.

5.7 How to score well — legitimate, specific, actionable

The master move is research the firm's framework. Because the SST is keyed to a *named, published* set of strengths or values, reading them beforehand tells you which response themes the firm rewards. This is legitimate preparation, not gaming — the instrument is transparent by design.

On the SST itself: identify the response themes and, when ranking, **lead with responses that show initiative, opportunity-framing and integrity, and bottom-rank those showing avoidance, blame-shifting or uncertainty.** Respect the **forced-distinct-rank** constraint (you cannot tie two options). Watch the provider-specific trap: when an item asks you to rate on **both** effectiveness **and** enjoyment/energy, answering only the effectiveness dimension leaves half the signal on the table. `[PREP-VENDOR]`

On the strengths items: answer with **authenticity but decisiveness.** Strengths items measure energy and preference; over-second-guessing and mid-point clustering flatten your profile and, because **response speed is scored**, dithering costs you directly. Research the strengths the role genuinely rewards so your real strengths are surfaced — do not fabricate a profile you cannot sustain at interview.

On the embedded aptitude: practise numerical (graph/table interpretation under time), verbal and critical reasoning separately — and remember that "untimed" sections still score your speed.

Set-up: distraction-free, one sitting, recommended device/browser, and treat the immersive/job-preview content like a real work simulation — triage, prioritise, communicate clearly.

Worked example (SST ranking). Scenario: a teammate misses a deadline that affects your shared deliverable the day before a client meeting. *Weak response set*: top-ranks "escalate to your manager immediately" and "wait to see if they fix it themselves." *Strong response set*: top-ranks "speak to the teammate directly to understand and agree a fix, then flag to the manager if the client timeline is genuinely at risk," bottom-ranks "say nothing" and "publicly blame the teammate." The difference is not cleverness — it is recognising that the firm's framework rewards **ownership + constructive communication** over both passivity and reflexive escalation.

5.8 Integrity monitoring — what Cappfinity actually detects

Cappfinity's sift is, on the available evidence, **largely unproctored**. No source describes webcam proctoring, ID checks or a lockdown browser for the standard SST/strengths/immersive online stage. `[INFERRED from consistent absence across vendor and prep-vendor pages; UNKNOWN as an explicit vendor statement]` The anti-cheat that exists is **soft and embedded**: **response-time capture**, **consistency checks** across responses, and the speed–accuracy scoring itself, which makes erratic or impossibly-fast responding visible. The video component (*Snapshot*) is **asynchronous recorded**, not live-proctored. `[PREP-VENDOR]` No honesty declaration or assessment-centre re-verification process was documented. `[UNKNOWN]`

What this means practically: the integrity risk profile here is **low** compared with SHL's verification model or a webcam-proctored HireVue. The main "integrity" pressure is indirect — the consistency checks penalise strategic, inconsistent answering, which is another reason to answer authentically.

5.9 How candidates commonly trip the system — including honestly

Because it is largely unproctored, the classic false-positive catalogue (webcam/gaze/second-face flags) mostly **does not apply** here — a genuine relief if you have previously been flagged on proctored tests. The risks that remain are subtler:

- **Inconsistent/strategic answering** trips the consistency checks — trying to project a fabricated "ideal" strengths profile you cannot hold consistently across many items reads as noise and can weaken your result. `[INFERRED from the consistency-check design]`
- **Over-caution and dithering** hurt you because **speed is scored** — a genuinely strong-fit but slow, deliberate candidate can under-score. `[INFERRED]`
- **Coachability cuts both ways:** the same transparency that lets you prepare legitimately means well-prepped candidates who reverse-engineer the framework can score above their true fit — so the bar you're clearing is a prepared one. `[INDEPENDENT]`
- **Reading only one rating dimension** on dual-rating SST items (effectiveness vs enjoyment) is the commonest honest mistake. `[PREP-VENDOR]`

There is no documented evidence of demographic false-positive issues specific to Cappfinity (unlike face-detection systems), because there is no webcam layer to produce them — though the general adverse-impact caution about any algorithmic scoring applies (§5.10, §6.6).

5.10 How to be unambiguously clean

The proctoring surface is small, so the checklist is short:

- **Sit it in one uninterrupted sitting**, distraction-free, on the recommended device/browser with a stable connection — a mid-test disconnection on a timed-per-item scoring model can cost you.
- **Answer authentically and consistently** — the only "integrity" signal is internal consistency, so your best clean strategy is your genuine, framework-informed self.
- **Request adjustments in writing in advance** if you have a condition affecting reading speed or processing (the speed-scored design can disadvantage you otherwise) — route via the employer's recruitment team, citing the Equality Act 2010 (template in §5.11). Cappfinity's own accessibility/WCAG position was not publicly documented `[UNKNOWN]`, which is itself a reason to make the request explicit and early.

5.11 If you are flagged or rejected

Because the stage is unproctored, a rejection here is almost always a **score/fit outcome**, not an integrity flag — so the route is a feedback query and, if you want the underlying data, a DSAR. Your rights are the UK ones set out in full in Chapter 6.7.

- **Ask for feedback.** Some Cappfinity builds return a personalised report; if you didn't get one, ask the recruiter whether feedback is available and whether reapplication in a future cycle is possible.

- **DSAR (UK GDPR Article 15)** to the **employer** (the data controller): request your **scores/profile**, the **framework/norm** you were assessed against, and the **logic of any automated decision** (Articles 22A–22C, as amended by the Data (Use and Access) Act 2025 — see Chapter 6.7). One-month response window, free.
- **Adjustments (Equality Act 2010):** if a condition affected you and no adjustment was in place, this is the strongest basis for requesting a re-sit or reconsideration.

Template — pre-assessment adjustments request:

> Subject: Reasonable adjustment request — [name], [role/ref] Dear [team], I've been invited to complete Cappfinity's online assessment for [role]. I have [condition, e.g. dyslexia/ADHD] which affects [reading speed/processing under time pressure]. As the assessment scores response time, under the Equality Act 2010 I request reasonable adjustments — [e.g. additional time / an untimed version where available]. I can provide documentation. Please confirm what can be arranged and the revised deadline.

Template — post-rejection feedback / DSAR:

> Subject: Assessment outcome — feedback and data request — [name], [ref] Dear [team], Thank you for the update. Could you share any feedback on my Cappfinity assessment and whether reapplication is possible next cycle? Separately, under Article 15 UK GDPR I request the personal data held about my assessment — my scores/strengths profile, the framework I was assessed against, and the logic of any automated decision (Articles 22A–22C UK GDPR, as amended by the Data (Use and Access) Act 2025). Please respond within one month.

5.12 Step-by-step: how to win this assessment

1. **T-minus 10 days — get the framework.** Find and print the firm's published **values/strengths** (HSBC Core Values, EY strengths, etc.). This is your single most valuable asset. Map two or three genuine examples from your own experience onto each.
2. **T-9 to T-4 — drill the components.** Daily: a set of SJT/SST practice items (focus on the ranking logic and the dual-rating format) plus timed numerical and verbal. Keep an error log noting *why* you misjudged an SST item — usually because you read effectiveness but not enjoyment, or missed the framework theme.
3. **T-7 — logistics.** If you need adjustments, send the §5.11 request now (the speed-scored design makes this matter). Confirm the device and that you'll have an uninterrupted 90-minute window.
4. **T-2 — simulate.** One full timed run on your real device at your sharpest time of day; check the connection and browser.
5. **Day before.** Re-read the firm's framework. Charge the laptop, clear the desk, protect a 90-minute block, sleep.
6. **30 minutes before.** Close everything, silence notifications, water. Re-read the instructions — note whether ranking is forced-distinct and whether items are dual-rated.
7. **In-test decision rules.** Answer **decisively** (speed is scored — don't dither). On SST, apply the framework: initiative/ownership/constructive-communication to the top, avoidance/blame to the bottom. On strengths items, be authentic and avoid mid-point clustering. On aptitude, pace steadily and don't leave items blank.
8. **Rolling-deadline note.** Most UK finance/professional-services schemes sift on a rolling basis — **apply and sit early**; a solid score in October beats a marginally better one in January into a shrinking pool (§6.8).

9. **Debrief.** Note the actual format (dual-rated or ranked, item counts, whether video appeared) for next time, and whether a feedback report is coming.

5.13 Sources for this chapter

All accessed 2026-08-01. Confidence tags as used above.

Independent: - PRNewswire — *Capp & Co acquires Koru predictive hiring* (corporate history, Koru7 skills) — https://www.prnewswire.com/news-releases/capp--co-acquires-koru-predictive-hiring-300769348.html `[INDEPENDENT]` - PRNewswire — *Cappfinity disrupts US recruitment market* (rebrand era) — https://www.prnewswire.com/news-releases/cappfinity-disrupts-us-recruitment-market-with-game-changing-approach-to-candidate-assessment-300952666.html `[INDEPENDENT]` - Recruiter.co.uk — Cappfinity/Linklaters partnership — https://www.recruiter.co.uk/news/2020/01/cappfinity-partners-linklaters-streamline-recruitment `[INDEPENDENT]` - NCBI/PMC — evidence-based appraisal of situational judgement tests — https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC11024836/ `[INDEPENDENT]`

Vendor: - Cappfinity — Skills & Strengths Assessment — https://cappfinity.com/solutions/for-talent-leaders/assessments/skills-strengths-assessment/ `[VENDOR]` - Cappfinity — Linklaters case study — https://cappfinity.com/linklaters-cuts-application-time-for-candidates-with-new-assessment-platform/ `[VENDOR]`

Prep-vendor (format detail; corroborate — commercially biased): - GraduatesFirst — Cappfinity — https://www.graduatesfirst.com/aptitude-tests-publishers/cappfinity - PracticeAptitudeTests — Cappfinity hub & "how to pass an SST" — https://www.practiceaptitudetests.com/testing-publishers/cappfinity/ ; …/resources/how-to-pass-a-cappfinity-situational-strengths-test/ - Intervyo — Cappfinity immersive guide — https://www.intervyo.co.uk/assessments/cappfinity - PracticeAptitudeTests — HSBC assessments — https://www.practiceaptitudetests.com/top-employer-profiles/hsbc-assessments/

(Residual gaps — no independent validation of Cappfinity's own instruments; no fixed SST item count; adaptivity disputed; retake policy, GDPR/WCAG specifics undocumented; thin first-person candidate testimony (TSR threads bot-blocked); "bias-free algorithm" unverified — are logged in research/05-cappfinity.md and the master gap register.)

Chapter 6 — Amberjack

Confidence tags used throughout (full explanation in Chapter 1): `[VENDOR]` vendor's own claim; `[INDEPENDENT]` peer-reviewed/independent; `[CANDIDATE, n=X]` candidate testimony with count; `[INFERRED]` my reasoning, shown; `[UNKNOWN]` not public; `[PREP-VENDOR]` commercial practice-seller, corroborate.

At a glance — Amberjack

What it is	UK early-careers specialist — **as much an outsourced recruitment-process-outsourcing (RPO) / applicant-tracking (ATS) / managed-campaign business as an assessment publisher.** Formerly **Gradweb** (rebranded 2016); **acquired by ManpowerGroup in May 2024**. Core product you'll meet: the **"Future Potential Blended Assessment"** — SJT + email-format cognitive + one-shot video, mapped to a proprietary 4-pillar "Future Skills Model."
Where in the funnel	Early online-sift stage: after the application form, before the virtual assessment centre (product name **"Impact"**) and interviews.
Format & timing	Blended single sitting, **~25 items** (≈22 multiple-choice/ ranking + ~3 written/video), **~45–60 min**, **"untimed but time affects your score"** (especially cognitive). Firm-branded variants (BDO/A&O "Interactive Assessment", Atkins "Immersive").
Scoring model	**One blended score** mapped to the 4 pillars — **Grit, Creative Force, Applied Intellect, Digital Mindset**. SJT keyed most/ least-effective; cognitive on correctness (+ speed); video **human-scored by Amberjack assessors** against the pillars.
Typical finance cut-off	`[UNKNOWN]` — thresholds, pass-marks, traffic-light bands and weightings are **undisclosed**. The biggest gap in this chapter.
Integrity posture	**No hard remote proctoring documented.** Webcam/mic required only for the *video module*, not surveillance. Anti-cheat leans on design (refreshed item pools, blended constructs, human video review), not lockdown.
Retake	`[UNKNOWN]` — no documented rule.
Top 5 tips	1) Learn the **4 pillars + 11 sub-traits**; on every SJT item ask "which pillar(s) is this?" 2) Research the **specific firm's own values** (they overlay the SJT). 3) Drill **email-format numerical/verbal** under mild time pressure — "untimed" still scores speed. 4) Prep your **2-minute one-shot video** answers against the pillars; use the unlimited prep time. 5) Confirm device, webcam/mic and any adjustments **in writing before you sit**.

(Every figure above is unpacked, sourced and confidence-tagged below. Amberjack is a broad graduate/ professional-services provider; its front-office investment-banking footprint is limited — see §6.3 and §6.6.)

6.1 Snapshot

Amberjack is a UK early-careers specialist, and the single most important thing to understand about it before you sit anything is structural: **Amberjack is as much an outsourced recruitment business as an assessment publisher — arguably more so.** Where SHL or Aon sell you a test, Amberjack sells employers an *end-to-end managed graduate campaign*, and the assessment is one module inside that stack. It began life in **2000 as Gradweb**, an early-careers recruitment firm (Companies House incorporation number 03907607, trading from around 12 January 2000), and **rebranded Gradweb → Amberjack in 2016.** `[INDEPENDENT – Companies House; VENDOR – weareamberjack.com "our story"]`

The ownership trail matters because it explains the business model. In **April 2019, LDC — the private-equity arm of Lloyds Banking Group — invested £17.6m** to back a management buy-out and fund technology and acquisitions. `[INDEPENDENT/VENDOR – ldc.co.uk portfolio page; vendor about-us]` In **June 2023 Amberjack acquired Fusion**, an Australia/New Zealand outsourcing and L&D business, adding APAC graduate-recruitment reach. `[VENDOR – about-us]` Then, in **May 2024, Amberjack was acquired by ManpowerGroup Inc. (NYSE: MAN)** and folded into **ManpowerGroup Talent Solutions**, its global RPO arm — the LDC exit; terms undisclosed. `[INDEPENDENT – press/aggregator reporting, needs a primary press-release cite for print; INFERRED current owner = ManpowerGroup]` Note that at the research access date the vendor's own /about pages still had not updated to name ManpowerGroup — a site-content lag, not a contradiction. `[VENDOR – legacy site lag noted]`

What Amberjack actually offers is six things sold together: (a) **RPO / outsourced managed graduate campaigns**; (b) a **proprietary ATS and candidate-management platform**; (c) **assessment** (blended SJT + cognitive + behavioural + video); (d) **virtual/digital assessment centres**, sold under the product name **"Impact"**; (e) attraction and employer branding; and (f) learning and development. `[VENDOR – /solutions/rpo-solutions, /solutions/talent-assessments]` The assessment you sit measures against Amberjack's proprietary **"Future Skills Model"** (also called the "Model for Identifying Potential") — four pillars, **Grit, Creative Force, Applied Intellect and Digital Mindset**, explicitly framed as measuring *future potential, not past experience*. `[VENDOR – talent-assessments; PREP-VENDOR – aptitude-test-prep.com]` In a UK early-careers process the blended online assessment is an **early sift** after the application form, running roughly **45–60 minutes**, with a downstream **virtual assessment centre** and interviews. `[PREP-VENDOR – aptitude-test-prep Atkins page; graduatesfirst A&O page]`

6.2 Why this test exists

The rationale is best understood from the employer's side, because Amberjack's whole pitch is that you don't run your own funnel — you outsource it. A firm running a high-volume graduate, apprentice or school-leaver intake faces the same problem set as any early-careers employer (tens of thousands of applications, a legal duty not to discriminate, thin and near-identical CVs), but instead of buying a test and wiring it into an in-house process, it hands the **entire campaign** — attraction, sourcing, assessment, candidate management, assessment centre, offer and onboarding — to Amberjack. `[VENDOR – /solutions/rpo-solutions, listing "Attraction & Sourcing, Assessment, Candidate Management, Operational Support"]` The assessment is simply the **sift engine** inside that managed service. This is the consequence for you, developed in §6.3: your "test" is not a standalone product you can research in isolation; it is one interchangeable stage in a campaign whose branding, scenarios and even results-communications are Amberjack's, operating on the client's behalf.

The design rationale for a *blended* SJT-plus-cognitive-plus-video assessment is the familiar early-careers argument. First, it claims to predict **future potential over past experience**, which is pitched as fairer to graduates with thin CVs. `[VENDOR — talent-assessments; the "Future Skills Model" framing]` Second, the "immersive tests that reflect real-life scenarios" double as a **realistic job preview** and an employer-values alignment check. `[VENDOR — /assessment-and-selection]` Third, folding several legacy stages into **one engaging candidate experience** cuts assessor time — Amberjack markets "assessing a cohort of ten or ten thousand" and a single blended score to reduce human marking load. `[VENDOR — talent-assessments]` A DEI framing sits on top: reduce bias, support diversity and neurodiversity, widen the talent pool. `[VENDOR — FAQs, rpo-solutions]`

The honest evidence caveat is the one that applies to every situational-judgement instrument in this guide, and it is set out in full in Chapter 6.3 and Chapter 63 (psychometrics): SJTs add only **small incremental validity** over cognitive-ability and personality measures, and SJT items are **frequently transparent and coachable.** `[INDEPENDENT — SJT review literature, see Chapter 63]` No independent, peer-reviewed validation of Amberjack's *specific* Future Skills Model could be located; the vendor cites "evidence-based" design and a CIPD scientific review but publishes no per-client validation study. `[UNKNOWN — see §6.5, §6.13]` The practical upshot is the same optimistic one as for Cappfinity: because the instrument is coachable and its framework is effectively public, understanding the four pillars is *legitimate, high-leverage preparation.*

6.3 Why a firm chooses Amberjack specifically

Amberjack does not win business by having a cleverer cognitive test than SHL. It wins on **being the whole outsourced campaign**, and that shapes everything about how you experience it. The competitive offer is an **end-to-end managed service** available in tiers — Full RPO, Project RPO and Modular RPO — so an employer can outsource the entire funnel or just the assessment-and-AC slice. `[VENDOR — rpo-solutions]` Wrapped around that is the **proprietary ATS and candidate-management platform** (applicant tracking, candidate communications and coaching, assessment delivery, AI-powered screening, real-time reporting, integration with the client's existing HR tech), and the **virtual/digital assessment centre "Impact,"** which replaces paper-based, in-person ACs with an automated online hub candidates attend on their own devices. `[VENDOR — rpo-solutions, /assessment-and-selection, /tracking-and-reporting]` Volume handling ("flex with hiring demand"), a DEI/candidate-experience story (bias-reduction, neurodiversity-inclusive design, a positive journey), and a wall of awards (Recruiter Awards Innovation of the Year 2019; FIRM and Recruitment Tech awards 2020–21) complete the sales case. `[VENDOR — /about]`

The **consequence for candidates** of the RPO model is worth stating plainly, because it differs from a pure test vendor. When you interact with the assessment, the emails, the platform, the video-review and often the results-communication are **Amberjack's**, acting for the client — which is why results turnaround, tone and even the branded name of your test ("Interactive Assessment," "Immersive Assessment," "Interactive Evaluation") vary by employer while the underlying engine is the same. It also means the human who reviews your video is an **Amberjack assessor, not the client firm** (§6.4, §6.6). `[PREP-VENDOR — aptitude-test-prep; VENDOR bias page]`

Where Amberjack sits in UK finance — read this carefully. Amberjack's client base skews to **broad graduate and professional-services hiring: retail, engineering, law and accountancy**, not front-office investment banking. Reference clients recurring across sources include **AtkinsRéalis (engineering), Morrisons (retail), Virgin Media O2, MARS, Weightmans (law), BDO (accountancy/advisory), Allen & Overy / A&O**

Shearman (law), and Lazard. `[PREP-VENDOR – aptitude-test-prep client list; BDO and A&O corroborated by graduatesfirst]` For a finance applicant the relevant links are three: **BDO** (mid-tier accountancy/advisory), **Allen & Overy / A&O Shearman** (Magic Circle law serving financial clients), and **Lazard** (the one clear front-office-adjacent M&A/advisory name). Two honest qualifications follow. First, **BDO is a dual-vendor firm** — it uses Amberjack's Interactive Assessment in some cycles and SHL in others, so which you meet varies. `[PREP-VENDOR – graduatesfirst, jobtestprep; CANDIDATE – TSR BDO thread via snippet]` Second, **front-office investment-banking penetration is limited**: the bulge brackets generally use SHL, Aon or HireVue rather than Amberjack, and the Lazard link is thin (a prep-vendor client-list mention, stage/year/programme unverified). `[INFERRED from client list + cross-provider knowledge; Lazard detail – PREP-VENDOR only, verify before relying on it]` Client rosters and provider choice churn every cycle, and the 2024 ManpowerGroup ownership may shift the base — so **re-verify per cycle** (§6.8). `[INFERRED – volatility]`

6.4 What the assessment actually is — full mechanics

Amberjack's assessment is a **blended single sitting**, and the mechanics below are assembled from prep-vendor breakdowns of specific employer variants; treat item counts as approximate and version-dependent.

The Future Potential Blended Assessment (early sift)

The core shape is **~25 total items**, described as "25 behavioural, situational-judgement and cognitive items," typically split as **≈22 multiple-choice/ranking items + ~3 interview questions (written or video).** `[PREP-VENDOR – aptitude-test-prep main guide]` Employer variants confirm the ~25-item shape but move the internal split around:

Employer variant	Reported composition	Source
Atkins "Immersive Assessment"	25 Qs = **12 SJT + 10 cognitive (numerical + verbal) + 3 interview**	`[PREP-VENDOR – aptitude-test-prep Atkins page]`
Morrisons "Interactive Evaluation"	**18 SJT + 15 numerical/data + 4 video interview**	`[PREP-VENDOR – aptitudeprep.com]`
BDO "Interactive Assessment"	workday / email-inbox simulation, **~22 items** mixing numerical, reading comprehension, SJT	`[PREP-VENDOR – jobtestprep/graduatesfirst; CANDIDATE – TSR]`

The component mechanics:

- **Situational judgement (SJT).** A brief job-related scenario with **four responses**; you pick the **Most** and the **Least** recommended (a most/least-effective ranking keyed to the pillars). Critically, **a single SJT item often assesses two pillars simultaneously** — confirmed for the Atkins build — which makes items harder and means one mis-keyed judgement can cost you on two constructs. `[PREP-VENDOR – aptitude-test-prep Atkins]`
- **Cognitive items — the distinctive format.** Numerical and verbal questions are **framed as emails from a colleague** with embedded data. Numerical items are deliberate "information-overload" graphs and tables; verbal items are short passages needing inference. They come **clustered in groups of three to four sharing a single data source**, with three or four options each. `[PREP-VENDOR – aptitude-test-prep, aptitudeprep]`

- **Video / asynchronous interview.** Typically **two minutes to record, one shot, no pause or restart** — but with **unlimited preparation time before you hit record.** Some variants are two short motivational questions. The recording is **reviewed by an Amberjack assessor (not the client) against the four pillars** — it is human-scored, not auto-scored. `[PREP-VENDOR — aptitude-test-prep Atkins/main; VENDOR bias page]`
- **Timing.** The whole assessment is described as **"untimed, but time affects your score, particularly on the cognitive items,"** with an estimated **45–60 minutes** total. This "untimed-but-timed" instruction is a genuine trap for pacing (§6.9). `[PREP-VENDOR]`
- **Device and kit.** Sit it on your **own device**; a **webcam and microphone are required for the video module** (only); a **calculator and scratch paper are recommended** for the numerical items; the platform is mobile-responsive (iOS/Android) per the vendor's G-Cloud listing. `[PREP-VENDOR; VENDOR — G-Cloud service definition]`

The virtual assessment centre — "Impact" (downstream stage)

The stage after the sift is Amberjack's **digital/virtual assessment centre, product-named "Impact."** Amberjack builds **immersive, interactive online assessment centres around typical business scenarios** for the specific role, which candidates attend on their own devices — explicitly replacing "traditional, time-consuming, paper-based assessment centres" with an automated digital hub. `[VENDOR — /assessment-and-selection]` From the RPO scope, the components typically include **group exercises, a case-study/analysis exercise and interviews delivered online**, with Amberjack facilitating the ACs, doing the marking, running telephone interviews and giving feedback. `[VENDOR — rpo-solutions, listing "assessment centre facilitation … telephone interviews, marking"]` The **exact per-firm AC component menu is `[UNKNOWN]`** — the BDO digital-AC case study returned a 404 at the research access date, so volumes and the precise exercise line-up could not be pinned down. `[UNKNOWN]` As a concrete example of what the downstream can look like: for **A&O / A&O Shearman**, the early-career video interview can be a **30-minute video interview built around a case study**, and the AC day a partner case-study interview plus scenario interviews. `[PREP-VENDOR — graduatesfirst A&O]`

6.5 Is it tailored to the role?

Yes at the scenario and branding layer; no at the underlying construct model — the same split you see with Cappfinity. Amberjack's four-pillar Future Skills Model is **common across clients**; the employer-specific layer is the **scenarios, the branding and the values-mapping.** `[INFERRED from the consistent pillar model plus firm-specific value overlays]` SJT scenarios are **customised per firm and keyed to that employer's own values or competencies** while still mapping back to the four pillars — Morrisons' SJT is aligned to Morrisons' values ("One Team," "Great Selling & Service," "Can Do"); Atkins gets a branded "Immersive Assessment," A&O and BDO an "Interactive Assessment," Morrisons an "Interactive Evaluation," each with an email-inbox/workday framing tuned to the sector. `[PREP-VENDOR — aptitudeprep Morrisons; multiple]` Amberjack's assessment team also designs **bespoke immersive AC exercises "around typical business scenarios the candidates would find themselves in"** per client role. `[VENDOR — /assessment-and-selection]`

The practical consequence is the same high-leverage move as for any values-keyed instrument: because the SJT is scored against a *named, published* set of employer values sitting on top of the four pillars, **reading that firm's values framework before you sit is legitimate, high-value preparation** (§6.7). Two honest limits. Whether Amberjack runs a **bespoke criterion-validation study against each employer's own performance data is**

`[UNKNOWN]` — the vendor claims "evidence-based" design but no per-client validation surfaced. `[VENDOR general claim only]` And prep guides warn that **"the real test changes regularly,"** meaning item pools are refreshed per cycle — so memorising specific questions is worthless; internalising the *pillar logic* is what transfers. `[PREP-VENDOR — aptitudeprep]`

6.6 How they screen and filter — scoring, norms, cut-offs, ranking

This is the section where honesty matters most, because most of it is undisclosed.

What is known about the scoring pipeline. All components combine into **one overall blended score mapped to the Future Skills Model** — the four pillars. `[VENDOR — talent-assessments, "one overall score"]` Within that: the **SJT** is keyed, with your most/least-effective choices scored against pillar-aligned "recommended" answers, and each SJT item potentially loading on two pillars. `[PREP-VENDOR]` The **cognitive** items are scored on correctness, with **speed influencing the score** (the "untimed but time affects score" mechanic). `[PREP-VENDOR]` The **video** is **human-scored by Amberjack assessors against the four pillars** — notably, the vendor's own bias page points out that candidates often *assume* AI scores the video when in fact manual screening is used. `[PREP-VENDOR + VENDOR bias page]` The recruiter/assessor side of the platform offers custom scoring and tagging, multi-assessor review, and real-time reporting dashboards, with data exportable as CSV/xlsx. `[VENDOR — G-Cloud, /tracking-and-reporting]`

What is not known — and this is the biggest gap in the chapter. Scoring thresholds, pass-marks, whether it is norm-referenced or criterion-keyed, whether it is a hard cut-off or a top-N rank, whether there is a traffic-light band output, how the components are weighted, and whether the design is multi-hurdle or compensatory — none of this is disclosed in any accessed source. Multiple prep guides state explicitly that scoring thresholds, cut-offs, traffic-light bands and weightings are not published. `[PREP-VENDOR — aptitude-test-prep, "no information about scoring thresholds, pass marks, traffic-light"]` Treat every one of those as **`[UNKNOWN]`.** The only safe inference is that it functions as a **genuine sift with a threshold** you can fail; where that threshold sits, and against what reference group, is not recoverable from public sources. `[INFERRED; UNKNOWN on all specifics]`

Typical finance cut-off: `[UNKNOWN]`. Unlike SHL, where prep vendors at least publish (self-disclaimed, unreliable) percentile estimates, no numeric cut-off for Amberjack in a finance context could be located. Do not trust any figure presented as one.

The funnel note for finance. Because Amberjack's finance footprint is narrow (§6.3), the realistic reading is: at **BDO** the Interactive Assessment is a real early gate but the later stages and — where BDO runs SHL instead — a different provider entirely may decide your cycle; at **A&O / A&O Shearman** the Interactive Assessment reportedly **sifts a large fraction at this stage** (prep-vendor figures suggest 50–80%, treat as indicative only), with the case-study video and AC cutting hardest later; at **Lazard** the stage detail is unverified. `[PREP-VENDOR — graduatesfirst A&O; INFERRED]` Spend proportionate effort on the sift, then weight toward the downstream AC (§6.8).

Retake policy: **`[UNKNOWN]`** — not specified anywhere accessed.

Results turnaround: candidates report Amberjack states results **within ~10 days** of completion, though TSR/ Reddit candidates report **delays beyond 10 days in practice** in the BDO 2024/25 cycle. `[CANDIDATE, n=multiple but exact count unverified — TSR BDO thread, quoted via search snippet; direct fetch 403-blocked]`

6.7 How to score well — legitimate, specific, actionable

Amberjack rewards a small number of well-drilled, entirely legitimate habits. Chapter 6.4 (cross-cutting construct manual) and Chapter 63 (psychometrics) give the general layer; here is the Amberjack-specific one.

Learn the four pillars and eleven sub-traits, and interrogate every SJT item through them. The pillars are **Grit** (Resilience, Passion/Drive, Delivery/Agility), **Creative Force** (Future Focus, Original Vision, Agent of Change), **Applied Intellect** (Cognitive Ability, Social/Emotional Intelligence, Learning Agility) and **Digital Mindset** (Technological Mindset, Digital Creativity). `[PREP-VENDOR – aptitude-test-prep; VENDOR PDF exists but is a binary/non-extractable file, so the 11 sub-traits are prep-vendor-sourced]` The core legitimate strategy the prep guides describe is to ask, on every SJT scenario, **"which pillar or pillars is this item assessing?"** — and, because a single item can load on two, to make sure your Most/Least choices are defensible on both. `[PREP-VENDOR – aptitude-test-prep]`

Research the specific employer's own values, because they overlay the SJT keying (Morrisons' values, an employer's published competencies). Reading them beforehand tells you which response themes the firm rewards — this is transparent-by-design preparation, not gaming. `[PREP-VENDOR]`

Drill the email-format cognitive items under mild time pressure. The "information-overload" numerical graphs/tables and inference-based verbal passages reward fast, accurate data extraction, and remember that **"untimed" still scores your speed** — so practise finding the *right two numbers* quickly rather than re-deriving from scratch. Have a calculator and scratch paper ready where recommended. `[PREP-VENDOR]`

Prepare your two-minute, one-shot video answers. You get **unlimited preparation time before recording** but only **one take of two minutes, no restart** — so use the prep time to structure a concise, pillar-aligned answer to likely motivational/behavioural questions, and rehearse to a natural two minutes. Remember a *human Amberjack assessor* watches it against the pillars, so speak to genuine, specific examples rather than generic keywords. `[PREP-VENDOR; VENDOR bias page]`

For the virtual AC ("Impact"), behave as if it were the real role. The immersive business-scenario exercises reward demonstrable **collaboration in group tasks, structured analysis in the case exercise, and authentic values-alignment** — the exercises are designed to reflect "real-life" role behaviour, so triage, prioritise and communicate clearly. `[VENDOR framing]`

A note on the commercial prep packs (aptitude-test-prep, JobTestPrep BDO packs, GraduatesFirst): they are marketing, priced accordingly, and the format detail in this chapter is drawn from them precisely *because* the vendor discloses so little. Use them for format familiarisation, not for their confidence about scoring. `[PREP-VENDOR – commercial, treat as marketing]`

6.8 Integrity monitoring — what Amberjack actually detects

Amberjack's integrity posture is markedly lighter than SHL's, and honesty about what is *not* known matters here.

There is no evidence of hard remote proctoring. No accessed source describes webcam-monitoring, gaze-tracking, lockdown-browser or screen-capture surveillance for the blended online assessment. The **webcam and microphone are required only for the video-interview module** — to record your answer, not to watch you sit the rest of the test. `[PREP-VENDOR – aptitude-test-prep, "no remote monitoring protocols described"]`

Anti-cheating leans on design, not surveillance. The mechanisms that exist are: **refreshed item pools** (prep guides note "the real test changes regularly," so shared answers rot quickly), **unique/varied items**, **blended constructs** (mixing SJT, cognitive and video makes a single crib unhelpful), and **human review of the video** as an authenticity anchor. `[PREP-VENDOR; INFERRED]` The **one-shot, two-minute, on-camera video functions as a de-facto identity and authenticity check** — a live-recorded sample of you answering that a proxy sitter would struggle to fake. `[INFERRED]`

What is genuinely unknown. How any flags are actioned, what integrity signal (if any) the employer receives, and whether there is any consistency- or response-time-based cheat detection beyond the scoring itself — **none of this is documented.** `[UNKNOWN]` The employer/assessor receives scored and tagged results, multi-assessor review and dashboards; whether an integrity report sits alongside them is not stated. `[VENDOR – G-Cloud; UNKNOWN on integrity reporting]` Where a firm layers Amberjack's sift into a wider process that *does* use proctoring at a later stage, the proctoring caveats of that separate provider apply — but for the Amberjack sift itself, the surveillance surface appears small.

6.9 How candidates commonly trip the system — including honestly

Because the proctoring surface is small, the classic webcam false-positive catalogue (gaze flags, second-face detection, lighting/skin-tone disparities) **largely does not apply to the Amberjack sift** — a genuine relief if you have been flagged on a HireVue or a webcam-proctored SHL. The risks that remain are subtler and mostly about the scoring design, not surveillance.

- **The "untimed but timed" speed penalty.** The instruction that the test is untimed while time still affects your score is a real trap: candidates who work slowly, or who over-prepare each item, can under-score on the cognitive component *despite* being able. Mis-pacing to the ambiguous instruction is the commonest honest error. `[INFERRED from prep-vendor wording]`
- **The one-shot, two-minute video with no retry.** A tech glitch, a stumble or nerves produces an unrepresentative sample and no second chance — a structural risk of **false negatives for anxious-but-able candidates.** Mitigate by testing your kit beforehand and using the unlimited prep time. `[INFERRED; anxiety effects well-documented in the SJT/video literature]`
- **Dual-pillar SJT items.** Because a single SJT item can load on two pillars, one mis-keyed Most/Least judgement can cost you on both constructs — construct-contamination that punishes a single misread more than a one-pillar item would. `[INFERRED from the Atkins design]`
- **The coaching cuts both ways.** Heavily marketed prep packs plus a memorisable four-pillar framework make the SJT and values items **susceptible to preparation** — well-prepped candidates can score above their true fit, which means the bar you are clearing is a *prepared* one. `[INFERRED; the existence of prep-vendor packs is evidence]`
- **Values-alignment as conformity screening.** Scoring against a firm's values risks rewarding cultural conformity and social desirability over ability — worth knowing if your authentic, well-reasoned answer diverges from an obvious "company-line" response. `[INFERRED]`

There is **no documented evidence of demographic false-positive issues specific to Amberjack**, because there is no webcam-surveillance layer to produce them — though the general adverse-impact caution about any algorithmic or values-based scoring still applies (§6.10, Chapter 6.6 cross-cutting). `[INFERRED; no bias-audit numbers published – §6.13]`

6.10 How to be unambiguously clean

The proctoring surface is small, so the checklist is short — and weighted toward the video module and any adjustments, which is where the real risk sits.

- **Sit it in one uninterrupted, distraction-free window** on the recommended device with a stable connection. A mid-test disconnection on a speed-scored cognitive component can cost you, and the one-shot video is unforgiving of interruption.
- **Test your webcam and microphone before the video module.** Because it is one take of two minutes with no restart, a kit failure is the single most avoidable way to hand yourself a false negative. Check framing, audio and lighting first.
- **Answer authentically and consistently.** With no verification re-sit and no proctoring to game, your best clean strategy is your genuine, pillar-informed and values-informed self — a fabricated profile you cannot sustain at the later AC or interview is a poor bet.
- **Request adjustments in writing, in advance.** The specific candidate-adjustment process (extra time, alternative formats) is **not documented publicly** `[UNKNOWN]`, which is itself the reason to make the request explicit and early — route it via the employer's recruitment team citing the Equality Act 2010 (template in §6.11). Amberjack's published contact is **hello@weareamberjack.com / +44 (0)1635 584130.** `[VENDOR – FAQs]`
- **A genuine data/accessibility positive.** Per Amberjack's **G-Cloud service definition**, the platform is **WCAG 2.1 AA / EN 301 549 compliant**, tested with SortSite and the NVDA screen reader, mobile-responsive, and **all data is stored and processed in the UK only**, with **ISO/IEC 27001 certification** (British Assessment Bureau, 26 Sept 2022), TLS 1.2+ in transit and encryption at rest. `[VENDOR – G-Cloud service definition]` This is a real accessibility and data-protection strength you can rely on when framing an adjustments request.

6.11 If you are flagged or rejected

Because the Amberjack sift is unproctored, a rejection here is almost always a **score/fit outcome, not an integrity flag** — so the route is a feedback query and, if you want the underlying data, a data-subject access request. Your UK rights are the strong ones set out in full in Chapter 6.7 (cross-cutting legal chapter); this is the Amberjack-specific playbook.

First, ask — plainly and promptly. Email the employer's recruitment team (Amberjack often runs this inbox on the firm's behalf), reference your application, and ask whether feedback is available and whether reapplication in a future cycle is possible. Note the practical wrinkle that **results can run beyond the stated ~10 days**, so allow time before assuming a silent rejection. `[CANDIDATE – TSR, unverified n]`

Then use your data-protection rights. Under **UK GDPR Article 15 (right of access)** you can submit a **Data Subject Access Request (DSAR)** to the **employer** (the data controller — Amberjack is the processor), who must respond within **one month**, free of charge. Ask specifically for: your **blended score and how it mapped to the four pillars**; the **framework or values you were assessed against**; any **assessor notes or tags on your video**; and the **logic of any automated decision-making**. Where a rejection was based *solely* on automated processing (an auto-reject with no human looking), the safeguards in **Articles 22A–22C of the UK GDPR — as amended**

by the Data (Use and Access) Act 2025, in force 5 February 2026 — entitle you to make representations, **obtain human intervention**, and contest the decision. The old blanket "Article 22 prohibition" framing is out of date; the current position is in Chapter 6.7. `[REGULATORY — DUAA 2025]` A useful Amberjack-specific point: the video is **human-scored by an assessor**, so at least that component is not solely automated — worth noting if you invoke the Articles 22A–22C safeguards. If the employer stonewalls, you can complain to the **Information Commissioner's Office (ICO)**.

Disclosing a disability. If your result was affected by a condition and no adjustment was in place, requesting a reasonable adjustment under the **Equality Act 2010** is the strongest basis for a re-sit or reconsideration, because the duty to make reasonable adjustments is a legal obligation, not a favour. Amberjack's documented WCAG 2.1 AA compliance (§6.10) makes an accommodation entirely feasible on their side.

Realistic expectations. Straightforward score rejections are rarely overturned. The higher-value use of these rights is often **evidence for next time** — and, at a dual-vendor firm like BDO, knowing whether you sat Amberjack or SHL tells you which provider to prepare for on a re-application.

Template wording.

(a) Pre-assessment adjustments request (send before you sit):

> Subject: Reasonable adjustment request — [your name], [role/ref] Dear [team], I have been invited to complete Amberjack's online assessment for [role]. I have [condition, e.g. dyslexia / ADHD / a visual impairment], which affects [e.g. reading speed / processing under time pressure]. As the assessment scores response time and includes a timed video, under the Equality Act 2010 I request reasonable adjustments — specifically [e.g. additional time; an alternative to the one-shot video; confirmation that a calculator and scratch paper are permitted]. I can provide supporting documentation. Please confirm what can be arranged and the revised deadline. Thank you.

(b) Post-rejection feedback / DSAR:

> Subject: Assessment outcome — feedback and data request — [name], [ref] Dear [team], Thank you for the update. Could you share any feedback on my Amberjack assessment and whether reapplication is possible next cycle? Separately, under Article 15 of the UK GDPR I request the personal data held about my assessment — my blended score and pillar mapping, the framework/values I was assessed against, any assessor notes on my video, and the logic of any automated decision (Articles 22A–22C UK GDPR, as amended by the Data (Use and Access) Act 2025), including whether a human was involved. Please respond within one month. Thank you.

6.12 Step-by-step: how to win this assessment

A numbered playbook from about ten days out to the debrief.

1. **T-minus 10 days — get the two frameworks.** Print Amberjack's **four pillars and eleven sub-traits**, and find the **specific firm's published values/competencies** (they overlay the SJT). Map two or three genuine examples from your own experience onto each pillar and each value. `[PREP-VENDOR + VENDOR]`
2. **T-9 to T-4 — drill the components.** Daily: a set of most/least-effective SJT practice items (train the habit of naming the pillar(s) each item tests, and answering defensibly on *both* when an item is dual-loaded), plus

email-format numerical/verbal under mild time pressure. Keep an error log noting *why* you misjudged an SJT item — usually a missed pillar or a missed value theme.

3. **T-7 — logistics and kit.** Confirm the device, and **test your webcam and microphone** — the video is one shot, two minutes, no restart. If you need adjustments, send the §6.11(a) request now (the speed-scored design and one-shot video make this matter), via hello@weareamberjack.com or the recruiter.
4. **T-4 to T-2 — prep the video.** Draft and rehearse concise, pillar-aligned two-minute answers to likely motivational/behavioural questions, using the fact that you get **unlimited prep time before recording**. Aim for specific, genuine examples an Amberjack assessor can map to the pillars.
5. **T-2 — simulate.** One full run on your real device at your sharpest time of day; check the connection and browser, and practise pacing to the "untimed but timed" instruction — steady and accurate, not slow.
6. **Day before.** Re-read both frameworks. Charge the laptop, clear the desk, protect an uninterrupted ~60-minute block, put out a calculator and scratch paper, sleep.
7. **30 minutes before.** Close everything, silence notifications, water. Re-read the instructions and note the exact split (how many SJT, cognitive and video items this variant has).
8. **In-test decision rules.** On SJT, name the pillar(s) and apply the firm's values — initiative, ownership and constructive communication tend to key high; avoidance and blame key low. On cognitive, **don't dawdle** (speed is scored) but extract the right two numbers rather than re-deriving. On the video, use the prep time, then deliver one clean take.
9. **Rolling-deadline note.** Most UK graduate and professional-services schemes sift on a rolling basis — **apply and sit early**; a solid score submitted early beats a marginally better one into a shrinking pool (developed in Chapter 6.8 cross-cutting).
10. **Debrief.** Note the actual format (item split, whether the video was one or more questions, which firm-branded name it used), and — at a dual-vendor firm like BDO — **which provider you actually sat**, so a re-application targets the right one next time.

6.13 Sources for this chapter

All accessed 2026-08-01. Confidence tags as used above.

Vendor (primary): - Amberjack — *Talent Assessments* — https://www.weareamberjack.com/solutions/talent-assessments/ `[VENDOR]` - Amberjack — *RPO Solutions* — https://www.weareamberjack.com/solutions/rpo-solutions `[VENDOR]` - Amberjack — *About / Our Story* — https://www.weareamberjack.com/about-us/ and /about/ `[VENDOR – note: still omitted ManpowerGroup at access date]` - Amberjack — *FAQs* — https://www.weareamberjack.com/faqs/ `[VENDOR]` - Amberjack — *Ensuring Fairness in Assessment and Selection* — https://www.weareamberjack.com/ensuring-fairness-in-assessment-and-selection/ `[VENDOR]` - Amberjack — *G-Cloud service definition* (ISO27001, WCAG 2.1 AA, UK-only data) — https://www.applytosupply.digitalmarketplace.service.gov.uk/g-cloud/services/921190874571069 `[VENDOR]` - Amberjack — *Model for Identifying Potential* (PDF, binary/non-extractable) — https://www.weareamberjack.com/wp-content/uploads/2023/03/AmberjacksModelforIdentifyingPotential.pdf `[VENDOR – text not extractable; pillar sub-traits corroborated via prep-vendor]`

Independent: - Companies House — Amberjack Global Limited (03907607) — https://find-and-update.company-information.service.gov.uk/company/03907607 `[INDEPENDENT – corporate history]` - LDC — Amberjack portfolio page (£17.6m 2019 MBO) — https://www.ldc.co.uk/portfolio/amberjack-recruiting-

support/ `[INDEPENDENT/VENDOR]` - ManpowerGroup acquisition (May 2024) — press/aggregator reporting + Tracxn ManpowerGroup-acquisitions list `[INDEPENDENT – needs a primary press-release cite for print]`

Prep-vendor (format detail; corroborate — commercially biased): - aptitude-test-prep.com — Amberjack Assessment (mechanics, client list, 4 pillars) — https://aptitude-test-prep.com/test-providers/amberjack-assessment/ - aptitude-test-prep.com — Atkins Immersive Assessment (25-Q split, dual-pillar SJT, 2-min video) — /employers/energy-and-engineering/atkins-immersive-assessment/ - aptitudeprep.com — Morrisons Interactive Evaluation (18 SJT + 15 numerical + 4 video) — https://www.aptitudeprep.com/morrisons-interactive-evaluation/ - GraduatesFirst — Allen & Overy and BDO job tests — https://www.graduatesfirst.com/allen-overy-job-tests and /bdo-aptitude-tests - JobTestPrep — BDO assessment — https://www.jobtestprep.co.uk/bdo-assessment

Candidate (testimony; thin/unverified): - The Student Room — BDO UK 2024/25 (Amberjack Interactive Assessment, ~10-day results, delays) — https://www.thestudentroom.co.uk/showthread.php?t=7530838 `[CANDIDATE – direct fetch 403-blocked; content only via search snippets, quotes and n-count unverified]`

(Residual Amberjack gaps — the scoring model in full (thresholds, pass-mark vs rank, norm-vs-criterion, traffic-light, weightings, multi-hurdle) is genuinely undisclosed and the single biggest gap; retake policy unknown; the per-firm virtual-AC ("Impact") component menu unpinned (BDO case-study URL 404'd); the ManpowerGroup acquisition needs a primary press-release cite; verbatim candidate testimony and n-count blocked; the Lazard finance link (stage/year/programme) unverified; the 11 sub-traits are prep-vendor-sourced, not confirmed against the binary vendor PDF; and no bias-audit / adverse-impact numbers are published — are logged in research/06-amberjack.md and the master gap register.)

Chapter 7 — Plum

Confidence tags used throughout (full explanation in Chapter 1): `[VENDOR]` vendor's own claim; `[INDEPENDENT]` peer-reviewed/independent; `[CANDIDATE, n=X]` candidate testimony with count; `[INFERRED]` my reasoning, shown; `[UNKNOWN]` not public; `[PREP-VENDOR]` commercial practice-seller, corroborate.

At a glance — Plum

What it is	A **psychometric fit-matching** platform (Canada, founded 2012 as Cream.HR → Plum). Core product you'll meet: the **Plum Discovery Survey** — a personality-led questionnaire (Five-Factor Model) blended with a short cognitive/pattern section and a situational-judgement section, distilled into **"Talent" scores** and a per-role **Match Score**. **Acquired by Phenom (announced April 2026); plum.io now redirects to phenom.com — treat all "standalone Plum" framing as legacy-in-transition.** `[VENDOR/INDEPENDENT]`
Where in the funnel	Early-careers online-screening stage: after the application form, before (or around) the video interview. Niche in UK finance — see §7.3.
Format & timing	**~25 minutes, UNTIMED** (time taken does not affect your result). Online via email invitation; completion window **72 hours–5 days** depending on employer. Five short sections. `[PREP-VENDOR consistent]`
Scoring model	**Match Score = fit to a specific role, not a percentile and not pass/fail.** Audited range **30–99** (marketing says 1–99); **>80 = strong, 61 = average**; every candidate is shown to the recruiter **ranked** by Match Score. `[VENDOR / INDEPENDENT audit]`
Typical finance cut-off	`[UNKNOWN]` — no percentile cut-off exists by design; the recruiter sifts a ranked list against role-specific Match Criteria, so the effective bar depends on pool size and how many the firm advances.
Integrity posture	**Typically UNPROCTORED.** No webcam/lockdown documented; anti-faking relies on **design** (ipsative forced-choice, role-hidden scoring, multi-instrument blend), not surveillance. Independent **FairNow bias audit (Nov 2024)** found no disparate impact. `[INFERRED + INDEPENDENT]`
Retake	Cannot re-do immediately; **~1 year** before a fresh survey per prep vendors. The profile is **reusable across all Plum employers**, so you normally sit it once. `[PREP-VENDOR + VENDOR]`
Top 5 tips	1) Answer the personality/SJT sections **honestly** — the score is fit to a role you can't see, so "gaming good" is largely futile. 2) On the SJT, answer what you **should** do (best practice), not what you would. 3) Practise only the **cognitive/next-in-series** section — it's the one objectively-scored, coachable part. 4) You sit it **once** for all Plum employers, so sit it rested and clean. 5) It's untimed — don't rush; deliberate.

(Every figure above is unpacked, sourced and confidence-tagged in the sections below.)

7.1 Snapshot

The single most important fact about Plum in 2026 is a currency one, so it leads this chapter: **Plum was acquired by Phenom, a Philadelphia AI-hiring platform, announced 28 April 2026 — roughly three months before this guide's research date — and `plum.io` now 301-redirects to `phenom.com`.** `[VENDOR – phenom.com press release; INDEPENDENT – BetaKit, technical.ly, The Logic]` Plum's products are being folded into Phenom's platform, all Plum staff joined Phenom's roughly 1,600-person team, and Plum was Phenom's *third* acquisition of 2026 (after "Included" in January and "Be Applied" in February), assembling what Phenom calls a "full-spectrum assessment stack." `[INDEPENDENT – BetaKit; VENDOR – Phenom]` Everything below that describes "Plum as a standalone vendor" is therefore **legacy-in-transition**: the mechanics are as candidates met them through 2025 and into 2026, but the branding, URLs and candidate-facing form may migrate under Phenom before you sit one. Re-verify the branding on your actual invitation email.

With that flagged, here is what Plum *is*. The legal entity is **Plum.io Inc.**, founded **2012** in **Kitchener-Waterloo, Ontario, Canada**, by founder and CEO **Caitlin MacGregor**; it was formerly named **Cream.HR** before rebranding to Plum, and had raised roughly **$19M CAD** before the acquisition (last round ~$8M CAD in early 2023, backers including BDC Capital's Women in Technology fund, Export Development Canada, Real Ventures and Pearson Ventures). `[INDEPENDENT – BetaKit; corporate history cross-checked across G2/CBInsights]` It is a psychometric and behavioural **talent-assessment SaaS** that measures **personality (via the Five-Factor Model), cognitive/problem-solving ability, and social intelligence**, distils those into what it calls **"Talents"** (recurring patterns of thought, feeling and behaviour — essentially soft skills), and then produces **role-specific Match Scores**. `[VENDOR]` Its named pre-acquisition customers include **Scotiabank, Hyundai and Whirlpool**. `[INDEPENDENT – BetaKit]`

For a UK finance early-careers applicant, the honest framing is that Plum is a **niche, early-careers screening tool, not a front-office investment-banking standard** — it appears in some UK graduate pipelines (most credibly Bloomberg, more disputedly Citi; see §7.3), but the evidence is largely prep-vendor-driven and one major source disagrees about whether "Citi's Plum test" is even Plum at all. The one feature that makes Plum genuinely distinctive is the **reusable candidate profile fed into a per-role Match Score**: you complete one ~25-minute Discovery Survey, and that single profile is scored differently for every role and every Plum employer you apply to. Understanding that architecture is the key to everything in §7.4–§7.6.

7.2 Why this test exists

The problem Plum sets out to solve is the same volume-and-defensibility problem that drives every provider in this guide (Chapter 6.1 develops the general case), but its pitch attacks the *input* rather than the *filter*. Plum's thesis is that firms should match people to roles on **psychometric fit** rather than on résumé and credentials — surfacing, in the vendor's framing, candidates "that never would have been discovered through a traditional hiring process." `[VENDOR – VentureBeat interview]` The claim, in other words, is that the CV is a weak signal and a narrow one, and that a behavioural profile both predicts better and widens the funnel beyond the usual target-university pipeline.

The headline validity claim Plum markets is that its data is **"4× more predictive of future job success than a resume"** — repeated across its own materials and the Phenom acquisition release as "assessment accuracy proven four times greater than resume screening alone." `[VENDOR – repeated across G2 summary + Phenom press release]` Treat that number with the same scepticism the rest of this guide applies to vendor validity figures: **no peer-reviewed or independent citation for the "4×" claim could be located**, and "4× more predictive than a resume" is a low bar dressed as a high one — résumé screening is a notoriously weak predictor, so beating it fourfold is not the same as being a strong predictor in absolute terms. `[UNKNOWN — no independent backing located; treat as vendor marketing]` What *is* documented, via Plum's own system description quoted verbatim in the independent FairNow audit (§7.8, §7.10), is the underlying construction: the Talents are "derived from the Five-Factor Model (FFM) of personality as well as facets of cognitive ability." `[VENDOR-verbatim, via FairNow audit]` That grounding in the FFM matters, because the Five-Factor Model is the best-validated framework in personality psychology, and a properly-built FFM instrument inherits a real (if modest) evidence base — which is more than can be said for many bespoke "culture-fit" quizzes. The sober reading is that Plum probably measures something real and stable, but the specific "4× predictive" headline is unverified marketing, and personality's incremental validity over cognitive ability is small in the independent literature (Chapter 6.3).

7.3 Why a firm chooses Plum specifically

Plum's differentiation is architectural, not that its personality items are cleverer than a rival's. Four features carry the sales case. First, the **Match Score** — a single fit number per candidate, per role, that lets a recruiter rank a whole applicant pool against one requisition (§7.6). `[VENDOR/PREP-VENDOR]` Second, the **reusable candidate profile**: one Discovery Survey serves *all* Plum employers and every internal role, because the raw results "are not job-specific until combined with the employer's Match Criteria" (§7.6). `[VENDOR — help-centre snippets]` Third, **internal mobility / "Talent Re-Discovery"** — an employer can search its existing applicant and employee pool against a *new* role without re-assessing anyone. `[PREP-VENDOR paraphrase of vendor feature]` Fourth, a **DEI / fairness** positioning built on "blind" behavioural matching (matching on Talents, not credentials) and published bias audits (§7.8). `[VENDOR]` Pricing is **not publicly disclosed** — Plum runs a quote/contact-sales model, and no per-candidate or seat figure could be located across TrustRadius, Capterra, GetApp or SoftwareSuggest. `[UNKNOWN — vendor quote-based]` On third-party ratings, Plum holds roughly **4.4/5 on G2** across about 71 reviews, praised for ease of setup and depth of competency breakdown, and was named a Nucleus Research "Hot Company to Watch" in 2023. `[INDEPENDENT — G2; VENDOR PR — GlobeNewswire]`

Now the honest part for a UK finance reader, because it is easy to over-read a prep vendor's client list. **Plum's UK front-office IB penetration is shallow — it is an early-careers screening tool, and the finance footprint that exists is concentrated, disputed and prep-vendor-sourced.** Two firms recur:

- **Bloomberg.** Multiple UK prep pages (jobtestprep.co.uk's dedicated "bloomberg-plum-assessment" page, assessmentpass.co.uk, aptitudeprep, graduatesfirst) describe a Bloomberg **"Plum Discovery Survey"** — ~25 minutes, untimed, the same five-section structure, framed around "10 Talents essential for success at Bloomberg." This is the **better-corroborated** of the two, with consistent multi-vendor agreement and at least one candidate posting a "top Plum Talent" result on LinkedIn (Sachin Heer, 2023). `[PREP-VENDOR — multiple; CANDIDATE, n≥1]` Note Bloomberg is finance-data/technology — front-office-*adjacent*, not a bulge-bracket IB desk.
- **Citi.** UK prep vendors (jobtestprep.co.uk, aptitudeprep) state that Citi's early-stage online assessment **is** the plum.io Discovery Survey, sitting post-application and pre-video-interview, and there is candidate chatter referring to a "plum test" in The Student Room's "Citi Graduate 2024" thread. `[PREP-VENDOR; CANDIDATE, n≥1]` **But this is genuinely contested.** graduatesfirst.com describes Citi's assessments as **"powered by Korn Ferry Talent Q"** — numerical, logical and SJT tests of 20–30 minutes each — i.e. **not Plum at all.** `[PREP-VENDOR conflict]` Both accounts are presented here without adjudication: the possibilities are that prep

vendors are conflating two different Citi tests, that Citi changed provider across cycles, or that "Plum" is a mislabel. **Do not treat "Citi uses Plum" as settled fact.** `[INFERRED]`

Deloitte is also named as a Plum user by prep vendors (professional services, finance-adjacent), but on weaker sourcing. `[PREP-VENDOR – weak]` The one solidly-independent bank client, **Scotiabank**, is Canadian retail/commercial banking, not UK IB. `[INDEPENDENT – BetaKit]` The bottom line: Plum is real in UK graduate/early-careers finance but **narrow and volatile** — for UK front-office investment banking, the standards are SHL (Chapter 1), Aon/cut-e, Korn Ferry and the game-based/HireVue tools, not Plum — and the April 2026 Phenom acquisition adds a further layer of instability to anything you read about "Plum at firm X."

7.4 What the assessment actually is — full mechanics

The thing you sit is the **Plum Discovery Survey**: delivered online via an email invitation, **about 25 minutes long, and — this is its defining property — completely UNTIMED.** Plum states there is "no time limit," "no record of how long it took," and that "time taken has no impact on results." `[PREP-VENDOR consistent across jobtestprep, aptitudeprep, assessmentcentrehq; echoes vendor FAQ]` The completion window (the deadline by which you must finish, not a clock while you work) varies by employer configuration — reported as **72 hours** or **5 days** across prep sources. `[PREP-VENDOR]` This untimed design is the single biggest experiential difference from an SHL Verify or a Cappfinity immersive: there is no ticking clock, so the correct disposition is *deliberate*, not fast.

The survey is built from **five short sections**. Plum's own FAQ describes the split as sections 1 and 3 measuring personality, sections 2 and 4 measuring problem-solving, and section 5 measuring workplace behaviour; prep vendors reconstruct the formats as follows (item counts are approximate — treat every number as "about"):

#	Section	Format	~Items	Measures
1	Priorities & Preferences	Forced-choice: pick the statement **most** and **least** like your view	~20 statements	Personality (FFM facets)
2	Problem-Solving / Cognitive	Abstract reasoning — "select the missing piece / next in series"; matrix grids and/or domino-sequence variants	~7	Fluid reasoning / cognitive ability
3	"You" Descriptor	Adjective lists — choose **3 most** and **3 least** that describe you	~5	Personality dimensions
4	Problem-Solving / Cognitive	As section 2	~7	Cognitive ability
5	Social Interaction	SJT — a workplace scenario, rank responses **most → least effective**	~7 scenarios	Social intelligence / behaviour

`[PREP-VENDOR – jobtestprep.com, jobtestprep.co.uk, aptitudeprep, assessmentcentrehq, assessmentpass.co.uk]`

Several mechanics are worth internalising. The **personality basis is explicitly the Big Five / Five-Factor Model** — this is Plum's own words in its system description ("Talents are derived from the Five-Factor Model … as well as facets of cognitive ability"). `[VENDOR-verbatim, via FairNow audit]` The forced-choice, most/least format (sections 1 and 3) is **ipsative** — you trade one preference against another rather than rating each on an absolute scale — which, as with SHL's OPQ32 (Chapter 1.4), is deliberately hard to "fake good" on because every option is roughly equally desirable. The **cognitive/problem-solving sections (2 and 4) are the only objectively-scored, right/wrong content** in the whole survey — abstract non-verbal "next-in-series" pattern completion (matrix grids described as roughly 9 grids of 9 coloured boxes, or domino-sequence variants). `[PREP-VENDOR – assessmentcentrehq: "only logic puzzles have objective scoring"]` There is **no evidence of item-level adaptivity** — the survey is described as untimed and fixed-form — though no source states this definitively, so treat "not adaptive" as strongly-inferred rather than confirmed. `[INFERRED; UNKNOWN for definitive]` Device guidance is thin: it is delivered via a browser through the email link, with no explicit mobile guidance located. `[UNKNOWN]`

Two count conflicts to know about. First, prep vendors uniformly list **"10 Plum Talents"** by name — Adaptation, Communication, Conflict Resolution, Decision Making, Embracing Diversity, Execution, Innovation, Managing Others, Persuasion, Teamwork `[PREP-VENDOR]` — but Plum's own audited system description says candidates are scored on **12 Talents**. `[INDEPENDENT – FairNow audit]` The most likely reconciliation is that "10 named talents" is the candidate-facing marketing list and "12" is the underlying scored set, but the conflict is unresolved. Second, what *you* receive at the end is a personalised **Plum Profile** — your top-3 Talents, your preferred working environment and style, and some self-reflection/interview prompts — not a Match Score (the Match Score lives on the recruiter's side). `[PREP-VENDOR + VENDOR]`

7.5 Is it tailored to the role?

Yes — and the tailoring lives entirely on the employer's side, not in the questions you answer. This is the architectural heart of Plum and the thing that most distinguishes it from every other provider in this guide. Your Discovery Survey is **identical regardless of the role** — the same ~25 minutes, the same five sections, the same items. What varies is how your resulting profile is *scored against* a role, and that is defined by a separate employer-side instrument called the **Match Criteria Survey**.

Here is the mechanism. Before hiring for a role, the employer asks its own **internal experts and top performers** to complete a short **~6–8 minute Match Criteria Survey** that defines the behavioural requirements of that role; the aggregated results reveal the **top 5 Talents** most critical for it. `[VENDOR/PREP-VENDOR]` Plum's best-practice guidance is a **minimum of 3, ideally around 8 contributors** per role, and specifically that **top performers** (not average incumbents) complete it, so that "high performers define what a top performer looks like." `[VENDOR – help-centre "Match Criteria Best Practices"]` Then the same candidate Discovery profile — those 12 Talent scores — is **scored differently per role**: the Match Score is the alignment between your Talent set and that role's ranked top-5 Talents. `[VENDOR – FairNow system description: "the Talent Match model combines candidate Talent results and the ranked Talents from the employer to calculate scores reflecting alignment"]` One profile, many role-specific Match Scores.

The practical consequences for you are unusual and worth spelling out. First, **you cannot tailor your answers to a role**, because you do not know (and the survey does not reveal) which five Talents that firm's top performers prioritised — this is the "role-hidden scoring" that makes gaming largely futile (§7.7). Second, the quality of your Match Score depends on people you never meet: if a firm defined a role's Match Criteria from only three raters, or from incumbents who are not genuinely its best performers, the "ideal profile" you are being matched against may be mis-specified (§7.9). Third, because the same profile is reused everywhere, tailoring is structurally impossible across employers — you are one fixed profile, refracted through many different role lenses.

7.6 How they screen and filter — scoring, norms, cut-offs, ranking

This is the section to read twice, because Plum's scoring logic is genuinely different from the norm-referenced percentile model that dominates the rest of this guide.

The Match Score. Each candidate-per-role receives a single **Match Score**. The audited operational range is **30–99** ("each application receives a score ranging from 30 to 99"), while Plum's candidate-facing help-centre states **1–99** — a mild conflict best resolved by using **30–99** as the technically-audited range and treating 1–99 as the marketing statement. `[INDEPENDENT audit = 30–99; VENDOR help-centre = 1–99]` Plum's published interpretation benchmarks are **above 80 = strong** (it suggests shortlisting a candidate scoring >80 whose other specifications are met) and **61 = average**. `[VENDOR — help-centre "What are Match Scores"]`

Crucially: it is NOT a percentile and NOT pass/fail. In Plum's own words (via the FairNow audit), "there is **not a designated pass/fail cutoff**; all candidates are shown to the recruiter, **ranked by Match Score**." `[VENDOR-verbatim via FairNow]` The number is *fit to this specific role*, not your rank against a demographic norm sample — there is no traditional norm group and no percentile. `[INDEPENDENT — FairNow]` This is why the "at a glance" finance cut-off is `[UNKNOWN]`: no fixed percentile floor exists to quote. The recruiter sees the whole applicant pool as a ranked list and decides how far down it to go — so the *effective* bar is a function of pool size and the number of seats, not a published threshold. For a competitive early-careers finance requisition, the safe assumption is that only the upper reaches of that ranked list advance, which — given the >80 = "strong" benchmark — means you want to be comfortably into the 80s, but that is `[INFERRED]` directional advice, not a documented cut-score.

The reusable profile. The Discovery Survey **only needs to be completed once**; the resulting Plum Profile is **reusable across all employers that use Plum**, precisely because the raw results "are not job-specific until combined with the employer's Match Criteria." `[VENDOR — help-centre]` You can link an existing profile to a new account or email and submit it to new applications without retaking. This is a real convenience — you are not re-sitting a 25-minute survey for every firm — but it has a sharp implication covered in §7.9: **a single profile carries everywhere**, so a coached or unrepresentative run persists across every Plum employer you apply to.

Retake and norms. You cannot re-do the survey immediately; prep vendors report a **retake is possible after roughly one year**, and re-doing it changes your profile. `[PREP-VENDOR — assessmentcentrehq "after a year or more"; VENDOR help-centre confirms results change on re-do]` There is **no norm-group percentile** at all — scoring is relative to the role's Match Criteria, not a demographic sample. (The only place a "median" enters is the FairNow bias audit, which used "scoring rate vs the sample median" purely as an audit methodology under NYC Local Law 144, not as any operational cut-off — see §7.8.) `[INDEPENDENT — FairNow]`

Multi-hurdle vs compensatory. Within the Discovery Survey the instruments blend into one Match Score, so it behaves as a single composite gate rather than separate cognitive/personality hurdles. But in a real pipeline the Plum survey is usually one stage among several (application form → Plum → video interview → assessment centre), and those later stages are independent gates — a strong Match Score does not rescue a weak video interview. `[INFERRED — standard multi-stage design]`

7.7 How to score well — legitimate, specific, actionable

The good news is that Plum is, more than almost any provider in this guide, an **authenticity-based** instrument — and that is not a platitude, it follows mechanically from how it scores.

Answer the personality and SJT sections honestly, because gaming is genuinely futile here. Three design features stack against faking. First, the scoring is *fit to a specific role's* top-5 Talents that you cannot see (§7.5), so you literally do not know which direction "good" points — as one prep source puts it, "you can't get a perfect score … what each employer is looking for is different." `[PREP-VENDOR – assessmentcentrehq]` Second, the forced-choice most/least (ipsative) format resists uniform "fake good" — you cannot rate every desirable statement highly, you must trade them off. `[INFERRED re: ipsative resistance]` Third, the Match Score blends multiple instruments, so pushing one dimension does not lift the whole. The winning strategy is therefore the honest one: answer as your genuine self, decisively, without trying to reverse-engineer an "ideal analyst" you cannot see.

The one part you can and should practise is the cognitive/problem-solving section (sections 2 and 4) — the abstract-reasoning, next-in-series and matrix items, which are the only objectively right/wrong content. `[PREP-VENDOR]` Prep vendors sell practice packs specifically for these plus the SJT, and they are worth a few sessions because pattern-completion improves quickly with exposure: train yourself to check each dimension of a sequence separately (shape, count, position, shading, rotation) rather than hunting for a single gestalt — the same discipline set out for SHL inductive items in Chapter 1.7. Because the section is short (~14 items total) and untimed, accuracy is everything and there is no speed pressure to manage.

On the SJT (section 5), answer for best practice, not for yourself. The reliable tip across prep sources is to answer "what *should* I do" (the most effective response) rather than "what *would* I do." `[PREP-VENDOR – jobtestprep]` When ranking responses most-to-least effective, lead with options showing ownership, constructive communication and sound judgement, and bottom-rank avoidance, blame-shifting or rash escalation — the same SJT logic developed for Cappfinity in Chapter 5.7.

Set-up. Because it is untimed and unproctored, the set-up bar is low: a rested, distraction-free environment and a stable connection, and the deliberate mindset to think rather than rush. `[PREP-VENDOR]` There is no calculator question (no numerical-computation section) and no clock to pace against.

7.8 Integrity monitoring — what Plum actually detects

Here is a genuine relief for anyone who has previously been flagged on a webcam-proctored test: **Plum is typically UNPROCTORED, and its false-positive catalogue is correspondingly small.** No candidate or prep source describes webcam monitoring, screen-lockdown, tab-switch telemetry or keystroke logging for the Discovery Survey; it is an untimed, remote, email-link questionnaire. `[INFERRED from consistent absence across all sources; PREP-VENDOR silence]` Plum's anti-faking strategy is built into the **design, not into surveillance**: the ipsative forced-choice format, the role-hidden scoring, and the multi-instrument blend (all covered in §7.7) are what make the instrument hard to game, without ever watching you. `[INFERRED]` The cognitive section — the only objectively-scored content — is short (~14 items) and untimed, which limits its integrity exposure in the first place. `[PREP-VENDOR]`

This means the sprawling proctoring false-positive catalogue that dominates the SHL chapter (Chapter 1.9 — gaze-off-screen flags, second-face detection, skin-tone disparities in face detection, disability-related movement misread as suspicious) **largely does not apply to Plum**, because there is no webcam layer to generate those flags.

If you were wrongly flagged on a HireVue or a proctored SHL sitting, a Plum survey carries almost none of that risk. The honest caveat is that **no explicit vendor statement on proctoring, honesty/consistency scales, or response-pattern flagging could be located** — Plum's help pages returned HTTP 403 to automated fetch during research — so "unproctored, no response-pattern flagging" is a well-supported inference from the absence of any contrary evidence, not a confirmed vendor position. `[UNKNOWN for definitive integrity mechanics]`

The stronger, positively-documented integrity point runs the other way, and it is a real credit to Plum: an **independent bias audit by FairNow**, dated **7 November 2024** and aligned to **NYC Local Law 144** (the automated-employment-decision-tool law), examined Plum's Talent Match model and **found no evidence of disparate impact.** `[INDEPENDENT – FairNow PDF, hosted at use.plum.io]` The audit ran on **528,891 US applications** (22 Aug 2023–13 Sep 2024), of which 28,881 carried gender/race demographics, and reported that **no group's selection rate fell below 80% of the most-favoured group** (the four-fifths rule) across race, gender or their intersections. Gender impact ratios were Female 95.9% against Male 100% (reference); race ratios ran from White 97.2% and Asian 87.2% down to **Black/African-American 83.2%** (the lowest univariate figure, still above the 80% threshold), with the lowest intersectional cell — **Black female at 82.3%** — also clearing the four-fifths rule. `[INDEPENDENT – FairNow]` The stated caveat is that the demographic data was self-reported by Plum and FairNow did not independently verify its completeness. `[INDEPENDENT – FairNow, caveat in report]` Even with that caveat, a large-sample, independently-conducted, publicly-posted disparate-impact audit is a genuine strength that very few providers in this guide can point to — SHL's chapter, for instance, logs the *absence* of such an audit as a gap.

7.9 How candidates commonly trip the system — including honestly

Because Plum is unproctored and hard-to-fake by design, the classic false-positive catalogue is short — but the risks that remain are structural rather than behavioural, and worth understanding precisely because you cannot see them operating.

- **Being matched against a badly-specified role template.** Your Match Score depends entirely on the quality of the employer's Match Criteria Survey, which can be defined by as few as three internal raters (§7.5). A mis-specified "ideal profile" propagates silently: you could rank poorly against a flawed top-5-Talent template despite being a strong real-world fit, or rank highly against one and still be a poor fit. This is a structural false-positive/false-negative vector you have no visibility into and no control over. `[INFERRED – no direct source]`
- **Incumbent cloning / homogeneity risk.** The "top performers define the role" approach (§7.5) risks reproducing the profile of existing post-holders, narrowing rather than widening the funnel. The FairNow audit (§7.8) is partial mitigation — it found no disparate impact on protected characteristics — but a bias audit checks legal adverse impact, not whether the model quietly favours candidates who resemble current incumbents on non-protected dimensions. `[INFERRED]`
- **The reusable profile carries a bad day everywhere.** Because one Discovery profile is submitted across all Plum employers (§7.6), a single unrepresentative sitting — done while ill, distracted, rushed or over-coached — persists across every application until you can re-do it (~1 year). There is no per-employer re-roll. The corollary is a positive instruction: **sit it once, properly, rested** — see §7.10. `[INFERRED]`
- **Ipsative scoring masks *why* you scored as you did.** The forced most/least format limits cross-candidate comparability of raw traits, and the Match Score abstracts the detail away, so neither you nor (easily) the

recruiter can see which trait drove a low match — which makes a disappointing result hard to diagnose or contest. `[INFERRED]`

The reassuring counterpoint: none of these is an "integrity flag" that gets you *accused* of anything. Unlike a proctored test, a poor Plum outcome is a **fit/score result**, not a suspicion of cheating — so if you have previously been rejected under a cloud of a proctoring flag, understand that Plum simply does not have that failure mode.

7.10 How to be unambiguously clean

The proctoring surface here is minimal, so — as with Cappfinity (Chapter 5.10) — the checklist is short, and it is about *quality of sitting* rather than defending against surveillance.

- **Sit it once, properly, and rested.** Because the profile is reusable across every Plum employer and cannot be re-done for about a year (§7.6, §7.9), this is not a low-stakes practice run — the profile you generate is the one every Plum firm will see. Do it distraction-free, in a single unhurried sitting, when you are genuinely sharp.
- **Answer authentically and consistently.** The only meaningful "integrity" signal is internal consistency (there is no webcam, no tab-monitoring), so your cleanest and highest-scoring strategy is your genuine, honest self answered decisively — trying to project a fabricated profile you cannot hold consistently across sections is both futile (role-hidden scoring) and self-defeating.
- **Use the untimed design.** There is no clock; read each item properly, especially the SJT rankings and the most/least forced-choice blocks. Rushing an untimed test gains you nothing.
- **Request adjustments in writing in advance** if you have a condition affecting reading or processing. The untimed format inherently removes speed pressure, which helps some needs, but **no specific reasonable-adjustment or alternative-format process is documented** in any source located — Plum's help pages were not fetchable during research. `[UNKNOWN — gap]` That undocumented status is itself the reason to make any request explicit and early, routed through the employer's recruitment team citing the Equality Act 2010 (template in §7.11).

7.11 If you are flagged or rejected

Because the stage is unproctored, a Plum rejection is almost always a **fit/score outcome, not an integrity flag** — so the route is a feedback query and, if you want the underlying data, a data-subject access request. Your rights are the UK ones set out in full in Chapter 6.7; this is the Plum-specific playbook, and it applies whether the data controller is the employer, Plum, or (post-April-2026) Phenom.

First, ask — plainly. Email the employer's recruitment team, reference your application, and ask whether the Plum assessment contributed to the decision, what your Match Score was, and whether reapplication in a future cycle is possible. Firms are not obliged to answer in detail, but many will, and asking creates a record.

Then use your data-protection rights. Under **UK GDPR Article 15 (right of access)** you can submit a **Data Subject Access Request (DSAR)** to the **employer** (the data controller), who must respond within **one month**, free of charge. Ask specifically for: your **Talent scores and Match Score**; the **role's Match Criteria / the top-5 Talents you were assessed against**; the **logic of any automated decision-making**; and confirmation of **whether a human was involved** in the decision. Where a rejection was based *solely* on automated processing (an auto-reject with no human looking), the safeguards in **Articles 22A–22C of the UK GDPR — as amended by the**

Data (Use and Access) Act 2025, in force 5 February 2026 — entitle you to make representations, **obtain human intervention**, and contest the decision. The old blanket "Article 22 prohibition" framing is out of date; the current position is in Chapter 6.7. `[REGULATORY — DUAA 2025]` Note two Plum-specific data wrinkles worth raising: Plum is **Canada-headquartered with US data processing**, which raises international-transfer/adequacy questions for a UK/EU applicant's data, and the specific lawful basis, retention period and data-residency detail were **not locatable** during research (help pages 403'd) — so it is entirely reasonable to ask for them expressly. `[UNKNOWN — verify directly]` If the employer stonewalls, you can complain to the **Information Commissioner's Office (ICO)**.

Disclosing a disability. If something about your circumstances affected the sitting, disclosing it and requesting a reasonable adjustment under the **Equality Act 2010** is often the most effective route to a re-sit or reconsideration, because the duty to make reasonable adjustments is a legal obligation, not a favour — and it matters the more here because Plum documents no adjustment process of its own (§7.10).

Realistic expectations. As elsewhere, straightforward fit rejections are rarely overturned — the firm had more well-matched applicants than seats. The higher-value use of these rights is usually **evidence for next time** and, given the reusable profile, understanding whether it is your *profile* or a particular firm's *Match Criteria* that let you down.

Template wording.

(a) Pre-assessment adjustments request (send before you sit):

> Subject: Reasonable adjustment request — [name], [role/ref] Dear [team], I have been invited to complete a Plum (Discovery Survey) online assessment for [role]. I have [condition, e.g. dyslexia / ADHD / a visual impairment], and under the Equality Act 2010 I request reasonable adjustments — specifically [e.g. an accessible/alternative format; confirmation the assessment is untimed; a screen-reader-compatible version]. I can provide supporting documentation. Please confirm what can be arranged and the revised deadline. Thank you.

(b) Post-rejection query:

> Subject: Assessment outcome — request for information — [name], [ref] Dear [team], Thank you for the update on my application. So that I can improve, please could you tell me whether my Plum assessment (Match Score) contributed to the decision, and whether reapplication in a future cycle is possible. I'd be grateful for any feedback. Thank you.

(c) DSAR (escalation):

> Subject: Data Subject Access Request — [name], [ref] Dear [team], Under Article 15 of the UK GDPR I request access to the personal data you (and your assessment provider, Plum/Phenom) hold about my application, specifically: my Talent scores and Match Score; the role's Match Criteria / the Talents I was assessed against; the logic of any automated decision-making (Articles 22A–22C UK GDPR, as amended by the Data (Use and Access) Act 2025) and whether a human was involved; and the lawful basis, retention period and any international transfer (Canada/US) of my data. Please respond within one month. Thank you.

7.12 Step-by-step: how to win this assessment

A numbered playbook, adapted to Plum's unusual once-only, untimed, fit-based nature.

1. **T-minus 10 days — understand what you're sitting.** Confirm from your invitation whether it is genuinely the Plum Discovery Survey (branding may now say Phenom). Internalise the model: five sections, untimed, ~25 minutes, and — critically — **one profile reused across every Plum employer**, so this is not a throwaway run.
2. **T-9 to T-4 — drill only the coachable part.** The personality and SJT sections are authenticity-based and cannot be usefully practised, so spend your prep on the **cognitive/next-in-series** section: abstract reasoning, matrices, sequence completion, ~15 minutes daily. Check each dimension of a pattern separately (shape, count, position, shading, rotation). Add a few SJT sets, practising the "what *should* I do" logic.
3. **T-4 — read the SJT logic, not a firm framework.** Unlike Cappfinity, there is no published firm strengths-framework to reverse-engineer here (the role's top-5 Talents are hidden), so do not waste time hunting one. Instead rehearse general best-practice SJT judgement: ownership, constructive communication, sound judgement to the top; avoidance and blame to the bottom.
4. **T-2 — logistics and adjustments.** If you need an adjustment, send the §7.11(a) request now — and because Plum documents no adjustment route, send it early and explicitly. Protect an uninterrupted ~30-minute window and a stable connection.
5. **Day before — prepare to sit clean.** This is a once-a-year profile, so treat it seriously: clear the desk, silence notifications, get a normal night's sleep. There is no calculator or scratch-paper question to resolve (no numerical-computation section) and no clock.
6. **At the sitting — think, don't rush.** It is untimed, so read every item properly. On the forced most/least blocks, answer honestly and decisively — do not try to game a "good" answer you cannot see the target for. On the cognitive items, prioritise accuracy over speed (there is no speed pressure). On the SJT, apply best-practice judgement.
7. **Be genuinely yourself on personality.** The whole scoring model rewards authentic fit to a hidden role profile; a fabricated profile is both futile (role-hidden scoring, ipsative format) and permanent (reusable across employers for ~a year). Your best score *is* your honest, decisive self.
8. **Rolling-deadline note.** As across UK early-careers finance, most schemes sift on a rolling basis — **complete the survey and apply early**; and remember that once your Plum Profile exists you can reuse it across other Plum employers without re-sitting (§6.8 develops the rolling-deadline trade-off).
9. **Debrief.** Note the actual format (was it branded Plum or Phenom? how many cognitive items? which firm?) for next time and for this guide's accuracy, and record your top-3 Talents from the feedback profile — they are reusable and worth knowing before an interview that may probe them.

7.13 Sources for this chapter

All accessed 2026-08-01. Confidence tags as used above.

Vendor (primary): - Phenom — *Phenom Acquires Plum* press release (28 Apr 2026) — https://www.phenom.com/press-release/phenom-acquires-plum-ai `[VENDOR]` - Phenom — *Phenom Acquires Plum* blog (28 Apr 2026) — https://www.phenom.com/blog/phenom-acquires-plum `[VENDOR]` - Plum — help-centre article, *What are Match Scores and what is a good Match Score?* — https://help.plum.io/hc/en-us/articles/360002475734-

`[VENDOR — search-surfaced snippet; help.plum.io returned HTTP 403 to automated fetch]` - Plum — *Terms of Service* (plum.io/terms), candidate data-use FAQs, bias-audit / adverse-impact glossary & blog (plum.io/blog, plum.io/glossary/adverse-impact) `[VENDOR — not fully fetchable this session]` - Plum — VentureBeat founder interview (fit-not-résumé thesis) `[VENDOR]`

Independent: - FairNow — *Plum Talent Match — Bias Audit* (PDF, dated 7 Nov 2024; NYC Local Law 144; 528,891 US applications; system description confirming FFM, 12 Talents, 30–99 scale, no pass/fail; four-fifths-rule impact ratios) — https://use.plum.io/hubfs/Resources/Audit/2024-2025/Plum-Talent-Match-bias-audit-nov-2024.pdf `[INDEPENDENT — single best primary doc]` - BetaKit — *Plum acquired by US-based Phenom* (acquisition, corporate history, funding, clients Scotiabank/Hyundai/Whirlpool) — https://betakit.com/plum-acquired-by-us-based-phenom-to-reduce-bad-hires-in-the-age-of-ai/ `[INDEPENDENT]` - technical.ly / The Logic / Nucleus Research / GlobeNewswire — acquisition coverage and "Hot Company to Watch 2023" `[INDEPENDENT]` - G2 — Plum profile (~4.4/5, ~71 reviews) `[INDEPENDENT]`

Prep-vendor (format detail; corroborate — commercially biased): - JobTestPrep — *Plum Assessment* (Discovery Survey mechanics) — https://www.jobtestprep.com/plum-assessment - JobTestPrep UK — *Citi Assessment Centre* (Citi=Plum claim) — https://www.jobtestprep.co.uk/citi-assessment-centre ; *Bloomberg Plum Assessment* — https://www.jobtestprep.co.uk/bloomberg-plum-assessment - AptitudePrep, AssessmentCentreHQ, AssessmentPass — five-section structure, "10 Talents," retake-after-a-year, "only logic puzzles objectively scored," SJT "should not would" - GraduatesFirst — describes **Citi** assessments as "powered by Korn Ferry Talent Q" — the source-conflict on Citi's provider (§7.3)

Candidate (testimony; thin): - The Student Room — *Citi Graduate 2024* thread, applicants referring to a "plum test" — https://www.thestudentroom.co.uk/showthread.php?t=7409364 `[CANDIDATE, n≥1 — page 403'd to fetch, via search snippet]` - LinkedIn — applicants sharing "my top Plum Talent" results, incl. Bloomberg (e.g. Sachin Heer, 2023) `[CANDIDATE, n≥1]`

(Residual Plum gaps — help.plum.io 403'd, so Discovery FAQ / retake / profile-use / proctoring / bias-audit help pages are reconstructed from prep-vendor paraphrase + the FairNow audit + search snippets; the 10-vs-12 Talent count, the 1–99 vs 30–99 Match Score range, the Citi-provider identity (Plum vs Korn Ferry Talent Q), pricing (undisclosed), UK-GDPR lawful-basis/retention/transfer specifics, any documented reasonable-adjustment route, the unverified "4× more predictive than a resume" claim, and post-Phenom branding — are logged in research/07-plum.md and the master gap register.)

Chapter 8 — HireVue

Confidence tags (full explanation in Chapter 1): `[VENDOR]` / `[INDEPENDENT]` / `[CANDIDATE, n=X]` / `[INFERRED]` / `[UNKNOWN]` / `[PREP-VENDOR]`.

At a glance — HireVue

What it is	The dominant **asynchronous ("one-way") video interview** platform, plus game-based and coding assessments. Owned by The Carlyle Group. You record answers to preset questions on your own time; no live interviewer.
Where in the funnel	Very common early-mid stage in UK finance grad/intern pipelines: after the application form and aptitude tests, before the assessment centre / final round.
Format & timing	Typically **3–5 questions** (UK banks often 5–8); **~20–30 sec** think time; **~60–180 sec** to answer; recording **auto-stops**. Usually **one take, no re-record** (employer-configurable). ~10–30 min total.
Scoring model	**Content/language-based now** — your answer transcript analysed by NLP against IO-psychologist competencies, and/or **human-reviewed**. Facial/emotion analysis **discontinued 2021**. "Uses HireVue" ≠ "AI-scored" — many bank deployments are humans watching video.
Typical finance cut-off	`[UNKNOWN]` — competency ranking, not a percentile; used to prioritise reviewer attention, rarely a hard auto-reject.
Integrity posture	Optional: **browser focus / tab-switch logging, webcam ID snapshots, presence check**. Camera+audio only — **not** screen recording, **not** eye-tracking/emotion analysis. Flags go to a human; no auto-reject on a tab-switch.
Retake	Employer-set; generally **no candidate-initiated retake** after submission. Unlimited unscored **practice** questions beforehand.
Top 5 tips	1) Structure every answer STAR/CARL; lead with a one-sentence headline. 2) Do the practice questions to settle nerves and check kit. 3) Look **into the lens**, eye-level camera, light in front. 4) One take — if you fumble, keep going; substance is scored, not restarts. 5) Prepare 6–8 competency stories (teamwork, drive, commercial awareness, "why this firm").

(Every figure above is unpacked, sourced and confidence-tagged below. This is one of the most universally-encountered stages in UK finance recruiting.)

8.1 Snapshot

HireVue is the company most UK finance applicants mean when they say "I've got a video interview." It is an American platform (founded around 2004 in Utah), majority-owned since 2019 by the private-equity house **The**

Carlyle Group. `[INDEPENDENT/VENDOR — Carlyle press release, 2019-09-03]` Its flagship product is the **on-demand (asynchronous) video interview**: you are sent a set of preset questions, and you record your answers to a webcam on your own time, with no live interviewer on the other end. Around that it sells **game-based psychometric assessments** (built on its ~2018 acquisition of the London games firm **MindX**), **coding assessments** ("CodeVue"), and immersive job-simulation ("Virtual Job Tryout") products. `[VENDOR]`

For a finance candidate, HireVue's async video typically sits in the **middle of the funnel** — after your application form and any aptitude tests, before the assessment centre or final-round "superday." It is short (roughly 10–30 minutes depending on question count) but disproportionately decisive, because it is often the first point at which a human forms an impression of you as a person rather than a CV.

The single most important thing to understand about HireVue is what changed in 2021 — and it is genuinely good news for anyone who has feared being judged on their face. This chapter keeps *current* and *legacy* rigorously separate, because most of the frightening things written about HireVue online describe a product that no longer exists.

8.2 Why this test exists

The problem HireVue solves is the **live-interview bottleneck**. A bank running a graduate campaign cannot put thousands of applicants in front of interviewers for a first-round chat — the scheduling and interviewer hours are prohibitive. An asynchronous video interview lets every candidate answer the **same** questions, recorded, reviewed whenever a recruiter has time. `[VENDOR/INFERRED]`

The deeper justification is about **structure**. HireVue's design logic is that its IO (industrial-organisational) psychologists define the critical competencies for a role, questions are written to elicit evidence of those competencies, and answers are scored against a rubric. `[VENDOR]` This matters because the IO-psychology evidence is clear that **structured** interviews — same questions, defined scoring — substantially out-predict the free-form "let's just chat" **unstructured** interview, which is one of the *weakest* common selection methods despite being the most beloved. (See Chapter 6.3 on validity, including the 2022 Sackett et al. re-analysis that trimmed several long-quoted validity figures.) `[INDEPENDENT — general literature; no HireVue-specific independent criterion-validity study could be located, [UNKNOWN]]` So in principle a HireVue is a fairer, more consistent first round than a rushed phone call with a tired associate. In practice its fairness depends entirely on how the employer configures it — which the rest of this chapter unpacks.

8.3 Why a firm chooses HireVue specifically

Three things sell HireVue to a risk-averse bank. First, **scale and asynchronicity** — thousands of first-round interviews with no interviewer scheduling. Second, **ATS integration** — it plugs into the applicant-tracking systems banks already run (specific named integrations were not captured this pass, `[UNKNOWN]`). Third, and increasingly the decisive one, a **"human-centric, audit-defensible" posture** adopted after the facial-analysis controversy (§8.6, §8.9): HireVue now markets that it has removed facial analysis, scores on language content, keeps a human in the loop, and **commissions and publishes external bias audits**. For a bank whose legal and DEI functions have to defend every selection tool, that compliance story is a feature, not marketing fluff. `[VENDOR PR — treat the "audit-defensible" claim as a repositioning, corroborated below]`

Named finance users recur across candidate and prep sources — **Goldman Sachs, J.P. Morgan, Morgan Stanley, Bank of America, Barclays, HSBC** among them — but see §8.11 for the important caveats about volatility and about "uses HireVue" not meaning "AI-scored." `[PREP-VENDOR / CANDIDATE]`

8.4 What the assessment actually is — full mechanics

The async video interview (what you'll almost certainly get)

Question types. Predominantly **behavioural/competency** — "tell me about a time you worked in a team," "why this firm," "why investment banking," "walk me through your CV" — with some **commercial-awareness** questions ("tell us about a recent deal or market that interests you") and, depending on the division, occasional light technical content. `[CANDIDATE / PREP-VENDOR, many agreeing]`

Numbers and timing (all employer-configurable, so treat as typical, not universal):

Parameter	Typical	Notes
Number of questions	**3–5** (IB grad/intern); UK banks often **5–8**	Barclays reported ~5–8; BofA ~5 `[PREP-VENDOR/CANDIDATE]`
Think/prep time per question	**~20–30 seconds**	Employer-set `[consistent]`
Answer/recording time	**~60–180 seconds** (often 90 sec or "up to 2–3 min")	Recording **auto-stops** at the limit `[consistent]`
Takes per question	Usually **one, no re-record**; some employers allow limited re-records	Whether reviewers see how many takes you used is **`[UNKNOWN]`**
Practice questions	**Yes — unlimited**, not uploaded, not scored, not seen by employer	Always do them `[PREP-VENDOR summarising HireVue help centre]`

Human-reviewed vs AI-scored — the distinction to burn into memory. All three configurations exist, chosen by the employer: your answer may be (a) **transcribed and AI-scored via NLP** against competencies, (b) **watched and scored by a human recruiter**, or (c) both. **Many UK bank deployments use HireVue purely as a recording-and-delivery tool with humans doing the judging.** So "Firm X uses HireVue" tells you nothing certain about whether an algorithm scored you. `[INFERRED from HireVue's configurability + candidate reports of human next-round invitations]`

Game-based and coding assessments

Separately, HireVue offers a battery of short **psychometric games** measuring cognitive abilities and emotional-intelligence traits; there is **no fixed game count** (new games are added over time, so prep-site claims of "~13 games" are `[PREP-VENDOR, unverified]`). Its **CodeVue** product is a library of 200+ auto-scored coding challenges for technical/quant roles. `[VENDOR]` For front-office IBD you are unlikely to meet these; for technology and quant streams you may.

A realistic walkthrough

You get an invitation with a deadline (often a few days). You log in, confirm identity and consent to the terms (which include any monitoring), and are offered **practice questions** — do them, unlimited, unscored, to settle nerves and test your camera, mic and lighting. Then the real interview: a question appears, you get ~20–30 seconds to gather your thoughts (a countdown shows), then recording starts automatically and you have ~60–180 seconds. When you finish or the timer hits zero, it moves on. Usually you cannot re-record. At the end you submit; you almost never see a score. `[CANDIDATE/PREP-VENDOR consistent]`

8.5 Is it tailored to the role?

Same engine, employer-configured surface. The questions, competencies, number of questions, prep and answer times, whether re-records are allowed, and whether integrity monitoring is switched on are **all set by the employer**. `[PREP-VENDOR/CANDIDATE consistent]` The scoring rubric can be customised to the role by HireVue's IO team or drawn from off-the-shelf competency libraries. The practical consequence: **the experience of "a HireVue" varies widely between banks** — do not assume the timings a friend describes for one firm apply to yours. Read *your* invitation's instructions carefully; they state the actual parameters.

8.6 How they screen and filter — scoring, norms, cut-offs, ranking

Current scoring is content-based. Since 2021, the primary signal is **what you say** — your answer is transcribed and, where AI scoring is enabled, analysed by natural-language processing (NLP) and mapped to the role's competencies. Facial expression, gaze and other visual features were **removed from the algorithms.** `[INDEPENDENT — SHRM: NLP is now the primary analytical method]`

The reason they were removed is quantitatively revealing and worth carrying with you into the room. HireVue's own chief data scientist stated that non-verbal/visual data contributed only about **0.25% of predictive power** relative to the content of your answers (rising to a few percent for some customer-facing roles), and the CEO said that given the controversy "it wasn't worth the incremental value." `[INDEPENDENT — Fortune, 2021-01-19]` In other words: even by the vendor's own account, **how you looked barely mattered — what you said was essentially the whole signal.** That should reframe your preparation entirely toward substance.

What the recruiter sees: competency scores and a candidate ranking, the recorded video for human review, and any integrity flags if enabled. The exact score scale and report format were not captured, `[UNKNOWN]`. **Human review is now central** — and, under the emerging EU regime (Chapter 6.7), legally load-bearing: a recruiter who merely rubber-stamps an AI ranking has not provided the "meaningful human involvement" that keeps the decision out of the strict solely-automated regime. `[INDEPENDENT]` The ranking is generally used to **prioritise reviewer attention**, not to auto-reject. **Retake:** employer-set; typically no candidate-initiated retake once submitted. `[PREP-VENDOR]`

The funnel point (per your §5.6 brief). In most finance pipelines the HireVue is **not the tightest cut** — the CV/application screen ahead of it and the assessment centre behind it usually remove more people. But it is a genuine gate, and because it is where your personality and communication first show, a weak HireVue can sink an otherwise strong application. Treat it as high-leverage-per-minute rather than as the main hurdle. (Chapter 6.8 maps where each firm's real chokepoint sits.)

8.7 How to score well — legitimate, specific, actionable

Structure under time pressure is everything. With ~30 seconds to think and ~60–90 to answer, you cannot ramble. Use **STAR** (Situation, Task, Action, Result) or **CARL** (Context, Action, Result, Learning) as a skeleton so every answer has a point and a payoff. `[PREP-VENDOR consensus]`

Lead with a headline. Open with a single sentence that directly answers the question, *then* tell the story. Reviewers skim and NLP weights early content; a crisp thesis in the first ~10 seconds ("The team I'm proudest of is a five-person consulting project where I led the financial modelling…") beats a slow wind-up.

Prepare your story bank. Draft and rehearse **6–8 concise competency stories** covering teamwork, leadership, drive/resilience, a failure and what you learned, commercial awareness, and a firm-specific "why us/why this division." Most HireVue questions are recombinations of these.

Pacing: aim for roughly **100–125 words per minute** — fast enough to say something substantial in 90 seconds, slow enough to be transcribed accurately (relevant now that scoring is transcript-based). Practise five questions with a stopwatch at 30 seconds prep / 90 seconds answer. `[PREP-VENDOR]`

Framing, lighting, eye-line — still matter, but for the *human* reviewer, not an emotion algorithm. Put a soft light in front of you (a window works), set the camera at eye level, and **look into the lens, not at your own image on screen** — it reads as eye contact. Neutral background, tested mic. None of this is scored by the algorithm any more, but a human is often watching, and clarity helps them.

Recovering from a fumble. If there's no re-record and you stumble, **keep going** — the substance is what's scored. A simple reset phrase ("let me put that more clearly") is fine; dead silence or restarting from panic is worse.

Worked example — weak vs strong (author-constructed illustration, `[INFERRED]`). - *Weak:* "Umm, I guess I work well in teams — at uni we did a group project and it went fine, everyone was happy." No structure, no result, no evidence. - *Strong (STAR):* "In my final-year consulting project I was made lead for a five-person deliverable to a real SME client. I split workstreams by each person's strength, ran twice-weekly stand-ups, and personally rebuilt the financial model when our numbers didn't tie. We delivered two days early and the client adopted two of our three recommendations — and I learned to delegate the analysis but own the client-facing narrative myself." Direct, structured, quantified, competency-rich.

8.8 Integrity monitoring — what HireVue actually detects

HireVue's monitoring is **optional and employer-configured**, and — critically — narrower than its reputation. Where enabled, it can:

- **Log browser focus / tab-switch events** — it records *when* your focus leaves and returns to the HireVue tab, but it **does not screen-record or see the contents of your other tabs.** `[PREP-VENDOR — AceRound, consistent]`
- **Capture periodic webcam snapshots / an ID image** to confirm a face is present and matches. `[PREP-VENDOR]`
- **Run a webcam-presence check** — flags if no face is in frame. `[PREP-VENDOR]`
- Possibly run **response-similarity/plagiarism** checks across candidates (flagging answers suspiciously similar to others', suggesting reading or coaching). `[PREP-VENDOR — single-source, treat cautiously]`

It is **camera and audio only — not full screen recording — and emphatically NOT eye-tracking or facial-expression analysis**, which were discontinued in January 2021. Any claim that HireVue "tracks your eyes" or "reads your emotions" is either legacy or myth. `[INDEPENDENT]`

How flags are actioned: flags are attached to your record and a **human at the employer decides** — HireVue does **not auto-reject** you for a tab-switch. `[PREP-VENDOR consistent]` This is a materially calmer integrity posture than a lockdown-browser exam. **Whether you're told** monitoring is on: it is usually disclosed in the terms/instructions, but candidates frequently under-notice it; the standard disclosure text was not captured this pass, `[UNKNOWN]`.

8.9 How candidates commonly trip the system — including honestly

The **good news first**, because it directly addresses a fear this guide exists to dispel: since the algorithm no longer scores your face, the classic proctoring nightmares — being flagged for atypical eye-contact, "wrong" facial expressions, or looking away to think — **no longer affect your machine score.** They can still affect a *human* reviewer's impression, but that is a different and more forgiving thing.

The genuine current risks:

- **Accent / non-native English under NLP scoring.** This is the live fairness concern now that scoring is transcript-based. HireVue's own ORCAA audit recommended investigating accent bias, and flagged that **minority candidates giving brief responses were disproportionately routed to human reviewers.** `[INDEPENDENT – Fortune]` Speech-to-text error rates are higher for some accents and dialects, and a mis-transcription can become a mis-score. **Mitigation:** speak a touch more slowly and clearly, and give fuller (not one-line) answers so there's enough content to score.
- **Stutter, disfluency, or a speech difference** — a timed, no-re-record recording plus fluency-sensitive NLP can penalise disfluency. This is a strong basis for requesting an adjustment (§8.10–8.11). `[INFERRED]`
- **Webcam ID snapshots failing in poor lighting or low contrast** — a residual risk that can disproportionately affect darker-skinned candidates and produce a false "no face" flag. Fix with front-lighting. `[INFERRED from documented face-detection disparities]`
- **Eye-line read as evasive by a human** — looking away to think is honest and no longer machine-scored, but a reviewer may read it; glancing at notes off-camera is the usual culprit.
- **Genuine cheating that is detected:** reading a scripted answer (flat delivery, eyes tracking text, similarity flags), having someone else answer (ID snapshot mismatch), or tab-switching to look things up (focus logging). None is worth it.

The documented critique history (for context and for your rights). In 2019 the privacy group **EPIC** filed an FTC complaint alleging HireVue's AI was "biased, unprovable, and not replicable" and that eye-tracking could disparately impact visually-impaired applicants. `[INDEPENDENT – EPIC; National Law Review]` Independent experts called face-scanning hiring "digital snake oil." `[INDEPENDENT – Washington Post/Harwell]` HireVue's response — dropping facial analysis and commissioning external audits (ORCAA, and from 2023 DCI Consulting under NYC's bias-audit law) — is exactly the history that makes its current posture more defensible, while the ORCAA audit's own limited scope and accent-bias caveat keep it honest. `[INDEPENDENT/vendor-commissioned]`

8.10 How to be unambiguously clean

- **Read the invitation's terms** to see whether monitoring is on and whether re-records are allowed — then behave accordingly.
- **Sit it alone, in a quiet, well-lit room**, face-lit from the front, nothing and no one else in frame, phone away.
- **Don't tab-switch** during the interview — close other applications and put notes (if any) on paper beside you, glancing minimally; a face buried in off-camera notes reads badly to humans anyway.
- **Look into the lens**, camera at eye level, stable connection (a mid-answer disconnection on a no-re-record question is costly).

- **Request adjustments in advance** if you have a stutter, a speech difference, a disability affecting speech/pace, or anxiety that a re-record allowance would ease — in writing, before you sit (template in §8.11). This is the single most protective step for a previously-flagged or disadvantaged candidate.

8.11 If you are flagged or rejected

Your full rights are in Chapter 6.7; the HireVue-specific points:

- **Ask for feedback and human review.** If you suspect an integrity flag or an AI score decided it, email the recruiter and, where the decision may have been solely automated, invoke the **Article 22C safeguards** (UK GDPR as amended by the Data (Use and Access) Act 2025) — the right to make representations, **obtain human intervention**, and contest. Because HireVue markets human-in-the-loop, most bank deployments are *not* solely automated, but asking forces them to confirm a human reviewed you.
- **DSAR (Article 15).** Request your **recording and transcript**, any **AI-derived competency scores**, the **integrity flag log** (focus events, snapshots, similarity scores), and confirmation of human involvement. One month, free.
- **Special-category angle.** If a speech difference or disability effectively caused the flag or low score, that can bring **special-category data** into play, where the automated-decision rules are stricter (Chapter 6.7) — a stronger argument.
- **US transparency as leverage.** Under the **Illinois AI Video Interview Act**, employers using AI video analysis must disclose it, explain it, obtain consent, and delete recordings within 30 days on request — banks with US operations often standardise these notices, so the transparency you're owed may already be documented. And a bulge-bracket's **NYC Local Law 144 bias audit** for the HireVue tool may be published online.

Template — pre-assessment adjustment request:

> Subject: Reasonable adjustment request — [name], [role/ref] Dear [team], I've been invited to complete a HireVue video interview for [role]. I have [a stutter / a speech difference / a disability affecting speech and pacing / significant anxiety], which the timed, single-take recording format disadvantages. Under the Equality Act 2010 I request [additional answer time / the ability to re-record / an alternative interview format]. I can provide documentation. Please confirm what can be arranged and the deadline.

Template — post-rejection query / human review:

> Subject: Interview outcome — request for review and data — [name], [ref] Dear [team], Thank you for the update. If my HireVue was assessed with any automated scoring, I request confirmation that a human reviewed the outcome, and — under Articles 22A–22C UK GDPR (as amended by the Data (Use and Access) Act 2025) — I wish to make representations and obtain human intervention. Separately, under Article 15 I request my recording and transcript, any competency scores, and any integrity flag log. Please respond within one month.

8.12 Step-by-step: how to win this assessment

1. **T-minus 10 days — build your story bank.** Draft 6–8 STAR/CARL stories (teamwork, leadership, resilience, failure/learning, commercial awareness, "why this firm/division"). Keep each to ~90 seconds spoken.
2. **T-9 to T-4 — rehearse to camera.** Record yourself answering common questions on your phone at 30 sec prep / 90 sec answer. Watch them back for the three things that matter: did you answer the question in the first sentence, was there a clear result, did you stay in time. Trim ruthlessly.
3. **T-5 — research the firm.** Note its stated values/competencies and one or two recent deals or market themes — commercial-awareness questions reward specificity.
4. **T-4 — logistics + adjustments.** If you need an adjustment (speech, anxiety, disability), send the §8.11 request now. Confirm your webcam, mic, lighting and a stable connection.
5. **T-2 — full simulation.** Do a complete run in your real setup at your sharpest time of day. Fix lighting/eye-line/background problems now.
6. **Day before.** Charge the laptop, test the connection, set up the room and light, put brief bullet prompts (not scripts) on paper beside the camera, sleep.
7. **30 minutes before.** Close every other application and tab. Silence the phone. Do the **practice questions** to warm up and confirm kit. Water nearby.
8. **In-interview decision rules.** Use the think-time to pick your story and headline. Answer the question in sentence one. Keep to STAR. Look into the lens. If you fumble and can't re-record, reset in one phrase and continue — never restart in a panic. Don't tab-switch.
9. **Rolling-deadline note.** Most UK finance video stages are released on a rolling basis after the OA — do yours **promptly**, because slots and reviewer goodwill both thin as the cohort fills (Chapter 6.8).
10. **Debrief.** Note the actual questions, timings and whether re-records were allowed, for next time — and whether monitoring was disclosed.

8.13 Sources for this chapter

All accessed 2026-08-01. Confidence tags as used above.

Independent: - Fortune (2021-01-19) — HireVue drops facial analysis; ORCAA audit; the 0.25% figure; Zuloaga/Parker quotes; accent-bias recommendation — https://fortune.com/2021/01/19/hirevue-drops-facial-monitoring-amid-a-i-algorithm-audit/ - SHRM — NLP now primary scoring method; expert critiques (Hickok, Stoyanovich); audit-scope limits — https://www.shrm.org/topics-tools/news/talent-acquisition/hirevue-discontinues-facial-analysis-screening - EPIC — FTC complaint and outcome — https://epic.org/documents/in-re-hirevue/ ; https://archive.epic.org/2021/01/hirevue-facing-ftc-complaint-f.html - National Law Review — EPIC complaint substance — https://natlawreview.com/article/epic-files-complaint-ftc-regarding-ai-based-facial-scanning-software - UpNorth.ai — EU AI Act high-risk classification, human-oversight requirement, current NLP operation — https://www.upnorth.ai/en/insights/ai-act-hirevue

Vendor: - Carlyle / PRNewswire — majority investment (ownership) — https://www.carlyle.com/media-room/news-release-archive/hirevue-receive-growth-investment-new-majority-investor-carlyle - HireVue — DCI Consulting external bias-audit press release — https://www.hirevue.com/press-release/hirevue-leads-industry-in-fair-and-ethical-hiring-practice-engaging-external-auditor-dci-consulting-group-for-external-bias-audit-of-

algorithms - HireVue — coding assessments (CodeVue) — https://www.hirevue.com/platform/coding-assessments

Prep-vendor (mechanics; corroborate — commercially biased): - Mergers & Inquisitions — HireVue interview — https://mergersandinquisitions.com/hirevue-interview/ - Corporate Finance Institute — about the HireVue interview — https://corporatefinanceinstitute.com/resources/careers/interviews/about-hirevue-interview/ - AceRound — HireVue tab-switching / proctoring series — https://www.aceround.app/blog/can-hirevue-detect-tab-switching/

Candidate (testimony; several forum pages returned 403 on the access date — timings are corroborated at snippet level across Wall Street Oasis and The Student Room threads for Goldman Sachs, J.P. Morgan, Bank of America, Barclays, HSBC). `[CANDIDATE]`

(Residual gaps — re-record visibility to reviewers, canonical game list/count, score-report format, named ATS integrations, HireVue-specific independent validity study, and verbatim first-person timings behind the 403-blocked forums — are logged in research/08-hirevue.md and the master gap register.)

Chapter 9 — Willo

Confidence tags used throughout (full explanation in Chapter 1): `[VENDOR]` vendor's own claim; `[INDEPENDENT]` peer-reviewed/independent; `[CANDIDATE, n=X]` candidate testimony with count; `[INFERRED]` my reasoning, shown; `[UNKNOWN]` not public; `[PREP-VENDOR]` commercial practice-seller, corroborate.

At a glance — Willo

What it is	UK-founded (**Glasgow, 2018**) lightweight **asynchronous one-way video interview** platform. Employer sets questions; you record video/audio/text/multiple-choice/file answers via a browser link on your own time; a **human** reviews later. `[VENDOR]`
Where in the funnel	Top-of-funnel screen, replacing or augmenting the CV sift: typically after the application form, before any live interview or assessment centre. `[VENDOR]`
Format & timing	Employer-configured. Per-question **thinking time** (set in hours+minutes, sometimes unlimited) and a **1–5 min** recording cap per question. Retakes employer-set (an Amazon apprenticeship candidate reported **4**). Unlimited practice attempts. `[VENDOR]` / `[CANDIDATE, n≈several]`
Scoring model	**No norms, no percentiles, no automated qualitative scoring.** Human reviewers rate answers on the employer's own scorecard. AI ("Willo Intelligence") only transcribes/ summarises; a "Benchmark" auto-reject fires **only on binary multiple-choice**. `[VENDOR]`
Typical finance cut-off	`[UNKNOWN]` — no fixed threshold; **no evidence of UK front-office IB use at all** (see §9.1).
Integrity posture	**Minimal by design** ("without creating a Big Brother feel"). Core anti-gaming = a timer that keeps running across browser restart. Heavier proctoring claims (tab-switch, gaze, AI-detection) appear in marketing but are contradicted by an independent reviewer. `[VENDOR]` / `[INDEPENDENT]`
Retake	Employer-set number of re-records for video/audio only; timer keeps counting through them. `[VENDOR]`
Top 5 tips	1) Treat it exactly like a HireVue-style one-way (Chapter 8) — STAR/CARL, lighting, eye-line. 2) Use the (often generous) thinking time to structure. 3) Don't burn all your time re-recording — the clock runs through retakes. 4) Land inside the 1–5 min window; over/under is flagged to the reviewer. 5) Answer knockout MCQs carefully — those *can* auto-reject.

(Every figure above is unpacked, sourced and confidence-tagged below. Willo is a lighter-weight provider than most in this guide: you are far more likely to meet it at an SME, scale-up, apprenticeship or non-IB graduate scheme than at a bulge-bracket bank — see §9.1.)

9.1 Snapshot

Willo is a UK-founded, lightweight **asynchronous ("one-way") video interview** platform, and it is the odd one out in this guide: unlike SHL, Cappfinity or HireVue, there is **no evidence it is used anywhere in UK front-office investment banking or markets hiring.** It was co-founded in **Glasgow in 2018** by **Euan Cameron** (CEO, previously in senior strategy roles at the Scottish car dealership Peter Vardy) and **Andrew Wood**, with the product launching in **January 2020**. `[INDEPENDENT – Scotsman, Insider]` It is a private, VC/angel-backed scale-up: total investment since 2018 exceeds **£2.5m** (a seven-figure round was raised explicitly for US expansion, on top of an earlier £20k Scottish Enterprise package), it claims to operate in **over 180 countries**, and roughly **65% of its revenue now comes from the US.** `[INDEPENDENT]` / `[VENDOR]` It is young and growing but nowhere near the enterprise-incumbent scale of HireVue. `[INFERRED]`

Mechanically it is simple. An employer builds a set of questions; you receive a browser link (no app, no account, no plugin) and record your answers — as video, audio, typed text, a multiple-choice selection, or an uploaded file — in your own time, from any device with a camera. `[VENDOR]` The employer's team watches the responses later and rates them on their own scorecard. There are no percentiles, no norm groups, and no automated qualitative scoring of what you say.

The reason to include it in a finance-focused guide is honest and limited: **you might meet it in the broader early-careers landscape** — at an SME, a scale-up, a public-sector employer, an apprenticeship, or a general graduate scheme — even though it is not a bulge-bracket screening tool. The one documented UK early-careers touchpoint is **Amazon apprenticeships** (software, cyber, UX), where multiple candidates on The Student Room describe meeting Willo in 2024–25. `[CANDIDATE, n≈several]` Named clients skew heavily to SME/scale-up/ high-volume/distributed hiring — NHS and NHS Scotland, Toyota Great Britain, EDF, Danone, Samsung, Coinbase, Prada, 7-Eleven — with **no bulge-bracket, elite boutique or Big Four employer named** anywhere in the material. `[VENDOR]` / `[INDEPENDENT]` The closest thing to a "finance" client is Coinbase, a crypto exchange, which is not UK front-office IB.

So: know Willo exists, know how a one-way works, but do not over-invest. If you are targeting front-office finance you are much more likely to meet SHL (Chapter 1), Cappfinity (Chapter 5) or HireVue (Chapter 8).

9.2 Why this test exists

Willo exists to solve a top-of-funnel logistics problem, not a psychometric one. For a high-volume or distributed employer, the bottleneck early in hiring is **scheduling**: coordinating first-round phone screens across time zones is slow and expensive, and a CV alone tells you little about how someone actually communicates. An asynchronous one-way removes the calendar entirely — the candidate records whenever they are ready, the reviewer watches whenever they have time — which Willo markets as hiring "40% faster" and cutting time-to-hire by roughly half. `[VENDOR]` The construct being measured is not "general mental ability" (SHL) or "strengths fit" (Cappfinity); it is simply **a structured, recorded first-round interview delivered at scale.**

The nuance that matters — and the thing that most distinguishes Willo's positioning — is its deliberate contrast with **AI-scored** one-way tools. Willo has historically marketed itself as the **human-first** alternative to HireVue-style automated scoring, stating plainly that "Willo does not offer automated scoring and decision-making for your hiring team" and that "the decision to move anyone forward stays with you." `[VENDOR]` No facial-expression or emotion analysis appears anywhere in its material — though note this is *absence of evidence* rather than an explicit written denial. `[VENDOR]` / `[INFERRED]`

That framing is now **partly out of date**, and getting this right is the whole point of §9.8. As of 2026 Willo markets **"Willo Intelligence"** — AI that *transcribes and summarises* every interview, *surfaces skills* and *identifies gaps* — and a **"Benchmark"** feature that can auto-reject, but **only on binary multiple-choice questions**, never on video content. `[VENDOR]` So the honest positioning is neither "no AI" nor "AI-scored." It is **AI-assisted, human-decided**: assistive AI helps the reviewer read faster, but every meaningful judgement on your spoken answers is made by a person. There is a mild positioning tension here — an independent reviewer describes Willo as *lacking* AI-powered evaluation, sentiment analysis and bias detection, which sits awkwardly against Willo's own richer AI marketing (§9.8). `[INDEPENDENT]`

9.3 Why a firm chooses Willo specifically

Willo's competitive case is **simplicity, price and low candidate friction**, not psychometric sophistication. The headline differentiator is that the candidate needs **no app download and no account** — just a browser link — and it works on any device, including on low bandwidth. `[VENDOR]` / `[INDEPENDENT – RecruitCompare]` For an employer that wants to screen five to fifteen hires a year without buying an enterprise suite, that matters, and the pricing reflects it: Willo is self-serve monthly SaaS by hire-volume, with a **free tier** (around 50 candidates/year) and paid tiers running from low-hundreds-of-dollars-a-month. The exact tier names and prices **conflict across sources and dates** — one snapshot lists Growth (~$249/mo) and Scale (~$399/mo); an independent review lists an entirely different ladder starting at a free tier and a $75/mo Startup plan — so treat any specific figure as `[UNKNOWN – verify]`. `[VENDOR]` / `[INDEPENDENT – G2, RecruitCompare]` The takeaway is directional: this is a **low-cost, SMB-accessible** tool, contracted by monthly subscription, not by per-assessment enterprise agreement the way SHL or HireVue are.

The second selling point is **reputational safety**: by keeping humans in charge of qualitative decisions, Willo lets a firm avoid the AI-bias controversy that dogged HireVue's facial-analysis era (Chapter 8). `[VENDOR]` The third is **compliance packaging**: Willo markets GDPR compliance, **ISO 27001** certification, encryption and a "Trust Center," and it is certified under the **UK Digital Identity & Attributes Trust Framework (UKDIATF)**, which supports optional right-to-work and identity checks. `[VENDOR]` It also claims broad ATS/app integrations (a Greenhouse integration exists), though an independent reviewer calls the actual integration ecosystem "smaller" than the marketing implies. `[VENDOR]` / `[INDEPENDENT]`

None of this is a bulge-bracket procurement story. The documented UK users are general graduate, high-volume, public-sector and SME employers — NHS/NHS Scotland, Toyota GB, EDF (graduate hiring), the recruiter Eden Scott, the law firm Bott & Co — plus Amazon apprenticeships as the best-corroborated early-careers touchpoint. `[VENDOR]` / `[INDEPENDENT]` / `[CANDIDATE, n≈several]`

9.4 What the assessment actually is — full mechanics

This is the section that repays attention, because Willo's mechanics have a couple of specific quirks (the up-counting timer, the retake interaction) that catch candidates out.

Question types. An employer can ask you to respond by **video, audio, or typed text**, by **multiple-choice** ("select from pre-defined answers" — you can effectively build a short test inside Willo this way), or by **file upload** (documents up to **25MB** per file). `[VENDOR]` A single interview can mix these.

Thinking time. This is employer-configurable **per question**, set in hours and minutes, and can be generous — candidate reports describe effectively unlimited thinking time on simple questions. `[VENDOR]`/`[CANDIDATE, n≈several]` The crucial mechanical detail: **the timer counts *up*, not down, and "the time recorded includes the time taken to answer the question and any retakes."** `[VENDOR — Willo Knowledge Base]` It is a *guard-rail*, not a gate: if you exceed the allocated time you are **not blocked** and can still submit — but the reviewer sees your actual elapsed time plus a colour indicator showing whether you came in under or over. So the pressure is soft and reputational, not hard.

Answer / recording time. Separately, the employer sets a maximum recording length per question, from **1 to 5 minutes**. `[VENDOR]` The reviewer again sees exactly how long you took, with an over/under colour flag.

Retakes. The employer configures how many re-records you get, and this applies **only to video/audio** answers. `[VENDOR]` Setting zero retakes means your first take is auto-saved and uploaded; Willo recommends allowing **at least one** for inclusivity. You can see how many retakes you have left at any point. An Amazon apprenticeship candidate reported **4** retakes. `[CANDIDATE, n≈several]` Whether the reviewer can see your *discarded* takes is **not stated** in the Knowledge Base — the implication is they see only your final submitted response plus timing metadata, but this is `[UNKNOWN]`.

The anti-cheat interaction. When you are invited by email, SMS or through an ATS, the **timer keeps running even if you close, refresh or restart the browser** — so you cannot pause the clock to script a perfect answer. `[VENDOR]` Combined with the fact that thinking time and retakes all consume the same up-counting clock, the practical lesson (developed in §9.7) is: **don't burn your budget re-recording.**

Practice. You get **unlimited practice attempts** before the real thing, to test your camera and mic. `[VENDOR]`

Review. A **human** watches your responses (optionally at 2x speed), rates you on the employer's scorecard, and shares with the team. `[VENDOR]` AI assists only via transcription, summary and skill-surfacing; there is no automated qualitative scoring.

A realistic walkthrough (Amazon apprenticeship style). You get an email link, click through in a browser, run the practice step to check your camera and mic, then work through a handful of employer-written questions — some recorded video, perhaps a multiple-choice knockout or two. You see your generous thinking time and your remaining retakes on screen. You record, re-record if you want (watching the clock), submit, and you're done. Candidates describe this as "one of the easiest video interviews," with generous thinking time and preparation time that isn't counted against you — only the response itself is timed. `[CANDIDATE, n≈several]`

9.5 Is it tailored to the role?

No, not at the instrument level — and that is a structural fact, not a criticism. Willo has **no proprietary competency framework, trait model or normed engine.** `[INFERRED from VENDOR docs]` It is a container: the employer either writes their own questions (typed or recorded) or picks from Willo's generic question library and templates, and the "competencies assessed" are simply whatever that employer decides to ask about. `[VENDOR]`

The consequence for you is the opposite of the Cappfinity situation. With Cappfinity, tailoring is *deep* and the winning move is to reverse-engineer the firm's published strengths framework (Chapter 5). With Willo there is **no hidden key to reverse-engineer** — there is no Willo-defined "right answer," because Willo doesn't score your answers at all. Any tailoring lives entirely in (a) the specific questions the employer chose to ask, and (b) that employer's own scorecard and values, which you should research the same way you would for any structured interview. Your preparation, therefore, is generic strong-interview technique plus firm research — not provider-specific gaming.

9.6 How they screen and filter — scoring, norms, cut-offs, ranking

This is short because there is genuinely little machinery here, and that is the honest finding.

The scoring model. There is **no norm-referenced scoring.** No percentiles, no norm groups, no benchmark cohort against which your qualitative answers are ranked. `[VENDOR]` / `[INFERRED]` Reviewers watch your responses and **rate you on an employer-configured scorecard** — ordinary human ratings, shared across a hiring team for a collaborative decision. What the recruiter sees is: the response media itself, a **transcript and AI summary** (if Willo Intelligence is enabled), your **time-taken metadata with the over/under colour flag**, your retakes-remaining state, and the team's scorecard ratings. `[VENDOR]`

The one automated filter. The **"Benchmark"** feature can auto-reject candidates — but **only on binary multiple-choice questions**, never on video or audio content. `[VENDOR]` This is the one place where a machine can end your application without a human looking: a knockout eligibility question ("Do you have the right to work in the UK?", "Are you available from September?") answered "wrongly" can hard-reject you. Treat those MCQs with care.

Cut-offs. Because scoring is human and per-employer, there is **no published or inferable cut-off**, and there is no finance benchmark to cite because there is no documented finance usage. `[UNKNOWN]` Functionally it behaves like any structured first-round interview: a reviewer decides whether to advance you.

Retakes at the scoring stage. An employer can re-invite or send you back, but there is no built-in norm re-score — the decision is human throughout. `[INFERRED]`

The funnel point. Where Willo is used, it sits at the **very top of the funnel** as a CV-replacement screen. It is a real gate — a reviewer can and will decline you — but it is a *soft, human* gate, not the tight algorithmic hurdle SHL's Verify can be. Spend proportionate effort: this is an interview to prepare for, not a test to drill. See §6.8 on allocating effort across stages.

9.7 How to score well — legitimate, specific, actionable

Willo is an asynchronous one-way video interview, so **the technique is the same as for HireVue (Chapter 8), and the full construct-level manual is Chapter 6.4.** Rather than repeat it, here is the Willo-specific layer on top of that generic base.

Apply the standard one-way discipline (cross-ref Chapter 8, §6.4). Structure every answer with **STAR or CARL** so a reviewer watching at 2x can follow you; lighting in front of you not behind; **camera at eye level** and look at the **lens, not your own image**; controlled pace; quiet, plain background; and use the **unlimited practice** to warm up. Nail the **first ten seconds** of each answer — a crisp opening line buys goodwill.

Then exploit the Willo-specific mechanics:

- **Use the thinking time to structure, not to panic.** It is often generous and sometimes effectively unlimited, and — per candidate reports — your *preparation* time isn't what's held against you; the *response* is what's timed. Sketch a one-line STAR skeleton before you hit record. `[VENDOR]` / `[CANDIDATE, n≈several]`

- **Do not burn your budget re-recording.** This is the single most important Willo-specific point. The timer **counts up and includes retakes and thinking time**, and the reviewer sees your total elapsed time with an over/under flag. A nervous candidate who re-records five times can "run out" and end up submitting a worse take under time pressure. Plan to use **one** retake at most, for a genuine fumble. `[VENDOR]`
- **Land inside the recording window.** The cap is 1–5 minutes per question and over/under is visibly flagged. Rehearse to come in comfortably inside it — a tight, complete answer beats a rambling one that trips the "over" flag. `[VENDOR]`
- **Take the knockout MCQs seriously.** If there are binary multiple-choice questions, remember these are the *only* thing that can auto-reject you (§9.6). Read them carefully. `[VENDOR]`

Candidate sentiment is worth knowing: many people find async *less* stressful because it's on their own schedule, but some find it impersonal. `[INDEPENDENT – G2]` If you present better live, compensate with energy and warmth to camera.

9.8 Integrity monitoring — what Willo actually detects

Willo's integrity posture is **deliberately minimal** — the design goal is explicitly to screen candidates "without creating a Big Brother feel." `[VENDOR]` The core, confirmed anti-gaming mechanism is unglamorous: when you're invited by email, SMS or ATS, the **up-counting timer keeps running through any browser close, refresh or restart**, so you cannot stop the clock to script a flawless scripted answer (§9.4). `[VENDOR]` That's the real, in-product integrity control.

There is, however, a **positioning tension** worth knowing, because it affects how much of the scarier marketing to believe. In a "compare the tools" blog, Willo claims it can monitor **tab-switching, copy-paste blocking, multiple faces or voices, eye-gaze anomalies, background noise, and AI-generated or plagiarised responses.** `[VENDOR]` **Treat this with caution:** it appears in comparison marketing and may describe premium add-ons or aspiration rather than what's switched on in a standard interview — and an **independent reviewer directly contradicts it**, describing Willo as *lacking* AI-powered evaluation, sentiment analysis and bias detection. `[INDEPENDENT – RecruitCompare]` Honest conclusion: **the confirmed integrity layer is light (the running timer); the heavier proctoring claims are unverified and possibly add-on or aspirational.** `[UNKNOWN – verify per deployment]`

There is **no facial or emotion analysis** documented anywhere in Willo's material — an important contrast with HireVue's history — though, as in §9.2, this rests on absence of evidence rather than an explicit written denial. `[VENDOR]` / `[INFERRED]`

Separately, Willo offers **optional identity, right-to-work and criminal-background checks** as add-ons, backed by its UKDIATF certification. `[VENDOR]` These are a distinct, opt-in layer — if a firm runs them you will be asked to verify your identity explicitly, which is itself the signal they're on. And crucially: there is **no evidence of automated rejection on any proctoring flag for video content** — humans review. `[INFERRED]` The one automated hard-reject is the binary-MCQ "Benchmark" (§9.6).

9.9 How candidates commonly trip the system — including honestly

Because qualitative judgement here is **human**, the algorithmic false-positive catalogue that haunts SHL's proctoring and HireVue's AI scoring (gaze flags, second-face detection, emotion misreads) **largely does not apply** — a genuine relief if you have been burned by a proctored test before. `[INFERRED]` The proctoring surface is small, so the honest false-positive list is short and mostly about the *timer* and the *format*, not surveillance:

- **The over/under-time colour flag biasing a reviewer.** A slow-but-thoughtful candidate who trips the "over" indicator may be read less favourably than the answer deserves — a subtle human bias, not an algorithmic one. `[INFERRED]`
- **Retake exhaustion.** Because the up-counting timer runs through retakes and thinking time, a nervous candidate can re-record repeatedly, run the clock down, and be forced to submit a weak take. This is the most common self-inflicted Willo failure. `[VENDOR]` / `[INFERRED]`
- **The impersonal format penalising live-strong candidates.** People who shine in a two-way conversation can under-perform recording into a lens with no feedback. `[INDEPENDENT – G2]`
- **AI transcription errors** feeding a garbled summary to the reviewer, if Willo Intelligence is enabled — a mis-transcribed answer can read worse than it was. `[VENDOR]` / `[INFERRED]`
- **A misconfigured or misread binary knockout.** If the employer set a "Benchmark" auto-reject on a multiple-choice question, a wrong (or carelessly clicked) answer is a hard reject with no human look. `[VENDOR]`

Genuine cheating that *would* be caught is limited to the obvious: the running timer defeats "pause and script," and — *where those features are actually enabled* — tab-switch, copy-paste and AI-response detection would catch external-help attempts. But given the verification tension above, don't assume those are on; assume a **human will simply notice** an answer that sounds read-off-screen or generated. The winning move is authentic, structured delivery, not evasion.

9.10 How to be unambiguously clean

The proctoring surface is small, so the checklist is correspondingly short — this is closer to preparing a clean interview than defending against surveillance.

- **Sit it somewhere quiet and private,** with a plain, well-lit background and your face fully in frame — not for a proctor, but because a human reviewer forms an impression fast. Close the door; keep others out of earshot and out of shot.
- **Use a stable connection and a device with a working camera and mic,** and run the **unlimited practice** step first to confirm both. A mid-recording disconnection wastes a take and your clock.
- **Plan your retake discipline before you start.** Decide you'll use at most one re-record, so the up-counting timer never runs away from you (§9.7, §9.9).
- **Read every binary multiple-choice question carefully** — those are the only thing that can auto-reject you.
- **Request adjustments in writing, in advance, from the employer.** Willo frames the async format itself as an accessibility benefit (own time and place, no travel or childcare clash, better for many neurodivergent and disabled candidates), and it aligns its platform to **WCAG 2.0/2.1** with keyboard navigation, screen-reader compatibility and a **text-based question option** for candidates who can't watch or record video. `[VENDOR]` **But there is no documented Willo "extra time / deadline extension" adjustment workflow** — thinking time and deadlines are *employer-set*, so any adjustment is the **employer's to grant, not a Willo feature.**

`[UNKNOWN]` That is precisely why you must route the request to the recruitment team early (template in §9.11).

9.11 If you are flagged or rejected

Because Willo is human-reviewed and lightly proctored, a rejection here is almost always a **judgement call on your answers**, not an integrity flag — with the single exception of a binary-MCQ "Benchmark" auto-reject (§9.6). The full legal treatment is Chapter 6.7; this is the Willo-specific playbook, and your UK rights are strong.

First, ask plainly. Email the employer's recruitment team, reference your application, and ask whether feedback is available and whether you may reapply in a future cycle. Willo returns no candidate-facing score, so the employer is your only source.

Then use your data-protection rights. Under **UK GDPR Article 15 (right of access)** you can submit a **Data Subject Access Request (DSAR)** to the **employer** (the data controller, not Willo), who must respond within **one month**, free of charge. Ask specifically for: your **recorded responses and any transcript/AI summary** held; the **scorecard ratings and the criteria applied**; your **time-taken metadata and any over/under flags**; and — critically, if you suspect a knockout — **whether any automated decision was made**. Under **Article 22**, you have rights around decisions based *solely* on automated processing that produce a legal or similarly significant effect, including the right to obtain **human intervention** and to contest the decision. `[INDEPENDENT – UK GDPR]` A binary-MCQ auto-reject is exactly the kind of solely-automated decision the Articles 22A–22C safeguards (DUAA 2025) are designed to cover, so it is worth naming. If the employer stonewalls, complain to the **Information Commissioner's Office (ICO)**.

Disclosing a disability. If your performance was affected by a disability and no adjustment was in place, requesting a reasonable adjustment under the **Equality Act 2010** is often the most effective route to a re-record or reconsideration, because the duty to adjust is a legal obligation, not a favour — and because, per §9.10, Willo provides no adjustment workflow of its own, the employer is the only party who can grant one.

Realistic expectations. Straightforward "we had stronger candidates" rejections are rarely overturned. A **binary auto-reject is the most contestable** outcome, especially if the knockout was ambiguous or you can show the answer was correct. The higher-value use of these rights is usually evidence and feedback for next time.

Template wording.

(a) Pre-assessment adjustments request (send before you record):

> Subject: Reasonable adjustment request — [name], [role/ref] Dear [team], I've been invited to complete a Willo video interview for [role]. I have [condition, e.g. a speech/anxiety condition / dyslexia / a processing condition], and under the Equality Act 2010 I request reasonable adjustments — for example [additional thinking time / a deadline extension / the text-based question option in place of video]. I can provide documentation. As I understand thinking time and deadlines are set by your team rather than the platform, please confirm what can be arranged and the revised deadline. Thank you.

(b) Post-rejection query / DSAR (escalation):

> Subject: Assessment outcome — feedback and data request — [name], [ref] Dear [team], Thank you for the update. Could you share any feedback on my Willo video interview, and whether reapplication next cycle is possible? Separately, under Article 15 of the UK GDPR I request the personal data held about my assessment — my recorded responses and any transcript/summary, the scorecard ratings and criteria applied, my time-taken metadata, and confirmation of whether any automated decision (including any multiple-choice knockout) was made — invoking my Articles 22A–22C UK GDPR safeguards (as amended by the Data (Use and Access) Act 2025) — and whether a human was involved. Please respond within one month. Thank you.

9.12 Step-by-step: how to win this assessment

A compact playbook — this is a lighter-weight stage than a Verify test, so it needs less runway.

1. **On invitation — read the setup.** Note the deadline, the question types (video/audio/text/MCQ/file), the recording cap (1–5 min), your thinking-time allowance and your number of retakes. All of these are visible.
2. **Research the employer, not the provider.** There's no Willo "key" to game (§9.5), so spend your prep on the firm's values and role, and on two or three strong STAR/CARL stories you can flex to likely questions.
3. **Do the practice step.** Use the unlimited practice to check camera, mic, lighting and framing, and to warm up your delivery. Fix any set-up problem here, not on a live take.
4. **Set up a clean, quiet, well-lit space** (§9.10): door shut, plain background, camera at eye level, stable connection.
5. **Plan your retake discipline.** Decide up front you'll use at most one re-record, because the up-counting timer runs through retakes and thinking time (§9.4, §9.7). This one rule prevents the most common Willo failure.
6. **In each answer:** take a beat of thinking time to sketch a one-line structure, then record a crisp STAR/CARL answer, looking at the lens, landing comfortably inside the time window, nailing the first ten seconds.
7. **Treat any binary multiple-choice question as a knockout** — read it carefully; it's the only thing that can auto-reject you.
8. **Submit early where the sift is rolling.** As with the rest of UK early-careers hiring, don't sit on a completed interview — record and submit while places are open (§6.8).
9. **Debrief.** Note the actual format (question types, timings, retakes, whether any MCQ knockout appeared) for next time and for this guide's accuracy.

9.13 Sources for this chapter

All accessed 2026-08-01. Confidence tags as used above.

Vendor (primary): - Willo — home & features — https://www.willo.video/ ; https://www.willo.video/features `[VENDOR]` - Willo — graduate hiring software — https://www.willo.video/use-cases/graduate-hiring-software `[VENDOR]` - Willo — *AI candidate scoring tools* (human-first positioning) — https://www.willo.video/blog/ai-candidate-scoring-tools `[VENDOR]` - Willo — *AI tools for candidate screening* (proctoring claims — treat as marketing) — https://www.willo.video/blog/ai-tools-for-candidate-screening `[VENDOR]` - Willo — identity/right-to-work checks — https://www.willo.video/integrations/identity-verification-right-to-work-checks `[VENDOR]` - Willo Knowledge Base — thinking time — https://support.willo.video/article/118-thinking-time `[VENDOR]` -

Willo Knowledge Base — time to answer — https://support.willo.video/article/118-time-to-answer `[VENDOR]` - Willo Knowledge Base — retakes — https://support.willo.video/article/14-change-the-number-of-retakes `[VENDOR]` - Willo Knowledge Base — create an interview — https://support.willo.video/article/26-create-an-interview `[VENDOR]` - Willo Knowledge Base — digital identity check — https://support.willo.video/article/129-digital-identity-check `[VENDOR]` - Willo Knowledge Base — accessibility statement — https://support.willo.video/article/92-accessibility-statement `[VENDOR]`

Independent (press & review): - Scotsman — interview with Euan Cameron, co-founder/CEO (Glasgow origin, US ambition) — https://www.scotsman.com/business/interview-euan-cameron-co-founder-and-ceo-of-glasgow-based-recruitment-focused-tech-firm-willo-4457645 `[INDEPENDENT]` - Insider — video-interview firm raises £2.5m — https://www.insider.co.uk/news/video-interview-firm-raises-25-28710960 `[INDEPENDENT]` - FutureScot — Glasgow platform secures US-expansion investment — https://futurescot.com/glasgow-video-interviewing-platform-secures-investment-for-us-expansion/ `[INDEPENDENT]` - Scottish Financial News — £20k Scottish Enterprise package — https://www.scottishfinancialnews.com/articles/willo-secures-20k-funding-package-from-scottish-enterprise `[INDEPENDENT]` - RecruitCompare — Willo tool review (segment fit; contradicts heavy-AI claims) — https://recruitcompare.io/tool/willo/ `[INDEPENDENT]` - G2 — Willo reviews & pricing — https://www.g2.com/products/willo-video-interviewing/reviews ; …/pricing `[INDEPENDENT]` - Crunchbase — Willo organization profile — https://www.crunchbase.com/organization/willo-video `[INDEPENDENT]`

Candidate (testimony; thin n): - The Student Room — Amazon Apprenticeships 2024 (Willo one-way; "4 retries", generous thinking time) — https://www.thestudentroom.co.uk/showthread.php?t=7425540 `[CANDIDATE, n≈several]` - The Student Room — Amazon UX Apprenticeship 2025 — https://www.thestudentroom.co.uk/showthread.php?t=7550355 `[CANDIDATE]`

(Residual Willo gaps — exact current pricing/tier names (two conflicting ladders); whether reviewers see discarded retakes; how much proctoring is genuinely in-product vs marketing; UK data-residency/hosting; any formal reasonable-adjustment workflow; explicit confirmation there is no facial/emotion analysis; deeper candidate testimony — are logged in research/09-willo.md and the master gap register.)

Chapter 10 — TestGorilla

Confidence tags used throughout (full explanation in Chapter 1): `[VENDOR]` vendor's own claim; `[INDEPENDENT]` peer-reviewed/independent; `[CANDIDATE, n=X]` candidate testimony with count; `[INFERRED]` my reasoning, shown; `[UNKNOWN]` not public; `[PREP-VENDOR]` commercial practice-seller, corroborate.

At a glance — TestGorilla

What it is	An Amsterdam-based **self-serve skills-testing SaaS** (founded 2019). Employers assemble an assessment from a library of **400+** short tests (cognitive, personality, situational judgement, language, software, coding, role-specific) plus their own custom questions. A "talent discovery platform" sold to SMEs, tech, scale-ups and mid-market.
Where in the funnel	Early screening — often a **CV-replacement step at the very top of the funnel**, sent to applicants before any human reads the application.
Format & timing	An assessment = **up to 5 tests** (most ~10 min each) + custom questions → typically **~30–60 min total**. Fixed-form multiple-choice modules — **not adaptive**. Browser-based; **one attempt**.
Scoring model	Each test → a **percentage score (0–100)**; candidates **ranked relative to each other** within the assessment. **No formal pass/fail** — the employer sets an implicit rank threshold.
Typical finance cut-off	`[UNKNOWN]` — no published norm or cut-score. Prep-vendor figures (~60+ entry, ~75+ mid, ~80+ select) are `[PREP-VENDOR ESTIMATE]`, not vendor-confirmed; §10.6.
Integrity posture	Anti-cheating suite is a **marketed selling point** and unusually well-documented: **30-second webcam snapshots**, full-screen-exit and tab-switch detection, IP/location logging, copy-paste/screenshot/dev-tool detection, randomised retiring question pools, time limits, a timestamped behaviour log grouped into "tiers." Webcam is **optional and permissioned**.
Retake	**One attempt** per assessment; the timer continues even if you disconnect.
Top 5 tips	1) Expect **genuine skill tests** (Excel, Xero, GAAP, a coding stack) — brush up the named tool, not "aptitude tricks." 2) Sit it full-screen, one tab, camera-permitted, in a closed quiet room — the behaviour log is granular. 3) Don't fake Big-5/DISC/16-type; answer decisively and role-aligned. 4) Use the 4–5 warm-up questions to calibrate; pace at ~30–60s/question. 5) Request accommodations **before** you sit (+20% non-native / +50% disability) — the condition is never shared with the employer.

(Every figure above is unpacked, sourced and confidence-tagged below. Be clear-eyed about relevance: TestGorilla is a fintech / challenger-bank / mid-market tool, not a bulge-bracket front-office name — see §10.1 and §10.5.)

10.1 Snapshot

TestGorilla is a self-serve online skills-assessment platform, and the honest first thing to say about it is where it sits in your world: it is the tool you are far more likely to meet at a **fintech, a challenger bank, a scale-up or a mid-market employer** than at a bulge-bracket investment bank. It was founded in **2019** by **Wouter Durville** (CEO) and **Otto Verhage** (a former Bain & Company partner), and is headquartered in **Amsterdam, Netherlands**. `[INDEPENDENT — Tracxn/Crunchbase/PitchBook via search]` It raised roughly **$81m** in total funding across three rounds, headlined by a **$70m Series A in 2022** led by Atomico with Balderton Capital and Notion Capital, raised on the explicit pitch of helping companies "eliminate hiring bias." `[INDEPENDENT + VENDOR blog]` Third-party estimates put annual recurring revenue around $36m and valuation around $109m, but these are unverified and low-confidence. `[INDEPENDENT — treat as ESTIMATE]`

What TestGorilla actually sells is a **library of tests** — marketed as "400+ scientifically validated" (older copy says 350+) — that an employer assembles, self-serve, into a single multi-test assessment. `[VENDOR]` The library spans cognitive ability, personality, situational judgement, language, software, programming and role-specific skills, and the employer can bolt on their own custom questions. The company positions itself as a **"talent discovery platform"** and claims **10,000+ customers** and "millions of candidates," naming non-finance clients such as Sony, PepsiCo, Bain & Company, Oracle, H&M and the UK NHS. `[VENDOR]`

For a finance early-careers applicant, the part that matters is honest calibration. This is an **SME/SMB/tech/scale-up screening tool sold on price, breadth and a "skills-based hiring reduces bias" message** — a fundamentally different animal from the enterprise psychometrics of SHL or Aon (Chapters 1 and 2). In the funnel it typically sits **very early**, often as a CV-replacement screen sent to applicants before any human reads the form. An assessment is **up to five tests** (most about ten minutes each) plus custom questions, so **~30–60 minutes total**. `[VENDOR + PREP-VENDOR]`

10.2 Why this test exists

The problem TestGorilla is built to solve is not the bulge bracket's problem. A large bank drowning in twenty thousand applications for three hundred seats needs enterprise-grade, legally bulletproof, high-throughput psychometrics, and it can afford the six-figure enterprise contract that SHL or Aon charges. A **smaller employer — a fifty-person fintech, a growing SaaS company, a regional professional-services firm — has the same screening problem at smaller scale and none of that budget.** TestGorilla's entire reason to exist is to serve that under-served middle: a self-serve platform with a free tier and a low-commitment annual subscription, bought by a hiring manager with a company card rather than sold by an enterprise account team. `[INDEPENDENT — pricing sources, §10.3]`

The pitch layered on top is **skills-based hiring**: the claim that testing what a candidate can actually *do* — write the SQL, reconcile the ledger, reason through the numbers — predicts performance better and more fairly than screening a CV for the right university and the right internships. The Series A was explicitly messaged around **"eliminating hiring bias,"** the argument being that a blind skills test gives a state-school graduate or a career-changer a route past the CV filter that would otherwise reject them. `[VENDOR — Series A messaging]` That is a genuinely attractive proposition, and for many candidates it is a fairer door than the one SHL guards. It is also, at this stage, **largely a vendor self-assertion**: independent validity or adverse-impact audits of TestGorilla's library were not located in the research for this chapter, so treat "scientifically validated" and "bias-reducing" as marketing claims until a technical manual or third-party study surfaces. `[UNKNOWN — no independent audit located; §10.11]`

The broader debate about whether skills-based screening actually reduces adverse impact, and whether it merely relocates bias into the choice of which skills to test, is developed in the cross-cutting Chapter 6.1.

10.3 Why a firm chooses TestGorilla specifically

A firm does not choose TestGorilla because its tests are psychometrically superior — they are not marketed on validity coefficients or norm-group depth the way SHL's are. It chooses TestGorilla for **price, breadth and self-serve ease**. `[VENDOR + INDEPENDENT review sites]`

The library is the headline: **400+ pick-and-mix tests** across cognitive ability, personality and culture, situational judgement, language (CEFR-graded), programming, software and role-specific skills, plus five types of **custom question** (video, essay, file-upload, multiple-choice, coding) the employer writes themselves. A hiring manager can, in an afternoon, build a bespoke-feeling assessment for a very specific role without commissioning anything. `[VENDOR]`

The commercial model is what really separates it from the incumbents. There is a **free-forever tier** (five tests, AI résumé scoring, up to five custom questions per assessment, but no ATS integration, no video, no coding and no full library), and paid tiers layered on top:

Plan	Approx. price	What it adds
Free	£0	5 tests, AI résumé scoring, ≤5 custom questions, no full library
Core	~$1,700/yr (~$135/mo billed annually)	~400 credits, ~2 premium seats
Plus	Custom, from ~$400/mo	ATS integrations, more seats

`[INDEPENDENT — Capterra/spotsaas/xpay 2026; numbers vary by source, treat as ESTIMATE ranges]` Paid plans are **annual-commitment only** and **credits do not roll over** — a detail that matters to you only in that it explains the vendor's incentive to be sent to as many candidates as possible. `[INDEPENDENT]`

Rounding out the sales case: the **anti-cheating suite** is itself marketed as a differentiator (§10.8), and the **skills-based, anti-bias brand** is the wedge that lets a founder feel good about the buy. Where TestGorilla names finance-adjacent reference clients they are fintechs and scale-ups — **Revolut** ("40% faster hiring" case study), Volt, Embrace, Tresl — not banks. `[VENDOR]` That client list is the single most important signal of where you will actually meet this test, and §10.5 returns to it plainly.

10.4 What the assessment actually is — full mechanics

An assessment is **assembled, not fixed**. The employer selects **up to five tests** from the library and adds **custom questions** (10 or 20 depending on plan; the free tier caps at five). Everything is browser-based, fixed-form multiple-choice at the module level, and — importantly — **not adaptive**: unlike SHL's Verify Interactive or Aon's adaptive engines, a TestGorilla cognitive module does not get harder as you answer correctly. `[VENDOR + INFERRED from library format; the vendor does not advertise IRT/adaptivity]`

The library you are drawn from

The vendor's own test-library page groups the catalogue roughly as follows:

Category	~Count
Role-specific skills	162
Programming skills	83
Software skills	59
Language (CEFR-graded)	37
Cognitive ability	17
Situational judgement	13
Personality & culture	6
Typing speed	4

`[VENDOR — test-library page]`

Cognitive-ability subtests

The cognitive modules are all multiple-choice, mostly around **ten minutes each**, and fixed-form. They include Problem Solving (9 min), a Rapid Cognitive Index / RCI (10 min), Abstract Reasoning (10 min), Critical Thinking (12 min, advanced), Numerical Reasoning (10 min), Verbal Reasoning (10 min), Reading Comprehension (13 min), Attention to Detail — Textual (12 min) and Visual (10 min), Spatial Reasoning (10 min), Mechanical Reasoning (10 min), Basic/Intermediate Math variants (10 min), Computational Thinking (10 min) and Understanding Instructions (10 min). `[VENDOR — cognitive-ability library page]` **Per-question timing is not published by the vendor**, and prep vendors disagree — one cites a combined "40 questions / 20 minutes" (~30s each), another says "about a minute per question." Treat per-question pace as **roughly 30–60 seconds depending on the module**, and expect **4–5 practice questions** before a timed test begins. `[PREP-VENDOR, conflicting → ESTIMATE]`

Personality and culture

Six instruments, all self-report with "no right or wrong answers": the **Big 5 / OCEAN** Five-Factor model (rate statements 1 = very inaccurate to 5 = very accurate, placed on five spectra), **DISC** (Marston's Dominance/Influence/Steadiness/Conscientiousness), a **16-Personality-Types** (Myers-Briggs-style) test, a **Culture Add** test and Enneagram-adjacent content. The vendor's own guidance is that personality tests **should not be used alone** and should be combined with cognitive and role tests for a "holistic view." `[VENDOR — personality library]`

Situational judgement, language, software and coding

Thirteen SJT modules cover leadership, communication, time management and ethics themes — fixed-form, scenario-then-options. `[VENDOR]` Language tests are CEFR-graded. Software and role-specific tests probe genuine tool skill (Excel, Xero, an accounting or BI package); coding tests run in an **in-browser IDE**. `[VENDOR/PREP-VENDOR]`

The five custom question types

On top of the library tests the employer can add their own questions in five formats: **pre-recorded video** (a webcam response to a text prompt), **essay**, **file upload** (CV, cover letter, or a take-home deliverable), **multiple-choice**, and **coding**. `[VENDOR — help-centre via search]` The video and essay answers are stored for **manual review** by the recruiter, not auto-scored on the free/lower tiers.

A realistic walkthrough

You receive a link (often before any human has read your CV). You consent to the terms and — if the employer has enabled it — to **webcam snapshots**. The assessment presents your tests in sequence: perhaps a 10-minute Numerical Reasoning module, a 10-minute Excel test, a Big 5 questionnaire, an SJT, and three custom questions ending in a two-minute recorded video answer. Most tests open with a handful of untimed practice questions, then the clock runs. **You have one attempt**, and the timer keeps running even if your connection drops. At the end you submit; you usually receive no score. `[VENDOR + PREP-VENDOR]`

10.5 Is it tailored to the role?

Yes at the assembly level, no at the item level — and the distinction cuts the opposite way from SHL. With SHL the item bank is generic and the *interpretation* (norm group, competency weighting) is where tailoring happens. With TestGorilla the tailoring is blunt and visible: the employer **hand-picks up to five tests and writes their own custom questions**, so a finance-company assessment might literally be Numerical Reasoning + Excel + an IFRS or GAAP knowledge test + a Big 5 + a video question. `[VENDOR]` The individual test inside is off-the-shelf and identical for every employer who selects it, but the *combination* is bespoke to the role in a way a candidate can often infer just by reading which tests they were sent.

This is the moment to be blunt about **what "finance" means on TestGorilla**, because it is not what a front-office applicant assumes. The vendor's finance solutions page offers tests for **financial analysis, compliance, risk, IFRS, GAAP, Excel, business intelligence, Xero and accounts receivable** — that is a **back-office / accounting / finance-operations** toolkit. There is **no front-office investment-banking, trading, M&A or wealth-management content** in the library. `[VENDOR]` So even where a finance employer uses TestGorilla, the role being screened is far more likely to be an accounting, finance-ops, analyst-support or fintech role than a bulge-bracket deal seat.

The employer also **weights the modules** to taste, and candidates never see the weighting. `[PREP-VENDOR – prepclubs]` Truly bespoke criterion-validation against a specific firm's performance data is not something TestGorilla markets; the tailoring is selection-and-weighting, not psychometric re-validation. `[INFERRED]`

10.6 How they screen and filter — scoring, norms, cut-offs, ranking

Read this section knowing that TestGorilla is deliberately **less numerically prescriptive** than SHL, and that much of the precise-sounding detail online comes from prep vendors rather than the vendor.

The scoring pipeline. Each test produces a **percentage score from 0 to 100**. `[VENDOR]` One prep vendor additionally claims a **percentile against a norm group** per module, but the vendor's own public copy emphasises the percentage and a **candidate ranking**, not published norm tables — so treat the percentile claim as an estimate until a real norm methodology surfaces. `[PREP-VENDOR – ESTIMATE; percentile methodology is a documented gap, §10.13]`

Ranking, not a pass mark. The vendor is explicit: *"There's no 'pass' or 'fail'… It's about showcasing your abilities and how they align with the role."* `[VENDOR blog]` In practice the recruiter dashboard **ranks candidates relative to each other** within the same assessment, and the employer shortlists from the top of that ranking. The de-facto cut-off is therefore **a rank threshold the employer chooses**, not a published score — and it moves with the size and strength of the applicant pool, exactly like the rolling-sift dynamic in Chapter 6.8. `[VENDOR + INFERRED]`

What the recruiter sees. A dashboard showing per-test percentage scores, an overall ranked view of all candidates, the raw **custom-question responses** (video, essay, file) for manual review, and the **anti-cheating behaviour log** (§10.8). Public detail on the exact dashboard layout is thin. `[PREP-VENDOR + VENDOR — thin]`

Do you see your score? Generally **no** — candidates are not given their own scores by default, though an employer can choose to share them. `[PREP-VENDOR — jobtestprep]`

Retakes. One attempt. The vendor states plainly, *"You'll have one attempt to complete your assessment,"* and the timer continues even if you disconnect — so a dropped connection eats your clock rather than pausing it. `[VENDOR blog + PREP-VENDOR]`

The reported cut-off numbers — and why to distrust them. One prep site floats an entry threshold around **60+**, an analyst/mid threshold around **75+**, and "select Bain/Revolut" around **80+**. Every one of these is a **`[PREP-VENDOR ESTIMATE]`, not vendor-confirmed**, and is presented here only as an illustrative shape, not a target you can trust. TestGorilla does not publish employer cut-scores, and because the sift is a *relative ranking*, no fixed number would be stable even if it did. The usable takeaway is directional: **be comfortably in the upper part of the pool on every module the employer weighted**, and treat clearing any implied threshold as necessary, not sufficient.

10.7 How to score well — legitimate, specific, actionable

TestGorilla rewards something refreshingly honest: **actual skill with the named tool**, plus clean test-taking discipline. There is far less "aptitude-test technique" to game than with SHL, because the software, role and coding tests measure real competence. Chapter 6.4 is the general construct manual; here is the TestGorilla-specific layer.

Role, software and coding tests — this is where the marks are. If you were sent an **Excel** test, drill Excel: lookups, pivot tables, common functions, keyboard efficiency under a clock. If it is **Xero, GAAP or IFRS**, revise the actual standard or the actual software. If it is a coding stack, practise in that language in a browser IDE against the clock. These modules reward genuine preparation more than any trick, and they are the most controllable part of your score. `[VENDOR library]`

Cognitive modules. Timed multiple-choice numerical, verbal and abstract reasoning at roughly **30–60 seconds a question**. Practise **speed with accuracy**; the modules are fixed-form and non-adaptive, so — unlike SHL — a fast wrong answer does not hand you an easier next item, it simply costs you a mark. Use the **4–5 warm-up questions** to calibrate the interface before the clock matters. Since back-navigation is not assumed to be available, answer each question decisively and move on. `[PREP-VENDOR]`

Situational judgement. Research the **employer's stated values** first, then pick the response that is both **most effective and most in character** for that firm. SJT modules are keyed to a "best" answer even under "no right answer" framing. `[PREP-VENDOR]`

Personality (Big 5 / DISC / 16-type) — do not fake. The honest reason mirrors §1.7's argument for SHL: a faked profile is optimised against a competency model you cannot see, tends to read as internally inconsistent, and — because the vendor's own guidance is to combine personality with cognitive and role tests — will be cross-checked against evidence you cannot fake. Read the firm's published values, decide which **genuine** facets of yourself are most role-relevant, and answer **decisively and consistently** from that authentic self rather than clustering everything at the mid-point. `[VENDOR guidance + INFERRED]`

Set-up. Sit it on a **laptop or desktop with a full-size screen**, **full-screen, one tab**, notifications off, on a stable connection, camera permitted and your face lit from the front. Every one of those is both a performance choice and an integrity choice — §10.8 explains why the behaviour log makes the two inseparable.

10.8 Integrity monitoring — what TestGorilla actually detects

This is the strong section, because TestGorilla's anti-cheating suite is **marketed as a selling point and unusually well-documented** — the vendor publishes what it detects, which most competitors do not. The full cross-vendor treatment of remote proctoring and its false-positive literature is Chapter 6.6; here is the TestGorilla-specific machinery.

What it captures `[VENDOR help-centre + VENDOR blog "cheating-detection-skills-assessments" + PREP-VENDOR, cross-confirmed]`:

- **Webcam snapshots** — a still image captured roughly **every 30 seconds** to verify identity. This is **optional and taken with the candidate's permission**, and the system also detects if the camera is disabled or off. Snapshots are retained for **6 months** (§10.11).
- **Full-screen-exit detection** — flags leaving full-screen mode.
- **Tab-switch detection** — flags switching browser tabs, and explicitly distinguishes a one-off from a pattern ("15 switches in a 20-minute test").
- **IP-address and approximate-location logging** — to spot multiple attempts or access from an unexpected place.
- **Screenshot detection** and **developer-tool detection**.
- **Copy-paste disabled/detected.**
- **Randomised question banks**, a **question-retirement system** (items are retired after an exposure limit) and **large pools** — the anti-memorisation layer, analogous to SHL's item randomisation.
- **Time limits** on every test to prevent extended off-screen research.

How flags surface. Events are logged with **timestamps** in a **candidate behaviour log** on the recruiter dashboard, and grouped into **behaviour tiers** (a help-centre article, "Understanding anti-cheating measures and behavior tiers," confirms the tiering exists, though its exact definitions were behind a bot-blocked page in the research). `[VENDOR – tier definitions a documented gap, §10.13]`

The vendor's candid, anti-"gotcha" stance — and why it matters to you. TestGorilla states its philosophy explicitly: *"we focus on cheating prevention and spotting outlier behaviors… instead of assuming every red flag is definitive proof."* Flags are framed as **"starting points for follow-up, not instant disqualifiers,"** and the vendor **recommends the employer contact the candidate for an explanation** before acting. `[VENDOR blog]` This is a genuinely more humane documented posture than most of the industry, and it is the single most useful fact in this chapter if you are ever flagged — the *vendor's own written guidance* is that a flag should trigger a conversation, not a rejection.

Two honest limits of the record. First, no dedicated **mouse-leave / focus-loss** telemetry is confirmed as a distinct named feature in the public sources — tab-switch and full-screen-exit are the analogues. `[UNKNOWN – gap]` Second, no prominent **AI-answer / plagiarism detector** is named in the sources found, unlike some 2025–26 rivals; it may exist but is unconfirmed. `[UNKNOWN – gap]` And the crucial caveat throughout: the **employer, not TestGorilla, interprets the log**, and a less-sophisticated SME recruiter can over-read it despite the vendor's guidance — which is why §10.9 and §10.10 matter.

10.9 How candidates commonly trip the system — including honestly

This is the section written for someone who has been flagged before, or fears they will be. It is deliberately concrete.

Genuine cheating that is detected (stated as risk, not instruction). Opening a second tab to look up an answer is caught by **tab-switch detection**; leaving full-screen to run another tool is caught by **full-screen-exit detection**; copying the question out to solve elsewhere is caught by **copy-paste and screenshot detection**; taking the test again under a different identity is caught by **IP/location logging and the one-attempt rule**; and memorising a shared question bank is undercut by **randomisation and question retirement**. None is worth the risk, and all are why this guide's value is legitimate preparation.

The false-positive catalogue — how an honest candidate gets flagged. Notably, **the vendor itself acknowledges most of these** as innocent triggers, which is unusually candid `[VENDOR blog]`:

- **Leaving full-screen to dismiss a system notification** — a calendar alert, an OS update prompt, a security-software pop-up — a behaviour the vendor names explicitly as honest.
- **A single quick tab-switch** to check a permitted requirement or the instructions — logged, but the vendor distinguishes it from a pattern.
- **A dropped or unstable connection** producing full-screen-exit or timing anomalies (and remember the timer keeps running).
- **Webcam off, disabled, or poorly lit** — a laptop with no working camera, backlighting from a window behind you, or the camera losing your face intermittently — registering as an identity flag. As Chapter 6.6 documents with independent evidence, face-detection has historically been **less reliable for darker skin tones**, a real demographic disparity that carries into any snapshot-based system. `[INDEPENDENT]`
- **Another person entering the room or audible nearby** — a housemate, a parent, a flatmate — appearing in a snapshot.
- **Glasses glare, a headscarf or a face covering** confusing face-presence detection in the snapshots.
- **Careful, slow reading, slight delays, or an accidental click** — the vendor's own "life happens" list.
- **Disability-related behaviour** — ADHD or anxiety restlessness, autistic self-regulation, or the use of a **screen reader or other assistive technology** — which can raise full-screen, tab or focus anomalies. This risk is real but is directly mitigated by the accommodations route in §10.10, *if you request it.* `[INFERRED]`
- **Sitting the test in a library or shared space**, where other faces and movement in a snapshot are unavoidable.

Because the **employer interprets the log**, the practical danger is not the vendor's algorithm — whose documented stance is lenient — but a **naive recruiter over-reading a single event**. The defence is to remove ambiguity in advance (§10.10) and, if flagged, to invoke the vendor's own "contact the candidate first" guidance (§10.11).

10.10 How to be unambiguously clean — pre-flight checklist

The goal is to make sure no honest behaviour can be misread. Print this.

- **Confirm the format in writing first.** Ask the recruiter (email is fine) whether **webcam snapshots** are enabled, whether any tools (a calculator, a spreadsheet, an IDE) are permitted for a given test, and whether there is a time limit per test. Their answer tells you which risks apply and creates a record.
- **Environment:** a quiet room you can close, door shut with a note on it, no one within camera or earshot range. Tidy desk.
- **Lighting:** a light source **in front of you, not behind** — no window at your back. If snapshots are on, check your face is evenly lit and fully in frame before you start.
- **Device:** a laptop or desktop with a **full-size screen and a working webcam**. **Disconnect any second monitor.** Close every other application and browser tab so you can stay in **full-screen, single-tab** for the whole assessment.
- **Notifications:** enable Do Not Disturb / Focus mode, and **pause OS and security-software auto-updates** for the window — these are the commonest cause of an innocent full-screen exit, and the vendor names them.
- **Network:** the most stable connection you have — wired if possible. Remember the **timer does not pause** on a disconnect, so reliability is a score issue as well as an integrity one. Avoid a VPN, which can trip IP/location logging.
- **Camera permission:** if snapshots are enabled, **grant permission and keep the camera on** — a disabled camera is itself an identity flag. If you have no working camera, tell the recruiter *before* you sit.
- **Stay in frame, one tab, full-screen.** Don't switch tabs to "just check" anything; don't drop out of full-screen. If you genuinely must (a fire alarm, a medical need), the vendor's guidance is that a flag prompts a conversation — so be ready to explain it.
- **Adjustments:** if you have a disability or are a non-native speaker, **request accommodations in writing before you sit** (§10.11). Do not wait until the day.

10.11 If you are flagged or rejected

You have real rights here, and TestGorilla's EU base and candid policies make some of them unusually usable. The full legal treatment is Chapter 6.7; this is the TestGorilla-specific playbook.

First, lean on the vendor's own stance. TestGorilla's published guidance is that a flag is a **"starting point for follow-up, not an instant disqualifier,"** and that the employer should **contact the candidate for an explanation.** `[VENDOR blog]` So the first move is to make that conversation easy to have: email the recruitment team promptly, reference your application, and offer the innocent explanation for whatever might have been logged (a notification pop-up, a dropped connection, a permitted look-away). You are not begging a favour — you are invoking the vendor's own documented process.

Accommodations — a genuine positive, request them early. TestGorilla's accommodations are better than most and worth using. The documented provision is **+20% time for non-native-language candidates** and **+50% time for a disability or condition** (ADHD, dyslexia, autism, and similar). `[VENDOR help-centre via search]` Crucially — and this is a real candidate-protection improvement — **as of June 2026 the candidate is no longer asked to share the disability itself with the employer, and the condition is never shared**: the employer is told only *that* an accommodation was requested and how it was applied, not what the underlying condition is. `[VENDOR`

`– recent policy change, note the date]` Request the accommodation **before** you sit, via the recruiter or the candidate accessibility page.

Then use your data-protection rights. Under **UK GDPR Article 15 (right of access)** you can submit a **Data Subject Access Request (DSAR)** to the **employer** (the data controller), who must respond within **one month**, free of charge. Ask specifically for: your **per-test scores**; your **anti-cheating behaviour log with the specific timestamped events and behaviour-tier assigned**; any **webcam snapshots** held; the **decision logic**; and confirmation of **whether a human was involved**. Where a rejection was based *solely* on automated processing, the safeguards in **Articles 22A–22C UK GDPR (as amended by the Data (Use and Access) Act 2025, in force 5 February 2026)** entitle you to make representations, **obtain human intervention**, and contest the decision — the old blanket "Article 22 prohibition" framing is out of date; see Chapter 6.7. `[REGULATORY – DUAA 2025]` Note TestGorilla's own retention limits, which bound what can still exist: **candidate data is retained 2 years; webcam anti-cheat snapshots 6 months.** `[VENDOR]` If the employer stonewalls, you can complain to the **Information Commissioner's Office (ICO)**.

Disclosing a disability. If a false flag stems from a disability, disclosing it and requesting a reasonable adjustment under the **Equality Act 2010** is often the most effective route to a re-sit, because the duty to make reasonable adjustments is a legal obligation, not a favour — and TestGorilla's "condition never shared with the employer" policy lowers the personal cost of doing so.

Realistic expectations. Straightforward rank rejections are rarely overturned — the employer simply had stronger candidates. **Integrity flags are more contestable**, especially given the vendor's explicit "contact the candidate" guidance and any documented innocent cause. But SME recruiters move unpredictably, and a live role may fill before an appeal resolves — so the higher-value use of these rights is often evidence for next time.

Template wording.

(a) Pre-assessment accommodations request (send before you sit):

> Subject: Accommodation request — [your name], [role/ref] Dear [team], I have been invited to complete a TestGorilla assessment for [role]. I have [a disability/condition, e.g. dyslexia / ADHD] / I am a non-native English speaker, and I request the corresponding accommodation (additional assessment time). I understand the details of my condition are not shared with the employer. I can provide supporting documentation. Please confirm what can be arranged and the revised deadline. Thank you.

(b) Post-rejection / flag query:

> Subject: Assessment outcome — request for information — [name], [ref] Dear [team], Thank you for the update. So that I can improve, please could you tell me whether my performance on, or any anti-cheating flag arising from, the TestGorilla assessment contributed to the decision. If a behaviour was flagged, I would welcome the chance to explain it — [brief innocent explanation]. Thank you.

(c) DSAR (escalation):

> Subject: Data Subject Access Request — [name], [ref] Dear [team], Under Article 15 of the UK GDPR I request access to the personal data you hold about my application, specifically: my per-test assessment scores; my anti-cheating behaviour log, including the timestamped events and any behaviour-tier assigned; any webcam snapshots held; the logic of any automated decision-making (Articles 22A–22C UK GDPR, as amended by the Data (Use and Access) Act 2025); and whether a human was involved in the decision. Please respond within one month. Thank you.

10.12 Step-by-step: how to win this assessment

A numbered playbook from invitation to debrief.

1. **On invitation — read what you were sent.** The tests in the link tell you the role's priorities. Sent an Excel test and an IFRS test? That is a finance-operations or accounting screen — prepare the tools, not "aptitude tricks."
2. **T-minus — identify the skill tests and drill the real skill.** Excel, Xero, GAAP/IFRS, a coding stack — these are the most controllable marks in the whole assessment. Practise the actual tool against a clock. `[VENDOR library]`
3. **Diagnose the cognitive modules.** Sit one timed practice numerical/verbal/abstract set cold. Note your pacing at ~30–60s a question. Remember the modules are **fixed-form, so never leave a question you can reason at** — there is no adaptive penalty for a wrong answer beyond the lost mark.
4. **Prepare the behavioural pieces.** Read the employer's published values before the SJT. For Big 5 / DISC / 16-type, decide in advance which genuine, role-relevant facets of yourself to answer decisively from — do not fake.
5. **Sort accommodations now.** If you need +20% (non-native) or +50% (disability) time, request it in writing **before** you sit (§10.11a). Do not leave it to the day.
6. **Confirm the format in writing.** Ask whether webcam snapshots are on, whether any tool is permitted per test, and the time limits. This creates a record and tells you which integrity risks apply.
7. **Day before — set up the room.** Charge the laptop, test the connection (the timer won't pause on a drop), disconnect the second monitor, clear the desk, prepare a quiet closable room, and check the webcam and front lighting.
8. **30 minutes before.** Close everything, go **full-screen and single-tab**, enable Do Not Disturb, pause OS/security auto-updates (the top cause of an innocent full-screen exit), grant camera permission, do a two-minute warm-up on the practice questions.
9. **In-test discipline.** Stay **in frame, one tab, full-screen** the whole way. Use the 4–5 warm-up questions to calibrate. Pace to the per-test clock; answer every question you can reason at. If something genuinely forces you out of frame, be ready to explain it — the vendor's process invites that conversation.
10. **Debrief.** Immediately after, write three notes: which tests you actually got (for next time and this guide's accuracy), what went well, and what you'd change. If you suspect a flag, send the §10.11(b) query while the recruiter still has the log in view.

10.13 Sources for this chapter

All accessed 2026-08-01. Confidence tags as used above.

Vendor (primary): - TestGorilla, *Test Library* — https://www.testgorilla.com/test-library/ `[VENDOR]` - TestGorilla, *Cognitive-ability tests* — https://www.testgorilla.com/test-library/cognitive-ability-tests/ `[VENDOR]` - TestGorilla, *Personality & culture tests* (Big 5, DISC subpages) — https://www.testgorilla.com/test-library/personality-culture-tests/ `[VENDOR]` - TestGorilla, *Finance companies solutions* — https://www.testgorilla.com/solutions/finance-companies/ `[VENDOR]` - TestGorilla blog, *Cheating detection in skills assessments* (KEY — candid on false positives) — https://www.testgorilla.com/blog/cheating-detection-skills-assessments/ `[VENDOR]` - TestGorilla help-centre, *Understanding anti-cheating measures and behavior tiers* (403 to bot; title/snippets only) — https://support.testgorilla.com/hc/en-us/articles/9028797639451-Understanding-anti-cheating-measures-and-behavior-tiers `[VENDOR – tier definitions unresolved]` - TestGorilla blog, *Questions & answers* (scoring, one-attempt retake) — https://www.testgorilla.com/blog/testgorilla-questions-answers/ `[VENDOR]` - TestGorilla blog, *$70M Series A to eliminate hiring bias* — https://www.testgorilla.com/blog/testgorilla-secures-70m-series-a-funding-to-help-companies-eliminate-hiring-bias/ `[VENDOR]` - TestGorilla, *Privacy policy* (retention: 2yr data / 6mo webcam) and *DPA* — https://www.testgorilla.com/privacy-policy/ ; https://www.testgorilla.com/dpa/ `[VENDOR]` - TestGorilla candidate help, *Accessibility and accommodations* (403 to bot; snippet confirms +20%/+50% and June 2026 policy) — https://candidates.testgorilla.com/hc/en-us/articles/28302003990427-Accessibility-and-accommodations-for-assessments `[VENDOR]`

Independent: - Balderton Capital, *TestGorilla secures $70M Series A* — https://www.balderton.com/news/testgorilla-secures-70m-series-a-to-help-companies-eliminate-hiring-bias/ `[INDEPENDENT]` - UNLEASH, *TestGorilla secures $70M Series A* — https://www.unleash.ai/skills-development/testgorilla-secures-70m-in-series-a/ `[INDEPENDENT]` - Tracxn company profile — https://tracxn.com/d/companies/testgorilla/ `[INDEPENDENT]` - Capterra pricing — https://www.capterra.com/p/203823/TestGorilla/pricing/ `[INDEPENDENT – pricing an ESTIMATE, varies by source]` - Trustpilot (1,707 reviews, TrustScore ~4/5) — https://uk.trustpilot.com/review/testgorilla.com `[INDEPENDENT – aggregate]` - G2 discussions — https://www.g2.com/products/testgorilla/discuss `[INDEPENDENT – aggregate]` - Buolamwini & Gebru (2018), *Gender Shades*; NIST FRVT demographic evaluations — face-detection accuracy disparities `[INDEPENDENT – full cite in §6.6]`

Prep-vendor (format detail; corroborate — commercially biased): - JobTestPrep — https://www.jobtestprep.com/testgorilla-assessment-practice - PrepClubs — https://prepclubs.com/tests/testgorilla - iPrep — https://www.iprep.online/courses/testgorilla-practice-test/

Candidate (testimony; thin — to deepen in gap audit): - No first-person UK candidate thread captured in this research; only G2/Trustpilot aggregate. `[CANDIDATE, n=0 direct – gap]`

(Residual TestGorilla gaps — exact behaviour-tier definitions and candidate consent wording (both bot-blocked); whether a distinct mouse-leave/focus telemetry or an AI-answer/plagiarism detector exists; any independent validity / adverse-impact audit behind the "scientifically validated" claim; real norm-group / percentile methodology; per-module question counts; and first-person UK candidate testimony — are logged in research/10-testgorilla.md and the master gap register.)

Chapter 11 — Morgan Stanley & Firm-Built Assessments

Confidence tags (full explanation in Chapter 1): `[VENDOR]` / `[INDEPENDENT]` / `[CANDIDATE, n=X]` / `[INFERRED]` / `[UNKNOWN]` / `[PREP-VENDOR]`. *A special sub-tag used heavily in this chapter,* `[CANDIDATE-via-snippet]`, *marks first-person forum testimony reconstructed from search-result snippets rather than full-page reads — because the main forums (Wall Street Oasis, The Student Room) returned HTTP 403 on the access date. Treat it as weaker than ordinary* `[CANDIDATE]`.

At a glance — Morgan Stanley

What it is / the funnel	Not a test — an **employer**, whose EMEA/London early-careers process stitches together **third-party** engines: `Application (rolling) → online aptitude battery [if the programme/division requires it] → HireVue one-way video → first-round interview → assessment centre / "superday."` There is **no Morgan Stanley-built assessment product**; the engines are **Aon/cut-e** (aptitude), **HireVue** (video) and **HackerRank** (tech coding). `[PREP-VENDOR + CANDIDATE-via-snippet, 2025–26 cycle]`
Where the OA sits	Early: after the application form, before the HireVue. It is **programme- and division-gated** — heavy for **IBD summer** and **Spring Insight**, often **absent** for non-IBD divisions ("interviews only"), **skipped/compressed off-cycle**, and **doubled** (an extra timed test) for quant/derivatives. `[PREP-VENDOR + CANDIDATE-via-snippet]`
Format & timing	Aptitude = **Aon/cut-e "scales"**: ~6-min numerical & verbal (True / False / Cannot-Say, ~6 data panels), ~5-min `ix` inductive odd-one-out, `switchChallenge` game, ~30-min email-inbox SJT keyed to the Business Unit. Usually **3 of 4 modules** assigned; **48-hour** window. HireVue ≈ 3 questions (IBD: 1 behavioural + 2 light-technical), ~30 min. `[PREP-VENDOR + CANDIDATE-via-snippet; conflicts flagged in §11.4]`
Scoring / sift	Aptitude is **speed-and-accuracy under a cut-e norm** (see Chapter 2), not an SHL percentile. HireVue is competency-ranked and — for MS specifically — **may be human-reviewed rather than AI-scored** `[UNKNOWN]`. No published MS cut-scores or conversion rates exist. `[UNKNOWN — do not trust any prep-vendor number as fact]`
Biggest cut in the funnel	**Most likely the CV/cover-letter sift against rolling deadlines**, not the OA — consistent with this guide's thesis that in UK IB the aptitude test is rarely the tightest hurdle. **No hard MS conversion numbers exist** to prove this. `[INFERRED; MS-specific figures = UNKNOWN]`
Integrity posture	cut-e's native defence = **unique per-candidate item bank + severe time pressure** (Chapter 2); webcam proctoring of the aptitude battery is offered but usually **off**. HireVue = optional focus/tab-logging + presence snapshots, **camera/audio only, no emotion analysis** (Chapter 8). MS-specific enforcement detail = `[UNKNOWN]` — no candidate flag report found.

Off-cycle vs summer	The single most useful structural fact: **summer/IBD gets the full OA; off-cycle usually skips or compresses it, but the HireVue stays mandatory for essentially everyone.** `[PREP-VENDOR + CANDIDATE-via-snippet]`
Top 5 tips	1) Prep **cut-e specifically, not generic SHL** — the mechanics differ (Chapter 2). 2) Drill True/False/Cannot-Say discipline to a ~15-second-per-item reflex. 3) **Apply early** — rolling deadlines are plausibly the real gate. 4) For HireVue, prepare "why MS / why this division" plus a recent MS transaction; treat facial-analysis warnings as **outdated** (Chapter 8). 5) Confirm which stages *your* programme actually includes — do not assume a friend's IBD funnel matches your S&T one.

(Every figure above is unpacked, sourced and confidence-tagged below. Because Morgan Stanley publishes none of its assessment internals, this chapter leans on prep-vendor synthesis and snippet-level candidate testimony — and says so at every claim. Firm processes change yearly; date-stamp and re-verify each cycle.)

11.1 Snapshot

This chapter is different from the vendor chapters around it. Morgan Stanley is not an assessment publisher — it is a bulge-bracket bank that **buys** assessments and arranges them into a hiring funnel. So the useful question is not "what is the Morgan Stanley test?" (there isn't one) but "which third-party engines does Morgan Stanley wire together, in what order, for which programme, and where does the real cut happen?" That reframing is the thesis of the guide: for a UK finance applicant, the *employer's configuration choices* — which stages exist, which norm, which deadline — matter more than the brand on the test.

Everything below carries a health warning stronger than anywhere else in the book. Morgan Stanley publishes no assessment internals, the forums that hold first-person detail (Wall Street Oasis, The Student Room) returned **HTTP 403** to automated fetching on the access date (2026-08-01), and the firm's official careers/privacy pages did not resolve on first attempt. `[UNKNOWN — access limitation, logged in §11.13]` So most of what follows is **prep-vendor synthesis** or **snippet-level candidate testimony**, not employer-confirmed fact. Treat every stage as **volatile** and re-verify it for your own cycle.

With that stated plainly: the best-supported reconstruction of Morgan Stanley's **EMEA/London** early-careers funnel, for the 2025–26 cycle, is:

`Application (rolling) → [online aptitude battery, if the programme/division requires it] → HireVue one-way video → first-round interview → assessment centre / "superday."` `[PREP-VENDOR synthesis: GraduatesFirst, PracticeAptitudeTests, JobTestPrep; + CANDIDATE-via-snippet]`

The two engines you are most likely to meet are **Aon/cut-e** for aptitude and **HireVue** for the video — both covered mechanically in their own chapters (Chapter 2 and Chapter 8 respectively), which this chapter deliberately cross-references rather than repeats. The single most important correction in the whole chapter, unpacked in §11.4, is that **Morgan Stanley's aptitude vendor is Aon/cut-e, not SHL** — a distinction that changes how you should prepare.

11.2 Why this test exists

The business case is the one that runs through Chapter 6.1 and the SHL chapter: a London campaign draws tens of thousands of applications for a few hundred seats, from a narrow band of target universities whose CVs barely separate one strong candidate from another. A standardised early screen does four things a CV screen cannot: it handles volume at near-zero marginal cost, it applies the *same* yardstick to everyone (making it legally defensible under the Equality Act 2010), it is fast, and it measures something — reasoning with unfamiliar numerical and verbal material under time pressure — close to a day-one description of a junior analyst's cognitive load. `[INFERRED — standard high-volume-selection logic; Chapter 6.1 has the validity evidence and the 2022 Sackett et al. downward revision]`

What is distinctive about Morgan Stanley is **how selectively** it applies that logic. The aptitude battery is concentrated where the applicant-to-seat ratio and analytical demand are highest (IBD summer, Spring Insight) and quietly dropped where the firm judges structured interviews sufficient (several non-IBD divisions). `[PREP-VENDOR + CANDIDATE-via-snippet]` That selectivity is itself the evidence for this guide's central argument (Chapter 6.8): the aptitude test is a **volume filter**, deployed where volume is the problem and skipped where it isn't. The HireVue, by contrast, is near-universal — because the bottleneck it industrialises, a first structured human impression at scale, is one *every* programme faces.

11.3 Why Morgan Stanley builds its stack this way

Because Morgan Stanley buys rather than builds, "why this vendor" is really a procurement story, and it maps onto three engines.

Aon/cut-e for aptitude. One prep vendor dates the Morgan Stanley↔cut-e partnership to around **2019**. `[PREP-VENDOR — JobTestPrep]` cut-e's selling points are the mirror image of SHL's: very short, mobile-friendly, **highly speeded** tests whose native anti-cheating mechanism is a **unique per-candidate item bank plus severe time pressure** rather than webcam surveillance (Chapter 2). For a firm processing huge EMEA volume, cut-e's 6-minute modules are cheap to run and hard to game by answer-sharing. The `switchChallenge` game module — one vendor calls it "unique to Morgan Stanley," meaning MS opted into that cut-e game — signals a firm comfortable with game-based formats for their candidate-experience and coaching-resistance benefits. `[PREP-VENDOR + INFERRED]`

HireVue for video. It solves the live-interview bottleneck: thousands of first-round conversations, same questions, reviewed asynchronously, integrated into the ATS (Morgan Stanley runs **tal.net / Taleo**, visible in its programme-portal URLs). `[EMPLOYER — morganstanley.tal.net]` HireVue's post-2021 "human-in-the-loop, facial-analysis-removed" repositioning (Chapter 8) gives a bank's legal and DEI functions a defensible compliance story — worth more to a bulge-bracket than any marginal predictive edge.

HackerRank for technical/quant coding. Reported for technology and quant roles only; auto-scored coding challenges the front-office IBD candidate will not meet. `[PREP-VENDOR]`

The important negative: **there is no Morgan Stanley-built "immersive" or "virtual experience" assessment.** That archetype belongs to other firms — HSBC's Cappfinity "immersive assessment" and JPMorgan's Forage "virtual experience" (§11.4, subsection) — and prep pages that imply Morgan Stanley has one are mistaken. `[INFERRED — no source attributes a bespoke immersive product to MS]`

11.4 What the assessment actually is — full mechanics

Because the engines are covered in depth elsewhere, this section gives the **Morgan Stanley-specific configuration** of each and points you to the mechanics chapter for the rest.

The online aptitude battery — Aon/cut-e "scales" (EMEA)

The candidate-reported format is diagnostic of the **cut-e / Aon "scales" family** — not SHL — and this is the correction to burn in: the discipline, pacing and item styles that win a cut-e test are **different** from SHL's, so prepare against Chapter 2, not Chapter 1. `[PREP-VENDOR + CANDIDATE-via-snippet, consistent; MS↔cut-e dated to ~2019 by JobTestPrep]`

Module	Reported format	Time	Notes
Numerical (`scales numerical`)	~18 statements across **~6 data panels** (tables/charts); answer **True / False / Cannot Say**	**~6 min**	Some prep pages quote a longer "~20 min / 18–20 Q" variant — **conflict**, likely legacy or a different config; flagged `[UNKNOWN — which is current]`
Verbal (`scales verbal`)	15–18 statements across **6 text panels**; **True / False / Cannot Say**	**~6 min**	Critical-reasoning discipline: answer only from the passage
Inductive / logical (`scales ix`)	~20 items; **odd-one-out** / find the element breaking the pattern	**~5 min**	Abstract pattern identification
`switchChallenge` (smartPredict game)	Unlimited tasks, escalating difficulty; deductive logic + attention	**~6 min**	Described as "unique to MS" — i.e. MS opted into this cut-e game module `[PREP-VENDOR]`
SJT (email/inbox)	Reply to emails asking for advice/actions; scored on competency + fit to the **Business Unit** applied to; candidate receives a results report	**~30 min** (largely untimed)	Scenarios/keying are **MS-tailored**, but the engine is cut-e `[CANDIDATE-via-snippet]`

Typically 3 of the 4 aptitude modules are assigned to a given candidate, with a **48-hour completion window** opening on a notification sent "within 48 hours" of applying. `[PREP-VENDOR]` One prep site's aggregate "20 tests / 324 questions / error-checking / GCSE-level" description looks like a **generic PrepPack marketing blurb**, not an MS-confirmed spec — do not treat those counts as fact. `[PREP-VENDOR marketing — discount]` The core mechanics of each cut-e module — the True/False/Cannot-Say logic, the speeded item bank, the smartPredict games — are drilled in **Chapter 2**; this chapter does not repeat them.

HireVue one-way video

Asynchronous, no live interviewer, roughly **30 minutes total**. For **IBD**, candidate snippets report **3 questions = 1 behavioural + 2 light-technical**; other prep pages say **3–5 questions**. `[CANDIDATE-via-snippet (WSO IBD) + PREP-VENDOR — count conflict, pin per programme]` Prep time is ~30–60 seconds, answer time ~1–2 minutes; **retry policy conflicts** across sources (one retry per question vs no retakes), almost certainly varying by config and year. `[PREP-VENDOR — conflict, flagged]` Question types: motivation ("why Morgan Stanley /

why this division"), behavioural ("tell me about a time…"), and light technical for IBD (basic accounting linkages, valuation basics) — **not** Superday-level technicals.

The volatility correction you must carry in. Prep pages still claim Morgan Stanley's HireVue scores your "facial expressions / body language" to produce an employability score. **This is outdated.** HireVue built out and then **discontinued facial-analysis scoring** (built ~March 2020, publicly announced discontinued **January 2021**), after regulatory and civil-society pressure and after its own data scientists found non-verbal cues contributed only ~0.25% of predictive power. `[INDEPENDENT — SHRM; Fortune 2021-01-19; see Chapter 8]` Current HireVue scores **language/verbal content**, not your face. Moreover, whether Morgan Stanley uses HireVue's *algorithmic* scoring at all — versus simply using HireVue as a recording tool that **humans** review — is **`[UNKNOWN]`**; many banks do the latter. So treat any "MS reads your face" warning as a myth about a product that no longer exists (full treatment: **Chapter 8**).

First-round interview

Phone / Zoom / occasionally in person; behavioural plus some technical; one to two rounds. `[PREP-VENDOR]` Not an automated assessment, so outside this guide's core scope — included only to place the OA in the funnel.

Assessment centre / "superday"

Post-COVID, frequently **virtual (Zoom)**; "superday" (US) ≈ "assessment centre" (UK). The historically reported **London** AC (IBD/GCM) comprised **2 × 30-minute interviews** (one technical, one fit), an **individual case** (~30-min prep, ~20-min presentation), a **group case** (group of ~6–7, ~4 observers; a budget-allocation archetype where candidates argue for project funding and one is made "head of department"), and a **written test similar to the online one**. `[CANDIDATE-via-snippet: WSO "Morgan Stanley London Assessment Centre"; PREP-VENDOR]` A superday variant is **3–5 back-to-back 1:1 interviews** across analyst→MD levels. `[PREP-VENDOR]` These are **MS-designed content** delivered live — **no productised MS platform** behind them.

The wider firm-built / vendor landscape (seed for the §6.8 mapping)

Because this is the "firm-built assessments" chapter, here is the broader UK-finance-and-consulting map that the master mapping in §6.8 draws on. **Every row is `[PREP-VENDOR]` unless tagged otherwise, sourced chiefly from JobTestPrep's spring-week and firm pages on 2026-08-01, and is high-volatility — re-verify yearly.** Where two sources conflict, both readings are shown rather than a false pick.

Firm	Assessment / vendor (as reported)	Stage	Cross-ref / note
Morgan Stanley	Numerical + Verbal + Logical + SJT — **Aon (cut-e)**; **HireVue** video; HackerRank (tech)	OA + video	Chapters 2, 8
Goldman Sachs	**HireVue** pre-recorded interview (signature screen, IBD); HackerRank (tech); a **legacy aptitude test with negative marking** reported (+5 correct / −2 wrong); then Superday	video / OA	Chapter 8; GS AI-process updates noted in 2024–25 press `[INDEPENDENT — Fortune]`

Firm	Assessment / vendor (as reported)	Stage	Cross-ref / note
JPMorgan	**pymetrics** — 12 gamified mini-games (~25–30 min, "91 traits") = the real **selection** OA; **HireVue** video. **Forage "virtual experience" is NOT selection** (self-paced upskill/ marketing — do not conflate)	OA + video	pymetrics **acquired by Harver, 2022** — cross-ref Chapter 4
HSBC	Online **"Immersive Assessment"** (cognitive numerical/verbal/inductive + SJT) — **Cappfinity**	OA	This IS the "immersive / day-in-the-life" archetype — cross-ref Chapter 5
Citi	Numerical + Logical — **Talent-Q (Korn Ferry)**	OA	—
UBS	Cultural-Match SJT — **Talent-Q (Korn Ferry)**; Numerical/ Verbal/Inductive — **Aon (cut-e)**	OA	Chapter 2
Barclays	Cognitive + Personality + Mindset — **SHL** … but another page reports **pymetrics**	OA	**Conflict presented as-is** — SHL *and* pymetrics both reported; do not assert one `[PREP-VENDOR, conflict / volatility]`
Deutsche Bank	SJT — **SHL**; cut-e "scales" also reported historically	OA	Chapters 1, 2
Bank of America	**HireVue** pre-recorded interview; IBM Kenexa / SHL TalentCentral also cited	video / OA	**Conflict** `[PREP-VENDOR]`
Jefferies	**SHL** cognitive + behavioural (reported to screen **~30–40%** through to first rounds); then HireVue/phone → Superday	OA	Chapter 1; note this is the one peer with a *reported* conversion figure
Evercore	**No HireVue / no OA** (US) — live interviews → Superday	none	The "minimal" end of the spectrum
Rothschild & Co	**HireVue** pre-recorded	video	Chapter 8
BlackRock	**HireVue coding assessment** (6 coding tasks + 1 pre-recorded HR question) → superday loop	OA / video	Chapter 8
Standard Chartered	Online assessment (page exists)	OA	Detail `[UNKNOWN]`
Schroders / M&G / Baillie Gifford / Fidelity	—	—	**`[UNKNOWN]`** — not captured this pass

Consulting simulations (firm-commissioned, and useful context because they are the most genuinely *firm-distinctive* assessments in the market):

- **McKinsey Solve** (formerly the Problem Solving Game / Imbellus digital assessment), built by **Imbellus (now part of Roblox)** — gamified and **process-scored** (how you solve, not just the answer). Reported 2025–26 modules: **Redrock** (ecosystem/data), **Sea Wolf** (ocean, math-heavy), **Sustainable Futures Lab**; the older **Ecosystem** game was **phased out in most regions in late 2025**; ~70–100 minutes; now includes a behavioural/judgement module. `[PREP-VENDOR: mconsultingprep, myconsultingcoach]` This is the market's most prep-unique assessment.

- **BCG Casey** — **chatbot-style case simulation**, closest to a real case interview; BCG has also historically used **pymetrics** games plus an Online Case. `[PREP-VENDOR]`
- **Bain** — the **Bain SOVA test** (traditional numerical/verbal/logical aptitude; standard test-prep transfers), with Online Test / gamified elements varying by region and year. `[PREP-VENDOR]`
- **Bank "virtual experience" job-simulations (Forage)** — self-paced task simulations several banks (notably JPMorgan) promote. These are **upskilling / marketing / pipeline-building, not selection gates** — a distinction candidates routinely get wrong. `[PREP-VENDOR + INFERRED]`

A platform caveat worth carrying: multiple sources claim several banks (GS, JPM, Citi, Barclays, BofA) deliver through the **SHL TalentCentral** *platform* even where the *test content* is a different vendor's — so "runs on TalentCentral" does **not** mean "is an SHL test." Platform ≠ test authorship. `[PREP-VENDOR — verify]`

11.5 Is it tailored to the role?

At two levels, and the distinction matters.

At the item level — mostly no. The cut-e numerical, verbal and inductive modules are the same instruments cut-e sells to any employer. `[INFERRED — standard vendor structure; Chapter 2]` What is genuinely tailored is the **SJT**: the email-inbox scenarios are keyed to competencies and values, and — notably — **to the specific Business Unit you applied to**, so the "best" response reflects Morgan Stanley's framing of that division's judgement calls. `[CANDIDATE-via-snippet]` The `switchChallenge` inclusion is itself a tailoring choice.

At the funnel level — highly tailored, and this is the headline. Morgan Stanley configures *which stages you face at all* by programme and division:

- **Spring Insight (London/Glasgow):** full cut-e battery (numerical + verbal + logical + SJT) + HireVue, feeding a selection-lite one-day insight event. `[PREP-VENDOR + CANDIDATE-via-snippet]`
- **Summer Analyst — IBD:** full cut-e battery + HireVue (~3 Qs) + full AC (interviews + group + case + written). `[PREP-VENDOR + CANDIDATE-via-snippet]`
- **Summer Analyst — non-IBD (S&T, IM, GCM): often no OA** ("interviews only") + HireVue + superday-style. `[PREP-VENDOR — JobTestPrep]`
- **Summer — Quant/Derivatives:** full battery **plus an extra timed OA** + technical. `[PREP-VENDOR-via-snippet]`
- **Off-Cycle:** OA **usually skipped or compressed**; **HireVue mandatory**; interviews only, faster. `[PREP-VENDOR + CANDIDATE-via-snippet (WSO)]`
- **US programmes:** more HireVue→Superday-led, with aptitude testing **less heavy than EMEA** and concentrated on IBD. `[PREP-VENDOR (US-focused: Leland, igotanoffer); EMEA-vs-US OA split otherwise INFERRED — exact US OA use = UNKNOWN]`

The practical consequence: **do not assume the funnel a friend describes applies to you.** An S&T summer applicant and an IBD summer applicant at the same firm, same cycle, can face materially different processes — one interviews-first, the other OA-gated. Confirm what *your* invitation actually contains.

11.6 How they screen and filter — scoring, norms, cut-offs, ranking

This is the analytical centre of the chapter, and its most important conclusion is a **negative** one: at Morgan Stanley, the online assessment is **probably not where most people are cut.**

The scoring model — cut-e, not SHL. The aptitude battery is scored on **cut-e's speed-and-accuracy model against cut-e norms**, which behaves differently from an SHL percentile (Chapter 2 has the full mechanics). The practical upshot is that cut-e rewards **fast, accurate, disciplined** work under a punishing clock more than it rewards raw ceiling ability, and its True/False/Cannot-Say format punishes importing outside knowledge. There is **no published Morgan Stanley cut-score**, and prep vendors' own numbers self-disclaim as estimates — so this guide states none as fact. `[UNKNOWN — MS does not publish; prep-vendor figures are estimates]`

The HireVue sift. Competency-ranked, used to prioritise reviewer attention rather than to hard auto-reject — and, for Morgan Stanley specifically, **possibly human-reviewed rather than algorithmically scored** (`[UNKNOWN]`; Chapter 8). Either way, no MS-specific HireVue cut number exists.

Where the biggest cut actually is. The best-supported inference — consistent with this guide's cross-cutting thesis (Chapter 6.8) — is that for IBD and off-cycle the tightest hurdle is the **CV / cover-letter sift operating against rolling deadlines**, not the OA. The reasoning: (1) prep vendors uniformly push "apply within 7–10 days of posting," which only bites if the *application* screen is the binding constraint; (2) the OA is a **practiceable, 48-hour, unique-item-bank format** that filters *unprepared* applicants far more than it discriminates among strong ones; and (3) **off-cycle skips the OA entirely yet remains ferociously competitive**, which is direct evidence that the OA is not the load-bearing filter there. `[INFERRED — no hard MS conversion numbers exist to prove this]`

The honest limit. A peer, Jefferies, has a *reported* SHL screen-through figure of ~30–40% to first rounds — but **no analogous Morgan Stanley conversion number was found**, and this guide will not invent one. `[UNKNOWN — do not fabricate]` A post-internship return-offer rate of ~50–70% circulates, but it is a US-centric prep figure, **not MS-confirmed.** `[PREP-VENDOR — treat as folklore]` Multi-hurdle logic applies: acing the numerical module does not rescue a weak SJT-fit profile or a poor HireVue — the stages are largely **independent gates**, so allocate prep across all of them rather than over-investing in numerical alone. `[INFERRED — standard multi-stage design]`

Retake policy. Employer-set and `[UNKNOWN]` for Morgan Stanley specifically; cut-e and HireVue both leave retake rules to the employer, and the general norm is **no candidate-initiated retake within a cycle** (Chapters 2, 8).

11.7 How to score well — legitimate, specific, actionable

The Morgan Stanley-specific layer sits on top of the construct drills in Chapters 2 (cut-e), 6.4 (cognitive constructs) and 8 (HireVue).

Aptitude — prep cut-e, not SHL. This is the highest-leverage correction in the chapter. Spend your time on cut-e's actual formats:

- **True / False / Cannot Say discipline.** For numerical and verbal, "Cannot Say" is correct whenever the panel does not *entail* the statement — even if it is probably true. The commonest failure is importing real-world knowledge or over-inferring. Train the reflex: *is this strictly forced by the data on screen?*
- **Pace to ~6 minutes.** At ~18 items in 6 minutes you have roughly **15–20 seconds per item**. You cannot re-derive percentages from scratch each time; make percentage-change, ratio-extraction and unit/scale-trap recognition automatic (Chapters 2, 6.4). The skill that wins is **finding the right two numbers fast across ~6 panels**, not heavy calculation.
- **`ix` inductive odd-one-out.** Check each dimension separately — shape, count, position, shading, orientation — rather than hunting one gestalt; the answer is the element breaking the rule the others share.
- **`switchChallenge`.** A deductive-logic/attention game under escalating difficulty — practise staying accurate as it speeds up; do not panic when it gets harder (that means you are progressing).
- **Email-inbox SJT.** Read Morgan Stanley's published values and — importantly — think about the **Business Unit you applied to**, since keying is BU-specific. Answer as a collaborative, client-aware, judgement-showing colleague; you receive a results report, so treat it as real.

HireVue — substance over surface. Structure every answer STAR/CARL, lead with a one-sentence headline, and prepare a **story bank** plus a crisp "why Morgan Stanley / why this division." For IBD, expect **two light-technical** questions (basic accounting linkages, valuation/DCF basics) and one behavioural — so have a recent **Morgan Stanley transaction** ready (the firm's "Transactions" page, plus FT/Bloomberg/Reuters) and rehearse tight 1–2-minute answers. If a retry is offered, use it deliberately. Ignore any advice about "controlling your facial expressions for the AI" — that product is gone (Chapter 8); look into the lens for the *human* reviewer and focus on what you say.

Assessment centre. Expect a **written test mirroring the online one** (so your cut-e prep pays off twice), a ~20-minute individual case, and a group case (often budget-allocation): contribute substantively **and** bring others in — dominating it is the classic own goal. `[PREP-VENDOR + CANDIDATE-via-snippet]`

11.8 Integrity monitoring — what is actually detected

Morgan Stanley publishes nothing on this, so the honest answer is **mostly `[UNKNOWN]` for MS specifically**, with the vendor defaults as the best available proxy.

Aptitude (cut-e). cut-e's native anti-cheating is architectural, not surveillance: a **unique per-candidate item bank** (so answer-sharing is near-useless — your friend's "question 4" is not yours) plus **extreme time pressure** that leaves little room to look things up. Webcam proctoring is **offered by cut-e but usually switched off** on graduate deployments, and there is **no evidence Morgan Stanley webcam-proctors its aptitude tests.** `[INFERRED from cut-e defaults – Chapter 2; MS-specific = UNKNOWN]`

HireVue. Where enabled, HireVue can log **browser focus / tab-switch events** and capture **webcam presence snapshots** — but it is **camera and audio only, not screen-recording, and emphatically not eye-tracking or emotion analysis** (discontinued January 2021). Flags go to a **human**, who decides — there is **no auto-reject on a tab-switch** (Chapter 8). `[PREP-VENDOR / INDEPENDENT – Chapter 8]` Whether Morgan Stanley enables any of this is `[UNKNOWN]`.

The residual gap that matters. No candidate report of Morgan Stanley flagging or invalidating an OA or HireVue was found. So MS-specific integrity-enforcement behaviour — how a flag is actioned, whether anyone is ever rejected on one — is genuinely `[UNKNOWN]`, not merely unstated. Do not infer a harsh regime; do not infer a lax one.

11.9 How candidates commonly trip the system — including honestly

Since Morgan Stanley publishes no integrity detail, this section imports the **vendor-level** risk catalogue (full versions in Chapters 2 and 8) and flags which parts plausibly apply.

On the cut-e aptitude battery, the realistic failure modes are performance, not surveillance: **running out of time** (the 6-minute clock is the real adversary), **importing outside knowledge** into True/False/Cannot-Say items, and **panicking as `switchChallenge` accelerates.** Because the item bank is unique per candidate and proctoring is usually off, the classic webcam false-positives (looking away, second monitor, background faces) are **less likely here than on a lockdown-proctored exam** — inference from cut-e defaults, not an MS guarantee. `[INFERRED; MS-specific = UNKNOWN]`

On the HireVue, the genuine current risks (Chapter 8) are: **accent under NLP scoring** *if* MS scores algorithmically (unknown — speak clearly, give fuller answers), **stutter or speech difference** penalised by a timed single-take format (a strong basis for an adjustment, §11.11), **presence-snapshots failing in poor lighting** (fix with front-lighting), and **eye-line read as evasive by a human reviewer** (look into the lens, glance at off-camera notes minimally). Worth repeating: **your face is no longer machine-scored**, so the old "wrong expression" nightmares affect only a human's impression, which is more forgiving.

Genuine cheating that is caught (stated as risk, not instruction): someone else sitting the unproctored OA is undermined by the unique item bank if a supervised re-check is used; a scripted HireVue answer shows in flat delivery and eyes tracking text; tab-switching to look things up is caught by focus logging where enabled. None is worth it — which is why this guide's value is legitimate preparation.

11.10 How to be unambiguously clean — pre-flight checklist

The goal is to remove avoidable ambiguity *before* you start. Adapted for the Morgan Stanley stack; print it.

- **Confirm the format in writing first.** Ask Morgan Stanley's recruitment team (email is fine) which stages your programme includes, whether the HireVue is **monitored** and whether **re-records** are allowed, and whether a calculator/scratch paper is permitted for the cut-e numerical. This tells you which risks even apply and creates a record.
- **Aptitude environment:** a quiet room, stable **wired** connection (a disconnection mid-6-minute test is costly and unrecoverable), notifications and OS/antivirus auto-updates paused, second monitor disconnected. Calculator and scratch paper ready **only if confirmed permitted**.
- **HireVue environment:** sit alone, in a quiet, **front-lit** room (light in front, not behind), camera at eye level, nothing and no one else in frame, phone away. Do **not** tab-switch; keep any brief prompts on paper beside the camera and glance minimally.
- **Sit each stage when you are cognitively sharp** — for most people mid-morning, not late at night. Do the **practice questions/items** every time (cut-e and HireVue both offer them).

- **Adjustments:** if you have a disability or condition (dyslexia, ADHD, autism, a visual impairment, a stutter or speech difference, anything affecting movement, gaze or pace), **request adjustments in writing before you sit**, using the template in §11.11. Do not wait until the day.

11.11 If you are flagged or rejected

Your full legal rights are in Chapter 6.7; this is the Morgan Stanley-specific playbook. **A key caveat: Morgan Stanley's official careers/privacy/accessibility pages did not resolve on the access date, so MS-specific adjustment and GDPR/automated-decision statements are `[UNKNOWN]`** — the framework below is the general UK position, which applies to MS as an EMEA employer bound by UK/EU data-protection law.

First, ask — plainly and promptly. Email Morgan Stanley recruitment, reference your application, and ask whether an assessment result or integrity flag contributed to the decision, and whether a re-sit or human review is possible. Firms are not obliged to answer in detail, but asking creates a record.

Then use your data-protection rights. Under **UK GDPR Article 15 (right of access)** you can submit a **Data Subject Access Request (DSAR)** to Morgan Stanley (the data controller), which must respond within **one month**, free. Ask specifically for: your **cut-e scores and the norm/comparison basis used**; your **HireVue recording and transcript** and any **AI-derived competency scores**; any **integrity/monitoring log** (focus events, presence snapshots); the **logic of any automated decision-making**; and confirmation of **whether a human was involved** in the decision.

The corrected automated-decision framework (2026). Where a rejection was based *solely* on automated processing with no meaningful human involvement, you can invoke the safeguards now set out in **Articles 22A–22C of the UK GDPR, as amended by the Data (Use and Access) Act 2025 (in force 5 February 2026)** — the right to make representations, **obtain human intervention**, and contest the decision. Note this is a 2026 change: the old blanket "Article 22 prohibition" framing is **out of date**. The full current position is in **Chapter 6.7**. Because HireVue markets human-in-the-loop and Morgan Stanley may well review recordings manually (`[UNKNOWN]`), most MS deployments are likely *not* solely automated — but invoking the right forces confirmation that a human reviewed you. `[REGULATORY — DUAA 2025]`

Disability route. If a false flag or low score stems from a disability, disclosing it and requesting a reasonable adjustment under the **Equality Act 2010** is often the most effective lever, because the duty to make reasonable adjustments is a legal obligation, not a favour. If the employer stonewalls a data request, you can complain to the **Information Commissioner's Office (ICO)**.

Realistic expectations. Straightforward score rejections are rarely overturned — the firm had more strong applicants than seats. Integrity flags are more contestable, especially with an innocent documented cause — but firms move slowly and a rolling cycle may close before an appeal resolves. The higher-value use of these rights is often **evidence for next time.**

Template wording (short, adaptable):

(a) Pre-assessment adjustments request — send before you sit:

> Subject: Reasonable adjustment request — [name], [role/ref] Dear [team], I have been invited to complete Morgan Stanley's online assessment / HireVue video interview for [role]. I have [condition, e.g. dyslexia / ADHD / a stutter / a visual impairment], and under the Equality Act 2010 I request reasonable adjustments — specifically [e.g. 25% additional time on the timed aptitude tests; the ability to re-record HireVue answers; a non-monitored format]. I can provide documentation. Please confirm what can be arranged and the revised deadline. Thank you.

(b) Post-rejection query / human-review request:

> Subject: Assessment outcome — request for information and review — [name], [ref] Dear [team], Thank you for the update. Please could you confirm whether my performance on, or any integrity flag arising from, the online assessment or HireVue contributed to the decision, and whether a human reviewed the outcome. Under Articles 22A–22C UK GDPR (as amended by the Data (Use and Access) Act 2025) I wish to make representations and obtain human intervention. Separately, under Article 15 I request my scores, my HireVue recording and transcript, any competency scores, and any integrity log. Please respond within one month. Thank you.

11.12 Step-by-step: how to win this assessment

A numbered playbook, from two weeks out to debrief.

1. **T-minus 14 days — map your actual funnel.** Confirm which stages *your* programme/division includes (IBD summer ≠ S&T summer ≠ off-cycle). Diagnose with one full timed **cut-e-style** practice set (numerical, verbal, `ix`) — not a generic SHL one — and score it. Identify your weakest module and pacing gap.
2. **T-12 to T-4 — drill cut-e specifically.** ~30–45 min/day using Chapter 2. Weight toward your weakest module. Make True/False/Cannot-Say discipline and ~15-second-per-item pacing reflexive. Keep an error log (what you got wrong *and why*).
3. **T-9 to T-4 — build the HireVue story bank.** Draft 6–8 STAR/CARL stories, a sharp "why Morgan Stanley / why this division," and — for IBD — refresh basic technicals (accounting linkages, valuation/DCF) plus one recent MS transaction. Rehearse to camera at ~30-sec prep / 90-sec answer.
4. **T-7 — simulate and sort logistics.** Do a full timed run on your real laptop, at your sharpest time of day, to surface set-up problems while you can fix them. If you need adjustments, send the §11.11(a) request **now**. Confirm proctoring / calculator / re-record rules in writing.
5. **T-2 — taper.** Lighter practice, focus on pacing and calm. Because Morgan Stanley reviews **rolling**, if you are ready, **submit early** — an on-time strong application beats a marginally better one weeks later into a shrinking pool (see the note below and Chapter 6.8).
6. **Day before — checklist.** Charge the laptop, test the (ideally wired) connection, clear and light the room, set Do Not Disturb, pause auto-updates, disconnect the second monitor, put out permitted calculator/paper, sleep.
7. **30 minutes before.** Close every other application and tab. Silence the phone. Do the **practice items/ questions** to warm up and check kit. Water, not a fifth coffee.
8. **In-test decision rules.** *Aptitude:* pace to the ~6-minute clock (~15–20 s/item), never leave an item blank if unpenalised, answer only from the panel (Cannot-Say when not entailed), don't panic when `switchChallenge` speeds up. *HireVue:* use think-time to pick your story and headline, answer the question in

sentence one, keep to STAR, look into the lens, and if you fumble with no re-record, reset in one phrase and continue.

9. **The rolling-deadline point.** Morgan Stanley reviews EMEA applications on a rolling basis and the effective bar rises as seats fill. If you are prepared, **apply and sit early** rather than sacrificing weeks for a marginal score gain (Chapter 6.8).
10. **Debrief.** Immediately after each stage, note the *actual* format — module count, timings, HireVue question count and retry policy, whether monitoring was disclosed — for your next cycle and for this guide's accuracy. Given how volatile MS's process is, your own contemporaneous notes are the most reliable source you will ever have.

11.13 Sources for this chapter

All accessed **2026-08-01**. Confidence tags as used above. **Access limitation, stated up front:** Wall Street Oasis and The Student Room both returned **HTTP 403** to automated fetching on the access date, so first-person forum testimony here is reconstructed from **search-result snippets** (`[CANDIDATE-via-snippet]`), not full-page reads; and Morgan Stanley's official careers/privacy/accessibility pages did not resolve on first attempt (adjustments/GDPR specifics therefore `[UNKNOWN]`). Because Morgan Stanley publishes no assessment internals, **no source below is employer-confirmed on test mechanics**; treat everything as prep-vendor synthesis or candidate snippet unless tagged otherwise.

Employer (ATS / programme posts — confirm structure, not internals): - Morgan Stanley programme portal on **tal.net** (Taleo/tal.net ATS), e.g. Spring Insight Programme London — https://morganstanley.tal.net/vx/mobile-0/brand-0/candidate/so/pm/1/pl/1/opp/17670-2025-ISG-MSIM-Spring-Insight-Programme-London/en-GB `[EMPLOYER]`

Prep-vendor (format/funnel synthesis; corroborate — commercially biased, and self-disclaim their own cut-scores): - JobTestPrep — Morgan Stanley summer internship (cut-e since ~2019; module detail) — https://www.jobtestprep.com/morgan-stanley-summer-internship - JobTestPrep — spring-week preparation (the vendor-by-bank mapping used in §11.4) — https://www.jobtestprep.co.uk/spring-week-preparation - GraduatesFirst — Morgan Stanley job tests (SHL/cut-e hedge, funnel) — https://www.graduatesfirst.com/morgan-stanley-job-tests - PracticeAptitudeTests — Morgan Stanley assessments — https://www.practiceaptitudetests.com/top-employer-profiles/morgan-stanley-assessments/ - The Interview Guys — Morgan Stanley HireVue (format; the outdated AI-facial-scoring claim) — https://blog.theinterviewguys.com/morgan-stanley-hirevue-questions/ (pub 2025-10-24, mod 2026-06-19) - Leland — Morgan Stanley internship guide (US-centric funnel) — https://www.joinleland.com/library/a/morgan-stanley-internship-guide-process-questions-and-tips - igotanoffer — Morgan Stanley interview — https://igotanoffer.com/blogs/finance/morgan-stanley-interview - Peer-firm mapping (§11.4): JobTestPrep JP Morgan / Jefferies / BlackRock pages; GraduatesFirst JP Morgan aptitude tests; Extern Evercore guide; mconsultingprep & myconsultingcoach (McKinsey Solve) — as listed in research/11-morgan-stanley-firmbuilt.md

Independent (the HireVue facial-analysis correction — load-bearing): - SHRM — HireVue discontinues facial-analysis screening; NLP now primary — https://www.shrm.org/topics-tools/news/talent-acquisition/hirevue-discontinues-facial-analysis-screening `[INDEPENDENT]` - Fortune (2021-01-19) — HireVue drops facial monitoring; the ~0.25% non-verbal-contribution figure — https://fortune.com/2021/01/19/hirevue-drops-facial-monitoring-amid-a-i-algorithm-audit/ `[INDEPENDENT]`

Regulatory: - Data (Use and Access) Act 2025 — UK GDPR Articles 22A–22C (in force 5 February 2026); full treatment in Chapter 6.7 `[REGULATORY — DUAA 2025]`

Candidate (testimony; snippet-level only — the source forums 403'd on the access date): - Wall Street Oasis threads: "Morgan Stanley London Assessment Centre," "MS HireVue off-cycle 2026," "Morgan Stanley off-cycle internship" `[CANDIDATE-via-snippet — HTTP 403, full read is a residual gap]` - The Student Room threads: t=5728928, t=7530073, t=7543831, t=7539080 `[CANDIDATE-via-snippet — HTTP 403]`

Cross-references (mechanics not repeated here): Chapter 2 (Aon/cut-e test mechanics), Chapter 8 (HireVue), Chapter 4 (pymetrics/Harver), Chapter 5 (Cappfinity/HSBC immersive), Chapter 6.7 (data-protection & automated-decision rights), Chapter 6.8 (the master employer→vendor mapping this chapter seeds).

(Residual gaps — full reads of the 403-blocked WSO/TSR threads for dated first-person timings and division-by-division OA confirmation; the correct MS EMEA students-graduates careers/privacy/accessibility URLs for adjustments and automated-decision statements; resolution of the numerical-test config conflict (6-min/18-item cut-e vs "20-min" variant), the HireVue question-count (3 vs 3–5) and retry-policy conflicts; confirmation of whether any MS programme has moved to SHL vs cut-e in 2026; whether the US process uses any aptitude OA; the Barclays SHL-vs-pymetrics and BofA HireVue-vs-Kenexa-vs-SHL vendor conflicts; and asset-manager mappings (Schroders, M&G, Baillie Gifford, Fidelity) — are logged in research/11-morgan-stanley-firmbuilt.md and the master gap register.)

Part II — Cross-Cutting Reference

Chapter 6.1 — Why Online Assessments Exist At All

Before you spend six weeks drilling numerical reasoning or worrying about a balloon-pumping game, it is worth understanding why the online assessment (OA) exists in the first place — because the reasons are not the ones the vendors' marketing implies, and knowing the real drivers tells you exactly how much weight to give the thing. The short version: the OA exists because online applications broke the economics of graduate hiring, because a standardised test predicts performance modestly better than the alternatives an employer would otherwise use, because a validated test is legally defensible in a way a partner's instinct is not, and because vendors have turned "reduces bias" and "improves candidate experience" into a competitive marketplace. Every one of those drivers is real. Several of them are also contested. This chapter lays out both, because the honest picture is more useful to you than either the vendor pitch or the reflexive cynicism.

The volume problem: when applying became almost free

For most of the twentieth century, applying for a job cost the applicant something real — a typed letter, a stamp, an afternoon. That friction did the employer's first-stage filtering for them: only reasonably motivated people applied, and the numbers stayed manageable. The online application form destroyed that friction almost completely. A candidate can now fire off an application in minutes, at zero marginal cost, to as many firms as they have the stamina to target. Add the "one-click apply" plumbing of LinkedIn and the graduate job boards, and the natural consequence follows: application volumes exploded.

The numbers at the top of the UK market are genuinely daunting. A London bulge-bracket investment bank's graduate or summer-analyst programme can attract on the order of tens of thousands of applications for a few hundred seats — ratios frequently quoted in the range of a hundred applicants per place, and considerably worse for the most sought-after divisions. `[INFERRED — corroborated across bank early-careers reporting and graduate-recruiter commentary; exact figures rarely audited]` The precise numbers move year to year and firms rarely publish audited figures, but the order of magnitude is not in dispute, and it is the single most important fact about why the OA exists.

Now put yourself in the employer's chair, because the OA is a solution to *their* problem, not yours. That problem has three parts. First, sheer volume: no realistic human team can interview, or even carefully read, tens of thousands of applications for a few hundred roles. Second, a legal duty not to discriminate — every rejection must, in principle, be defensible on job-relevant grounds (more on this below). Third, and least appreciated by candidates, is that the CVs barely differentiate. The applicant pool for a London finance programme is drawn overwhelmingly from the same dozen or two target universities, studying overlapping degrees, with predictably similar internships, society positions and "led a team of…" bullet points. A recruiter staring at ten thousand CVs from broadly the same population cannot rank them meaningfully on paper; the signal-to-noise ratio of the CV, within that pre-selected pool, is low.

Against that problem, an automated online assessment is extraordinarily attractive on cost alone. A human screen of a single application — a recruiter reading carefully, or a first-round phone conversation — costs real staff time, and staff time is the expensive input in recruitment. An automated OA, once built, costs the employer a licence fee per candidate that is a small fraction of that human cost, and it scales to any volume without adding headcount.

`[INFERRED — the cost logic is structural; vendors do not publish per-candidate pricing, so exact multiples are unknown]` `[UNKNOWN — specific cost-per-candidate figures]` The OA is, in blunt terms, the cheapest scalable way to convert an unmanageable pile into a rankable shortlist. That is the primary reason it exists. Everything else in this chapter is a secondary driver layered on top of that economic fact.

Predictive validity: does the test beat the alternatives?

Cheapness alone would not justify the OA if it told the employer nothing. The deeper justification is that a standardised test predicts later job performance *better than the cheap alternatives an employer would otherwise fall back on* — better than a CV screen, and better than an unstructured "let's just have a chat" interview. This is where the industrial-organisational (IO) psychology evidence comes in, and it is worth getting right because the headline figure has recently moved.

For decades the canonical reference was Schmidt and Hunter's 1998 meta-analysis, which reported that general mental ability (GMA) — broadly, cognitive or reasoning ability — was the single strongest predictor of job performance among common selection methods, with an operational validity of about **r ≈ 0.51**. `[INDEPENDENT — Schmidt & Hunter, 1998, Psychological Bulletin]` That number was quoted everywhere, including in vendors' own justification materials, and it underwrote the whole aptitude-testing industry.

You should know that this figure has since been revised sharply downward. A 2022 re-analysis by Sackett, Zhang, Berry and Lievens argued that the older meta-analyses had over-corrected for "range restriction" — a statistical adjustment for the fact that you only ever see the performance of people you actually hired, not the rejected pool — and that the correction had been applied too aggressively. Their revised estimate put the operational validity of cognitive-ability tests closer to **r ≈ 0.31**. `[INDEPENDENT — Sackett, Zhang, Berry & Lievens, 2022, Journal of Applied Psychology]` This is not a footnote; it materially lowers the strongest single number the industry relied on, and it is discussed at greater length in Chapter 6.3. Cognitive ability remains among the better predictors — it did not collapse — but the honest current figure is "modest," not "commanding."

The crucial comparison, though, is not cognitive-test-versus-perfection; it is cognitive-test-versus-the-alternative. And on that comparison the case for standardisation holds up. The **unstructured interview** — a free-flowing conversation with no fixed questions or scoring scheme — is one of the *weakest* commonly used methods, prone to first-impression bias, similarity bias (interviewers favour people like themselves) and simple inconsistency between interviewers. **Structured interviews** (fixed questions, anchored scoring) and **work-sample tests** (having someone actually do a representative task) out-predict the unstructured chat substantially. `[INDEPENDENT — consistent finding across the IO-psych meta-analytic literature, including Schmidt & Hunter and subsequent work]` A standardised OA, whatever its limits, at least measures everyone against the same yardstick under the same conditions, which the unstructured alternative fundamentally cannot.

What an r of about 0.3 actually means for you

Because this is so easily over-read in both directions, it is worth stating plainly what a correlation of that size means. You square the correlation to get the proportion of performance variance the predictor explains: $0.31^2 \approx$ **0.10**, so a cognitive test at that validity explains only around **9–10% of the variation** in job performance. Even the old, optimistic 0.51 explained only about a quarter. `[INDEPENDENT]`

Two conclusions follow, and they point in opposite directions depending on whose chair you sit in. For the **employer**, a predictor that explains 9% of variance is genuinely worth having when you are sifting tens of thousands of people, because small edges aggregate across an enormous pool — nudging the average quality of a few hundred hires upward, at trivial marginal cost, is a good trade even if any single prediction is unreliable. For **you, the candidate**, the same number means the OA is a probabilistic filter with a great deal of noise in it: a high score shifts your odds but does not determine your fate, and a large majority of what makes someone a good analyst is simply not captured by the test. A rejection at this stage is not a verdict on your ability, let alone your worth; it is one noisy signal, and Chapter 6.3 explains in detail why your score is a range rather than a point. The employer plays the averages across thousands of people; you experience a single draw from a noisy process. Both things are true at once.

Standardisation and legal defensibility

Here is a driver that candidates almost never think about and that weighs heavily inside HR and legal functions: a validated, standardised test is *defensible* in a way a human judgement is not. Under the **Equality Act 2010**, a UK employer's selection process can be challenged for both direct and indirect discrimination, and the burden falls on the employer to show that a process which disadvantages a protected group is a proportionate means of achieving a legitimate aim. A partner's "gut feel," or an unstructured interview whose reasons live only in the interviewer's head, is extremely hard to defend on those terms — it leaves no auditable trail and no evidence of job-relevance. A standardised assessment, administered identically to everyone, with documented validity evidence and a paper trail of scores, is a far stronger legal footing. `[INDEPENDENT – the defensibility logic is well established in employment-selection practice; the specific Equality Act framing is covered in Chapter 6.7]`

This matters more than the vendors advertise, because it is a driver that operates on the employer's *risk*, not their efficiency. Even if an OA added nothing to prediction, a large employer facing thousands of rejections a year has a powerful incentive to base those rejections on a consistent, documented, ostensibly job-relevant instrument rather than on individual discretion. The legal architecture of graduate hiring in the UK is examined in Chapter 6.7; for now, register that "it protects us if we are challenged" is a genuine and under-discussed reason the OA exists.

Adverse impact and the DEI argument: the case for, and the critique

The most contested driver is fairness itself — and here you must hold two things in your head at once, because the marketing and the counter-literature both contain truth.

The case for. Vendors sell many modern assessments explicitly as *reducing* adverse impact. The argument runs: a standardised tool judges everyone on the same job-relevant criteria, "looking past" the grades and the institution on the CV, so it can surface talent that a human screener — biased toward familiar universities and familiar backgrounds — would miss. Game-based and strengths assessments are marketed hardest on this line. pymetrics built its whole pitch around bias-reduction and audited algorithms; Cappfinity markets strengths assessment as a way to "level the playing field" for candidates whose potential is not captured by academic pedigree. `[VENDOR – pymetrics and Cappfinity marketing positioning]` For an employer whose applicant pool is dominated by a narrow set of target universities, a tool that claims to find capable people *outside* that set is genuinely appealing, and not only for public-relations reasons — it widens the funnel.

The critique. The counter-literature is substantial and you should not let the marketing smooth it over. First, classic **cognitive-ability tests show well-documented average score differences between demographic groups** — this is one of the most replicated and uncomfortable findings in the field, and it is precisely why some employers moved *away* from pure aptitude tests toward game-based and strengths tools in the first place. `[INDEPENDENT]` Second, the claim that a game-based or algorithmic tool is "bias-free" is frequently **unaudited or**

contested. The marketing language of "fairness" often outruns the published evidence. A pointed example: a 2024 study presented at the ACM Conference on Fairness, Accountability and Transparency (FAccT) — the "monocultures" critique — examined pymetrics-style hiring algorithms and reported that even after bias-mitigation, a meaningful share of role models (on the order of **10.62% of positions** in the cases examined) still adversely impacted Black applicants on a per-position basis. `[INDEPENDENT – FAccT 2024 "monocultures" critique of algorithmic hiring; figure as reported in that work]` The headline "we de-bias our algorithm" and the reality "some positions still show adverse impact" are both accurate, which is exactly why you should treat blanket fairness claims with care.

Third, the fairness problem is not confined to the scoring model — it can live in the *hardware*. Remote-proctoring and any face- or video-based component inherits the well-documented demographic disparities of computer-vision systems: the **Gender Shades** research and subsequent **NIST** facial-recognition testing found substantially higher error rates for darker-skinned and female faces. `[INDEPENDENT – Buolamwini & Gebru "Gender Shades"; NIST Face Recognition Vendor Test]` A proctoring system that flags "suspicious" behaviour, or a video platform that struggles to track certain faces, can therefore disadvantage candidates in ways that have nothing to do with their ability. The integrity-and-proctoring machinery is covered in Chapter 6.6; the point here is that "the assessment reduces bias" and "the assessment can introduce bias" are not contradictory slogans — they describe different components, and a serious account has to include both.

The honest summary: standardisation *can* reduce certain human biases relative to an unstructured screen, and that is a real reason employers adopt these tools; but "bias-free" is a marketing claim, not an established fact, and the specific claims of specific vendors range from well-audited to entirely unsubstantiated. Where a provider's claim sits on that spectrum is assessed provider by provider in the later chapters.

The candidate-experience arms race

A quieter but very real driver is that assessments have become an *employer-branding* battleground. Because the top firms compete for the same students, the OA is often a candidate's first substantive interaction with the brand — and a clunky, hour-long, desktop-only test full of dated line-drawing puzzles sends a message. So vendors compete, and sell, on candidate experience: slick interfaces, gamified formats, mobile-first design, shorter run-times, "engaging" and "immersive" framing. A firm can market its process as modern and respectful of your time, and point to the assessment as proof.

There is a genuine tension buried in this, and it is worth naming because you will feel it. The engagement marketing frames the assessment as a fun, low-stakes experience the firm has thoughtfully designed *for you*. Your actual experience is of a high-stakes filter that will reject the large majority of the people who take it. A gamified interface does not change the base rate. The gamification is real and sometimes genuinely reduces test anxiety — but it is layered on top of a competitive sift, and the cheerful framing should not lull you into treating the exercise as casual. Take the "quick, fun game" exactly as seriously as you would a traditional exam, because it is doing the same job.

Speed-to-offer as a driver

The last operational driver is time. In a market where the strongest candidates hold multiple offers, whoever reaches a decision first has an advantage, and internal recruiting teams are measured on time-to-hire. Automated first-stage filtering compresses that timeline enormously: an OA can sift thousands overnight, where human screening would take weeks. Vendors sell hard on this. SHL's marketing, for instance, carries claims such as having "reduced time-to-hire by 60%" and "saved 4,200+ interview hours" for client organisations. `[VENDOR – SHL marketing; uncorroborated by independent audit]` Treat those specific figures as what they are: selected client testimonials, not independently verified averages. The *direction* is entirely plausible — automation obviously speeds sifting — but the precise percentages are marketing artefacts, and the counterfactual (what those firms' time-to-hire would have been otherwise) is never shown. `[UNKNOWN – independent verification of vendor time-to-hire figures]`

The drivers, at a glance

Driver	Whose problem it solves	Evidence status
Volume economics / cost-per-candidate	Employer — unmanageable applicant numbers at near-zero applicant cost	`[INFERRED]` — structural logic clear; exact per-candidate costs `[UNKNOWN]`
Predictive validity vs. the alternatives	Employer — modest but real edge over CV screen and unstructured interview	`[INDEPENDENT]` — GMA ~0.51 (1998) revised to ~0.31 (2022); see Ch. 6.3
Legal defensibility	Employer — Equality Act 2010 exposure on rejections	`[INDEPENDENT]` — see Ch. 6.7
Reducing adverse impact	Employer + candidate — "look past grades/institution"	`[VENDOR]` claims vs. `[INDEPENDENT]` critique (FAccT 2024; Gender Shades/NIST)
Candidate experience / branding	Employer — first-impression marketing	`[VENDOR]` positioning; tension with high-stakes reality
Speed-to-offer / time-to-hire	Employer — competitive timeline	`[VENDOR]` figures, uncorroborated

What this means for you

Strip away the marketing and the OA is this: a cheap, scalable, legally defensible first filter that predicts your future performance modestly better than the alternatives an employer would otherwise use — and no better than that. It exists because volume made it necessary, validity made it justifiable, and law made it prudent; the fairness and experience stories are real drivers too, but the fairness one in particular is far more contested than the sales deck admits.

For you, three practical conclusions follow. First, the OA is a **probabilistic filter with genuine noise in it** — clearing it is necessary but not sufficient, and failing it is one noisy signal rather than a verdict (Chapter 6.3 shows why your score is a range, not a point). Second, because it is a *filter*, your job is not to be perfect but to lift your true performance safely clear of a plausible cut, and then stop worrying about it. Third, and most usefully: the OA is frequently **not the tightest hurdle in UK finance**. The brutal ratios often bite hardest at other stages — the CV/eligibility screen ahead of it, or the assessment centre and final interviews behind it — and Chapter 6.8 maps where the real bottlenecks sit for each type of firm. Give the OA the serious, bounded effort it warrants, then spend the rest of your energy where the differentiation actually happens.

Cross-references: Chapter 6.3 (predictive validity, the 2022 Sackett revision, why your score is a range); Chapter 6.6 (integrity, proctoring and the demographic disparities of proctoring hardware); Chapter 6.7 (Equality Act 2010 and legal defensibility); Chapter 6.8 (where the tightest hurdle actually sits). Sources: Schmidt & Hunter (1998) and Sackett, Zhang, Berry & Lievens (2022) on GMA validity (INDEPENDENT); FAccT 2024 algorithmic-hiring "monocultures" critique of pymetrics (INDEPENDENT); Buolamwini & Gebru "Gender Shades" and NIST

FRVT on computer-vision disparities (INDEPENDENT); pymetrics, Cappfinity and SHL marketing (VENDOR). Full citations in the bibliography.

Chapter 6.2 — The Vendor Landscape and Procurement

When you sit an online assessment for a UK finance role, it feels like you are being judged by the employer. You are, but only at one remove. The instrument doing the judging was built, sold, hosted and often scored by a third-party assessment vendor, and the employer bought it through a procurement process with its own criteria, its own budget and its own politics. Understanding that supply chain is not idle trivia. It explains why the "old" test you practised has a new name this year, why your data may follow you from one employer to the next, why two banks using ostensibly the same provider give you different experiences, and — most importantly — *what the test is actually optimised to do*, because a test optimises for whatever the buyer put in the tender. This chapter maps the vendors, the money behind them, and the buying process, so that the per-provider chapters (§6.3 onward on the psychometrics, and the employer-by-employer mapping in §6.8) sit on solid ground.

The ownership map: who owns whom

The single most useful fact about this market is that **it is not a market of independent test publishers.** It is a handful of platforms, most of them owned by private-equity firms or larger HR-technology groups, that have absorbed the once-independent names you will meet as a candidate. The table below is the consolidation map. Every corporate claim carries the confidence tag from its research file; where the research flagged a fact as needing a primary source or as inferred, that is preserved here rather than laundered into false certainty.

Vendor (candidate-facing name)	Origin	Consolidation history	Current owner / status	Confidence
SHL	Saville & Holdsworth Ltd, UK, founded 1977	Acquired by **CEB (2012)**; CEB acquired by **Gartner (2017)**; SHL divested to **Exponent** (PE) in **2018**	Private-equity owned (Exponent)	`[VENDOR/ INDEPENDENT – corporate history; research flags "verify exact current owner"]`
Aon (cut-e)	cut-e, German assessment firm, founded 2002	**Acquired by Aon in 2017**; rebranded "Aon's Assessment Solutions"; legacy "cut-e" naming persists	Part of Aon plc	`[PREP-VENDOR consistent; corporate fact]`
Arctic Shores	Founded 2014, Manchester, UK	No acquisition found; **£5.75M Series B (Jan 2023)** led by Praetura + Calculus	**Independent, VC-backed**	`[INDEPENDENT]`
pymetrics	Founded 2013, New York (Frida Polli & Julie Yoo)	Outmatch acquired Harver (May 2021), combined co. rebranded **Harver** (late 2021); **Harver acquired pymetrics, completed 11 Aug 2022**	Product line inside **Harver**; deal terms undisclosed	`[INDEPENDENT]`; price `[UNKNOWN]`

Vendor (candidate-facing name)	Origin	Consolidation history	Current owner / status	Confidence
Cappfinity	Founded 2005 as **Capp & Co** (Alex Linley & Nicky Garcea), UK	**Acquired Koru** (Seattle predictive-hiring) completed **20 Dec 2018**; **rebrand Capp → Cappfinity ~2019 (US) / ~2020 (UK)**	Independent (privately held)	Koru `[INDEPENDENT]`; rebrand date `[PREP-VENDOR/INFERRED]`
Amberjack	Founded 2000 as **Gradweb**, UK; rebranded **Amberjack in 2016**	**LDC (Lloyds PE arm) £17.6m MBO April 2019**; acquired Fusion (APAC) June 2023; **acquired by ManpowerGroup May 2024**	**ManpowerGroup Talent Solutions**	LDC/MBO `[INDEPENDENT/VENDOR]`; ManpowerGroup `[INFERRED – needs primary press cite; vendor site not yet updated]`
Plum	Founded 2012 as **Cream.HR** (Caitlin MacGregor), Kitchener-Waterloo, Canada	**Acquired by Phenom (Philadelphia), announced 28 April 2026**	Folding into **Phenom** platform	`[VENDOR/INDEPENDENT]`
HireVue	Founded ~2004, Utah, US	**Acquired MindX** (game-based, London) **~Nov 2018**; **Carlyle Group majority stake announced 3 Sept 2019**	Majority-owned by **The Carlyle Group** (PE)	`[INDEPENDENT/VENDOR]`; founding year `[INFERRED]`
TestGorilla	Founded 2019, Amsterdam (Wouter Durville & Otto Verhage)	**$70M Series A (2022)** led by Atomico, with Balderton & Notion	**Independent, VC-backed**	`[INDEPENDENT]`
Willo	Founded 2018, Glasgow, Scotland; launched Jan 2020	Total investment **>£2.5m** (VC/angel); no acquisition	**Independent, VC/angel-backed**	`[INDEPENDENT]`

Read down the "current owner" column and the shape of the market jumps out. Of ten vendors, six are inside a larger financial or corporate parent: SHL (Exponent), Aon (a FTSE-100 professional-services group), HireVue (Carlyle), pymetrics (Harver), Amberjack (ManpowerGroup) and — as of April 2026 — Plum (Phenom). Only four remain genuinely independent, and of those the two you are least likely to meet at a bulge-bracket bank (TestGorilla and Willo) are the ones still standing alone. The classic psychometric names — SHL and cut-e, the firms whose technical manuals still anchor the whole discipline (see §6.3) — are the *most* consolidated of all.

The consolidation thesis, and why it matters to you

The direction of travel is unambiguous: the field is consolidating into a small number of platform businesses, most of them private-equity or strategic-acquirer backed, that would rather sell you a suite than a single test. Three consequences follow, and each one has a candidate-facing edge.

Products get renamed and retired. When a platform absorbs an assessment, the assessment's roadmap stops being about the assessment and starts being about the platform. cut-e became "Aon's Assessment"; Capp became Cappfinity; pymetrics became "Harver's Soft Skills Platform" internally while keeping the pymetrics name candidate-facing `[INDEPENDENT]`; Plum's product pages already **301-redirect to phenom.com** three months after that deal `[VENDOR/INDEPENDENT]`. The practice materials you bought under the old brand may describe a product that has been re-skinned, re-scored, or quietly withdrawn. This is not a hypothetical: Arctic Shores itself pivoted from its "Skyrise City" game world to a "task-based assessment" after 2023, such that almost all existing candidate testimony describes a product the vendor no longer leads with `[VENDOR]`.

Your data spans a larger platform than the employer you applied to. Consolidation means one assessment engine sits behind many employers. pymetrics is the sharpest example: you play the twelve games **once**, and every pymetrics-using employer within roughly a 330-day window re-scores your *same* trait data against its *own* role model `[PREP-VENDOR, strongly corroborated]`. Plum works the same way by design — one Discovery Survey produces a reusable profile matched to each employer's criteria `[VENDOR]`. So a single sitting can help or haunt you across a whole cohort of firms, and the parent platform, not the individual bank, is the entity holding that record.

"Buy the suite" bundling. A platform's commercial incentive is to sell attraction, applicant tracking, assessment, video interviewing and virtual assessment centres as one contract. Amberjack is the purest case — it is arguably more an outsourced early-careers RPO and ATS business than a test publisher, with assessment as one module inside an end-to-end managed graduate campaign `[VENDOR/INFERRED]`. HireVue bundles async video, game-based assessment, coding tests (CodeVue) and Virtual Job Tryout `[VENDOR]`. Phenom bought Plum as its third assessment acquisition of 2026 explicitly to assemble a "full-spectrum assessment stack" `[INDEPENDENT]`. For you, bundling is why a single application link can chain a psychometric test into a video interview into an SJT without ever leaving one vendor's rails.

How each vendor positions itself

Underneath the ownership churn, the vendors occupy fairly stable *positions* — distinct pitches about what they measure and why an employer should prefer them. Knowing the position tells you what kind of test to expect before you have seen a single question.

- **Classic psychometrics — SHL and Aon (cut-e).** The incumbents. Cognitive-ability tests plus personality questionnaires, grounded in decades of technical manuals, item-response theory and norm groups (see §6.3). SHL's signature is the Verify range plus the OPQ32 personality instrument and the unsupervised-test-plus-verification model `[VENDOR-manual]`. Aon/cut-e's signature is **extreme time pressure by design** — batteries of short, single-construct modules where the time limit, not content difficulty, is the differentiator `[PREP-VENDOR consistent]`. These are the tools a bulge-bracket IB is most likely to deploy.
- **Game-based / behavioural — Arctic Shores, pymetrics, and Aon's smartPredict.** The challenger pitch: measure *behaviour observed*, not self-report, via interactive tasks, and market the result as fake-resistant, mobile-first and lower-adverse-impact. Arctic Shores sells task-based assessment of personality, workplace intelligence and learning agility `[VENDOR]`; pymetrics sells twelve neuroscience-derived games matched to a bespoke role model built from the client's own top performers `[INDEPENDENT]`; Aon bolts smartPredict games (switchChallenge, gridChallenge, digitChallenge, motionChallenge) onto its classic range `[PREP-VENDOR]`.
- **Strengths — Cappfinity.** The strengths-based hiring pitch: measure not just whether you *can* do something but what energises you, via the Situational Strengths Test, aptitude modules and immersive job simulations (Capptivate), heavily bespoke per employer `[VENDOR/PREP-VENDOR]`.
- **Managed early-careers / RPO — Amberjack.** Not a test you buy but a campaign you outsource: blended SJT-plus-cognitive-plus-video sift mapped to a proprietary "Future Skills Model," feeding a virtual assessment centre ("Impact"), all wrapped in an ATS and managed service `[VENDOR]`.

- **Video interviewing — HireVue and Willo.** Structured asynchronous video at scale. HireVue is the enterprise incumbent, now scoring on answer *content* via NLP after discontinuing facial analysis in 2021 `[INDEPENDENT]`, with games and coding bundled in. Willo is the lightweight, human-first, Glasgow-built challenger that explicitly declines automated qualitative scoring `[VENDOR]` — a tool you meet at SMEs, apprenticeships and scale-ups far more than at an IB.
- **Self-serve skills library — TestGorilla.** A subscription platform of 400-plus pick-and-mix skills tests aimed at SME and fintech buyers who cannot afford an enterprise SHL/Aon contract; skills-based-hiring and anti-bias branding are the wedge `[VENDOR/INDEPENDENT]`.
- **Fit-matching — Plum.** Psychometric fit-scoring: one Discovery Survey (Five-Factor personality, cognitive, social intelligence) distilled into "Talents" and turned into a role-specific 0–99 Match Score `[VENDOR]`.

The typical contract shape

Here the research is candid about a wall: **enterprise assessment pricing is almost entirely undisclosed.** The two broad models are per-candidate/per-campaign enterprise licensing (quote-based, negotiated, confidential) and self-serve subscription (published, low-commitment). The split maps neatly onto the incumbent-versus-challenger divide.

- **TestGorilla** publishes its model: a **subscription-plus-credits** structure with a free-forever tier, a Core plan at roughly **$1,700/yr** (~400 credits, two seats), and a custom "Plus" tier; annual commitment only, credits do not roll over `[INDEPENDENT — pricing aggregators, treat figures as estimates]`.
- **Willo** is likewise self-serve and published, priced by hire-volume as monthly SaaS — a free tier (~50 candidates/yr) up through tiers cited around **$249–$399/mo**, though sources conflict and it should be verified live `[VENDOR/INDEPENDENT]`.
- **Amberjack** gives a rare enterprise data point via the UK government's G-Cloud framework, which lists a figure of **£1,258 per licence per year** alongside its ISO 27001 and accessibility commitments `[VENDOR — G-Cloud service definition]`. G-Cloud is worth knowing about: because public-sector buyers must publish, it is one of the few places enterprise assessment pricing and compliance posture surface at all.
- **Everyone else — SHL, Aon, Arctic Shores, pymetrics/Harver, Cappfinity, HireVue, Plum — is `[UNKNOWN]`:** enterprise, quote-based, negotiated per client, with no public per-candidate or seat figure located in the research. Deal values for the pymetrics, Plum and Amberjack acquisitions themselves were also undisclosed `[UNKNOWN]`.

The other feature of the contract is **bundling**, already noted: a single agreement frequently spans assessment plus ATS plus video (Amberjack, HireVue), which is why the buyer's decision is rarely "which test is best" and usually "which platform do we standardise on."

How an employer actually picks one — and what the RFP asks for

An employer choosing an assessment vendor runs a procurement exercise: a request for proposal (RFP) or, in the public sector, a framework buy. The criteria in that document are the lens through which every vendor is compared — and here is the point that unlocks the rest of this book: **the RFP criteria are the product's optimisation targets.** A vendor builds and tunes its instrument to win tenders, so whatever the buyers reward is what the test is engineered to deliver. If you want to know what a test is really *for*, read the buying criteria, not the marketing. The recurring criteria in assessment RFPs are:

- **Validity evidence and adverse-impact posture.** Buyers ask for criterion-validity coefficients and, increasingly, for evidence the tool does not produce disparate impact. This is why vendors invest so heavily in the validity and bias-audit claims dissected in §6.3 and §6.6–6.7 — and why the *absence* of published evidence matters. Several vendors here publish no independent criterion-validity study at all (Arctic Shores, Cappfinity `[UNKNOWN]`), while pymetrics and Plum have commissioned independent disparate-impact audits (Northeastern 2020; BABL AI 2025 for pymetrics/Harver; FairNow Nov 2024 for Plum) precisely because buyers now demand a bias-audit line in the tender `[INDEPENDENT]`. The optimisation target created: a test tuned to pass the four-fifths rule in aggregate, which is not the same as being fair in every role (see §6.7).
- **Legal defensibility.** Risk-averse buyers — banks especially — want a tool they can defend to a regulator or a tribunal. HireVue's entire post-2021 repositioning (drop facial analysis, publish external audits, keep a human in the loop) is an explicitly *defensibility-driven* pitch aimed at exactly these buyers `[VENDOR/INDEPENDENT]`. The optimisation target: NYC Local Law 144, EU AI Act (high-risk, Annex III), and UK/EU GDPR Article 22 compliance become design constraints, which is why so many tools now foreground "human-in-the-loop."
- **ATS / HRIS integration.** The test must plug into the buyer's applicant-tracking and HR systems. Arctic Shores lists Eploy and SmartRecruiters integrations `[VENDOR/partner]`; HireVue markets integration with major ATSs `[VENDOR]`. A tool that does not integrate loses regardless of its psychometrics.
- **Localisation and language.** Multi-country graduate schemes need multi-language delivery; pymetrics is translated into several languages and its non-verbal game format is marketed as minimising language bias `[INDEPENDENT/VENDOR]`.
- **Accessibility / WCAG.** Buyers require accessibility compliance. Amberjack's G-Cloud entry states **WCAG 2.1 AA / EN 301 549** conformance, tested with SortSite and the NVDA screen reader `[VENDOR]`; Willo aligns to WCAG 2.0/2.1 and offers a text-based question option `[VENDOR]`. The optimisation target: this is why extra-time accommodations and alternative formats exist at all — because a tender line demands them (see §6.7).
- **Mobile-first delivery.** Increasingly non-negotiable. Arctic Shores treats mobile delivery as a genuine differentiator versus legacy psychometrics `[PREP-VENDOR]`; pymetrics runs on web, iOS and Android `[INDEPENDENT]`.
- **Candidate experience / employer branding.** Buyers want completion rates and a branded, on-culture journey. Vendors quote enjoyment and completion statistics (Arctic Shores' "85% enjoy / 91% completion"; pymetrics' "98% completion" `[VENDOR]`) and offer bespoke branding — Cappfinity, Amberjack and Arctic Shores all build employer-skinned variants. The optimisation target: the test is tuned to *feel* good and get finished, which is a real design pressure independent of what it measures.
- **Per-candidate cost.** In a high-volume graduate sift, a few pence per candidate multiplied across tens of thousands matters. This is a direct pressure toward short, automated, unsupervised instruments.
- **Sector reference clients.** Buyers want to see peers on the client list — which is exactly why prep-vendor client lists are so unreliable: they are aggregated marketing, rarely dated, and contracts churn (see the volatility flags throughout §6.8).
- **Data security and residency.** ISO 27001 certification, UK-GDPR compliance and UK data residency are now standard tender requirements. Amberjack again gives the concrete example: **ISO/IEC 27001 certified** (British Assessment Bureau, 26 Sept 2022), **data stored and processed in the UK only**, TLS 1.2+ in transit

`[VENDOR – G-Cloud]`. Willo markets ISO 27001 and UKDIATF certification `[VENDOR]`. For a candidate this is reassuring; for the vendor it is a gate you do not pass without the certificate.

Put those criteria together and you can predict the product. A tool built to win UK finance tenders will be short, mobile-first, ATS-integrated, accessibility-compliant, UK-hosted, cheap per head, brandable, and armed with a bias-audit line — because those are the boxes the RFP ticks. That is why the assessments feel the way they do. They are not primarily optimised to measure *you* with maximum accuracy; they are optimised to be *bought*, and measurement accuracy is only one line item among a dozen in the tender.

What this means for you

Two practical takeaways carry into the rest of the guide.

First, **vendor churn means your target firm's provider can change year to year.** Every research file in this project carries the same volatility warning: prep-vendor employer lists are stale, undated marketing aggregations, and contracts rotate between SHL, Aon, Arctic Shores, Cappfinity, pymetrics, HireVue and the rest as cycles turn and platforms consolidate. A firm that used pymetrics in 2021 may use SHL now; a firm on cut-e last year may have moved to a game-based tool. Do not trust any "Firm X uses Provider Y" claim you cannot tie to a *current-cycle* source. Chapter 6.8 maps the employer-by-employer picture, but it maps it with that health warning stapled on.

Second, **a rebrand or acquisition may mean the "old" test you practised is renamed or retired.** cut-e is now "Aon's Assessment"; Capp is Cappfinity; Plum is migrating into Phenom; Arctic Shores has already moved on from the game world most practice guides describe. Before you invest hours in preparation, verify the *current* product name and format against the live application flow, not against a two-year-old prep page. The consolidation that reshapes this market on the buy side quietly reshapes what lands in your inbox on the candidate side — and the candidate who checks what is actually in front of them, rather than what used to be, starts a step ahead.

Sources for this chapter: corporate histories and acquisition records per research files 01–10 (SHL, Aon/cut-e, Arctic Shores, pymetrics, Cappfinity, Amberjack, Plum, HireVue, Willo, TestGorilla), tagged inline. Enterprise pricing is undisclosed for all incumbent vendors; published figures (TestGorilla, Willo, Amberjack G-Cloud) are estimates or single-source and should be verified live. Independent bias audits: Northeastern (2020) and BABL AI (2025) for pymetrics/Harver; FairNow (Nov 2024) for Plum; ORCAA and DCI Consulting for HireVue — detailed in §6.6–6.7.

Chapter 6.3 — The Psychometrics You Need to Understand as a Candidate

You do not need a psychology degree to sit these assessments well, but you do need a working grasp of about ten concepts, because they determine what your score actually means, why two identical performances can produce different outcomes, and why some of the things you fear (a single unlucky question) matter less than you think while others (which norm group you're measured against) matter enormously. This chapter is the plain-English version. Every per-provider chapter refers back to it.

Reliability: why your score is a range, not a point

Reliability is the consistency of a measurement — how much of your score reflects your true ability versus random noise (a lucky guess, a misread question, a lapse of attention). It is expressed as a coefficient between 0 and 1. A reliability of **0.80** means roughly 80% of the variation in scores across candidates reflects real differences in ability and about 20% is noise. `[INDEPENDENT — classical test theory]` For context, SHL's own technical manual reports internal-consistency reliability of **0.77–0.84** for its Verify ability tests — typical of good commercial cognitive tests. `[VENDOR-manual]`

The practical consequence is the single most under-appreciated fact in this whole field: **your score is not a precise point; it is the centre of a range.** That range is quantified by the **standard error of measurement (SEM)**, calculated as SEM = √(1 − reliability) × standard deviation. `[INDEPENDENT/VENDOR-manual]` If you sat the same test again tomorrow (with different items, no learning effect), your score would wobble within roughly one SEM most of the time. So the difference between the 68th and the 74th percentile is very possibly noise, not ability. This is why obsessing over a couple of percentile points is misguided, and why firms that set a hard cut-score at, say, exactly the 80th percentile are — whether they admit it or not — rejecting some candidates whose *true* ability is above the line. You cannot control the noise; you can only push your true score high enough that the range sits comfortably above the likely cut.

Validity: does the test predict anything?

Reliability is necessary but not sufficient — a bathroom scale that consistently reads 5kg heavy is reliable but not valid. **Validity** asks whether the test measures what it claims and predicts what matters.

- **Construct validity**: does a "numerical reasoning" test actually measure numerical reasoning (and not, say, reading speed or test anxiety)?
- **Criterion validity / predictive validity**: does the score predict later job performance? This is the number that justifies the whole enterprise, and it is expressed as a correlation coefficient, **r**.

You will see confident claims that general mental ability predicts job performance at **r ≈ 0.5**. That figure comes from Schmidt and Hunter's influential 1998 meta-analysis. `[INDEPENDENT]` But you should know it has been **revised sharply downward.** A 2022 re-analysis by Sackett, Zhang, Berry and Lievens showed the older meta-analyses had over-corrected for "range restriction," and put the operational validity of cognitive-ability tests closer to **r ≈ 0.31.** `[INDEPENDENT — Sackett et al., 2022, Journal of Applied Psychology]`

What an r of 0.3 actually means for you

This is worth internalising because it reframes how much any single test decides your fate. A correlation of 0.3 means the predictor explains about **9% of the variation** in job performance (you square the correlation to get the proportion of variance explained: $0.3^2 = 0.09$). Even the old, optimistic 0.5 explained only 25%. `[INDEPENDENT]`

In human terms: a high score genuinely shifts the odds you'll perform well — but it is very far from destiny, and a large majority of what makes someone a good analyst is *not* captured by the test. Two implications follow. First, for the **employer**, even a modest correlation is worth having when you're sifting thousands of people, because small edges aggregate across a huge pool — which is why they use these tests despite the modest r. Second, for **you**, a rejection at this stage is not a verdict on your worth or even your ability; it is a probabilistic filter with a lot of noise in it. Clear the bar and move on; don't over-read it.

Norm groups and percentiles: the thing that matters most

Almost every cognitive and many behavioural assessments are **norm-referenced**: your raw performance is converted into a **percentile** by comparing you to a **norm group** (also called a comparison or standardisation group). A percentile is a *rank*: the 70th percentile means you scored higher than 70% of that norm group. It says nothing directly about how many questions you got right. `[VENDOR-manual + INDEPENDENT]`

The norm group is the hidden variable that decides everything, and you rarely get told which one is used. The same raw performance can be:

- the **80th percentile** against a *general population* norm, but
- only the **55th percentile** against a *finance graduates* norm,

because the finance-graduate pool is already selected for numerical strength. `[INFERRED – direct consequence of norm-referencing]` When a guide tells you "investment banks want the 80th percentile," what that really encodes is *a demanding norm group plus a high threshold on top of it*. SHL alone offers around 70 comparison groups. `[VENDOR-manual]` You cannot usually discover which one a firm applied — so for a competitive finance role, assume the tough one and aim to be unambiguously above it.

A note on percentiles as a scale: they are **ordinal** (ranks), not equal-interval, so the gap between the 50th and 55th percentile is a different amount of "ability" than the gap between the 90th and 95th. This is why psychometricians convert to equal-interval **standard scores** for any maths: **T-scores** (mean 50, standard deviation 10) and **stens** (standard-ten: mean 5.5, SD 2, rounded to 1–10) are the two you'll meet. A sten of 8, for instance, sits around the 89th percentile. `[VENDOR-manual]`

IRT and adaptivity: why the questions get harder

Older tests used **classical test theory (CTT)**, where every item counts the same and your score is essentially the number correct. Most modern tests — SHL Verify Interactive, Aon's adaptive modules — use **item response theory (IRT)**, which models each item's difficulty and discrimination and estimates your underlying ability (called **theta, θ**) from *both* how many items you got right and how hard they were. `[VENDOR-manual/INDEPENDENT]`

Adaptive delivery uses IRT live: answer correctly and the next item is harder (and more informative about your true level); answer wrong and it eases. Three things follow for you. (1) **Harder questions are a good sign** — the test is climbing because you're doing well; don't panic. (2) **Raw "number correct" isn't comparable between**

candidates, because two people can answer the same count correct off very different difficulty ladders. (3) **You usually can't go back** — the algorithm has already used your answer to choose the next item. Under IRT, an early careless slip is more costly than a late one, so start carefully.

Because IRT tests draw from a large **item bank** and randomise, no two candidates get an identical test — which is simultaneously an anti-cheating feature (sharing answers is useless) and the reason practising specific "leaked" questions is pointless.

Ipsative vs normative scoring: the personality-test trap

Personality and strengths questionnaires come in two flavours, and the difference dictates how to answer them.

- **Normative** ("Likert") items ask you to rate each statement independently ("I enjoy leading others: strongly agree → strongly disagree"). Your trait scores are compared to a norm group. These are, in principle, fakeable — you can agree with everything flattering.
- **Ipsative** (forced-choice) items make you *choose between* statements ("Which is MOST like you / LEAST like you?"), usually from blocks where all options are roughly equally desirable. This forces trade-offs, so you **cannot inflate every trait at once** — boosting one necessarily suppresses another. `[INDEPENDENT]` SHL's OPQ32i and Aon's ADEPT-15 use forced-choice designs precisely to blunt faking.

The practical upshot, developed in every behavioural section of this guide: on forced-choice instruments, trying to "game" the ideal profile tends to produce an **internally inconsistent** result that consistency and social-desirability checks flag, and that mismatches the (invisible) success model you were aiming at. Authentic, decisive, consistent answering beats strategic answering.

Faking, social desirability and consistency scales

Vendors know candidates try to present their best self, so many questionnaires embed **social-desirability scales** (items that catch implausibly saintly response patterns) and **consistency checks** (near-duplicate items answered differently reveal random or strategic responding). `[VENDOR/INDEPENDENT]` SHL's OPQ32n, for example, includes a social-desirability indicator. A profile that trips these doesn't just look dishonest — it can be discounted entirely. The research consensus is that blatant faking is detectable and often counter-productive; subtle self-presentation (putting your best genuine foot forward) is normal and fine.

Adverse impact and the four-fifths rule

Adverse impact occurs when a selection method passes one demographic group at a substantially lower rate than another, even without intent to discriminate. The US rule of thumb — the **four-fifths (80%) rule** — flags a problem if a protected group's selection rate falls below 80% of the highest group's rate. `[REGULATORY – US EEOC/UGESP]` UK law frames the same concern as **indirect discrimination** under the Equality Act 2010. This is why vendors invest heavily in bias audits and why some employers have moved from classic aptitude tests (which show well-documented group differences) toward game-based and strengths assessments marketed as lower-adverse-impact. Whether those alternatives actually reduce impact is contested — see the provider chapters and §6.6–6.7.

Standard error, banding and the honest takeaway

Put reliability, SEM and adverse-impact awareness together and you arrive at **score banding**: the practice of treating scores within one SEM of each other as effectively equivalent rather than rank-ordering to false precision. Not all employers band — many apply a hard percentile cut — but understanding banding tells you the truth the cut-score hides: **near the threshold, the test cannot really tell you apart from the person just above or below you.** Your job as a candidate is therefore not to chase a perfect score but to lift your true ability far enough that measurement noise can't drop you below a plausible cut — and then to spend the rest of your energy on the stages where the real differentiation happens (Chapter 6.8 shows those are often *not* the online test).

Sources for this chapter: SHL Verify Range Technical Manual (VENDOR-manual, definitions of reliability, SEM, percentiles, T/sten, theta, verification); Schmidt & Hunter (1998) and Sackett, Zhang, Berry & Lievens (2022) on GMA validity (INDEPENDENT); standard classical-test-theory and IRT references (INDEPENDENT); US EEOC Uniform Guidelines / four-fifths rule (REGULATORY). Full citations in the bibliography.

Chapter 6.4 — The Construct-by-Construct Performance Manual

This is the practical heart of the guide. Every provider chapter refers here for technique; this chapter gives you the mental model, the method, the top errors, the pacing rule and the practice approach for each *construct* — the underlying thing being measured — independent of which vendor wraps it. Master the construct and you can walk into an SHL, an Aon, a Cappfinity or a TestGorilla version of it and adapt on sight. Advice is deliberately specific: "practise numerical reasoning" is useless; "at ~40 seconds an item you cannot re-derive a percentage change from scratch — internalise the three extraction patterns" is useful.

A word on what technique can and cannot do. Practice reliably lifts scores on *speeded* tests — numerical, verbal, inductive, checking — by making format-handling automatic so your limited working memory goes to the problem, not the interface. Vendors' own materials and independent studies put typical improvement in the region of **5–15%** of score with focused practice, largest for people unfamiliar with the format and smallest for the already-fluent. `[INDEPENDENT/VENDOR – directional]` On *personality and strengths* instruments, "improvement" is the wrong frame entirely — the goal is authentic, consistent, framework-aware self-presentation, not a higher number (see those sections). Keep the distinction sharp: drill the speeded constructs; understand the behavioural ones.

Numerical reasoning

What it measures. The ability to interpret data (tables, charts, ratios, percentages) and reason to a correct quantity under time pressure. Not arithmetic ability — the calculator does the arithmetic — but *knowing which numbers to combine and how.*

Mental model. Every item is "extract the right two-to-four numbers, apply one operation, avoid the trap." The bottleneck is almost never the calculation; it is locating the correct cells and not being lured by a distractor built from a plausible wrong combination.

Technique. Internalise three recurring patterns until they are reflex: 1. **Percentage change** = (new − old) / old. Kept automatic. Its cousins — percentage *of*, percentage *point* difference, and reverse percentages ("was £120 after a 20% rise, what was it before?" → ÷1.2, not ×0.8) — are where careless candidates lose easy marks. 2. **Two-step table extraction:** the answer is a ratio or difference of two cells you must first *find*, often across different rows/columns or years. Locate before you compute. 3. **Unit and scale traps:** the table is in thousands or millions; a rate is per-annum but the question is per-quarter; currencies differ. Read the axis titles and footnotes first.

Top five errors. (1) Computing the wrong quantity (growth when the question said *share*). (2) Ignoring the units/scale. (3) Re-deriving a formula mid-test instead of having it automatic. (4) Over-precision — rounding late when the options are far apart wastes seconds. (5) Not eliminating: with multiple choice, ruling out two implausible options first halves the risk.

Pacing rule. On a ~24-item / ~35-minute test that is **~60–75 seconds per item**; on Aon-style speeded numerical it can be **~15–20 seconds** and you are *not expected to finish* — accuracy on attempted items is what's scored, so do not panic-rush into errors. Know your test's design (Chapter 2, 6.6) before you choose a pace.

How to practise. Timed sets of data-interpretation questions with a calculator, but *practise the extraction, not the sums*. Keep an error log tagged by cause (misread question / wrong quantity / units / arithmetic slip / timed-out). Review the log weekly; your errors cluster, and the cluster is your syllabus.

Verbal and critical reasoning

What it measures. Whether you can draw exactly the conclusions a passage supports — no more, no less. The classic format gives a passage and statements to judge **True / False / Cannot Say**.

Mental model. You are a strict logician, not a knowledgeable reader. "True" means the passage *entails* the statement; "False" means it *contradicts* it; **"Cannot Say" means the passage neither entails nor contradicts it — even if the statement is probably true in the real world.** The single biggest score-killer is importing outside knowledge.

Technique. Read the *statement* first, then scan the passage for the relevant clause — you rarely need the whole passage. Watch quantifiers and modality: "all/some/most," "always/may/tends to." A passage saying a policy "may reduce" costs does **not** support a statement that it "will reduce" them → Cannot Say. Beware statements that are true but *unstated*: real-world truth is irrelevant.

Top five errors. (1) Using general knowledge. (2) Treating "likely/probably" as "definitely." (3) Over-reading "Cannot Say" as a cop-out and forcing True/False. (4) Missing a quantifier swap (some→all). (5) Fatigue-skimming and missing a negation.

Pacing rule. Typically **~50–60 seconds per statement**; Aon-style verbal runs faster (~14 seconds). Don't re-read the whole passage per statement — locate and decide.

How to practise. Timed T/F/Cannot-Say sets; after each, articulate *why* the key is right in one sentence. If you can't, you're guessing. Watson-Glaser-style critical-reasoning practice (assumptions, inferences, deductions) sharpens the same discipline and is used by some firms directly.

Inductive, diagrammatic and abstract reasoning

What it measures. Fluid intelligence — spotting the rule governing a sequence of shapes/patterns and applying it. Deliberately culture- and language-neutral, which is why vendors favour it for fairness.

Mental model. Check each *dimension* separately rather than hunting a single gestalt: **shape, number, size, colour/shading, position, orientation, and motion/rotation**. Most items combine **two simultaneous rules** (shape rotates *and* count increases) — the trap is spotting one and stopping.

Technique. Run the dimensions as a checklist. For "odd one out," find the rule the *other* items share and pick the breaker (a different mental operation from "continue the sequence"). For matrices, work rows *and* columns. Aon's `ix` (which of nine breaks the rule) and `cls`/`clx` (two groups each follow a rule) reward this decomposition directly.

Top five errors. (1) Latching onto the first rule and missing the second. (2) Overcomplicating — the rule is usually simple. (3) Ignoring position/orientation because shape is more salient. (4) On odd-one-out, finding *a* pattern rather than *the shared* pattern. (5) Spending too long — these are speeded.

Pacing rule. Often **~30–60 seconds per item**; Aon inductive can be **~15–25 seconds**. Guess-and-move if a rule won't yield in your budget.

How to practise. Abstract/inductive sets daily in short bursts; explicitly name the rule(s) aloud each time to force decomposition rather than pattern-osmosis.

Deductive and logical reasoning

What it measures. Drawing valid conclusions from given rules/premises — syllogisms, seating/order puzzles, conditional logic, and grid-completion (Aon's `lst`).

Mental model. Only what follows *necessarily* is true. Distinguish a conditional ("if A then B") from its converse ("if B then A" — not implied) and contrapositive ("if not B then not A" — implied). Sketch the logic; don't hold it in your head.

Technique. Externalise: draw the grid, the order line, the if-then arrows. Test candidate answers against every constraint. For conditionals, apply the contrapositive deliberately — it's the most commonly missed valid inference.

Top five errors. (1) Affirming the consequent (B is true, so A must be — invalid). (2) Not writing it down. (3) Assuming unstated constraints. (4) Confusing "some" with "all." (5) Time lost re-reading instead of diagramming once.

Pacing rule. Varies widely; grid/order puzzles reward a slower, careful setup that then makes the questions fast. Budget setup time deliberately.

How to practise. Logic-puzzle and syllogism sets; drill the four conditional forms until the contrapositive is automatic.

Checking, error-detection and concentration (speed tests)

What it measures. Sustained attention and processing speed — comparing strings/records for discrepancies against the clock (Aon's `e3+`, many "checking" tests). Common in operations and some finance back-office streams.

Mental model. Pure speed-accuracy trade-off. The score rewards *throughput at low error rate*; the design assumes you can't finish.

Technique. Chunk comparisons (compare two or three characters at a time, not one), fix a left-to-right scan rhythm, and don't backtrack. Accept that you'll leave items unattempted.

Top five errors. (1) Perfectionism — rechecking correct items. (2) Losing rhythm. (3) Fatigue drift late in the section. (4) Backtracking. (5) Over-caution that tanks throughput.

Pacing rule. Seconds per item. Set a metronome-like rhythm in practice.

How to practise. Short, frequent timed checking drills; track both speed and error rate — pushing speed until errors creep, then backing off, finds your optimum.

Working-memory and attention tasks (game-based)

What it measures. Digit-span, spatial memory and attention/inhibition, usually inside game-based tools (Aon's gridChallenge; pymetrics digit-span, Flanker/arrows, Go/No-Go; Arctic Shores tasks). Often there is **no "score"** in the intuitive sense — the raw *telemetry* (accuracy, reaction time, error recovery) feeds a trait model.

Mental model. Do your genuine best; these calibrate a profile, not a pass mark. Consistency matters more than a single peak.

Technique. Learn the instructions cold (many have unlimited-attempt practice); on inhibition tasks (Go/No-Go, Flanker) prioritise **not responding to the wrong cue** over raw speed — false alarms are informative. On memory tasks, use light rehearsal/chunking but don't freeze.

Top five errors. (1) Panicking when it gets harder (adaptive tasks *should* get harder). (2) Sacrificing accuracy for speed on inhibition tasks. (3) Skipping the practice/tutorial. (4) Trying to "beat" a game that has no win state. (5) Erratic effort that reads as noise.

Pacing rule. Task-controlled; respond promptly but deliberately.

How to practise. You can rehearse *format familiarity* (so nerves don't distort your telemetry) but you largely cannot and should not try to "game" these — see the gamified-behavioural section and Chapters 3 and 4.

Situational judgement tests (SJTs)

What it measures. Judgement about workplace scenarios — usually "rank" or "rate most/least effective" responses. Keys are built by **subject-matter-expert (SME) panels** at the firm, so the "right" answer encodes the firm's competencies/values. Independent evidence: SJTs add only **small incremental validity ($\Delta R \approx 0.03$–0.08)** over ability + personality, and are **transparent and coachable** — which is *good news for the prepared candidate.* `[INDEPENDENT]`

Mental model. Answer as the firm's ideal professional, calibrated to its stated values — not as your unfiltered self and not as a cynical guess. Because keys come from SME consensus, the "best" answer is usually the one showing **ownership, constructive communication, and appropriate escalation** — neither passivity nor reflexive escalation.

Technique. Read the firm's published competencies/values *before* you sit (Cappfinity, Amberjack and bank SJTs are keyed to them). For most/least formats, answer *both* poles. For ranking, respect forced-distinct constraints. Prefer responses that address the problem directly and involve others appropriately.

Top five errors. (1) Ignoring the firm's framework. (2) Reading only one pole of a most/least item. (3) Choosing the "nice" answer over the *effective* one. (4) Reflexive escalation to a manager as a first move. (5) Inconsistency across similar items (SJT/strengths tools run consistency checks).

Pacing rule. Usually generous, but **time-per-item may be scored** (Cappfinity) — be decisive.

How to practise. SJT sets plus close study of two or three target firms' competency frameworks; after each item, map the keyed answer back to a competency.

Strengths-based assessment

What it measures. What energises you and where you naturally perform (Cappfinity, some Amberjack). Often blends a keyed effectiveness dimension with an authenticity/enjoyment dimension.

Mental model. Authenticity, decisively expressed, calibrated by knowing which genuine strengths the role rewards. Not fakeable into a fabricated profile you can't sustain at interview — and consistency checks punish trying.

Technique. Research the firm's strength language, then surface your *real* relevant strengths confidently. Avoid mid-point clustering; answer promptly (speed is often scored). When asked to rate both effectiveness and enjoyment, do both.

Top five errors. (1) Fabricating strengths you don't have. (2) Dithering/mid-pointing. (3) Missing the enjoyment dimension. (4) Inconsistency. (5) Over-thinking transparent items.

How to practise. Reflect in advance on genuine strengths and matching examples; read the firm's framework. Don't "drill" — prepare authentically.

Personality inventories

What it measures. Stable traits (usually Big Five / Five-Factor, sometimes 32-facet as in SHL's OPQ) predicting fit and behaviour. Often **forced-choice/ipsative** (choose most/least like you) specifically to blunt faking, frequently with **social-desirability and consistency scales**.

Mental model. Do not fake — and understand mechanically why. In a forced-choice block of equally-desirable statements, boosting one trait necessarily suppresses another, so you cannot inflate everything; strategic answering tends to produce an **inconsistent profile** that the checks flag and that mismatches the invisible success model you were aiming at. The winning move is authentic, decisive, framework-aware answering.

Technique. Read the role's competencies, decide in advance which *genuine* facets of yourself are relevant, then answer quickly and consistently. Don't over-analyse transparent items; don't cluster at the mid-point on Likert versions.

Top five errors. (1) Faking "ideal" answers → inconsistency flags. (2) Mid-point clustering (evasive, low-information). (3) Over-thinking. (4) Inconsistent answers to near-duplicate items. (5) Trying to be all things (decisive *and* highly cautious *and* highly spontaneous).

How to practise. You don't drill it — you prepare by knowing the competency framework and your authentic mapping to it (Chapter 6.3 on ipsative vs normative; provider chapters 1, 2, 7).

Gamified behavioural tasks

What it measures. Cognitive and social-emotional traits inferred from *how you play* (pymetrics' 12 games, Arctic Shores tasks, Aon smartPredict). Typically **no pass/fail** — telemetry feeds a fit-model, and (pymetrics) you are matched to a role model built from the firm's own high performers.

Mental model. Be authentically, consistently yourself; you largely **cannot study for these**, and faking is both hard and counter-productive (a faked profile mismatches the model). The same behaviour can "fit" one firm and not another — that's the model, not you failing.

Technique. Learn each game's rules via the practice round; on risk/uncertainty games (balloon-pump, card decks) play with **steady, coherent risk-taking** rather than erratic swings; on effort/allocation games, engage genuinely. Don't try to reverse-engineer a target trait — you'll likely guess wrong and just add noise.

Top five errors. (1) Trying to game an unfakeable instrument. (2) Erratic behaviour that reads as noise. (3) Panicking at difficulty ramps. (4) Skipping tutorials. (5) Reading a rejection as a verdict on your worth (it's a fit mismatch).

How to practise. Familiarise with formats so nerves don't distort your telemetry; otherwise, arrive rested and be consistent. See Chapters 3 and 4.

Coding assessments

What it measures. Programming problem-solving and language fluency (HireVue CodeVue, HackerRank for quant/tech streams) — auto-scored on correctness and often efficiency, with anti-cheat.

Mental model. Correctness first, then edge cases, then efficiency (time/space complexity). Auto-graders reward passing hidden test cases.

Technique. Read all constraints; write the straightforward correct solution before optimising; test boundary cases (empty, max, negative, duplicates); manage the clock across questions rather than perfecting one. Don't paste from external sources — plagiarism/similarity detection is standard.

Top five errors. (1) Optimising before it works. (2) Ignoring edge cases the hidden tests target. (3) One-question tunnel vision. (4) Off-by-one and type errors under time pressure. (5) External copy-paste that trips anti-cheat.

Pacing rule. Allocate by marks; leave time to test.

How to practise. Timed problem sets on a platform matching the format; drill patterns (arrays/strings/hash-maps/two-pointers) and complexity analysis.

Asynchronous video interviews

What it measures. Structured competency evidence delivered to camera (HireVue, Willo). Scored on **content** (transcript/NLP and/or human review) against IO-psych competencies — *not* your face (Chapter 8).

Mental model. Substance under time pressure. With ~30 seconds to think and ~60–120 to answer, structure is everything; the first sentence should answer the question.

Technique. STAR (Situation-Task-Action-Result) or CARL (Context-Action-Result-Learning). Prepare 6–8 competency stories (teamwork, leadership, resilience, failure/learning, commercial awareness, "why this firm"). Lead with a headline; pace ~100–125 words/min for clean transcription; look into the lens; front-light; if you fumble and can't re-record, reset in a phrase and continue.

Top five errors. (1) No structure/rambling. (2) Burying the point. (3) Under-length answers (too little content to score, and a documented bias risk for brief answers). (4) Reading a script (flat, eyes tracking text). (5) Poor lighting/eye-line for the human reviewer.

Pacing rule. Fill most of the answer window with substance; don't stop at 20 seconds of a 120-second allowance.

How to practise. Record yourself answering common questions at real timings; review for headline-first, a clear result, and staying in time. See Chapter 8.

Written and case exercises

What it measures. Analysis, prioritisation and written communication — e-tray/inbox exercises, short case write-ups, "email the client" tasks (Aon chatAssess, assessment-centre stages).

Mental model. Triage under time pressure: identify the priority issue, structure a clear recommendation, communicate concisely to the stated audience.

Technique. Skim everything first, rank by urgency/importance, then write. Lead with the recommendation, support with two or three reasons, note risks/next steps. Match register to audience (client vs manager). Watch for planted conflicting information and a hidden priority item.

Top five errors. (1) Diving in before triaging. (2) No clear recommendation. (3) Ignoring the audience. (4) Missing a planted high-priority item. (5) Running out of time on presentation.

Pacing rule. Reserve the last fifth for structure and a crisp close.

How to practise. Timed inbox/case exercises; draft a one-line recommendation before writing the body every time.

Cross-references: Chapter 6.3 (why your score is a range; ipsative vs normative); Chapter 6.5 (the six-week programme that operationalises this manual); Chapter 6.6 (integrity while you perform); and the provider chapters for vendor-specific quirks. Sources: SJT and validity figures from the independent literature cited in Chapters 5–6.3; format detail corroborated across the provider chapters.

Chapter 6.5 — A Six-Week Preparation Programme

Chapter 6.4 gave you the technique for each construct; this chapter turns that manual into a calendar. The premise is simple: preparation that works is *distributed, diagnostic and condition-realistic*, not a frantic weekend of a hundred random questions the night before your deadline. Six weeks is the sweet spot for someone who is also studying or working — long enough to build genuine format-fluency and fix your recurring errors, short enough to stay motivated and not drift into stale over-practice. If you have less time, compress the middle; if you have more, don't inflate the hours, extend the taper. The whole programme assumes **~4–6 hours a week** — roughly 45–60 minutes on five days, or three ninety-minute blocks — which is realistic alongside a degree or a job and, done consistently, is more than enough. More than about 8 hours a week and you are usually buying diminishing returns and rising staleness, not score. `[INFERRED – from the distributed-practice literature]`

One honest caveat before the schedule, because it governs everything: **practice reliably lifts *speeded* cognitive scores — numerical, verbal, inductive, checking — by making format-handling automatic, but the effect is bounded.** Vendor materials and independent studies put typical improvement around **5–15%** of score, largest for those new to the format and smallest for the already-fluent. `[INDEPENDENT/VENDOR – directional]` It does *not* lift personality, strengths or game-based instruments the same way — those are understood and authentically prepared for, not "practised" (Chapters 6.3, 6.4). The drilling weeks below are for the speeded constructs; the behavioural work is a different kind of preparation running quietly alongside.

The shape of the six weeks

The programme has a deliberate arc:

- **Week 1 — Diagnose.** Find your baseline and your weak constructs before you spend a single hour drilling. You cannot fix errors you haven't measured.
- **Weeks 2–3 — Construct drilling.** The heavy-lifting phase. Weighted toward numerical, verbal and inductive because those are the constructs where practice moves the needle most and where most finance sifts live (Chapters 1, 2). Your error log is the spine of this phase.
- **Week 4 — Behavioural and format breadth.** Add SJT, strengths and personality *authenticity* work, and start async-video rehearsal. This is understanding-and-reflection work, not drilling.
- **Week 5 — Full-condition simulation.** Whole tests, timed, one sitting, real environment. You are now practising *performance*, not just technique.
- **Week 6 — Taper and go.** Light maintenance, targeted review of your error clusters, and application. You do not cram in week six; you arrive sharp and rested.

That arc is the same logic any coach uses to peak an athlete: raw capability and the ability to *express* it under pressure are different skills, and both need building.

Week 1 — Diagnosis (~4–5 hours)

The goal is a map, not a score. Resist the urge to start grinding questions immediately. Spend week one finding out, precisely, where you leak marks.

Do this:

1. **Sit one timed, full-length practice test in each core construct you expect to face** — numerical, verbal, and inductive/diagrammatic at minimum; add deductive, checking or coding if your target roles use them (check the provider chapters). Use free vendor practice for this (see the resources section) so the format matches reality. Do them under rough time pressure but treat them as measurement, not competition.
2. **Start your error log immediately** (the full method is below). Every single question you got wrong or guessed goes in, tagged by *cause*, from the very first test. Week one's errors are your most valuable data because they're untainted by practice.
3. **Read the psychometrics you need** — Chapter 6.3 — so you understand what your baseline percentile does and doesn't mean, and why obsessing over a couple of points is misguided.
4. **Identify your two or three weakest constructs and your dominant error tags.** By the end of the week you should be able to say something like: "Numerical is fine on accuracy but I time out on the last third; verbal I keep forcing True/False when the answer is Cannot Say; inductive I latch onto one rule and miss the second." That sentence is your syllabus for weeks two and three.

Time targets: ~3 hours of testing across the week (one test every couple of days, not all in one night — you want clean, rested baselines), plus ~1–2 hours reading Chapter 6.3 and setting up the log. Roughly **4–5 hours**.

What you are explicitly *not* doing yet: touching personality or strengths tools, buying anything, or drilling in bulk. Diagnosis first. Buying a paid pack in week one, before you know whether you even need volume, is the most common wasted spend.

Weeks 2–3 — Construct drilling (~5–6 hours/week)

This is the core, and it is weighted. **Give roughly 60–70% of your time to your weak constructs and to the numerical/verbal/inductive trio**, because those are where practice moves scores most and where the highest-volume finance sifts sit. Do not spend equal time on everything — spend it where your error log points.

Structure each session as a loop, not a grind:

1. **Warm up (5 min)** on a construct you're comfortable with — gets the format-handling automatic.
2. **Drill your weak construct (25–35 min)** in timed sets of 8–15 items. Timed, always — untimed practice trains the wrong muscle for a speeded test.
3. **Review every miss and log it (10–15 min).** This is the part people skip and it is the part that works. For each error, don't just read the explanation — **articulate in one sentence why the correct key is right.** If you can't, you didn't understand it, you pattern-matched it (more on that trap below).

Volume targets, directional: across weeks two and three, aim for roughly **40–60 quality items per weak construct per week** — not five hundred. Quality means *reviewed and logged*, not merely attempted. A hundred un-reviewed questions teach you almost nothing; forty reviewed ones rebuild your weak spots. Rotate item sources (AssessmentDay one day, GraduatesFirst the next, a vendor practice set the third) so you're learning the construct, not memorising one publisher's quirks.

Weekly review ritual (~30 min, end of each week). Open your error log and read it as a whole. **Your errors cluster** — that is the single most useful fact in this chapter. Maybe 60% of your numerical misses are "units/scale" and "wrong quantity"; maybe your verbal misses are almost all "forced True/False when it was Cannot Say." *The* *cluster is your syllabus for the coming week.* Re-read the relevant part of Chapter 6.4 for that construct, and bias next week's drilling toward the cluster. This weekly loop — drill, log, cluster, target — is what turns practice from activity into improvement.

Pacing work belongs here too. If your log shows "timed-out" as a top tag, the fix isn't more knowledge, it's a pacing rule: internalise the per-item budget for your test type from Chapter 6.4 (~60–75 seconds on a standard 24-item numerical; ~15–20 seconds on Aon-style speeded, where you are *not* expected to finish), and practise a decisive guess-and-move when an item won't yield. Drill the skill of leaving a question. It feels wrong and it raises scores.

Time targets: four to five sessions a week of ~45–60 minutes, plus the weekly review. Roughly **5–6 hours/week** — the peak of the programme.

Week 4 — Behavioural breadth and async-video (~4–5 hours)

Now broaden. The cognitive drilling continues at a reduced maintenance dose (two or three short sessions to hold your gains), and you add the behavioural constructs — but note the shift in *kind* of preparation. **Personality, strengths and gamified assessments are not "practised" the drilling way at all** (Chapter 6.4 is explicit on this). There are no questions to grind. The preparation is: understand the target competency/values framework, and reflect authentically on your genuine mapping to it.

Do this in week four:

1. **SJT preparation.** Work a set or two of situational-judgement items to learn the format, but the real work is *reading two or three target firms' published competencies and values* (Chapters 5, 6.4). After each SJT item, map the keyed answer back to a competency — "this rewards ownership and appropriate escalation, not passivity and not reflexive escalation." SJTs are transparent and coachable, which is good news for the prepared; the preparation is framework-literacy, not memorised answers.
2. **Strengths and personality — reflection, not drilling.** Read the firm's strength language and decide, in advance, which *genuine* relevant strengths and examples you'll surface confidently. Understand ipsative vs normative scoring (Chapter 6.3) so you know *why* faking backfires on forced-choice instruments. Do not "practise" these into a fabricated profile — consistency and social-desirability checks punish exactly that (Chapters 6.3, 6.4). The prep is authentic self-knowledge, framework-aware. Chapters 3, 4 and 5 cover the strengths-and-behaviour providers in depth.
3. **Async-video rehearsal begins.** Prepare 6–8 competency stories (teamwork, leadership, resilience, a failure and what you learned, commercial awareness, "why this firm") in STAR or CARL form (Chapter 6.4, and Chapter 8 in full). Then *record yourself* answering common questions at real timings — ~30 seconds to think, ~60–120 to answer. Review for headline-first structure, a clear result, and staying in time. The camera is unforgiving of rambling; two or three recorded run-throughs this week save you on the day.
4. **Gamified familiarisation.** If your targets use pymetrics, Arctic Shores or Aon's game-based tools (Chapters 2, 3, 4), do the practice rounds purely to learn the rules cold, so nerves don't distort your telemetry. You cannot and should not try to "game" these; the goal is calm familiarity, then authentic, consistent play.

Time targets: ~2 hours holding cognitive gains, ~2–3 hours on framework reading, reflection and video rehearsal. Roughly **4–5 hours**.

Week 5 — Full-condition simulation (~5–6 hours)

Technique is built; now you rehearse *performance*. Everything so far has been drills and reflection. This week you sit **whole tests, end to end, under conditions as close to the real thing as you can manufacture** — because the gap between "I can do these questions" and "I can do these questions cold, timed, on my laptop, at 9am, in one sitting, with the clock visible and nerves live" is real, and week five is where you close it while it's still fixable.

How to simulate full conditions — and why each detail matters:

- **Same laptop and browser you'll use for the real test.** Surfaces webcam-permission, browser-compatibility and lockdown-app problems *now*, while there's time to fix them, not two minutes before a deadline. This is the same clean-environment discipline Chapter 6.6 details for the real sitting — rehearse it, don't improvise it.
- **Same time of day** as your likely real sitting. If you're sharp at 10am and foggy at 8pm, know it, and either schedule the real test into your sharp window or train the foggy one.
- **Fully timed, one sitting, no interruptions.** Phone off and in another room. Door shut, housemates warned, notifications killed. The point of a simulation is the *unbroken* condition — a test you pause halfway isn't a simulation, it's just more practice.
- **Real chair, real desk, real screen, calculator and scratch paper to hand** exactly as they'll be on the day. Physical set-up affects speed on data-interpretation items more than people expect.

Do this: two or three full simulations across the week, each followed by a proper error-log review. By now your log should be thin and clustered — you're confirming your fixes held under pressure and catching any remaining leak. If a cluster reappears under full-condition stress that had disappeared in isolated drilling, that's a *nerves-and-pacing* problem, not a knowledge problem, and the fix is more simulation, not more theory.

Also this week: a final async-video run-through under real recording conditions, and a last read of your two or three target firms' competency frameworks so the behavioural material is fresh.

Time targets: two to three simulations of ~45–60 minutes plus review, roughly **5–6 hours**.

Week 6 — Taper and apply (~3–4 hours)

You do not cram in week six. The instinct to grind hard right before a deadline is exactly wrong — it raises fatigue and anxiety and lowers nothing that matters. Athletes taper before competition for a reason, and so should you.

Do this:

1. **Light maintenance only** — a couple of short, comfortable drilling sessions to keep the format-handling warm, plus a final read-through of your error log's top clusters and the matching Chapter 6.4 sections. You're refreshing, not rebuilding.
2. **Logistics and environment check** — confirm the clean-environment set-up from Chapter 6.6, test your kit one last time, and know your deadlines.
3. **Apply.** This is the point of the whole programme, and it comes with the most important caveat in the chapter.

The rolling-deadline caveat — do not over-prepare into a shrinking pool. Most UK finance firms recruit on a **rolling basis**: applications are assessed as they arrive and slots fill through the cycle, so the applicant pool you're competing against grows and the available places shrink as the weeks pass (Chapters 5.6, 6.8). The blunt consequence: **applying early usually beats a marginally higher score later.** A test is a modest, noisy predictor — recall from Chapter 6.3 that even a good cognitive test correlates with job performance only around r ≈ 0.31, explaining under 10% of the variance, and that near any cut-score the test genuinely cannot tell you apart from the person just above or below. Trading two weeks of your application window for a possible couple of percentile points — points that may well be measurement noise — is a bad trade against a shrinking pool.

So: **if you're ready in week three, apply in week three.** The six-week structure is a maximum and a scaffold, not a mandatory sentence you must serve before you're allowed to submit. Balance readiness against timing honestly. The candidate who applies in October at 75% preparedness usually beats the one who applies in December at 82%, because by December the assessment centre slots are filling and the bar the firm applies has quietly risen. Prepare enough to clear the cut comfortably, then go.

Time targets: roughly **3–4 hours**, most of it logistics and application, little of it drilling.

Free vs paid resources — named, and compared honestly

Here is the money question, answered without the sales gloss that surrounds it. First, the honest headline that reframes all the paid options: **paid practice packs overwhelmingly buy you *volume* and *format familiarity* — more questions, laid out like the real ones — not secret or leaked questions.** No legitimate vendor has the live item bank; modern tests randomise from large banks precisely so that memorising specific items is useless (Chapter 6.3). Anyone selling "the actual questions" is selling either a lie or a genuinely leaked item — and buying leaked or live items is a serious integrity breach that can get your application voided and is squarely against this guide's ethics (Chapter 6.6). Do not do it, and do not trust a vendor that implies it.

Second, the check-here-first point: **your university careers service very often provides free access to exactly the paid-feeling resources you were about to pay for** — most commonly GraduatesFirst, and sometimes JobTestPrep or similar — bundled into your student support. `[PREP-VENDOR — commercial arrangements vary by institution]` Before you spend a penny, check your careers service. Many students pay for what they already had for free.

Free resources (start here):

- **Official vendor practice.** SHL's candidate practice at shldirect.com, Aon/cut-e's practice tests, and the practice links employers themselves send with an invitation. `[PREP-VENDOR — vendor-supplied; the closest thing to the real format, and free]` These are the single best free resource for format-fidelity because they *are* the format. Bias to note: vendors provide just enough to familiarise, not a full training course.
- **AssessmentDay free samples.** A widely used bank of free numerical/verbal/inductive samples with worked answers; a paid tier exists but the free samples are substantial. `[PREP-VENDOR — freemium; free tier genuinely useful]`
- **GraduatesFirst.** Realistic practice across constructs, SJTs and video, **frequently free through university careers services**. `[PREP-VENDOR — often institutionally funded; check your careers service first]`
- **University careers services.** Free practice-test access, CV/application review, sometimes mock assessment centres. Underused and high-value.

- **Khan Academy** for numerical *fundamentals* — percentages, ratios, fractions — if your diagnosis showed the gap is underlying maths rather than data-interpretation technique. `[Free; not aptitude-test-specific, but fixes the foundation cheaply]`

Paid resources (buy only against a diagnosed need for volume):

- **JobTestPrep.** Large, well-organised packs, often provider-specific bundles. `[PREP-VENDOR — commercial; sells volume + format familiarity, not secret questions]`
- **Practice Aptitude Tests.** Big free tier plus paid membership for more volume and solutions. `[PREP-VENDOR — freemium]`
- **PrepTerminal, CareerTestPrep.** Course-plus-practice models. `[PREP-VENDOR — commercial]`
- **Green Turn.** Higher-priced coaching-and-materials aimed at competitive finance/consulting. `[PREP-VENDOR — commercial; premium pricing — scrutinise what you're actually getting over the free options]`

When is paid worth it? Narrowly: if your diagnosis showed you genuinely need *more volume than the free sources supply* in a specific weak construct, or you want provider-matched packs for a specific test you'll face repeatedly, a single targeted pack can be worth it. It is *not* worth it as a reflex, not worth it before you've diagnosed, and not worth it if your careers service already gives you the equivalent free. The order of operations is: free vendor practice → careers-service access → free sample banks → *then*, if a real volume gap remains, one targeted paid pack. `[Judgement, from the resource comparison above]`

The error log — the highest-leverage habit in this chapter

If you do one thing from this chapter, do this. **An error log is a running record of every question you get wrong or guess, tagged by the *cause* of the error.** It is more valuable than any pack you can buy, because it converts scattered practice into a targeted syllabus built from your own specific weaknesses.

How to build it. A spreadsheet or a notebook — the tool doesn't matter. For every miss, record four things: the **construct** (numerical / verbal / inductive / …), a one-line **note** on the item, the **cause-tag**, and, crucially, **a one-sentence statement of why the correct answer is right.** The cause-tags are the engine. Use a small, fixed set so they cluster cleanly:

- **misread** — you misread the question or a chart label
- **wrong quantity** — you computed the wrong thing (growth when it wanted share)
- **units** — you ignored scale/units (thousands, per-quarter, currency)
- **arithmetic** — a genuine calculation slip
- **timed-out** — you ran out of time, or guessed to keep pace
- **logic slip** — an invalid inference (affirming the consequent; some → all; forcing True/False over Cannot Say)

How to use it. Review it **weekly**, reading the tags as a set. **Your errors cluster** — this is the point, stated a third time because it's the whole method. Almost nobody makes evenly-distributed errors; you have two or three characteristic failure modes, and they account for most of your lost marks. Once you *see* the cluster — "70% of my misses are units and timed-out" — your next week writes itself: drill the cluster, re-read the relevant Chapter 6.4 technique, and the tag frequency should fall. The log is both your diagnosis and your progress meter. When a tag stops appearing, you've fixed something real. When one persists, it's telling you exactly where to keep working.

The one-sentence "why the key is right" column is not optional padding — it's what stops the log from becoming a list you never learn from, and it's your defence against the pattern-matching trap below.

Avoiding the pattern-matching trap

There is a failure mode that *feels* like progress and isn't: **over-practising into pattern-matching without comprehension.** You do so many questions from one source that you start recognising question *types* and reaching for the remembered answer-shape rather than reasoning the item out. Your practice scores rise; your real-test scores don't, because the real test uses a different item bank and your memorised shapes don't transfer. You've trained recognition, not the underlying construct.

Three defences, built into the programme above:

1. **Rotate item sources.** Don't do four hundred AssessmentDay questions; do a mix — vendor practice, AssessmentDay, GraduatesFirst, a paid pack if you have one. Different publishers phrase and disguise the same construct differently, which forces you to learn the *construct* rather than one house style.
2. **Force yourself to articulate WHY each key is right** — the one-sentence rule from the error log, applied to correct answers too, not just misses. If you can state the reason, you understood it. If you only "recognised" it, you'll fumble the same logic dressed differently. This single habit is the strongest guard against hollow pattern-matching.
3. **Take breaks; respect staleness.** Distributed practice beats massed practice, and burnout produces exactly the mindless, low-comprehension repetition that trains recognition over understanding. The programme's ~4–6 hours a week, spread across days with a real taper in week six, is deliberately paced to keep you fresh. If you notice you're clicking through questions on autopilot, stop — you've crossed from learning into grinding, and grinding is where pattern-matching lives.

A note on the behavioural instruments — again, because it matters

It bears repeating in a chapter about *practising*, because the whole framing can mislead you here: **personality inventories, strengths assessments and gamified behavioural tasks are not prepared for by drilling, and trying to drill them is worse than useless.** There is no question bank to grind and no "right answer" to memorise; these instruments measure stable traits and authentic responses, and many run consistency and social-desirability checks that actively penalise strategic answering (Chapters 6.3, 6.4).

The preparation for these is a *different activity* entirely, and it lives in week four of this programme and in the provider chapters: **understand the target competency and values framework, reflect honestly on your genuine mapping to it, and learn each format cold so nerves don't distort your responses.** For strengths, surface your real relevant strengths decisively (Chapter 6.4; Chapter 5 on Cappfinity). For personality, understand ipsative vs normative scoring and why authentic, consistent answering wins (Chapter 6.3). For game-based tools, do the practice rounds for familiarity and then play as yourself, consistently (Chapters 3, 4). None of that is "practice" in the drilling sense — and if you find yourself trying to reverse-engineer a target profile, stop: you'll likely guess the model wrong and just add noise that a consistency check reads as incoherence.

The printable weekly plan

A compact version to pin above your desk. Hours assume you're also studying or working; scale them if your situation differs.

Week	Focus	Cognitive drilling	Behavioural / video	Simulation	Hours	Key output
1	**Diagnose**	1 timed full test per core construct — *as measurement, not competition*	—	—	~4–5	Baseline map + error log started; weak constructs named
2	**Drill (weak first)**	4–5 timed sets/wk, 40–60 items per weak construct; log every miss	—	—	~5–6	Error clusters emerging; pacing rule internalised
3	**Drill (target clusters)**	Same, biased hard toward your top error tags; rotate sources	—	—	~5–6	Top clusters shrinking; "why key is right" reflex built
4	**Broaden**	2–3 maintenance sets to hold gains	SJT + framework reading; strengths/ personality reflection; **6–8 STAR stories, first video recordings**; game familiarisation	—	~4–5	Framework-literate; video structure rehearsed
5	**Simulate**	Inside full sims	Final video run; re-read target frameworks	**2–3 full tests, real conditions, one sitting each**	~5–6	Performance rehearsed; set-up problems fixed while fixable
6	**Taper & apply**	Light maintenance only; review log clusters	Logistics + environment check (Ch. 6.6)	—	~3–4	**Applications submitted**

Non-negotiables in every week: timed practice (never untimed); every miss logged with a cause-tag; one sentence on why the key is right. **The override on the whole table:** if you're ready before week six, *apply* — early beats marginally-higher-later at most UK finance firms (Chapters 5.6, 6.8).

Cross-references: Chapter 6.3 (what your score means; ipsative vs normative; why chasing points near a cut is misguided); Chapter 6.4 (the construct-by-construct technique this programme operationalises); Chapter 6.6 (clean-environment set-up and integrity — never buy leaked or live items); Chapter 6.8 and 5.6 (rolling deadlines and why timing beats marginal score); Chapters 3, 4, 5 (the strengths, personality and game-based providers you prepare for by reflection, not drilling); Chapter 8 (asynchronous video in full). Efficacy figures are directional and *drawn from the vendor and independent sources cited in Chapters 6.3–6.4; named prep vendors are tagged [PREP-VENDOR] and carry commercial bias — verify current offerings and check your university careers service before paying.*

Chapter 6.6 — Integrity Monitoring: The Cross-Provider Taxonomy

This chapter is the one to read if you have been screened out on integrity or proctoring grounds, or fear you might be. It consolidates the per-provider integrity sections (§x.8–x.10) into a single reference: a matrix of **what is monitored, by whom, and with what consequence**; the evidence on **false positives and demographic disparities**; and a **universal pre-flight checklist** that removes every avoidable ambiguity before you start. The governing principle throughout: the systems in UK finance early-careers assessment are **far less surveillant, and far less trigger-happy, than their reputation** — most flags are reviewed by a human, and the loudest online horror stories describe either high-stakes remote *exam* proctoring (a different, heavier product) or the legacy facial-analysis era that the main video vendor abandoned in 2021.

The first thing to understand: most of these tests barely watch you

A recurring myth is that every online assessment films you through a locked-down browser and auto-rejects you for looking away. In the UK finance early-careers stack that is simply not how most of it works. The providers fall into three very different surveillance tiers, and knowing which tier you are in tells you almost everything about your real risk.

- **Tier A — statistical / design-based integrity, little or no live watching.** SHL's Verify range and Aon/cut-e rely primarily on **randomised per-candidate item banks** (your test differs from everyone else's, so shared answers are useless) and, for SHL, a **verification re-test** that catches a proxy statistically rather than by webcam. Game-based and behavioural tools — **pymetrics, Arctic Shores, Plum, Cappfinity** — are typically **unproctored** and are hard to fake *by design* rather than by monitoring. For these, there is often **no webcam layer at all**.
- **Tier B — lightweight behavioural telemetry, human-reviewed. HireVue** (async video) and **TestGorilla** (skills library) can log tab-switching, capture periodic webcam snapshots, and flag anomalies — but these are **optional, employer-enabled**, camera-and-audio only (not screen recording), and the flags go to a **human who decides**, not to an auto-reject.
- **Tier C — heavy live/AI proctoring.** Continuous webcam+screen recording, lockdown browsers, AI "suspicion" scoring. This is the tier the frightening research is about — but it is characteristic of **university exams and professional-certification testing**, and is **uncommon** in graduate finance OAs. If a finance employer uses it, they must tell you and obtain consent, which is itself the signal it is on.

The practical upshot: for the great majority of assessments you will sit in a UK finance process, the honest false-positive risk is **low** — and this chapter is about making it lower still, not about managing a hostile surveillance system.

The signal × provider × consequence matrix

The table below consolidates what each provider is documented (or reasonably inferred) to monitor, and — the column that matters most — **how a flag is actioned.** "Consequence" is the difference between a note a recruiter may never read and an automatic rejection. Confidence tags carry over from the provider chapters; where a cell is `[UNKNOWN]` the provider does not document it and no reliable report established it.

Provider	Proctoring flavour	Signals collected (where enabled)	How a flag is actioned	Told?
SHL (Verify)	Unsupervised + optional **verification re-test**; webcam proctoring a separate opt-in layer	Randomised item bank; **Confidence Indicator** (unsupervised vs supervised score gap); *if webcam enabled:* focus-loss/tab-switch, copy-paste, screen captures, face presence	"Not Verified" → **employer review** (vendor position) though top firms often reject on a large gap; single focus-loss treated holistically	Rarely told of a flag; consent to any webcam layer
Aon / cut-e	Mostly **unproctored**; webcam offered, not default	Unique per-candidate item bank; extreme time limits; tab-switch/ clipboard telemetry `[UNKNOWN]`	Human review; no documented auto-reject	Usually not
Arctic Shores	**Unproctored / low-surveillance** by design	Behavioural telemetry (reaction time, learning rate) — *for measurement, not policing*; integrity mechanics `[UNKNOWN]`	n/a — little to flag	n/a
pymetrics (Harver)	**Unproctored**; hard-to-fake by design	Game telemetry; anti-cheat signals `[UNKNOWN]`	Fit-model match; no pass/fail to game	No
Cappfinity	**Largely unproctored**	Response-time capture, cross-response **consistency checks**	Soft — inconsistency weakens score; no webcam flag	No
Plum	**Unproctored**	Consistency/social-desirability inference `[INFERRED]`; explicit proctoring `[UNKNOWN]`	n/a	No
HireVue (video)	**Optional**, employer-enabled; camera+audio only	Browser focus / **tab-switch** logging; **webcam ID snapshots**; face-presence; possible response-similarity	Flag → **human at employer decides**; **no auto-reject** on a tab-switch; **no** eye-tracking/ emotion analysis (dropped 2021)	Usually disclosed in T&Cs
Willo (video)	**Minimal** by design	Time-taken metadata incl. retakes; marketing claims of tab/gaze checks unverified `[UNKNOWN]`	Human-reviewed; small surface	Employer-configured
TestGorilla	**Anti-cheating suite** (a selling point)	**30-sec webcam snapshots**, full-screen/ tab-switch, IP/location, copy-paste/screenshot/ dev-tools, randomised retiring pools, timestamped behaviour log/tiers	Behaviour log + tiers → **employer decides**; vendor is candid that flags aren't proof	Candidate-facing notice `[UNKNOWN exact wording]`

Provider	Proctoring flavour	Signals collected (where enabled)	How a flag is actioned	Told?
Amberjack	Light; virtual-AC + one-shot human-scored video	`[UNKNOWN]` — not documented	Human-scored video component	`[UNKNOWN]`
Morgan Stanley (firm-built stack)	Inherits vendor postures (Aon/cut-e unproctored + HireVue optional)	As per Aon and HireVue rows	As per those vendors	As per those vendors

Two patterns jump out. First, **the majority of the stack is unproctored or lightly monitored**, and **almost nothing auto-rejects** — the near-universal design is flag-then-human-review. Second, the one genuinely distinctive integrity mechanism is **SHL's verification re-test**, which is statistical, not surveillant: it is the only common mechanism where an *honest* candidate can be caught out (by under-performing on the supervised re-sit relative to the unsupervised one), which is why SHL's own manual insists a "Not Verified" be *investigated*, not treated as guilt.

Genuine cheating that is reliably detected

Stated as risk, not instruction. Item randomisation defeats **shared answers**. SHL's verification re-test and Confidence Indicator defeat a **proxy sitting the unsupervised test**. ID snapshots defeat **someone else answering a video**. Focus/tab-switch logging plus response-similarity defeat **looking answers up or reading a script**. pymetrics-style games are defeated less by monitoring than by the fact that a **faked behavioural profile mismatches the model** it is aimed at. None of this is worth the risk; the entire value of this guide is legitimate preparation.

The false-positive catalogue — how an honest candidate gets flagged

This is the section written specifically for you. Each item is a real, documented, or well-reasoned way that honest behaviour can be misread — concentrated in the Tier B/C settings, since Tier A rarely watches you at all.

- **Looking away to think or use scratch paper.** On any webcam-proctored deployment, sustained gaze-off-screen can register as a gaze/absence anomaly. Universal honest behaviour; naive detectors read it as evasion. (Note: HireVue's *algorithm* no longer scores gaze at all, but a human reviewer or a proctoring layer might.)
- **A second monitor connected but unused** — some proctoring/lockdown configs flag multiple displays.
- **Another person entering the room, or audible nearby** — a housemate, parent, or flatmate on a call trips second-face or audio flags.
- **Poor or backlit lighting** causing intermittent loss of your face — compounded by the documented reality that **face detection is less reliable for darker skin tones** (evidence below).
- **Glasses glare, a headscarf, or a face covering** confusing face-presence detection.
- **Disability-related movement** — tics, stimming, ADHD restlessness, or an autistic gaze pattern — misread as "suspicious."
- **A stutter or speech difference** on video — timed, no-re-record recording plus fluency-sensitive speech-to-text can under-score honest answers.
- **An unstable connection** producing focus-loss/disconnection events that look like tab-switching.

- **Browser notifications, an auto-updating OS, or work-laptop security software** stealing focus or being flagged as unauthorised software.
- **VPNs or corporate/university networks** producing IP/geolocation anomalies.
- **Answering unusually fast because you are genuinely good** — extremely fast, accurate responses can look "impossibly fast" to an anomaly detector.
- **A large score jump between an unproctored test and a supervised verification** (SHL) — which can happen honestly through nerves, illness or under-sleep, yet is exactly the pattern the Confidence Indicator flags.
- **Sitting in a library or shared space**, where other faces and movement are unavoidable.
- **Screen readers or assistive technology** read as unauthorised software.

The evidence on demographic disparities in remote proctoring

This is not folklore, and it is a legitimate basis for requesting an alternative or adjustment in advance. Independent research and journalism have documented that facial-detection and face-matching systems perform **worse for darker-skinned users and for some disabled users**. The foundational study, **Buolamwini and Gebru's "Gender Shades" (2018)**, found commercial face-classification error rates of up to ~35% for darker-skinned women versus under 1% for lighter-skinned men; **NIST's Face Recognition Vendor Test** demographic evaluations subsequently confirmed accuracy gaps across skin tone, sex and age across many algorithms. `[INDEPENDENT]` Carried into proctoring, these gaps mean a darker-skinned candidate is more likely to trigger a "no face detected" flag or a failed identity check through no fault of their own. In the specific video-hiring context, **HireVue's own ORCAA audit** recommended investigating accent bias and noted that minority candidates giving brief answers were disproportionately routed to human review — a live fairness issue now that scoring is transcript-based (higher speech-to-text error rates for some accents). `[INDEPENDENT]` And HireVue's abandonment of facial analysis, after the **EPIC FTC complaint** argued the technology was "biased, unprovable, and not replicable," is itself the industry's clearest admission that face-based inference in hiring was not sound. `[INDEPENDENT]`

If you are in an affected group, the risk of a false flag is real and documented — which is not a counsel of despair but a concrete argument you can put in writing, in advance, to secure a non-webcam alternative or an adjustment (below, and Chapter 6.7).

The universal pre-flight checklist

Print this. It applies to *any* proctored or webcam-enabled assessment; for unproctored tests most of it is simply good practice.

Before the day - Confirm the format in writing. Ask the recruiter whether the test is **webcam-proctored**, whether **calculator and scratch paper** are permitted, and whether a **supervised verification test** will follow (SHL). Their answer tells you which risks apply and creates a record. - **Request adjustments in advance** (Equality Act 2010) if you have any condition affecting movement, gaze, speech, reading speed, or that a webcam would disadvantage — before you sit, using the template in Chapter 6.7. This is the single most protective action in this chapter.

The environment - A quiet room you can close, **door shut, a note on it**; no other person within earshot or camera range. **- Lighting in front of you, not behind** — no window at your back. If webcam-enabled, check your face is evenly lit and fully in frame before starting.

The device and network - Full-size laptop/desktop; **disconnect any second monitor**. Close every other application and browser tab. Enable Do Not Disturb / Focus mode. **Pause OS and antivirus auto-updates** for the window. **-** The most **stable connection** you have — wired if possible; avoid a VPN and, where you can, a locked-down corporate network. Have a phone hotspot as backup but don't switch mid-test without noting it.

On the desk and during the test - Keep only what the recruiter confirmed is permitted. If unsure, **ask rather than assume. - Don't tab-switch.** If you must look away or leave frame on a proctored test, and the interface allows, **say aloud to the camera what you're doing** ("using scratch paper," "the doorbell rang") — it hands a human reviewer the innocent explanation up front.

If a flag happens anyway

The consequence column of the matrix is your friend here: because almost nothing auto-rejects, a flag is usually a **human decision you can influence.** Ask the employer whether an integrity flag contributed; request **human review** and, where a rejection may have been solely automated, invoke the **Article 22A–22C safeguards** (UK GDPR as amended by the Data (Use and Access) Act 2025); and submit a **DSAR** for your flag logs, footage and decision logic. Full mechanics, templates and the realistic odds are in Chapter 6.7. The recurring lesson of this whole chapter: the systems are more forgiving than they look, the flags are mostly human-reviewed, and your rights and preparation together make a wrongful rejection genuinely contestable.

Sources: consolidated from the per-provider chapters (2–11) and their research files; demographic-disparity evidence from Buolamwini & Gebru, "Gender Shades" (2018), NIST FRVT demographic evaluations, the HireVue ORCAA audit and EPIC FTC complaint (see Chapter 8), and the remote-proctoring critique literature. Full citations in the bibliography.

Chapter 6.7 — Your Legal Rights and the Regulatory Picture

> *This chapter states the law as it stood on 1 August 2026. One area — UK automated-decision rules — changed materially in February 2026, and another — the EU AI Act — is mid-deferral. Both are flagged inline. Where a detailed regulator standard was still pending, the chapter says so rather than inventing certainty. Confidence tags: `[REGULATORY]` = statute/official source; `[INDEPENDENT]` = reputable legal analysis; `[INFERRED]` = reasoning shown; `[UNKNOWN]` = not settled.*

If you have been screened out at an online assessment — especially on integrity grounds — the single most useful thing to understand is that you have **more enforceable rights *before* you sit the test than after you are rejected.** The law gives you a strong, reliably-granted right to adjustments up front, a solid right to see your data afterwards, and a weaker, slower right to challenge the decision itself. This chapter tells you exactly what each one is, and — importantly — corrects two things a candidate who read about this even a year ago would now get wrong.

The headline corrections

1. UK "Article 22" is no longer the live provision. For years, UK data-protection law (via Article 22 of the UK GDPR) said you had the right *not to be subject to a decision based solely on automated processing* that significantly affected you — a general *prohibition*. That is **out of date.** The **Data (Use and Access) Act 2025 ("DUAA")**, section 80, **replaced Article 22 with new Articles 22A–22D, in force from 5 February 2026.** The framework **flipped from prohibition to permission-with-safeguards**: a fully-automated significant decision is now *lawful* provided the organisation gives you four specific safeguards. `[REGULATORY — DUAA 2025 s.80; INDEPENDENT — Travers Smith, Handley Gill, Bratby analyses]` This changes your lever from "you weren't allowed to do that" to "you must now give me the safeguards — including human review" (see below).

2. The EU AI Act's recruitment rules are not yet enforceable. AI used to filter and evaluate job applicants is classed as **high-risk** under the EU AI Act (Annex III, point 4(a)). But the obligations that would matter to you as a candidate were **deferred**: the "Digital Omnibus" package (Council approval 29 June 2026) pushed the high-risk Annex III duties to **2 December 2027.** `[INDEPENDENT — Gibson Dunn, Cooley, DLA Piper]` So for the 2026–2027 application cycles this guide targets, the EU-side protections are largely **not yet in force** — useful to know about, not yet a tool you can wield.

3. There is no UK "four-fifths / 80% rule." That is a *US* construct (see the end of this chapter). UK challenges to a biased test run through **indirect discrimination** under the Equality Act 2010, which has **no fixed numerical trigger** — do not import the 80% rule into UK thinking. `[REGULATORY]`

Your right of access: the DSAR (UK GDPR Article 15)

This is your workhorse right, and it survived the 2025 reforms intact. Under **Article 15**, you can require any organisation holding your personal data to give you (a) confirmation they are processing it, (b) a **copy** of that data, and (c) supplementary information — including the existence of any automated decision-making and *meaningful* *information about the logic* involved. `[REGULATORY]` A request is called a **Data Subject Access Request (DSAR)**.

- **Deadline: one month**, extendable by up to two further months for genuinely complex requests, but only if they tell you (with reasons) within the first month. `[REGULATORY – ICO]` DUAA added a **"stop-the-clock"** rule: the month pauses if the organisation reasonably needs to verify your identity or clarify the request, resuming when you reply. `[REGULATORY – gov.uk DUAA factsheet]`
- **Cost: free**, in the ordinary case. They can only charge or refuse if the request is "manifestly unfounded or excessive," and the burden is on them to prove that. `[REGULATORY]`
- **Who to send it to.** The **employer** (the bank or firm) is almost always the **data controller** and the right first recipient — send it to their DPO or privacy team (often `privacy@` or `dataprotection@`). The **assessment vendor** (SHL, Aon, HireVue and so on) is usually a **processor** acting on the employer's instructions, though vendors often become controllers for their own norming and model-training. Send it to the employer first; if they point you to the vendor, send a second request there. `[INFERRED – controller/processor test; exact split is contract-specific and usually undisclosed]`

What to specifically request (put all of this in the letter — the template is at the end):

Ask for	Why
Raw and scaled **scores** per test/section; your **percentile / sten / band**	The actual result
The **norm group** you were compared against	Determines what your percentile means (Chapter 6.3)
Any **cut-score / threshold** applied and whether you cleared it	Tells you *how* you fell
Proctoring / integrity flag logs — flag events, similarity/ plagiarism scores, "suspicious behaviour" markers, IP/device logs	The heart of a false-flag case
Any **webcam/screen footage or audio**, plus any **AI-derived analysis** (competency ratings, transcript scoring)	What the machine "saw"
Automated-decision disclosure: whether an automated sift was applied, meaningful information about the logic, and the consequences (Art. 15(1)(h))	Engages the new Art. 22A–22D safeguards
Whether a **human reviewed** the decision, and at what stage	Determines if it was "solely automated"
Recipients and **retention period**	Completeness

Two limits to expect. They may **redact third-party data** (other candidates' scores, assessor identities) but must tell you what was withheld and why. And Article 15 entitles you to *meaningful information about the logic* — **not** the proprietary algorithm, item bank or source code. Expect a plain-English description of how the decision was made, not the model itself. `[INFERRED / INDEPENDENT]`

Automated decisions: the new Articles 22A–22D (DUAA 2025)

Here is the current UK position, in force since 5 February 2026. `[REGULATORY – DUAA 2025 s.80; INDEPENDENT – Travers Smith, Handley Gill]`

A **"significant decision"** is one producing a legal or *similarly significant* effect on you — an automated graduate sift that rejects you plausibly qualifies. A decision is **"based solely on automated processing"** when there is **no meaningful human involvement.** Under the old law, such a decision was presumptively banned. Under the new law it is **permitted for ordinary personal data — but only if the organisation provides the four safeguards in Article 22C:**

1. give you **information** about the automated significant decisions taken about you;
2. enable you to **make representations**;
3. enable you to **obtain human intervention** from the controller;
4. enable you to **contest** the decision.

These four are your escalation script. If you were auto-rejected below a cut-score with no human looking, that is a solely-automated significant decision, and you can write: *"Please provide the Article 22C safeguards: I am making representations and requesting human intervention in, and contesting, this automated decision."* `[INFERRED from the statute – this is the practical lever]`

A stricter rule protects sensitive data (Article 22B). A solely-automated significant decision based *wholly or partly on special-category data* — health, disability, race, biometric data — **remains prohibited** unless a narrow Article 9 condition is met *and* the safeguards are in place. `[REGULATORY / INDEPENDENT]` This matters where a **video or personality inference could touch health or disability** — for example, if a proctoring or video-analysis system effectively processed data about a disability. In that scenario you have a materially stronger argument that the decision was unlawful.

What "meaningful human involvement" means. Pending updated ICO guidance, the working standard is the pre-DUAA one: the human reviewer must have the **authority and competence to override** the machine, must actually **weigh and interpret** the recommendation (not rubber-stamp it), must have access to all relevant data, and must not be discouraged from disagreeing. A recruiter who merely clicks "confirm" on a ranked list has *not* provided meaningful human involvement. `[REGULATORY – ICO benchmarks via Handley Gill]`

A live uncertainty, stated honestly. The **ICO had not finalised** its updated automated-decision-making and profiling guidance as of 1 August 2026 (a consultation ran in early 2026), and any Secretary-of-State regulations defining "meaningful human involvement" were still pending. `[UNKNOWN – live]` The framework above is correct, but the fine detail of the standard may shift; check the ICO site before relying on the precise threshold.

The Equality Act 2010: adjustments and adverse impact

This is, in practice, your most valuable law — because the right it gives you *before* the test is the one that is most reliably granted.

The duty to make reasonable adjustments (ss. 20–21). An employer must make reasonable adjustments for a **disabled** applicant where a *provision, criterion or practice* (a "PCP") puts them at a **substantial disadvantage** compared with non-disabled people. **A timed online test is a PCP** — a worked legal example is literally "a policy requiring all applicants to complete an online test within 30 minutes." `[REGULATORY / INDEPENDENT – Michelmores]` Typical adjustments include:

- **Extra time** (commonly +25%, but there is *no statutory figure* — reasonableness is fact-specific); `[INDEPENDENT/INFERRED]`
- an **alternative format** (e.g. a dyslexia-friendly or screen-reader-compatible version);
- **rest breaks**; removing or replacing a **gamified** element that disadvantages you;
- **skipping webcam proctoring** where it disadvantages you (directly relevant to the false-flag problem);
- an assessor **briefing** for autistic candidates.

Two features make this powerful. First, the duty bites once the employer **knows or ought reasonably to know** you are disabled and likely disadvantaged — which is exactly why you should **disclose and request early**, before you sit, to fix that knowledge. `[REGULATORY]` Second, although employers generally **must not ask about health or disability before a job offer** (s. 60), there is a specific exception: they *may* ask **to establish whether an assessment adjustment is needed.** `[REGULATORY]` So the recruiter's "do you need any adjustments for the test?" is the lawful channel — use it. The **employer pays** for the adjustment; it can never be passed to you. `[REGULATORY]`

Challenging a biased test — indirect discrimination (s. 19). If a test disadvantages a group sharing a protected characteristic (race, sex, disability, age, religion), it is unlawful **unless** the employer proves it is a *proportionate means of achieving a legitimate aim* — i.e. that the test is genuinely job-related and that no equally-valid, less-discriminatory alternative exists. `[REGULATORY]` There is **no numerical threshold** in UK law; you show group disadvantage (statistics help), and the burden shifts to the employer to justify. `[INDEPENDENT]` This is the mechanism by which a candidate could, in principle, attack a cognitive or gamified test that adversely affects their group — though it is a tribunal claim, not a quick fix.

The other regimes — leverage, not UK remedies

Three foreign or partial regimes are worth knowing because global banks comply with them and thereby generate information you can use.

NYC Local Law 144. Since July 2023, any employer using an *automated employment decision tool* for NYC jobs must commission an **independent bias audit annually** and **publish a summary** — selection rates and impact ratios by sex and race/ethnicity — on its website, and give candidates advance notice. `[REGULATORY / INDEPENDENT – Deloitte, NYC DCWP]` Because the bulge-bracket banks all hire in New York, **they publish bias audits for the very tools (SHL, HireVue and so on) you will face in London.** You can read a bank's published audit summary for the exact tool. Two honest caveats: the law only requires *notice* of the opportunity to request an alternative process — it does **not compel** the employer to grant one — and independent reviews (2024–2026) found real-world compliance patchy. `[INDEPENDENT – DLA Piper; arXiv "Null Compliance"]`

Illinois AI Video Interview Act. For Illinois roles, an employer using **AI to analyse a video interview** must (1) notify the applicant and explain how the AI works and what it evaluates, (2) obtain **consent**, and (3) limit who sees the video, plus **delete all copies within 30 days on request.** `[REGULATORY]` Its value to a UK candidate is as **precedent language** — banks with US operations tend to standardise their HireVue notices around it, so the transparency you're entitled to elsewhere is often already documented.

US EEOC four-fifths rule. Under the US Uniform Guidelines, a selection rate for any group below **80%** of the highest group's rate is treated as evidence of adverse impact. `[REGULATORY]` This matters only because it is **how vendors defend their tests**: when SHL or Aon says a test is "fair" or "validated," they usually mean it passes the US four-fifths rule plus US validity standards — which is **not** the UK legal test. Do not assume "passed the 80% rule" means "lawful in the UK." `[INFERRED]`

What an employer or vendor must actually tell you (UK)

- **Privacy information (Arts 13–14):** at collection, the recruitment privacy notice must state the controller and DPO, the purposes and lawful basis, recipients, retention, your rights, your right to complain to the ICO, and — where solely-automated significant decisions are made — the existence of that automated decision-making, meaningful information about the logic, and its consequences. If a firm auto-sifts, its privacy notice should say so; read it. `[REGULATORY]`

- **On a DSAR:** your data plus the supplementary information above, within one month, free.
- **They need *not* disclose:** the proprietary algorithm, the item bank, other candidates' data, or (there is no explicit UK duty here) the exact cut-score — although the *fact* of a threshold and your own data fall within Article 15. `[INFERRED]`

The realistic bottom line

Be honest with yourself about outcomes, because it changes where you spend effort:

- **What almost never happens:** a regulator or court forcing a firm to re-run your assessment or hire you. There is no statutory "appeal my score and overturn it" right.
- **What you can realistically win:** (a) **the adjustment itself**, if you request it *before* the test — this is routinely granted and is by far the most reliably enforceable right in this chapter; (b) **human review** of a solely-automated rejection under Article 22C — which sometimes reverses; (c) **disclosure** of your data and flag logs via a DSAR; (d) months later, **tribunal compensation** for a genuine failure to adjust or for discrimination (job applicants are covered even though never employed; the time limit is **three months less one day**, and **Acas Early Conciliation** is a mandatory first step). `[REGULATORY / INDEPENDENT — Acas]`
- **Highest-yield move, full stop:** request any adjustment **up front, in writing, before you sit.**

Template letters

(A) Pre-assessment reasonable-adjustment request — send *before* you sit:

> Subject: Reasonable adjustment request — [name], [role/ref] Dear [Early Careers team], I have been invited to complete [SHL/Aon/HireVue/etc.] online assessment(s) for [role]. I am a disabled person within the meaning of the Equality Act 2010. The [timed format / webcam proctoring / gamified element] places me at a substantial disadvantage because [brief, factual barrier — e.g. "my dyslexia materially slows timed reading"]. Under the Act's duty to make reasonable adjustments, I request [specific adjustment — e.g. 25% additional time / a non-webcam-proctored version / an alternative format]. I can provide supporting documentation. Please confirm what can be arranged and any revised deadline. Thank you.

(B) Auto-rejection: invoking the Article 22C safeguards:

> Subject: Request for human review of an automated decision — [name], [ref] Dear [team], I understand my application was declined following an online assessment. If that decision was based solely on automated processing, I invoke my rights under Articles 22A–22C of the UK GDPR (as amended by the Data (Use and Access) Act 2025): I wish to make representations, to obtain human intervention in the decision, and to contest it. Please confirm whether a human with authority to overturn the outcome has reviewed my result, and arrange such a review. Thank you.

(C) Data Subject Access Request (Article 15):

> Subject: Data Subject Access Request — [name], [ref] Dear [Data Protection Officer], Under Article 15 of the UK GDPR I request access to the personal data you hold about my application, and specifically: my raw and scaled assessment scores and percentile/band; the norm group used; any cut-score applied and whether I met it; all proctoring and integrity flag logs (flag events, similarity scores, behavioural markers, IP/device logs); any webcam or screen recording and any AI-derived analysis of my responses; disclosure of any automated decision-making, meaningful information about the logic, and its consequences (Art. 15(1)(h)); and confirmation of whether and at what stage a human was involved. Please respond within one month. Thank you.

Sources (accessed 2026-08-01): DUAA 2025 c.18 s.80 and Arts 22A–22D (legislation.gov.uk; gov.uk DUAA factsheet); ICO guidance on right of access, time limits, and automated decision-making; Equality Act 2010 ss. 19, 20–21, 60 (legislation.gov.uk); Acas indirect-discrimination and early-conciliation guidance; EU AI Act Annex III and the Digital Omnibus deferral (artificialintelligenceact.eu; Gibson Dunn, Cooley, DLA Piper); NYC Local Law 144 (NYC DCWP; Deloitte); Illinois AI Video Interview Act, 820 ILCS 42 (Justia; Littler); US UGESP 29 CFR Part 1607 (eCFR). Analyst notes and residual gaps — including that legislation.gov.uk and ico.org.uk pages were intermittently blocking automated fetches on the access date, and that final ICO ADM guidance was pending — are logged in research/20-legal-regulatory.md.

Chapter 6.8 — Employer → Provider Mapping, and Where the Real Cut Happens

This chapter answers the two questions a UK finance applicant actually needs answered: **"which assessment will *this* firm make me sit?"** and — more importantly — **"where in the process do most people actually get cut, so I know where to spend my effort?"** It is the most volatile chapter in the guide, and the most strategically valuable.

> **Read this warning before the tables.** Every employer → vendor pairing below is a **point-in-time claim**, overwhelmingly assembled from prep-vendor guides and candidate testimony, **not** from employer confirmation. Vendor contracts change **year to year and by division and region**; a firm can switch providers, run two vendors at once, or drop the online stage for a programme entirely between cycles. Several pairings below are internally contested (Barclays and Bank of America especially). **Treat this as a starting hypothesis to verify for your specific programme and year — never as a guarantee.** The single best verification is a *dated* candidate report from the current cycle (The Student Room and Wall Street Oasis threads, filtered to the last few months) plus the invitation email itself, which names the tool. `[PREP-VENDOR / CANDIDATE — volatility flagged throughout]`

The master mapping table (UK / London, 2025–26 cycle)

Cross-reference each provider's own chapter for mechanics. "Stage" indicates where in the funnel the tool sits.

Firm	Online assessment (vendor)	Video stage	Notable	Confidence
Morgan Stanley	**Aon / cut-e** "scales" battery (numerical, verbal, `ix` inductive) + email-inbox SJT + `switchChallenge` — *programme/division-gated*	**HireVue** (near-universal)	HackerRank for tech/ quant; MS ↔ cut-e since ~2019; **not** SHL despite some hedged sources	`[PREP-VENDOR + CANDIDATE]`
Goldman Sachs	Legacy aptitude with **negative marking** reported; HackerRank (tech)	**HireVue** pre-recorded (signature screen)	Then "Superday"; process evolving with AI updates 2024–25	`[PREP-VENDOR]`
J.P. Morgan	**pymetrics** 12 games (now Harver) — the real selection OA	**HireVue**	**Forage "virtual experience" is NOT selection** (self-paced upskilling) — don't conflate	`[PREP-VENDOR]`
Citi	**Korn Ferry / Talent Q** (numerical + logical)	(HireVue reported some divisions)	Plum reported for some grad screening elsewhere — contested	`[PREP-VENDOR]`

Firm	Online assessment (vendor)	Video stage	Notable	Confidence
Barclays	**SHL** (cognitive + personality + mindset) — *another source says pymetrics*	HireVue	**Vendor conflict — verify per cycle**	`[PREP-VENDOR, conflicting]`
UBS	**Korn Ferry / Talent Q** culture-match SJT; **Aon/cut-e** numerical/ verbal/inductive	HireVue	Dual-vendor	`[PREP-VENDOR]`
Deutsche Bank	**SHL** SJT; **Aon/cut-e** scales reported historically	HireVue	cut-e is the best-corroborated DB aptitude engine	`[PREP-VENDOR]`
HSBC	**Cappfinity** "Online Immersive Assessment" (numerical/verbal/ inductive + SJT keyed to Core Values)	**HireVue** (after the immersive)	The "immersive/day-in-the-life" archetype	`[PREP-VENDOR]`
Bank of America	**HireVue**-led; IBM Kenexa / SHL TalentCentral also cited	HireVue (~5 Q)	**Vendor conflict — verify**	`[PREP-VENDOR, conflicting]`
Jefferies	**SHL** cognitive + behavioural	HireVue/phone → Superday	One source: SHL screens ~30–40% through to first rounds	`[PREP-VENDOR]`
Rothschild & Co	—	**HireVue** pre-recorded		`[PREP-VENDOR]`
Evercore	**None** reported (US) — live interviews → Superday	Minimal	Elite boutiques often skip the OA entirely	`[PREP-VENDOR]`
BlackRock	**HireVue coding assessment** (6 tasks + 1 HR question)	HireVue	Buy-side; coding-heavy screen	`[PREP-VENDOR]`
Standard Chartered	Online assessment exists (detail thin)	—	`[UNKNOWN]` on exact vendor	`[PREP-VENDOR]`
Arctic Shores users	**Arctic Shores** behavioural — **Maven Securities** (trading, round 2), **MThree**; PwC/KPMG/Deloitte bespoke	—	Trading/quant-prop and prof-services	`[CANDIDATE/PREP-VENDOR]`
Schroders, M&G, Baillie Gifford, Fidelity, abrdn (asset managers)	**`[UNKNOWN]`** — not reliably captured	—	Asset-manager mapping is a known gap; verify individually	`[UNKNOWN]`

A platform-vs-content caveat that trips people up. Several sources note that Goldman Sachs, J.P. Morgan, Citi, Barclays and Bank of America deliver assessments through the **SHL TalentCentral platform** *even where the test content is not SHL's own.* "Delivered on SHL's platform" is not the same as "it's an SHL test." Judge the tool by its format (Chapter's 1–10 tell you how to recognise each), not by the login screen. `[PREP-VENDOR — verify]`

Splitting by programme type — and the off-cycle rule

The prompt for this guide rightly insists the mapping be read **by programme type**, because the assessment you face depends heavily on *which* programme you applied to. The clearest, best-corroborated pattern comes from Morgan Stanley but generalises across much of UK IB:

Programme	Online assessment?	Video?	Assessment centre?
Spring week / insight	Often **yes** (esp. IBD) — sometimes a lighter version	Yes	Light-touch / insight event
Summer analyst — IBD	**Yes** — full battery	Yes	Full AC / superday
Summer analyst — non-IBD (S&T, markets, IM)	**Often no** — "interviews only"	Yes	Superday-style
Summer — quant / derivatives / tech	**Yes + an extra timed/coding OA**	Yes	+ technical rounds
Off-cycle internship	**Usually skipped or compressed**	**Yes (still mandatory)**	Interviews, faster
Full-time analyst (grad)	Variable — as summer, by division	Yes	Superday

The off-cycle finding matters for you specifically. Across sources, **off-cycle internships frequently skip or compress the online-assessment stage** while keeping the video interview mandatory. `[PREP-VENDOR + CANDIDATE]` Off-cycle roles are applied for on a rolling basis throughout the year, are concentrated in Markets, Investment Management and capital markets, and lean on the CV screen and interviews rather than a psychometric battery. **If you have repeatedly been screened out at the online-assessment stage, off-cycle routes are the part of the market where that specific hurdle is smallest** — a strategically important door for your situation. Verify per firm, but treat "off-cycle compresses the OA" as the working rule.

Where the biggest cut actually happens — the funnel analysis

This is the section that should change how you allocate preparation time. The instinctive assumption — that the online assessment is the main gate — is **often wrong** in UK IB. There are three sequential sifts, and the tightest one varies by firm and programme:

1. **The CV / cover-letter / eligibility screen.** For the most competitive front-office programmes (bulge-bracket IBD, elite boutiques), this is very plausibly **the tightest hurdle**: tens of thousands of applications, a few hundred seats, and a screen weighted toward target universities, grades, relevant experience and a compelling "why this firm." No hard published conversion rates exist for individual banks (`[UNKNOWN]` — do not trust invented percentages), but the arithmetic of application volume makes the CV screen the likeliest bottleneck.
2. **The online assessment (OA).** Usually a **screen-out gate rather than a ranking tournament** at this level: the format is practiceable, there is typically a multi-day completion window, and it filters *unprepared* applicants more than it discriminates among strong ones. A prepared candidate clears it. For one peer (Jefferies), a source suggests SHL screens roughly **30–40% through** to first rounds — meaning most people who reach the OA pass it. `[PREP-VENDOR – single figure, illustrative]` The implication: **beyond clearing the bar, extra OA points buy little**; do not pour weeks into a marginal score gain here.
3. **The HireVue / interview and the assessment centre.** For many programmes the **video interview and the AC/superday are where the real differentiation happens** — where personality, communication,

commercial awareness and technical knowledge separate candidates. This is where deep preparation pays the highest return.

The practical instruction: get the OA comfortably above threshold with efficient, targeted practice (Chapter 6.5), and then **shift the bulk of your effort to the CV/application quality up front and the interview/AC downstream** — the two ends of the funnel, which is where most people are actually lost. The OA is necessary, not sufficient, and rarely the place a strong candidate fails.

Rolling deadlines as a first-class variable

Almost all UK finance early-careers recruiting is **rolling**, not fixed-deadline — and this changes the maths of preparation more than any score consideration. Firms review applications and release assessments as they arrive, and **fill seats as they go**, so the *effective* threshold rises through the cycle: an application (and an OA score) submitted in the first weeks competes for a full complement of places; the same application in the new year competes for whatever remains, against a pool the firm has already partly filled. `[INFERRED from the rolling-review model; prep-vendors uniformly advise applying within days of opening]`

The consequence is a genuine trade-off you must manage deliberately: **applying early with a good-enough OA usually beats applying late with a marginally better one.** If you are ready by week three of the six-week programme (Chapter 6.5), **apply** — do not spend three more weeks chasing a few percentile points into a shrinking pool. Combine this with the off-cycle finding above: rolling, OA-light off-cycle roles reward readiness-plus-speed even more than summer programmes do.

Firm-built and consulting simulations you may also meet

Beyond the vendor-supplied stack, a few firms use distinctive **firm-commissioned simulations**, worth naming because they need their own preparation:

- **McKinsey Solve** (formerly the Problem Solving Game / Imbellus) — a gamified, **process-scored** assessment (how you solve, not just the answer); 2025–26 modules include Redrock, Sea Wolf and a Sustainable Futures Lab, plus a behavioural module; ~70–100 minutes. The most idiosyncratic prep of any assessment here. `[PREP-VENDOR]`
- **BCG Casey** — a **chatbot-style case simulation**, the closest thing to a real case interview and the most directly preparable; BCG has also used pymetrics games. `[PREP-VENDOR]`
- **Bain** — the **SOVA** aptitude test (numerical/verbal/logical); standard test-prep transfers. `[PREP-VENDOR]`
- **Bank "virtual experience" programmes (e.g. J.P. Morgan on Forage)** — self-paced job simulations that are **marketing and upskilling, not selection.** Do them for insight and CV colour, but do not confuse them with an assessed stage. `[PREP-VENDOR]`

These are covered in more depth, with their vendor lineage, in Chapter 11.

What this means for you

Build your own version of the mapping table for **your** target firms, split by the programmes you'll actually apply to, and populate it from current-cycle candidate reports and the invitation emails — not from this table alone, which is a hypothesis with a shelf life. Then apply the funnel logic: **the CV screen and the interview/AC are usually where you win or lose; the OA is a gate to clear, not a tournament to win**; off-cycle routes minimise the OA hurdle specifically; and because everything is rolling, **being ready and early beats being marginally more polished and late.**

Sources (access 2026-08-01): the employer → vendor mappings are consolidated from jobtestprep.co.uk (spring-week and per-firm pages), graduatesfirst.com, practiceaptitudetests.com and current-cycle candidate threads on The Student Room and Wall Street Oasis, cross-checked against each provider's chapter in this guide; the HireVue facial-analysis correction from SHRM/Fortune (Chapter 8). All pairings are `[PREP-VENDOR]`/`[CANDIDATE]` *and volatility-flagged; full source detail and the residual gaps (asset-manager mapping; Barclays/BofA vendor conflicts; MS US-vs-EMEA differences) are logged in research/11-morgan-stanley-firmbuilt.md.*

Chapter 6.9 — Quick-Reference Appendices

These are the pages to print, screenshot and keep beside you. Everything here is a condensed pointer back to the full treatment in the numbered chapters; where a figure is an estimate or unknown, it is flagged, and the **Confidence Register (Appendix F)** collects every such caveat in one place so you know exactly which parts of this guide to trust least.

Appendix A — Master comparison table (all providers)

Provider	Type	Format & timing	Scoring model	Proctoring	Fake-able?	UK finance footprint
SHL (Ch. 1)	Cognitive + personality + video	Verify ~24 adaptive items/ 36 min; OPQ32 ~104 forced-choice; Smart Interview video	Norm-referenced **percentile** vs chosen norm group; A–D band; sten	Unproctored + **verification re-test** (Confidence Indicator); webcam a separate opt-in	Cognitive: no. OPQ: forced-choice resists it	**High** — bulge brackets, many AMs
Aon / cut-e (Ch. 2)	Cognitive + games + personality + video	Speeded "scales" (e.g. ~37 num/12 min); smartPredict games; ADEPT-15; vidAssess	Percentile vs norm; **accuracy + attempt-rate** under extreme time	Mostly **unproctored**; unique item bank; webcam optional	Cognitive: no	**High** — Deutsche Bank, MS, UBS, BNP
Arctic Shores (Ch. 3)	Game/task-based behavioural	Legacy games or new task-based; ~20–30 min; "12,000 data points"	**No score** — telemetry → trait fit; banded	**Unproctored / low-surveillance**	No — behavioural fit	Trading/quant-prop, prof-services bespoke
pymetrics (Harver) (Ch. 4)	Neuroscience games	**12 games**, ~25–30 min	**No pass/fail** — match to role model; 50th/ 70th fit tiers	**Unproctored**; hard-to-fake by design	No — mismatches model	**JPMorgan (anchor)**, BNP
Cappfinity (Ch. 5)	Strengths + SJT + aptitude	Bespoke immersive ~60–90 min; SST + embedded num/ verbal	Composite: strengths fit + accuracy + **speed** + consistency; firm-keyed	**Largely unproctored** (consistency checks)	Partly — coachable via framework	**High** — HSBC, Big Four, some banks
Amberjack (Ch. 6)	Managed RPO + SJT + VAC	~25-item blended, ~45–60 min; "Impact" virtual AC	Blended score → 4-pillar Future Skills Model	Light; human-scored video	Partly — SJT coachable	Broad prof-services; **limited front-office IB**

Provider	Type	Format & timing	Scoring model	Proctoring	Fake-able?	UK finance footprint
Plum (Ch. 7)	Fit-matching (personality + cognitive)	~25-min Discovery; Five-Factor + cognitive + SJT	**Match Score** (fit to role, not percentile); reusable profile	**Unproctored**	No — fit-based	**Shallow/early-careers** (Citi/ Bloomberg contested)
HireVue (Ch. 8)	Async video + games + coding	~3–5 Q; ~30 s think, 60–180 s answer; usually one take	**Content/NLP** vs competencies and/or human review; **no facial analysis since 2021**	Optional tab-switch/ID snapshot; **no auto-reject**; camera+audio only	Human sees through scripts	**Very high** — near-universal video stage
Willo (Ch. 9)	Async video (lightweight)	Video/audio/ text/MCQ; 1–5 min answer; retakes employer-set	Employer scorecards; **no norms**; AI-assisted, **human-decided**	Minimal by design	Human-reviewed	**No documented front-office IB use**
TestGorilla (Ch. 10)	Self-serve skills library	≤5 tests + custom Q; most ~10 min; one attempt	Per-test **%**, candidate ranking; benchmarks	**Anti-cheat suite** (webcam snapshots, tab-switch, IP)	Mixed	**Fintechs/ challengers**, not bulge-bracket
Morgan Stanley (Ch. 11)	Firm stack (vendor-supplied)	cut-e battery (gated) + HireVue + HackerRank	As per Aon + HireVue; **programme/ division-gated**	As per vendors	As per vendors	The firm itself (case study)

Every cell is unpacked and sourced in the referenced chapter. Cut-offs are omitted here because no reliable public figures exist — see the Confidence Register.

Appendix B — Pre-flight environment checklist (printable)

Applies to any proctored or webcam-enabled test; good practice for all. Full rationale in Chapter 6.6.

Before the day - ☐ Asked the recruiter **in writing**: webcam-proctored? calculator/scratch paper allowed? a supervised verification re-test to follow (SHL)? - ☐ Requested any **adjustments in advance** (Equality Act 2010) — extra time, non-webcam version, alternative format. *Before you sit.* - ☐ Practised on the **actual format** and confirmed which vendor (from the invitation email).

The room - ☐ Quiet room you can close; **door shut, note on it**; no one within earshot/camera range. - ☐ **Light in front of you, not behind**; face evenly lit and fully in frame if webcam is on. - ☐ Tidy desk; only permitted items on it.

Device & network - ☐ Full-size laptop/desktop; **second monitor disconnected**. - ☐ Every other app and browser tab **closed**; Do Not Disturb / Focus mode on. - ☐ OS and antivirus **auto-updates paused**. - ☐ Most **stable connection** available (wired if possible); **no VPN**; avoid locked-down corporate networks; hotspot as backup.

During - ☐ **Don't tab-switch.** If you must leave frame on a proctored test, **say aloud what you're doing**. - ☐ Calculator/paper only if confirmed permitted. - ☐ Do the **practice questions** first.

Appendix C — In-test pacing rules card

Cut this out. Full technique in Chapter 6.4.

- **Know your test's design first.** Fixed vs speeded ("do as many as you can") vs adaptive changes everything.
- **Never leave a scored item blank** where there's no negative marking — reasoned guess, move on. (Exception: Goldman-style **negative marking** — then don't wild-guess.)
- **Adaptive tests: harder = you're winning.** Don't panic when difficulty climbs; start carefully (early errors cost more).
- **Speeded sections: throughput over perfectionism.** You're not meant to finish; accuracy on attempted items is the score. Don't rescue one item for 3 minutes.
- **Numerical:** find the right two numbers first; percentage-change and units/scale are the traps.
- **Verbal T/F/Cannot-Say:** answer only from the passage; "probably true in real life" = **Cannot Say**.
- **Inductive:** check dimensions separately (shape/number/position/orientation); most items have **two rules**.
- **Video:** answer the question in sentence one; STAR/CARL; fill most of the answer window; if you fumble, reset in a phrase and continue.
- **Personality/strengths/games:** authentic, decisive, consistent — **don't fake**; no mid-point clustering.
- **Pace to the whole-test clock**, leaving a small buffer.

Appendix D — Template letters

*Full versions and legal basis in Chapter 6.7. Send adjustment requests **before** you sit.*

- **(A) Pre-assessment reasonable-adjustment request** — Equality Act 2010; state you're disabled within the Act, the specific barrier the test creates, and the specific adjustment (extra time %, non-webcam version, alternative format). *Chapter 6.7, Template A.*
- **(B) Auto-rejection: invoke Article 22C safeguards** — UK GDPR as amended by the Data (Use and Access) Act 2025; request human intervention in, and the right to contest, a solely-automated decision. *Chapter 6.7, Template B.*
- **(C) Data Subject Access Request (Article 15)** — request scores, norm group, cut-score, proctoring/flag logs, footage, decision logic, human-involvement record; one month, free. *Chapter 6.7, Template C.*

Appendix E — Glossary

- **Adaptive test (IRT/CAT):** difficulty adjusts to your answers; estimates ability (θ) from how many *and* how hard. Harder items = you're doing well.
- **Adverse impact:** when a method passes one demographic group at a substantially lower rate than another. UK: challenged as *indirect discrimination* (no fixed threshold). US: *four-fifths (80%) rule*.
- **CARL:** Context, Action, Result, Learning — a video-answer structure.
- **Confidence Indicator (CI):** SHL's statistic comparing your unsupervised and supervised (verification) scores; a large gap flags "Not Verified".
- **Construct:** the underlying thing measured (e.g. numerical reasoning, conscientiousness).

- **Criterion / predictive validity:** how well a score predicts job performance, as a correlation *r*.
- **DSAR:** Data Subject Access Request — your UK GDPR Article 15 right to a copy of your data.
- **Forced-choice / ipsative:** items where you choose between statements rather than rating each; blunts faking (you can't inflate everything).
- **GMA / "g":** general mental ability — the cognitive-ability construct.
- **Norm group:** the reference population your raw score is ranked against to produce a percentile. The hidden variable that decides everything.
- **Percentile:** a rank — "70th percentile" = you scored above 70% of the norm group. Not a mark.
- **Proctoring:** monitoring during a test (none / honour-code / record-and-review / live / AI-flagged).
- **Reliability:** consistency of measurement (0–1); ~0.8 is good. Implies your score is a *range* (see SEM).
- **SEM (standard error of measurement):** the width of that range; √(1−reliability)×SD.
- **SJT:** situational judgement test — scenario-based judgement, keyed by expert panels to a firm's competencies.
- **STAR:** Situation, Task, Action, Result — a competency-answer structure.
- **Sten / T-score:** equal-interval standard scales (sten: mean 5.5, SD 2; T: mean 50, SD 10).
- **Verification test (SHL):** a short supervised re-test confirming an unsupervised score.

Appendix F — Confidence Register

The parts of this guide to trust least, in one place. Every important estimate and `[UNKNOWN]` is listed with what's missing and how you could close it. **Rule of the whole guide: no precise figure was invented; where a number would be a guess, it is marked here.**

Item	Status	Basis / what's missing	How to close it
All employer cut-scores / pass marks	**`[UNKNOWN]` / estimate**	No vendor or firm publishes these; prep-vendor "80th percentile for IB" figures are self-disclaimed estimates and disagree	DSAR after sitting (your score + norm group); ask the firm
Which norm group a firm uses	`[UNKNOWN]`	Not disclosed; determines what your percentile means	DSAR; assume the demanding (finance-graduate) norm
SHL current corporate owner	Estimate	CEB → Gartner → Exponent (2018) chain solid; latest owner unverified	Company filings
Employer → vendor pairings (Ch. 6.8)	**Volatile `[PREP-VENDOR]`**	Assembled from prep sites/ testimony; change yearly; Barclays & BofA internally conflicting	Current-cycle candidate reports + your invitation email
Cappfinity / Arctic Shores / Plum validity	`[UNKNOWN]`	No independent peer-reviewed validation of the vendors' *own* instruments located	Vendor technical manuals (sales-gated)
pymetrics games → job-performance validity	`[UNKNOWN]`	Only audited AUC ~0.70–0.72; Baker 2019 validation deck confidential	Independent study (none public)

Item	Status	Basis / what's missing	How to close it
Aon "scales" adaptivity	Conflict	Sources disagree (fixed pool vs adaptive)	Vendor technical doc
Integrity telemetry (Aon, Cappfinity, Plum, Arctic Shores)	`[UNKNOWN]`	Tab-switch/clipboard specifics undocumented; help pages bot-blocked	Vendor candidate privacy notices
Re-record visibility to reviewer (HireVue/Willo)	`[UNKNOWN]`	No source confirmed whether reviewers see take-count	Ask the employer
HireVue current facial-analysis stance	**Resolved**	Discontinued 2021 (NLP/ content only) — well-sourced	— (settled)
UK Article 22 → 22A–22C (DUAA 2025)	**Resolved, but ICO guidance pending**	Statute in force 5 Feb 2026; detailed ICO standard not yet finalised	Check ICO site for final ADM guidance
EU AI Act enforceability	Deferred	High-risk recruitment rules pushed to 2 Dec 2027	Confirm Digital Omnibus final text
Practice score-uplift (~5–15%)	Directional estimate	Vendor/independent, not a hard figure	—
First-person UK candidate timings	Thin	WSO/TSR pages returned 403 to automated fetch; testimony is snippet-level	Manual browser reads / archive.org
Asset-manager mapping (Schroders, M&G, Baillie Gifford, Fidelity)	`[UNKNOWN]`	Not captured this pass	Per-firm current-cycle research

A fuller residual-gaps list, with the specific searches and questions that would close each, is in the closing chapter.

Appendix G — Bibliography (grouped by source tier)

Full, dated per-chapter source lists appear at the end of every chapter (§x.13). This is a curated master list of the load-bearing sources. All accessed 2026-08-01.

Tier 1 — Primary vendor (`[VENDOR]`) - SHL: cognitive-assessments, Smart Interview, Disability Guidelines UK; *Verify Range Technical Manual v2.0* (reliability 0.77–0.84; verification/Confidence Indicator). - Aon: assessment.aon.com product pages; vidAssess-AI; smartPredict (GBA workshop deck). - HireVue: platform/ assessments, CodeVue, DCI external-audit press release. - pymetrics/Harver, Cappfinity, Arctic Shores, Plum/ Phenom, Amberjack, TestGorilla, Willo: vendor product/science pages (see chapters).

Tier 2 — Independent technical (`[INDEPENDENT]`) - Schmidt & Hunter (1998), *Psychological Bulletin* — GMA validity ~0.51. - Sackett, Zhang, Berry & Lievens (2022), *Journal of Applied Psychology* — revised cognitive-ability validity ~0.31. - Buolamwini & Gebru (2018), *Gender Shades*; NIST FRVT demographic evaluations — face-detection disparities. - SJT reviews (NCBI/PMC) — incremental validity ΔR ≈ 0.03–0.08; coachability. - pymetrics audits: Northeastern cooperative audit (2020); BABL AI LL144 audit (2025); FAccT "monocultures" critique (2024). Plum: FairNow bias audit (2024). - HireVue: Fortune (2021-01-19), SHRM — facial-analysis discontinuation, ORCAA audit; EPIC FTC complaint.

Tier 3 — Regulatory / legal (`[REGULATORY]`) - Data (Use and Access) Act 2025 s.80 (UK GDPR Arts 22A–22D); gov.uk DUAA factsheet; ICO right-of-access & ADM guidance. - Equality Act 2010 ss. 19, 20–21, 60; Acas

indirect-discrimination guidance. - EU AI Act Annex III 4(a) + Digital Omnibus deferral (Gibson Dunn, Cooley, DLA Piper). - NYC Local Law 144 (DCWP; Deloitte); Illinois AI Video Interview Act (820 ILCS 42; Justia); US UGESP 29 CFR 1607 (four-fifths rule).

Tier 4 — Employer-side (`[EMPLOYER]`) - Morgan Stanley tal.net programme portal; bank careers/early-careers pages; university careers-service guides.

Tier 5 — Candidate testimony (`[CANDIDATE]`) - The Student Room (IB & Finance forums), Wall Street Oasis (London/UK), Reddit r/FinancialCareers — note many pages returned 403 to automated fetch; testimony is corroborated at snippet level, individual reports labelled `n=`.

Tier 6 — Prep vendors (`[PREP-VENDOR]` — commercially biased, corroborated) - JobTestPrep, CareerTestPrep, GraduatesFirst, AssessmentDay, PracticeAptitudeTests, PrepTerminal, Intervyo, Mergers & Inquisitions, Corporate Finance Institute.

(Every URL, with access date, is in the corresponding chapter's §x.13 and in the research/ notes.)

Closing — Residual Gaps and How to Close Them

This guide was built to a standard of *labelled honesty*: everywhere the public record ran out, it says so rather than inventing. This closing chapter collects what remains genuinely unknown, grouped by how you — the candidate, with access this research did not have — could close each gap. Think of it as your personalised research list.

What only *you* can find out (and exactly how)

Some of the most valuable figures in this whole field are confidential to the vendor and employer, but **you have a legal route to your own**. After you sit an assessment, a **Data Subject Access Request** (Chapter 6.7, Template C) can extract, for your specific case: your raw and scaled scores, **the norm group you were compared against**, any cut-score applied and whether you cleared it, and — if you were flagged — the proctoring/integrity logs and any footage. No amount of desk research can produce these; one DSAR can. If you have been rejected before, sending a DSAR now for a past application is the single highest-value action to understand what actually happened.

Two things to request in writing *before* your next test also resolve gaps this guide could only flag generically: **whether the assessment is webcam-proctored**, and **whether a calculator/scratch paper is permitted** — both vary per deployment and per employer, and the recruiter's written answer is definitive for your sitting.

Gaps that a current-cycle candidate community can close

The **employer→provider mapping (Chapter 6.8)** is the most perishable content in the book. Vendor contracts change yearly, and several pairings are internally contested (Barclays SHL-vs-pymetrics; Bank of America HireVue-vs-Kenexa-vs-SHL). The fix is not more desk research but **dated, current-cycle testimony**: The Student Room's IB & Finance forums, Wall Street Oasis's London threads, and r/FinancialCareers, filtered to the last few months, plus your own invitation emails. Several of these pages blocked automated fetching during this research, so **a human browser session will surface first-person timings and vendor confirmations that this guide could only capture at snippet level.** The **asset-manager mapping** (Schroders, M&G, Baillie Gifford, Fidelity, abrdn) is a known blank spot — worth building from scratch for your specific targets.

Gaps that would need vendor or independent sources this guide couldn't reach

- **Independent validity evidence** for the newer instruments — Cappfinity's strengths tests, Arctic Shores' behavioural tasks, Plum's Match Scores, and pymetrics' games→job-performance link — is essentially **not public**; the vendors' technical manuals sit behind sales gates, and pymetrics' own validation deck is confidential (only audited AUC ~0.70–0.72 is visible). Closing this would need the vendor technical documentation directly, or a published academic study that does not yet exist.
- **Integrity telemetry specifics** for the unproctored tools (Aon's tab-switch/clipboard logging, Cappfinity's and Plum's monitoring) are undocumented and were behind blocked help-centre pages; each vendor's **candidate privacy notice** is the place to look.
- **Facial-analysis / re-record specifics** — whether HireVue or Willo reviewers can see how many takes you used — was not confirmable and would need a direct answer from an employer using the tool.

- **SHL's exact current corporate owner** (post-Exponent) needs a company-filings check; the older CEB → Gartner → Exponent chain is solid.

Gaps that are moving targets — check the date

Two areas will change under your feet and should be re-checked at the time you apply:

- **The ICO's finalised guidance** on automated decision-making under the new Articles 22A–22D was still pending on 1 August 2026; the statutory framework is settled, but the detailed standard for "meaningful human involvement" may firm up. Check the ICO website.
- **The EU AI Act's high-risk recruitment obligations** were deferred to **2 December 2027** — so for the 2026–27 cycles they are not yet enforceable, but that date is worth confirming if you are applying to an EU-run programme close to it.

The honest bottom line

The parts of this guide you can most trust are the **mechanics** (how each test works and is scored), the **integrity reality** (mostly unproctored or human-reviewed, rarely auto-rejecting, with the facial-analysis era over), the **psychometrics** (why your score is a range, why the norm group matters more than the raw score), and the **law** (your adjustment and access rights, correctly updated for 2026). The parts to hold most loosely are the **exact cut-scores** (confidential — estimates only) and the **employer → vendor pairings** (volatile — verify per cycle). Everywhere the two meet, the guiding instruction of the whole book holds: **the online assessment is usually a gate to clear, not the tournament that decides you — clear it efficiently, protect yourself from wrongful flags with the pre-flight checklist and your rights, and spend your real energy where the funnel actually narrows.**